

Philosophy of Religion

by

R. Nielsen.

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Faith and knowledge are as principles absolutely heterogeneous.

The heterogeneity of the principles makes no breach in the universally valid laws of thought, but shows the impossibility of any scientific transition whatever, either from knowledge to faith or from faith to knowledge.

The long conflict between religion and science has its original ground in an obscure conflation of the heterogeneous principles, and must therefore cease when the conflation ceases.

The proposition that truth in religion is not truth in science is no longer a paradox, once the absolute boundary of knowledge coincides with the mystery from which the cognition of faith proceeds and to which it returns.

It is these principal theses that the Philosophy of Religion in its present form will develop and substantiate. Whether the development and the substantiation have any validity, examination must decide.

Copenhagen, 28 December 1868.

R. Nielsen.

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[1]

INTRODUCTION.

The relation of the philosophy of religion to religion cannot be stated satisfactorily in general conceptual determinations; its peculiar nature demands a peculiar treatment. What is said religiously: Show me your faith by your works, must be said philosophically: Show me your principle by its execution.

Religion and Philosophy.

§ 1.

If philosophy as a whole is a science, then the philosophy of religion, insofar as it is to deserve the name of philosophy, must naturally also be a science; but precisely the distinctive feature, that it is a science of religion, gives it a character diverging from the other sciences and stamps it with a mark of its own. What this means will best be understood by a glance at the principal forms the philosophy of religion has assumed in recent times.

The scientific form must be determined by the principle. The fundamental question is: do religion and philosophy have the same principle, or are the principles different? If the principle of religion is different from that of philosophy, which principle is science then to follow, that of philosophy or that of religion? Only by an answer to these [2] questions can the concept and method of the philosophy of religion be determined.

If one proceeds from the presupposition that religion and philosophy have the same principle, the philosophy of religion becomes a *speculative science*; if one assumes that the principles are indeed different, but that truth must nonetheless be judged by the principle of knowledge, the philosophy of religion becomes a *critical science*. If, finally, one takes the principles to be absolutely heterogeneous and lays the religious principle at the foundation of the scientific elucidation, the philosophy of religion becomes an *inverted science*. The first of these points of view is represented by Hegel; the second chiefly by L. Feuerbach; the third is the one brought to application in the present exposition.

a) The Philosophy of Religion as Speculative Science.

The object of religion as well as of philosophy is, according to Hegel, the eternal truth in its objectivity, God and nothing but God and the explication of God. Philosophy only develops itself in developing religion, and in developing religion it develops itself. Thus religion and philosophy then coincide into one. Philosophy is in actuality worship, is religion, for it is the renunciation of subjective fancies and opinions in the occupation with God. Nonetheless the occupation with God in philosophy is a different one, takes place in a different way and manner than in religion. In religion God is the immediate object of consciousness; in philosophy the consciousness of God is God's own consciousness of himself: the difference lies in the form. Religion as religion is popular, is for all, and for that very reason is referred to the figurative form of representation; but such a form is inadequate to the content. The form is finite, the content infinite: this is a disproportion. Can this disproportion be removed; can the

[3] same content, without changing, be presented in two entirely different forms? Here is the difficulty, and on this difficulty Hegel founders. For where it is a matter of the truth as truth, the Idea is so absorbed into the form that the form cannot possibly be changed without the content being changed. In the course of its movement of thought the speculative philosophy of religion is imperceptibly led to a different result from the one it originally aimed at. The movement is this: it begins with science being to acknowledge and ground the truth of religion; the truth of religion is determined by what is true in the content, i.e. by the greater or lesser quantum of vital ideality that a given religion, relative to the stage of formal development at which it stands, is able to express; since now the form of religion is not scientific, but the scientific form is the only perfect one, it is brought to consciousness that even the perfect religion has an imperfect form, and on account of the imperfection of the form can express what is true only in an imperfect manner. That by which the perfect religion is distinguished from philosophy is therefore a form that must be sublated; but in the sublation of the form, what is peculiar to religion is sublated, and therewith religion itself. In losing its form religion at the same time loses its content, for the truth of the content rests on the form. So it ends with this: that philosophy, in order to be able to comprehend what is true in religion, must comprehend religion itself as an untruth. The negative

relation between philosophy and religion, repellent from the side of science, has come to expression with vigorous consistency in Neo-Hegelianism.

b) The Philosophy of Religion as Critical Science.

While the speculatively positive tendency holds principally to the content common to religion and philosophy and strives to develop this true content of truth into the true form, the negatively critical tendency, in cognition of the difference in principle between religion and philosophy, proceeds principally from the form peculiar to religion, demonstrates its manifest conflict with reason, and so arrives, through a demonstration of what is untrue in the form, at what is untrue in the content. Immediately it looks as though religion had to do with nothing but actual, if supernatural, facts; but reason developed into knowledge comprehends that the supernatural facts are not actual, and the actual ones not supernatural. It is not spirit as spirit, but the ideal natural forces of the life of the soul, that originally stir in the originally religious consciousness. Religious representations are indeed not products of conscious arbitrariness; on the contrary, they are owed to an unconscious poetizing, a need of souls for self-objectification, a psychological necessity by which imagination, overwhelmed by the Idea, has placed the divine in man before man by placing it outside man. Religion is human; it is the first elementary breakthrough of human reason; it has its origin, not in God's love, but in man's passions. The dreams of the heart, the stirrings of the mind, the longings of the soul contain the basic elements out of which the Idea-inspired imagination has formed all the gods of faith, the one Almighty as well. This is confirmed by insight into the essence of monotheism as well as of polytheism. The mighty, wrathful, vengeance-snorting Jehovah of the Old Testament is, scientifically regarded, an idealized reflection of the abstract, mighty spirit of the Jewish people, of Israel's strong, law-bound and yet self-willed ego. Christ in the New Testament is not an actual God-man, for an actual God-man is a contradiction, but is nonetheless essentially a man-god, the reconciling God of the wounded heart, of the anguished soul, a God for the suffering. For imagination and feeling the ideal presents itself immediately; on this rests not only the wish itself but also its fulfillment. [4] Man, with his confining natural limitation, wishes for power; if he had power as he

has will, he would feel blessed and free; but alas, unfortunately he is powerless; so in his powerlessness he feels the need of divine assistance. The divine assistance is immediately determined thus: that a God who has power over nature arbitrarily intervenes in the course of things and helps by a miracle. In the miracle is intuited the unlimited will, freed from the compulsion of nature, a will that is able to annihilate all resistance, satisfy all wishes and hear all prayers. The miracle is the ground of faith, the way out for hope, the consolation of imagination, the holy fairy tale of the pious disposition; when a God has grown so old and weak that he can no longer work miracles, he does best to resign, to cease to be God, and likewise a religion that cannot continually show miracles must cease to be religion. Here is the turning point where the conflict between religion and philosophy culminates. Religion holds to the miracle, philosophy to reason. The miracle is in contradiction with reason; when reason awakens to the cognition of the laws of actuality, the miracle disappears, and with the miracle religion as well. Thus philosophy, as negative critique, has then, by its own assurance, accomplished the dissolution of religion.

By the negative path, however, a positive result has been reached. The result is that religion, rejected and scorned by “science”, is referred to its own principle and thereby called upon to rely on its own strength and assert its independence over against science. The decisive break between religion and science can then, on these terms, benefit religion just as well as science. The absolute heterogeneity of religion [6] with all objective knowledge and science has been demonstrated with penetrating sharpness and victorious superiority by S. Kierkegaard.

The fundamental question from which S. Kierkegaard proceeds is this: *To what extent can the truth be learned?* Here one then meets what Socrates in the Meno calls a contentious proposition: that a man cannot possibly seek what he knows, and just as impossibly can seek what he does not know; for what he knows he cannot seek, since he knows it, and what he does not know he cannot seek, for he does not even know what it is he is to seek. Socrates removes the difficulty by holding that all learning and seeking is only a recollecting, so that the ignorant one merely needs to be reminded in order, by himself, to call to mind what he knows. The truth is thus not brought into him, but was in him. This is what we may call the human explanation. From this

point of view “the moment”, the entry of the divine into time, the miracle, receives no significance. “For the Socratic view every man is himself the center, and the whole world centers only in him, because his self-knowledge is a knowledge of God.” He who learns the truth learns it by himself; the teacher is only the occasion; the moment at which the truth dawns is, in relation to the truth that is, and that inheres in the essence of man, a vanishing and to that extent indifferent point in time. “The point of departure is a nothing; for in the same moment that I discover that I have known the truth from eternity without knowing it, in that same instant that moment is hidden in the eternal, taken up into it in such a way that I, so to speak, cannot even find it, even if I sought it, because here there is no here and there, but only an *ubique et nusquam*.” It is otherwise from the exclusively religious standpoint. Here man is presupposed to be, not in the truth, but in untruth. If now he who through the guilt of the race and through his own guilt has lost the truth is to come to the cognition of truth, namely that cognition of truth which leads to blessedness, then it becomes necessary that God not only [7] enlighten the one in darkness about the untruth, but also, by himself entering into time and existing as a man, give the man who is in untruth the condition for attaining the truth. Through God’s self-communication in time the moment, the definite point in time, and therewith the miracle, receives absolutely decisive significance. The miracle is the paradox of the understanding. By holding fast to the miracle and setting up the paradox, S. Kierkegaard has secured religion against the encroachments of science and raised a bulwark against the incursions of negative critique; but then he has also, with decisive aim at his “introductory problem, not to Christianity, but to becoming a Christian”, come to a halt at the decision that Christianity is not a doctrine but an existence-communication, and an existence-communication expressed in the problem: “that the individual’s eternal blessedness is decided in time through the relation to something historical, which is furthermore historical in such a way that there is taken up into its composition that which by its essence cannot become historical, and thus must become so by virtue of the absurd”.

According to the negative critique it is science that declares religion an absurdity and thereby means to dissolve it; according to the Kierkegaardian settlement it is religion that, in spite of objective knowledge, declares itself an absurdity and thereby

once and for all excludes science. From this it is seen that religion and philosophy are not merely heterogeneous, but absolutely heterogeneous. With this presupposition, then, is a philosophy of religion possible?

c) The Philosophy of Religion as Inverted Science.

The exclusive relation to God, determined by the miracle, which is religion's own [8] inescapable presupposition, science cannot appropriate. This presupposition is the incomprehensible, the unfathomable, and can be acknowledged on one condition only, namely that human knowledge acknowledge a barrier, an absolute boundary, at which it must stop. What in other regions of cognition shows itself contradictory and unreasonable is always something lower, above which science can freely raise itself; it can discuss this lower, dissolve it, and by its dissolution continually advance further. But religion, what is contradictory for knowledge, is not something lower but something higher, for religion is the highest ideal power of life; where this power, by virtue of its original essence, comes forward with "an absurdity", there the way is objectively impassable, there reason finds the passage barred, there science must turn aside.

But what is absurd for scientific thinking, "the paradox", nevertheless falls within the thinking consciousness, as surely as it falls within religion; from which it follows in turn that what is unthinkable for science can be thinkable in religion. There is an essential difference between overstepping the boundary of knowledge and overstepping the boundary of thought, between falling outside knowledge and falling outside thought. The difference between the thinkable and the unthinkable is here to be determined by the principle from which thinking proceeds. That the paradox falls outside knowledge is certain; but does it therefore fall outside thought? In order that thought may strike upon the paradox, thinking must of course itself bring the paradox forth; the paradox is unthinkable only by being thought; its dialectical knot is an intertwining of absolutely heterogeneous threads of thought. Existentially the knot is insoluble; but it by no means follows that it must also be so intellectually. The intellectual solution is conditioned on the heterogeneous threads being unraveled and separated from one another. Science would not be able to apprehend and determine

its principle of knowledge if it were not able, by the opposition between what can be [9] known and what cannot be known, to characterize, if only negatively, the principle of faith that is impenetrable to knowledge. But if it is possible for science to separate the absolutely heterogeneous principles, then it is of course also possible for it to separate the thoughts proceeding from these principles, possible therefore to distinguish between thoughts of knowledge and thoughts of faith, between concepts of knowledge and concepts of faith. With the peculiar task of clarifying the relation of refraction between the heterogeneous thoughts, the philosophy of religion is most nearly to be determined as a *boundary science*.

The philosophy of religion does not, however, remain standing at general determinations of the boundary between faith and knowledge; it cannot possibly let religion develop its content without letting a whole system of concepts of faith come to development. But the religious content of faith is, according to the principle, a supra-scientific content; here then the contradiction enters, that a supra-scientific content is taken up into science. If now the form of science were actually confused with the true original form of the content and introduced and maintained in place of it, the contradiction would certainly be insoluble. But this is by no means the case. Scientific reflection has precisely the pliancy that it can bring the form of knowledge to reflect another and opposite form. For just as clear day can bring the eye to forget the gleam of the light and look at the objects, so reflection too can bring thought, in knowledge, to look at faith and forget knowledge. The philosophy of religion is so far from forcing a foreign form upon the religious content that its development of form consists, on the contrary, in freeing it from the admixtures of immediately individual representations, images, feelings, utterances of will, etc., with which in the life of faith itself it is always grown together. Insofar as reflection, as regards form as well as content, sublates knowledge through knowledge, in aiming to clarify not a scientific [10] but a supra-scientific truth, the relation between the truth and science is essentially inverted, and the philosophy of religion is in this respect to be characterized as an *inverted science*.

What is decisive for every science is the grounding. Now, to be sure, any thorough development of a content whatever can be regarded as a peculiar development of the

matter, thus as a development in which the matter unfolds its moments and grounds itself. But in all direct sciences the principle of the grounding of the matter is at bottom one with the universal principle of knowledge, so that the grounding of the matter coincides point for point with the self-grounding of the science in question. In the inverted science, on the other hand, the grounding is inverted. The fundamental principle here is so far from being absorbed into the principle of knowledge that the two absolutely heterogeneous principles, that of the miracle and that of reason, everywhere repel each other and in their negative relation determine each other negatively. Of this negative relation, with the reciprocal determinations corresponding to it, a clear knowledge can now certainly be given; but the universal knowledge, hovering above the opposed principles, is at the present stage no longer able to take the part of its own principle; the inverted science has precisely the task of putting faith into force and bringing knowledge itself to bow before it. As it goes with the grounding principle, so it must go with the grounding. The inverted science is neither to conceal nor to deny the universally valid grounds of knowledge, but it is to bring to clear insight how the self-confirmation of religion takes place precisely through the grounds of knowledge consistently dissolving themselves and giving place to the absolutely self-valid grounds of faith. By grounding the conversion and dissolution of the grounds of knowledge into grounds of faith, the philosophy of religion grounds its own scientific [11] dissolution and, on these terms, acquires significance as a science that offers itself up to religion, *a science that sublates itself in doctrine of faith*.

Religion and Mythology.

§ 2.

On the relation in which philosophy places itself to religion depends the scientific conception of the opposition between true and false religion, between religion and mythology. Speculative reason makes mythology into religion; the critical understanding makes religion into mythology; only in inverted knowledge can the separation in principle between religion and mythology be carried through. We shall consider these points of view more closely.

a) Mythology Is Essentially Religion: The Speculative Conception.

With the presupposition that the truth in religion and the truth in science are not two mutually heterogeneous truths but one and the same absolute truth, the speculative philosophy of religion must consistently acknowledge religion in every mythology, and regard the mythical clothing as a husk that can easily be removed. Religion is spirit, and for spirit as spirit the finite representations are indifferent. To fathom the essence of spirit is to fathom the essence of religion; in order to fathom the essence of religion, philosophy develops the concept of religion. The concept of religion is in its generality a genus-concept, but according to its particular modes of appearance a species-concept. The Idea of religion has divided its content and laid out its moments in a plurality of more or less one-sided religions, in order through these to gather itself out of dispersion and come to completion in the one, true, perfect [12] religion. “It has been”, says Hegel, “the work of spirit through millennia to carry out the concept of religion and make it the object of consciousness.” The task is to show how the human spirit, beginning in complete naturalness, has been able step by step to raise itself above the nature-bound condition to ever greater freedom and at last to reach the turning point at which spirit comprehended itself as spirit and expressed the concept in the exemplary existence that is to be appropriated and actualized by all in the form of community. Hegel’s systematics in the philosophy of religion is characteristic in this respect. From *nature religion*, the stage at which consciousness, in a fermenting unity of nature and spirit, intuits the divine, through the *religions of spiritual individuality or free subjectivity* — those of majesty, of beauty, and of purposiveness — the development advances to the apprehension and determination of the religion that is clear in itself, revealed, corresponding to the concept of revelation, *the absolute religion*, Christianity.

According to this view all religions are related, all sprung from one root, all branches on one trunk. The old distinction between the nature religions and the revealed religion is overlooked by Hegel, even to such a degree that the “religion of majesty” in Judaism is — for the sake of the concept — placed lower than the “religion of beauty” among the Greeks and the “religion of purposiveness” among the Romans. What now follows from this? That the Jewish religion is mythology just

as well as the Greek and Roman! But if Judaism is mythology, then Christianity is also mythology: the absolute religion is of the same origin as the relative ones. With the absolute religion, then, the mythical has not disappeared; on the contrary, it has become transparent to spirit as something belonging to the peculiar form of religion.

[13] Only when the concept represented in religion is comprehended in knowledge, that is, when religion is transformed into philosophy, does the mythical disappear.

“The absolute religion,” says Hegel, “is the revealed. Religion is the revealed only when the concept of religion is itself *for itself*, that is, when its concept has become objective to itself, not in a restricted, finite objectivity, but such that it is, according to its concept, objective to itself. We thus have two: consciousness and the object; but in the religion filled with itself, the revealed religion, which has grasped itself, the content is itself the object, and this object, *the self-knowing essence*, is *spirit*. Here for the first time is spirit as such the object, the content of religion, and spirit is only for spirit. In being content, object, it gives itself the other side of subjective consciousness, and thereby a finite appearance. It is religion that is filled with itself. This is the abstract determination of this Idea, or religion is in actuality Idea. For Idea in the philosophical sense is the concept that has itself for its object, i.e. has existence, reality, objectivity, is no longer the inner or subjective, but objectifies itself, only that its objectivity is at the same time its return into itself, or, insofar as we call the concept purpose, the fulfilled, accomplished purpose, which is consequently objective.”¹

But when the content of religion in this manner coincides with the Idea of philosophy, when religious cognition is made one with the absolute knowledge of speculation, who does not see, even at first glance, the consequence? Religion demands faith in its supernatural facts, holds fast to existential immediacy, and will not let itself be
[14] transformed into philosophy; philosophy, which has transformed the sacred facts into mythical representations, is sure of knowledge, declares all positive religion to be mythology, and gives up faith.

b) Religion Is Mythology: The Critical Conception.

The conflict between religion and philosophy began among the Greeks very early,

¹Religionsphilosophie II. Berlin 1840. S. 192–93.

and as for the Romans, two augurs in Cicero's time could, as is well known, not look at one another without laughing. To be sure, religion furnished the original foundation for the life of spirit among the Greeks as well as among the Romans; but in both it also becomes evident that the form of religious representations satisfies spirit only at the first, childlike stage of a people's life: the law of development is that consciousness, with increasing reflection and advancing culture, outgrows religion. When Socrates had discovered the dialectic of subjectivity, set self-knowledge as the goal of philosophy, and to that extent introduced "new gods," popular religion could no longer withstand the attacks of the philosophers. Even if the concept of myth itself was not developed in antiquity with the clarity and depth that has been achieved in our own time, it nonetheless soon became sufficiently evident, as regards the lives of the gods and the deeds of the heroes, that "the divine," to use an expression of Strauss, "could not have happened in such a way that what thus happened could not be divine." This dissolution, which explains the myths but annihilates the gods, is not a spiritual regression but, in the name of thought, of reason, of self-consciousness, an essential advance. The mythological is the unconsciously illusory; but this plainly illusory element religion cannot put off without laying bare its innate weakness and exposing itself to ridicule. The supernatural phenomena in the New Testament are just as contrary to reason as the events in the Greek war of the gods. Religion and mythology are synonymous concepts, and the difference between lower and higher, [15] more imperfect and more perfect religions is only a difference between lower and higher, more imperfect and more perfect mythologies.

The higher a mythology stands, the more it is filled with essence and spirit, the longer it will naturally hold out alongside the consciousness of culture; but precisely the circumstance that the most spirit-filled of all myths, the myth of the Risen One, has been able to carry culture through eighteen centuries and to hold out alongside the human spirit, until consciousness at last got the better of all obscure presuppositions and came to itself, in that it "as the free universal that is for itself, became transparent to itself," precisely this shows what it really is that in the "revealed" religion becomes the revealed. It is not a fundamental difference between myth and revelation that comes to light; no, what now comes to light is something entirely different, it is the

great objective truth that the human spirit, not the spirit of the individual human being, but the human spirit in its principle, is its own divinity, is in the religious self-duplication both subject and object, as finite spirit subject, as spirit in inner infinity object. This is no blasphemous self-deification; it is, after all, the discovery of the Absolute, of the Idea as Idea, of the divine-human unity of the subjective and the objective.

By carrying through the principle of knowledge, philosophical critique has consistently dissolved religion as religion—for to want to preserve the religious when the principle of religion has been dissolved is of course nonsense—and it has thereby at the same time reached the boundary line at which the powers of life react: the religious asserts its right, faith steps forward against knowledge, and the heterogeneous [16] principles measure themselves against one another.

c) Religion Is Absolutely Heterogeneous with Mythology: The Antirational Conception.

There is, in the stance of the critical as well as of the speculative philosophy toward religion, an ambiguity which must from first to last dazzle the observer and confuse his conception; this ambiguity lies in the use of the word truth. That the eternal, absolute truth is only one, and that the one divine truth cannot have fallen into discord with itself or have divided itself into two mutually conflicting truths, is certainly a presupposition as unambiguous as it is incontestable. But when one then without further ado overlooks the difference between a divine and a human knowledge of the truth, overlooks that what is absolute in God's knowledge must be relative in man's, overlooks the difference in principle between religious and scientific cognition, the ambiguity arises. It looks as though philosophy actually entered into religion's own presuppositions, let these presuppositions develop their religious consequences, and thereby arrived at conflicting, mutually canceling results. Indeed, if it actually went that way, then it could truly be said that philosophical critique let religion itself carry out its own dissolution. But that is not how it goes. Instead of beginning with the religious principle, science on the contrary begins with the principle of knowledge. By being applied to religion, the principle of knowledge consistently becomes a religion-

denying principle. When it then appears as though critique proves the self-dissolution of religion, this is only a semblance. The truth is that critique gets out what it has itself put in; it begins by putting in the denial of religion and ends by getting the denial of religion out: the dissolving critique moves in a circle. For what is it, then, that science in principle posits as the mythical? It is precisely the relation to God peculiar [17] to religion. To clarify and determine the relation to God is to clarify and determine the fundamental conditions decisive for the life of spirit. Now science ought surely to know that these fundamental conditions present themselves differently in the domain of faith than in the domain of knowledge. If it is truly the earnest intent of science to get the life of spirit itself clarified and understood from the ground up, then it must, at least for the time being, be able to show the self-denial of disregarding its own principle and letting religion have its say.

That the principle of religion is absolutely heterogeneous with the principle of science can be seen from the grounding. All grounds of knowledge are in the deepest sense grounds of necessity; the grounds of religion, on the other hand, are grounds of will. God's will is the Absolute of religion. If it were, as the thoughtless assert, a contradiction that science should come to know of a principle absolutely heterogeneous with knowledge, then it would have to be precisely the negative critique that has entangled itself in the contradiction. What does this critique want? To dissolve positive religion by virtue of knowledge. Why does it want to dissolve positive religion? Because its original presuppositions are absolutely incompatible with all science. Now if science cannot come to know of the presuppositions incompatible with science, then critique is, after all, dealing with something it does not know what it is, and its whole undertaking is meaningless; if it asserts that it knows fully what it is that it dissolves, then it has thereby conceded that science can come to know of what is intolerable in knowledge. But that the principle of religion is absolutely heterogeneous with the principle of knowledge means, after all, nothing other than that this principle, peculiar in itself, must, when it is to be conceived and applied as a principle of knowledge, become intolerable to science. And why? Because the principle of religion is God's unconditioned will.

To know God's will, to give oneself up to God's will, and to do God's will, is the [18]

one and all of religion. But an unconditioned will no science can assimilate. To be sure, will is not for itself without essence and Idea; but by the content of the Idea being posited in the form of will, and determined by will, the thoughts of essence become thoughts of will, and the truth becomes personal. In that the relation to God is posited as a relation of will, there is expressly posited a fundamental difference, and with it a boundary line, between the religious and the scientific, the personal and the impersonal truth. The impersonal truth is cognized by necessity of the Idea; it is inherent in the essence of man and cannot be lost without man losing his reason and ceasing to be man. The personal truth, the truth of will, is on the other hand identical with freedom and can be lost when freedom is lost, i.e. when the relation to God is disturbed. If the philosophy of religion is truly to begin with the principle of religion, then it must begin, not with a knowledge *of*, but with a knowledge *about* two absolutely heterogeneous principles.

Originally—so runs the word intolerable to science—man was placed in the incipient relation to God in such a way that he had therein all the presuppositions and conditions for the cognition of truth and of freedom. Through the misuse of will, and thus through the misuse of freedom, he has lost freedom, has sunk down into unfreedom and with it into personal untruth. In untruth he has lost the cognition of God's will, of God as God, and thereby at the same time the condition for cognizing himself according to his eternal destiny. As fallen man's cognition of God has become illusory, so too has his self-cognition become illusory. The capacity for general cognition of essence is preserved, but the cognition of will is lost: reason is preserved, but spirit is darkened. Now if the relation to God rested on man's being able, of himself, by his own spiritual impulse, to place himself in relation to God, then it would also rest with [19] man himself whether, after having stepped out of the relation, he would step in again and restore what he had forfeited. But that is impossible. It is not man who began by placing himself in relation to God, but God who from the beginning placed himself in relation to man; if the broken relation is to be restored, it must come about by God, through an express act of will, once again taking man to himself, thus by his *revealing himself* to man. This is—we repeat it—the fundamental thought of religion. What the knower, from the objective standpoint of a contemplation hovering above, will

judge of this thought, whether he will find it reasonable or unreasonable, acceptable or unacceptable, attractive or repellent, is inessential; the essential thing is that science come to know of it, take note of it, and see how it develops in religion.

By the fundamental thought stated here, the difference between revelation and myth, between religion and mythology, is irrefutably established. This difference is determined not by outward but by inward marks, not by historical reports but by the testimony of the Spirit. But how, then, is the testimony of the Spirit determined? If the testimony of the Spirit were nothing other than the religious individuals' immediate utterance of their own inner, individual experiences, then the Spirit would be without principle, and religion not to be distinguished from mythology. For what a multiplicity of theophanies, of proclamations of will, counsels, guidances, commands, threats and promises from gods to men is not contained in the ancient legends of the gods! This mixture of all manner of imaginings, this motley swarm of more and less ideal representations of God, cannot dazzle the mind that holds itself convinced that religion is the life of spirit, and that life has its principle. The relation to God which in one and all satisfies the demands of spirit, of eternal life, which fixes the goal, points out [20] the way and offers the means, is and must be the true one; every other that deviates from it, the untrue. Here, then, a critique is required that surely distinguishes the true relation to God from the untrue.

As the principle is, so must the critique be. Now since the principle, as principle of will, the absolute principle of freedom, belongs not to science but to religion, it follows from this that the critique which is to be able to discern religion from mythology in spirit and in truth must be, not scientific, but religious.

What, then, has science to do with this critique? It has to procure the formal conditions; it has to bring out all essential determinations, remove all irrelevant considerations, ward off all confusing mixtures of thought, secure the consistent progress of the movement, and come to know of the peculiar self-development of the religious principle.

The relation to God is a relation of spirit to spirit. On this, science can in general be at one with religion; but when the relation is to be determined more precisely, the separation sets in. For the relation has two main sides, the side of the Idea, which is

grounded in the necessity of reason, and the exclusive determination of will, which is grounded in freedom: the former is the abstract, for the side of the Idea can be brought out without will being cognized; the latter, on the other hand, is the concrete, for will, whether human or divine, cannot be cognized in truth without being cognized in the Idea. As little as spirit is an Idea universal in itself without will, just as little is it an empty, arbitrary will without Idea: the will of spirit is will of the Idea, spirit itself the absolute unity of Idea and will.

In the mythical relation to God, freedom is paralyzed, the element of will corrupted. The corruption shows itself, from the divine as well as from the human side, in egoism [21] having stepped into the place of the will of spirit; the mythical gods are egoists just as much as men are. The difference, however, is this, that only the human egoism is real, the divine invented and fantastic. Then reason awakens and discovers the fantastic; the will of the gods vanishes with the gods themselves: only the necessity of the Idea remains. From the standpoint of revealed religion the nature religions cannot possibly be taken to belong to the kingdom of truth; they are on the contrary testimonies to a relation to God sunk into untruth, a preceding apostasy from the true God. The mythical gods are, in the language of religion, idols, false gods; the unity of spirit and nature with which mythology begins is a false unity. Reason can shed light on the false gods, discover the laws of actuality and drive out superstition; but the ambiguity of the Idea, the false unity of nature and spirit, reason left to itself cannot possibly clear up, and that for the good natural reason that the necessity of reason and the necessity of the Idea essentially coincide. Reason can cognize a world order in the connection of things, can in the state, in art, in science unfold and clarify the system of Ideas; but spirit as spirit, the eternally free spirit working as absolute will, it cannot explain. Spirit as spirit has only one explanation, and that is its own, unconditionally free self-revelation. Reason is so far from being able to sublate the mythical that, by misjudging the will of God and letting freedom in an ambiguous manner be born of necessity, it is rather itself mythical in essence and ground. This is the fundamental thought of religion; whether religion will be able to develop it and defend it against scientific attacks, we shall see; but this much is certain: it is the fundamental thought of religion, and science must come to know of it.

In that the principle of will is posited as spirit's own divine principle, the conception of what is peculiar to religion must become, not rational, but antirational. The [22] antirational is by no means that which is in itself contrary to reason, but that which stands against reason with so peculiar a determinateness that the reasonable man, on closer reflection, must see the unreasonableness of wanting to comprehend it. The opposition of religion and reason is by no means determined by religion's supposedly either breaking with the general laws of thought or denying reason the right to test the objective truths grounded in the necessity of the Idea; no, the opposition is determined by the principle peculiar to religion, the principle of will. A scientific grounding of the principle of will is impossible; but for the same reason a scientific refutation of this principle is then also impossible. How antirational the principle is becomes especially evident when we consider that its essence is the miracle itself, that the absolute principle of will is precisely the principle of the miracle.

When the talk is of the supernatural and "unnatural" in religion, which offends reason, attention usually fastens on the miracles in the outward, the external signs and works, as though it were they alone that gave offense. In this one overlooks the inward supernatural principle. And when the talk then is of this principle, one again overlooks only too easily that the supernatural principle is the principle of will itself. So-called sound reason finds it objectionable to deny God a will, but it does not find it objectionable to deny religion its miracle. If—so one reasons—man, who is only a finite rational being, has a free will, however imperfect, then the Godhead, the infinite rational being, must necessarily have a perfectly free will. What is offensive is thus placed, not in the Almighty's having a rational will, but in an infinitely rational will's being supposedly able to resolve upon something so unreasonable as to perform a miracle. But the categorical expression of the unconditioned freedom of the almighty [23] will is the miracle. That God as God can will, can resolve, can in a single determinate work utter a single determinate thought of will, is precisely the miracle of miracles, the fundamental miracle: religion, the relation to God itself, is the fundamental miracle.

The difference between religion and mythology is, then, in brief this: religion expresses the true, almighty principle of will, mythology the false, impotent one; religion is known by the true miracle, mythology by the false, merely imagined

miracle.

Revelation and Faith.

§ 3.

If the God of spirit, that is, of will, were not revealed to himself, the will of spirit certainly could not become revealed to man either; but what is decisive for the concept of revelation is nevertheless not, as Hegel supposes, that spirit as spirit *becomes* revealed, but that spirit, self-determining, *makes* its will revealed: revelation, as an act of freedom, is expressly an act of will. On this rests, from God's side, the indissoluble unity of revelation with the miracle, from man's side, its indissoluble unity with faith. Just as faith becomes divinely determined by revelation, so revelation in turn becomes humanly determined by faith: revelation is a concept of faith, faith a concept of revelation. The same Spirit that works revelation works faith as well; and just as revelation becomes spiritless when its objective elements are separated from faith, so faith too becomes spiritless when the believing subjectivity tears itself loose from revelation. Since the unity of the two, however, is not a merely formal but a real unity, [24] and thus a unity of opposition, it will be necessary, for the clarification of the matter, to illuminate the relation from its different main sides: from the historical, through the opposition between revelation and sacred history; from the metaphysical, through the opposition between revelation and reason; from the psychological, through the appropriation of revelation in faith.

a) Revelation and Sacred History.

As an act of will of God himself, revelation is not the "manifestation" of a speculative Idea, but divine action, a work of the Spirit, a sacred fact. Revelation is, according to its principle, historical; only it matters that the historical not be brought under a false light. By applying the same measure to sacred as to profane history, critique easily manages not only to shake the credibility of the biblical narratives, but also to set up a divorce between revelation and faith that must annihilate the significance of

both. A consideration corresponding to this is the following: historically there appears a difference between immediate and mediate communication of what is revealed. The immediate communication is made not to all, but only to some. These few, the elect, who so to speak receive revelation at first hand, themselves experience the wondrous. But of what a man thus experiences he has, after all, a direct, immediate certainty; and to direct, immediate certainty there corresponds knowledge, not faith. I do not believe that I exist, for I know it; I do not believe that I actually see and hear, and that there are visible and audible things, for I know it. So with the elect: they do not *believe* that a revelation has taken place, for they *know* it. The multitude, on the other hand, the non-elect, that is, those who do not themselves experience the wondrous, but, by relying on reports of what others have experienced, receive revelation at second hand, and thus properly historically, become the believers in the proper sense. For to believe [25] in a revelation one has expressly received is, after all, no great matter, but to believe in a revelation one has not received is a strenuous task. In this way revelation and faith are made to fall outside each other: *blessed are they that have not seen, and yet believe*. By falling outside faith, revelation becomes outwardly objective, and thus spiritless: by falling outside revelation, faith, with an empty inward whose content must be sought in something outward, becomes formally subjective, and thus spiritless. This two-sided spiritlessness, however, concerns not religion, but critique alone.

In order to satisfy the demand of spirit, sacred history takes up and unites absolutely heterogeneous elements. God proclaims his will to the human being; the proclamation takes place immediately, in a finitely determinate manner. By the immediate determinateness the supernatural wants to be known; but the determinate immediacy, in its mode of expression, clings at the same time to the natural, to what is sensuous in the phenomenon; content and form, the inner and the outer, stand in decisive opposition: the content is supernatural, the form natural; the inner is supersensuous, the outer sensuous. This is a contradiction. Now if the content were commensurable with the form, and the relation between the inner and the outer an immanent relation of necessity, the contradiction would naturally have to be resolved in knowledge. But the content is precisely incommensurable with the form; the relation between the inner and the outer is by no means grounded in necessity, but on the

contrary posited with divine freedom. The contradiction is that the supersensuous is to be sensed, what is in itself invisible seen, the inaudible heard; such a contradiction must be resolved in faith. Only faith in the religious sense possesses the happy unity [26] of infinite reflection and childlike immediacy, the wonderful gift of knowing the supersensuous by the sensuous, and of joining the natural together with the supernatural. Faith binds together extremes of the holy and the sinful, of divine omnipotence and human impotence: by faith, and only by faith, is the human being set in a relation to God that is at once finite and yet infinite, as spirit to spirit.

We learn it from sacred history. By immediate revelation Abraham receives the command to sacrifice his son Isaac. Now if such a command could actually be apprehended with the same immediate, sensuous certainty with which one can apprehend a human command, the whole narrative of Abraham's obedience would be without religious significance. What Abraham does, anyone else in his place could and would have done. For who is it, after all, that commands? Jehovah himself, the almighty Creator! Here, then, on the presupposition of sensuous certainty, there can be as little thought of a possibility of evading the command as of any danger in fulfilling it. What indeed did the man venture who knew within himself that the God who spoke was his friend—when, mark well, he knew it with sensuous, undeceivable certainty? The Almighty might, after all, merely wish to let Isaac die in order to raise him up again, or, if it did not please him to raise the dead one, give his chosen one a thousand sons in compensation for the one. No, the religious significance lies precisely in this, that Abraham, by the nature of the case, could not possibly have any sensuously decisive certainty, and for just that reason had to have his assurance in faith. He believed he heard Jehovah's voice; he believed that the command, although, incredibly enough, it called for the sacrifice of Isaac, proceeded from God, and not, as the natural heart must after all find far more credible, from dark fancies or from an evil spirit. — If we turn to the Gospel, the contemporaries needed of course only to use their natural senses [27] in order to see and hear the man Jesus; but to discover in the Son of Man *Christ, the Son of the living God*, natural seeing and hearing were not sufficient: *blessed art thou, Simon, son of Jonas, for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven* (Matt. 16).

Just as little as an outer revelation can acquire religious significance without faith, just so little can faith acquire religious significance without a corresponding inner revelation. If the inner revelation is lacking, accounts of the supernatural will either be rejected with unbelief or be accepted in superstitious fashion according to a merely historical faith. For all straightforwardly historical faith in sacred history is superstition. Sacred history differs from other history, namely, in this, that it wants to be believed not with, but against, all probability. On account of the improbability, what is historical in revelation is, as regards its acceptance, not straightforwardly supporting but on the contrary repelling. The highest that can be attained by historical testimony is only the probability that the witnesses themselves believed in the improbable. The improbable, which is otherwise a mark of the unhistorical, is in sacred history precisely the sign of the religious, insofar as it is the sign of the miracle.

The Gospel accounts of Christ's resurrection by no means make the resurrection itself probable, any more than they give any perfect assurance of its actuality. This is no objection against the trustworthiness of the accounts; on the contrary, they could not be more trustworthy than they actually are, but the trustworthiness dwells in the repellent. Without the historical testimonies religious faith would lack its supernatural presuppositions, determined by determinate facts, and with them its proper foundation; but it is nonetheless true, for all that, that it is not the outward events, improbable in themselves, but what is inward in the events, the revealed, [28] which, revealing itself anew to the gaze of faith, sublates pastness and makes the divine present. The outer revelation is, on condition of faith, expressly set down in sacred history, in order that the historical may in turn, on condition of faith, be converted into inner revelation.

b) Revelation and Reason.

The opposition between revelation and reason is designated, briefly and sharply, as an opposition between unconditioned freedom and absolute necessity, between truth in faith and truth in knowledge. To want to veil what is conflicting and contentious in this opposition is in vain. People have appealed to the fact that truth must be one and undivided, in all respects in agreement with itself; but as soon as one sets about

stating where the highest criterion of truth lies, in revelation or in reason, the conflict breaks out.

When the question of the truth of revelation is made dependent on the judgment of reason, science comes forward with objections, each more loud-voiced than the last. Revelation in the religious sense is an unthinkable concept, equally self-contradictory whether we look to the essence of the human being, or of the world, or of God.

“If we have regard,” says a profound thinker, “merely to human nature in itself, we convince ourselves that revelation presupposes a receptivity in the human spirit which entirely conflicts with the essence of spirit. For since the essence of spirit consists in activity, it can be in suffering only insofar as it is at the same time in acting. But through a revelation, an immediate action of the highest being upon the human spirit, nothing is left over for the latter but an absolute suffering; for the highest being is [29] absolutely active, but the necessary correlate of absolute activity is absolute passivity.” (Schelling). Regarded from this side, then, a revelation is impossible. Revelation shows itself just as impossible when we consider the world, the natural order of things. Revelation is a miracle, but the concept of miracle sublates the concept of nature. Here no petty criticism is needed to find out the difference between reasonable and unreasonable, necessary and superfluous miracles; the point is that a single miracle annihilates the whole reality of nature. For what is nature? A revelation of the Idea necessary to reason; if not, then a sensuous, fantastic shadow-being. If things have a natural ground and a necessary connection, then the miracle is impossible; if the miracle is possible, then the ground of nature is hollow, the connection loose, and universal reason a misty fancy. A miracle such as, for example, that a staff is changed into a serpent and the serpent back into a staff is enough to show how a nature-less, unconditioned will can play with all conditions, treat finite causes as meaningless occasional causes, abolish the law, and rob nature of its reality.

The same absurdity shows itself with regard to God’s own essence. Religion teaches, to be sure, that God is unchangeable; but if we accept its stories of revelation, then God must in himself be very changeable. A comparison between present and past shows clearly enough that in the course of the ages a remarkable change must have taken place in his relation to the world and to human beings. The same God

who formerly spoke, and spoke almost incessantly, and worked so many miracles that the Old and New Testaments can hardly contain them, behold, he has in later times become entirely silent and works no miracles at all. From the standpoint of revelation this is inexplicable. If it is not the purpose of the miracles that they should strengthen faith and combat unbelief, what then is the purpose? But if a strengthening in faith is [30] the purpose: who then will explain to us why the miracles fail to appear? If there was ever a time when human beings might truly need to hear an actual word of God, an almighty word from God's own mouth, and to see an actual work of God, it would surely have to be this present time; for just as the soil after long drought and heat needs refreshing and fructifying rain, so must pious hearts, in the scorching sun of doubt and of culture, at last need refreshing and fructifying miracles. If faith in a supernatural revelation is to be kept alive, the unchangeable God must from time to time change himself to a remarkable degree.

But is a revelation, then, even necessary? Religion wants to ground the necessity on the universal corruption of the human race through the Fall; but here, if anywhere, there appears a striking disproportion between means and end. The corruption, it is said, is universal, and the need for the pretended help consequently universal as well; and yet, although all have become through the fall equally guilty, equally helpless, equally needy, the help has nonetheless by no means extended itself to all. Originally it was only the Jews whom God came to help by special revelations; the heathen, the great majority, had to help themselves as best they could by the use of reason. But to help some and pass over others, what is that other than divine partiality, groundless arbitrariness?

That this is on the whole "a reasonable line of thought" no one will surely deny: reason, as reason, when it is to make its own principle of cognition valid, cannot judge otherwise. But when reason cannot judge otherwise, what use is it then to want to conceal that revelation is and must be an offense to reason. If, conversely, [31] the matter is made dependent on the verdict of revelation, then the judgment will go straightforwardly against reason, and it may easily seem as though reason's right were being violated. Reason supposes that it can explain, comprehend, and see through spirit; it is this supposition that religion rejects as a fancy. For revelation alone explains

spirit and opens its depths: revelation is the sun of spirit. Just as the sensuous eye is dazzled when it stares into the sun, so reason is dazzled when it would stare at revelation. Reason does not know what spirit is, and cannot know it; for it does not know what a holy, almighty will is, and cannot know it. That reason can take up into its system of universally valid concepts the concept of will too, is not to be denied; by deifying the universal will bound to the necessity of the Idea it can even suppose that in the concept it actually acknowledges God's will. But the acknowledgment that reason grants to the divine will by robbing it of the unconditionedness of self-determination and raising it to the rank of "actual concepts" has no more significance than the acknowledgment a heathen emperor once showed Christianity by taking Christ up among his household gods. It is of no use to want to satisfy reason, which inquires according to grounds of necessity, with assurances that God's will is one with God's essence, and God's essence and will one with the eternal truth: every time the will would express itself in *this* or *that* commandment, in *this* or *that* work, and thus as will, the grounds of necessity vanish; the conditions disappear in the unconditioned; the sting of unconditionedness wounds reason, and wounded reason complains of arbitrariness. But when reason cannot comprehend the unconditioned freedom of the almighty will, and thus cannot comprehend the highest presupposition of revelation: [32] how then should it be in a position to master religion, penetrate into the relation to God, and comprehend faith?

Only on one condition can God's unconditioned will be cognized; but this condition, although at bottom one, is two-sided: from the divine side revelation, from the human side faith. What is first and decisive in revelation is not what God wills of the human being in this or that matter, but that God expressly wills something of the human being, has a will toward the human being, and thus, unconditionally: that God has will. Revelation is the divine act of freedom, the ideal action in which spirit originally proclaims itself as spirit. Faith, like revelation, is not an involuntary stirring or an unclear feeling, but an inner action, a first act of freedom, by which the will of spirit comes into being in the human being, and by which the human being essentially becomes spirit. What is first and decisive in faith is not this: that the human being, concerning this or that, immediately assures himself of what God wills, but this: that

the human being is to will God's will, and thus unconditionally: that the human being is to *will*, is to cognize that the relation to God is a relation of will, the relation in which alone there is spirit and freedom and eternal life.

Into this relation reason cannot possibly penetrate; it looks as though it had cut itself off from all grounds of essence: just because it takes up and encloses all objective grounds in subjectivity itself, in the ground of freedom, it looks in the eyes of reason as though it were groundless. Or on what, indeed, should faith be grounded? On revelation, and thus on a miracle. And on what, then, should the truth of revelation be grounded? On faith, and thus on a miracle that is itself grounded on a miracle. As an unconditioned relation of will, the relation to God, when grasped in its innermost peculiarity, is an anti-rational relation; by wanting to rationalize what is in itself anti-rational, reason only betrays its own blindness. In the highest concerns of spirit, [33] for all absolute decisions of the will, reason is blind, blind to the Fall and blind to the restoration; blind to the Fall, for the secret of the Fall lies in the will; blind to the restoration, for the secret of the restoration lies in the will. Reason would fathom wisdom, and yet with all its wisdom cannot cognize God in his wisdom; for all the secrets of wisdom hide themselves in the will; the Idea of wisdom, the Idea of God's will, is revealed only to the will. So religion judges "blind reason." From this standpoint it can be understood that it is not reason, but its overreaching, that is an offense to the faith of revelation.

The many lengthy and seemingly endless disputes between revelation and reason can be brought to a final decision only when they are led back to the first point of departure, namely the opposition between the principles of freedom and of necessity, between grounds of will and grounds of essence. Every decisive ground of will always draws the universal into singularity, sublates necessity by free choice, and makes the ground of essence insufficient; in the sufficient ground of essence, by contrast, the single is dissolved in the universal, necessity is posited with the given conditions, and the ground of will is unrecognizable. Both of these reason can see; but for that very reason it can also see that the ground sublated in the will, which gives the action as action the stamp of arbitrariness, cannot possibly be a ground of reason. In this connection it can at the same time be seen how idle and empty is the thinking that

fancies it can remove the separation between the heterogeneous principles by the assurance that freedom and necessity must absolutely be one in the absolute essence. For as soon as it is asked what it actually is that makes the absolute essence absolute, [34] then, as already shown, revelation again posits freedom, reason necessity, and the conflict begins all over again.

Here there is no other way out than to let the two absolutely heterogeneous principles furnish the centers of two absolutely heterogeneous groundings, two absolutely heterogeneous spheres of cognition. Now if it is just as impossible to derive necessity from freedom as freedom from necessity, and at the same time impossible to deny the original fundamental unity of the opposed principles: then the fundamental unity must necessarily be conceived as a Mystery impenetrable to human knowledge.

This Mystery is no paradox. For the paradox appears only when the knowing consciousness one-sidedly takes the side of reason and wants, by straining the understanding to the utmost, to comprehend revelation from the principle of reason. By acknowledging the Mystery we acknowledge the inner infinity of both spheres of cognition. All cognitions developed from the principle of necessity have full validity in their own sphere, and reason to that extent an incontestable right to investigate everything, test everything, and develop the content of its knowledge infinitely. Likewise all cognitions developed from the principle of freedom have full validity in their sphere, and the faith of revelation for its part an incontestable right to let its thinking test everything and judge of everything; in this respect reason cannot set any limit whatever to the consistent development of the content of faith.

But, it is asked, when revelation and reason now come into conflict over the same, the selfsame actuality, the same, the selfsame facts: what then? Why, then it follows from this that the same actuality must show itself differently, be judged differently, and be assigned a different significance, according as it is seen either in the light of revelation or in the light of reason. That revelation and reason contradict each other [35] is then so far from being a proof either against the religious cognition of truth of revelation or against the scientific cognition of truth of reason, that it is much rather a necessary consequence of the absolute heterogeneity of the principles.

c) The Appropriation of Revelation in Faith.

How entirely exactly revelation and faith correspond to each other is seen expressly from the fact that the concepts themselves, in their reciprocity, are defined by each other. What, indeed, is the revealed? Just that which alone can be apprehended by faith, cognized, preserved, and explained in faith; that whose truth alone can correspond to the truth of faith. And faith? Why, just as sight is determined specifically by the visible, hearing by the audible, thought by the thinkable, so faith must be determined by what the natural sense regards as the incredible, although it is nonetheless, by its nature, precisely what is in truth credible, the only thing that in the most proper and strictest sense of the word can be believed, namely what God himself has revealed. By this fundamental determination every attempt to involve reason in the concerns of religion is cut off once and for all. But by this there is at the same time laid upon the philosophy of religion the demand that it show how the relation between revelation and faith can be developed from the relation to God itself, and thereby open for us an insight into the psychology of faith.

If we consider the two main sides of the relation to God, the divine and the human, each by itself, then the first points specifically to the outward, the latter to the inward, in the miracle of revelation; the opposition between the outward and the inward is here so prominent that it grounds a distinction between the manifest and the hidden miracle.

The relation to God is posited by a divine action; the eternal takes its beginning in time, the supra- historical becomes historical. To reason this is an offensive contradiction, and the contradiction is sharpened to the utmost when the gaze fixes on a fact such as this, that God at a given time has revealed himself in a single human being, a human being in flesh and blood; this human being, who was born, has suffered and has died, is actually to be God! It looks, after all, as though contradiction itself had become incarnate. If the eternal has in this way become historical, then, says the understanding, incited by reason, it has become something that expressly conflicts with its nature, and must therefore have become so “by virtue of the absurd.” — But what is absurd in itself is *eo ipso* what is impossible in itself, and what is impossible in itself cannot be believed. Here, then, a difference must show itself between what is impossible in the thoughts of reason and what is impossible in itself. If the

self-revelation of the eternal in time is actually to belong to what is impossible in itself, then such religious expressions as divine work, divine action, divine will must necessarily be reckoned among what is impossible in itself. One of two: either God is will, and then he can also become incarnate; or God cannot become incarnate, and then he is not will either. The miracle as phenomenon is something outward, but the cause of the phenomenon, the will itself, is something inward. Offense at the outward, at the manifest miracle, is thus an offense at the inward, the hidden miracle, an offense at the absolutely religious presupposition that the almighty will is God, that God's will is free, that God can act.

In the relation to God determined by revelation and faith, the free, almighty action by which God comes to meet the human being is, unconditionally, the first thing. In the vision, in sign and speech, the communication takes place immediately. This vision, this sign, this word is addressed not to human beings in general but [37] to this determinate human being, concerns not human affairs in general but this or these determinate affairs: revelation comes from infinity like a lightning bolt that strikes down into the finite. The vision, the sign, the word, this supernatural thing, takes place by an immediate breaking-through of the natural; the miracle is manifest, and the emphasis falls on the outward. The faith that immediately appropriates such an outward revelation must, according to rational psychology, consistently be conceived as superstition. Were the possibility of an outward revelation to be counted as belonging to the reasonable order of things, then, as was stated above, such revelations would surely have to be able to take place at one time just as well as at another, and fall to the lot of one human being just as well as another; but anyone who in the actual concerns of life appeals to visions and revelations is regarded, if not outright as a deliberate deceiver, then at least as a superstitious enthusiast.

If we now turn to the next point, namely the human side of the relation to God, the matter takes on an opposite appearance. The external vanishes with its extraordinary influences; the divine will transforms itself into a universal will, determinable by the Idea of the good and yet supernatural; God withdraws; everything takes place within the believer: the manifest miracle gives way to the hidden one. From the standpoint of rational psychology the verdict on such a state of soul is characteristically pronounced

in Strauss's critique of Schleiermacher's faith in the historical Christ. "As a Christian," says Schleiermacher, "I feel the union of my lower and my higher self-consciousness facilitated, or my piety furthered. This furthering cannot proceed from myself, since, on the contrary, nothing proceeds from me but a stoppage of the religious life." Strauss asks: "How do you know that? You, that is, the modern-Christian I; for the old-fashioned believing I did indeed know it from the same source from which it knew that of itself it knew nothing true, that of itself it could do nothing good: it knew [38] both from its fundamental presupposition, the foreignness of the Spirit to it and its going out from it. But whence does the modern I, which has come to consciousness of itself and has become master of itself, get the means to make such a separation? Concerning something external and accidental, such as a piece of news, a historical notice, I can indeed know that I do not have it from myself but have learned it from others; but here it is a matter of two opposite movements in the innermost depths of the human heart, of which only the one is supposed to have its origin there, while the other has been led into it from without." The religious disposition thus becomes recognizable by "orthodoxy's childish sum, by which man first *per subtractionem* rids himself of all good, in order then *per additionem* to let it flow back to him as a gift of grace." The hidden miracle is the unclear consciousness's own hidden contradiction: such a reflection must consistently dissolve faith and end in unbelief.

Faith is determined by the extremes which, in consequence of the nature of the relation to God, must form between the external and the internal. The external, the divine influence in its immediate particularity, is a necessary condition for awakening the internal; but as external it is only a condition, only a means; the internal and its appropriation is the end. The vision is an external, but the essence of the Almighty an internal; the word that is heard is an external, but the thought in the word, the divine thought, an internal; the command an external, but the will that commands an internal. Now faith differs from superstition in that through the external it grasps and appropriates the internal; and it differs from knowledge in that the internal which it grasps is supernatural, hence an internal that is not determined by its external directly or by virtue of rationally necessary reflection: were faith to engage in objective reflections on essence, it would have to end in unbelief.

[39] Since superstition and unbelief both fall outside faith, they call each other forth reciprocally. Superstition wants sensuous certainty about the supernatural, a sign for every case, an omen for every event, a command of God for every action; it clings to the external. Understanding and reason then readily agree that such representations of the supernatural are unnatural and dishonor the divine. So signs and omens are rejected, and moral actions are brought under moral laws. With the moral laws follows the necessity of the Idea; but the necessity of the Idea is like a cloud that hides the face of God: “God has no will, there is no God”—that is the declaration of unbelief, and this declaration is empty and comfortless. The empty, God-forsaken mind then reaches once more for supernatural presuppositions, wants sensuous certainty once more: unbelief in turn gives birth to superstition, and so on to infinity. From faith as faith, on the other hand, superstition can never be born; for faith converts the outward into its corresponding inward and lives by the Spirit; nor can unbelief ever gain power over faith; for faith has inwardness, and inwardness rests upon supernatural facts, upon free, divine presuppositions that withstand necessity.

If, now, the internal is posited as the originally first, yet in such a way that it is at the same time conditioned by a sublated external, then surely a criterion of truth, an infallible mark of true and false, must be demonstrable in such an internal; this criterion must be determined by the relation between internal and external that corresponds to the principle of revelation. Where, then, is the criterion of truth to be sought? Not in feeling; for when feeling conflicts with feeling, according as moods change, a criterion for feeling is precisely what is needed here². Still less in the

²That the essence of religion cannot be placed exclusively in feeling, even if we take feeling in its substantial universality as the feeling of absolute dependence, Martensen has clearly shown. “When Schleiermacher designated the religious feeling as a feeling of absolute dependence, he thereby, like the mystics, designated piety as a *God-suffering* state, a state in which man in the innermost depths of his heart feels himself touched by the power in which we live, and move, and have our being, a holy pathos in which man feels himself to be the vessel and dwelling of the Godhead. But as this description is reminiscent of mysticism, so it is itself mystical; for it remains in indeterminate twilight *which* this absolute power is on which I feel myself dependent, whether it is the impersonal Absolute, whether it is fate, or whether it is the ethical, the holy, the good power. Only in the last case can the God-suffering state, can the feeling of absolute dependence, also be a liberating and uplifting feeling.” *Den christelige Dogmatik*. Indledning S. 10.

How difficult Schleiermacher finds it to make the distinction between the essence of God and of the world properly recognizable is evident also from what he says (“*Der christliche Glaube*”. Berlin 1835. 1. Bd. S. 169) about “the divided and the undivided unity”; for the unity of the world is indeed divided,

imagination, since the imagination can be moved just as easily by false as by true [40] promptings. Nor does it help to seek the criterion in universal thinking, since the movements of thought can be just as diverse as the principles by which it is moved. The criterion must, according to the nature of the relation, be sought originally in the will.

As a general act of will, faith can be determined from the ground up only by the will itself, namely by the fundamental will. In the fundamental will the innermost in man, the human self, is immediately touched, inspired, and moved by the innermost in God, by the divine Self, by the will of God.

But when the separation of true and false is made dependent upon the will, must it not then become arbitrary? By no means! The will of which we speak here is not the egoistic formal will choosing among finite, instinctive impulses, but the will of [41] the spirit itself, the will of freedom that penetrates all the powers of the mind, all feelings, representations, and thoughts, and gathers up the whole life of the soul, the will by virtue of which the inner man can and must will nothing but his own salvation. The awakening of this will of the spirit is conditioned exclusively by the influence of the divine will; it therefore rests upon a hidden miracle; hence may be seen its relation to historical facts of manifest miracles; it is an internal that, in the sense of faith, reflects its external. The unity of the will of the spirit with feeling, imagination, and thought gives, in the very deepest sense of the word, self-understanding, a self-understanding that rests solely upon an inward understanding with God. For the scientific testing of true and false, the philosophy of reason sets up *the principle of conceptual contradiction*; for the personal testing of true and false—for self-examination before God—the philosophy of religion sets up *the principle of self-contradiction*³.

but, seen from the standpoint of the immanent Absolute, it is nevertheless also undivided, and the impossibility of a feeling of absolute dependence in relation to the world is thus by no means proved.

³By conceptual contradictions we are thinking here not merely of contradictions between purely objective concepts of knowledge, such as a round square, a body falling outside space, etc., but also, and chiefly, of such contradictions as arise from a confusion of religion and science, when (cf. the lectures: Om Hindringer og Betingelser for det aandelige Liv i Nutiden) one draws scientific consequences from religious presuppositions, and religious consequences from scientific presuppositions. Instead of genuine concepts of knowledge and pure concepts of faith one then obtains a series of bastard concepts, all of which are naturally full of contradictions. That a scientific contradiction, moreover, taken formally, can also be conceived as a self-contradiction, and conversely every self-contradiction as a conceptual contradiction, goes without saying, and is stated expressly only to spare “verbal critique”

In self-understanding before God is salvation, in self-contradiction before God is perdition; these are the outermost poles of the life of the spirit; about these two [42] poles, in the inwardness of faith, all feelings, all fear, all hope, all the thoughts of the heart must move. The peculiarity of the relation to God now shows itself in this, that everything is at once so immediate and yet infinitely reflected, so simple and yet, once reflection properly begins, infinitely intricate. Faith is of a childlike nature: what is hidden from the wise and prudent is revealed to babes; but faith is nevertheless first and last of a spiritual nature; its essence is spirit, and “the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God.”

The Word and the Spirit.

§ 4.

But “the deep things of God” are not searched in the Spirit on the same terms as the depths of the Idea in reason; for the Idea of reason is sunk deep in necessity, but in God inwardness is free, infinitely deepened in self-determining. To an unfree internal corresponds an unfree external, and the utterance takes place with necessity; thus essence must necessarily have its appearance, the real ground its existence, the soul its body, etc. The free internal, by contrast, can give itself a true expression only in a free external, and the utterance takes place with freedom. The unfree internal can, under given conditions, be forced forth to revelation in its external; therefore nature can, if we may so put it, have no secrets from a reason that in its researches penetrates ever deeper and always goes further. But the free internal cannot be searched out in this way. That a human being under certain circumstances lets himself be taken by surprise and comes, against his will, to betray his inner self shows only that his freedom is imperfect; for God’s inner being, freedom itself in its inner infinity, no reason, however profound, shall bring to betray itself. What is to be known of God [43] must be revealed by God, revealed in the Word; for the Word is the external of the spirit, the free utterance of the free internal.

the trouble of making formal discoveries where discoveries are superfluous.

a) The Originality of the Word.

The significance of the word for the spirit, the free internal, is seen psychologically in the fact that language is at once both condition and consequence of man's self-consciousness. The liberation of thought into conscious thought, the liberation of the will into determining will, is possible only through language. The liberation is twofold: partly a theoretical one, through the formation of objective concepts and their development into science; partly a practical one, through the inner clarification of everything that belongs in a special sense to the life of the will. Through this twofold liberation the word acquires a twofold significance: a theoretical one, namely as word of knowledge, which speaks of impersonal truth, and a practical one as word of will, to express the truth personally. That the word of will presupposes another and freer opposition between the internal and the external than the word of knowledge is plainly enough evident from facts such as these: he who scientifically establishes a proposition will not demand that anyone should simply believe him on his word, but he demands that every thinking person who is able to follow the proof shall see the thought become manifest in the word, and the internal shine through the external; he, on the other hand, who speaks of his disposition, his free personal inner being, can lay his hand on his heart and expressly demand to be believed on his word, since the internal of which he speaks always has something hidden that cannot possibly be resolved directly into its external. What holds humanly of the spirit of man holds divinely of the Spirit of God. "What man knoweth the things of a man, save the spirit of man which is in him? Even so the things of God knoweth no man, but the Spirit of God."

In the doctrine of the original unity of the Word with God, revelation and reason—one would think—ought easily to be brought into agreement. Speculative knowledge [44] cognizes the necessity of an inner self-objectivation in the Absolute as spirit; such a self-objectivation is possible only by virtue of the Word from eternity, the original Word, the Logos. The Logos is the unity of essence and its revelation in divine thinking, the true identity of reason and the Word. Through the Word reason is God; in reason itself the Word is divine. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God"—this evangelical prologue is then so far from arousing offense

among philosophical thinkers or containing anything objectionable to philosophy that it rather looks like a religious philosopheme, a borrowing from speculative philosophy. And yet this is a great misunderstanding. Reason and revelation are, as far as the principle is concerned, just as much at odds in the doctrine of the Logos as on any other point whatever. The Logos of which philosophy speaks is, if we disregard the figurative and the mystical-symbolic, essentially that which runs through all true science; the Logos doctrine, objectively understood, is the apotheosis of speculation; in the speculative Logos doctrine science glorifies its own principle of reason immanent in the Idea. There is indeed a liberation of the internal here, insofar as the Idea, the internal, is thought through the word and comprehended in the word; but the liberation is only formal. One begins with essence and ends with essence; the self-objectivation of the Idea into spirit cannot rise above the necessity of thought (*libera necessitas*): “man’s knowledge of God is God’s knowledge of himself”; this is the unveiled secret of the word of knowledge, the true meaning of the objectively scientific Logos doctrine.

From the standpoint of revelation the movement of thought is exactly the reverse. Religion too, indeed, presupposes that the result and the presupposition of self-objectivation, God’s eternal freedom in the Spirit through the Word, is grounded [45] in God’s essence and insofar falls under the immanent necessity of divine knowledge itself. But essence, ground, necessity, all categories indispensable for an objective grounding in knowledge, are taken up by the thought of freedom and enter into the will, without its being possible to state the intermediate determinations necessary for the concept of knowledge. Just as the philosophy of reason with its rational Logos doctrine is not able to get from the necessity of the Idea to freedom, so neither is the philosophy of religion with its antirational Logos doctrine able to get from freedom to the necessity of the Idea immanent in God’s essence and exhausting all objective grounds. Nor is that its task; for the task is to bring out, hold fast, and develop the principle of revelation, the divine principle of will: here there is no question of the Word as word of knowledge, but as word of will, the unconditioned word of freedom, the word of faith.

For the word of knowledge freedom is a mystery; for the word of will necessity is. The fundamental unity of freedom with necessity, the conceptual unity of the

word of knowledge and the word of will, is the Word itself; the Word that was in the beginning with God and presupposes revelation. To revelation corresponds mystery; both categories belong essentially to the determination of the free internal. The God of revelation is the God of inwardness, and inwardness is infinitely deep.

In inwardness (*ad intra*) God is revealed to himself through the Word. For reflection the presupposition presents itself thus: the revealed Word is, in reflected immediacy, different from the God who reveals himself in the Word; God as subject has in the Word his inner object; self-deepening is self-objectivation: *the Word is with God*. But the Word could not possibly reveal God's essence to God himself if in its *difference* from God it were not originally one with God; the inner object is essentially itself subject; self-objectivation is self-deepening: *the Word is God*. This sounds speculative, so [46] speculative that it almost looks as though the philosophy of religion were now in real earnest about to penetrate into the ground of inwardness and search the deep things of God. But here is the limit. The features of the Logos doctrine adduced serve precisely to show, not the possibility, but the impossibility of developing any concept of knowledge whatever from the hidden essence of the divine self-objectivation. Questions about the metaphysical Logos-substance, about God's second I in the Logos, etc., betray abundantly the vanity of wanting to make manifest what has not been revealed to men.

The limit between what is revealed only to God in the Word and what God has revealed to men through the Word is a limit of essence, which categorically marks out the Mystery and sublates mysticism. The proposition: the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God, is the irrefutable fundamental principle of free, hidden inwardness, not a proposition of knowledge, but unconditionally a proposition of faith; for "the things of God knoweth no man, but the Spirit of God." The proposition: "God hath revealed them unto us by his Spirit," holds exclusively for believers, and is therefore likewise not a proposition of knowledge, but a proposition of faith. The proposition of faith posits the communication of the Spirit as an act of will, an unconditioned act of freedom, which cannot be checked by any science whatever.

As further proof that what is revealed through the Word is a communication of free inwardness, this too serves: that in the language of religion there is talk of

God's counsels, God's foreordained counsel, predestination, etc.; for such categories as counsel, resolve, and predestination are characteristic, not of necessity, but of freedom, not of the thoughts of knowledge, but of the thoughts of the will. The word [47] of revelation is a word of will and as word of will the object of faith.

b) The Trustworthiness of the Word.

That the word of faith is, by its principle, heterogeneous with the word of knowledge can be seen, when the question concerns the truth communicated through the word, in assurance. From the comparison between religious and scientific assurance we must of course at once exclude that domain of knowledge where an objective grounding leads directly to incontrovertible certainty, and confine ourselves to a consideration of that *cognoscendi genus* which expressly requires a special regard both to the free inner being of the one who communicates and to that of the one who receives, namely the historical. In the assessment of historical reports the opposition between religion and science shows itself chiefly in this, that science, as indicated above, makes trustworthiness depend upon probability, whereas trustworthiness in the religious sense is independent of probability.

"The experience," says Hume, "that a testimony usually agrees with the fact, and the experience that this latter occurs only very rarely, lead to a contest between two arguments, of which the stronger keeps the field, yet in such a way that it loses as much of its strength as the strength of the opposing argument amounts to. If, then, a Cato told me that he had seen a Fabius act rashly, I should have to calculate whether there were more cases in which, the conditions being given, I had seen Fabius do something that approached imprudence, or Cato say something that bordered—not exactly on being a lie, but, what makes it in high degree easier for an erroneous report to be possible, on being an incorrect conception and assessment of what was given: and if one now assumes that the grounds of probability *for* the correctness of the statement are = 1, the grounds *against* = $\frac{9}{10}$, then the statement would indeed keep the right, but would have only the slender surplus of a one-tenth preponderance [48] in probability." But how unreasonable it is to want to transfer such a calculation of probability to the trustworthiness of revealed facts will strike the eye when we

consider that the fundamental presupposition to which all such facts must be traced back, namely the presupposition that God has word and will, that God has spoken to men, that God therefore can actually speak, belongs to the most unreasonable, the most improbable thing that any knower can imagine. To believe the improbable is nevertheless by no means the same as to believe the impossible. The improbable must be believed; the impossible cannot be believed! The possibility of faith is conditioned precisely by a difference in principle between the improbable and the impossible.⁴

The trustworthiness of the Word has been disputed from the standpoint of reason especially with regard to those acts of revelation in which God directly addresses speech to man in such a way that the divine word becomes one with the human. God's speaking to the patriarchs, the Mosaic legislation, the word to the prophets must necessarily appear to reason, striving after concept and insight, as something unreasonable, improbable, indeed impossible. It is not primarily what is said, but that it is said and the manner in which it is said, that arouses offense. As explicable as it is that a human being can speak with a human being, and the thinking human being speak with himself in silence, just so inexplicable is it that a human being should be able either to speak to God or to be spoken to by God. Conversation between God and man, a language through whose words God himself audibly and clearly communicates to man his thoughts and counsel, reason reflecting by the understanding must count among [49] what is inconceivable in itself, the absurd. Were an explanation to be possible, analogies would have to be demonstrable in the universally human life of consciousness, in the sphere of inner experiences; but whatever analogies, whatever inner proclamations of the divine in man, whatever aesthetic, ethical, and intellectual inspirations of the Idea one may appeal to, the likeness dissolves into complete unlikeness. The only analogue that can be applied here is the religious consciousness's own mythical self-duplication, whereby its speaking with itself is transformed into a speaking with God; but this is no analogue, it is the thing itself: the divine communication is mythical, the Word is myth.

These objections of reason, however, are so far from weakening the religious

⁴Even mathematics makes this difference recognizable. Since probability is stated by a quotient of favorable and possible cases, it makes an essential difference whether the quotient is $\frac{0}{a} = 0$ or $\frac{a}{\infty} = 0$; the first denotes impossibility, the latter only an improbability bordering on impossibility.

credibility of the revealed word that the believer, who knows the principle from which they proceed, can find them very reasonable and yet altogether meaningless. What according to its nature must be determined by freedom cannot possibly be derived from necessity. The question of the credibility of the word coincides with the question of the reality of the relation to God: it is the relation to God in its exclusive peculiarity on which the credibility rests.

In his relation to God man has — by God's word and will — become a self in the spiritual and eternal sense; his self-understanding can therefore be grounded only in his understanding of God. But man's understanding of God is possible only in that God himself makes himself understandable to man; and God can make himself understandable to man only through the word. How the word in outward immediacy could sound forth to the elect, of this no explanation is given, nor, by the nature of the case, can any be given. The one thing on which everything turns is the transformation by which the outward, the revealed miracle can become the means and condition [50] for the awakening of the spirit, for the liberation of the inward: the explanation lies in the appropriation. Directly, i.e. in sensuous immediacy, no word, whether in outward or inward revelation, can be held fast by itself as a word of God; such an immediacy conflicts, as already said, with the essence of spirit. The understanding must be reflected in self-understanding, and the reflection is steered by the will. What matters is to will, as the word says, to understand God in the spiritual and eternal sense, to will to become revealed to oneself down to one's innermost being by becoming revealed to God. Expressions such as "God has said", "God says", must in the appropriation be transformed into: "I believe that God has said", "I believe that God says". Only by this transforming can man, in God's word and will, obtain unconditioned, decisive presuppositions for his human word, his human will: the believer must presuppose God's word by himself positing it in faith; the believing presupposing is in this sense a self-positing. Yet neither can this self-positing be held fast immediately. For what is humanly posited by the human word is indeed posited as that which has already beforehand been posited by God in God's word. It is by the positing and transposing of the divine into the human and conversely — immediate in feeling, finite in representation, but infinite in reflection — that man becomes able

to bind his word to God's word, to find his will moved by God's will, and to cognize that secret of the spirit, that the God of the word can speak credible words, that in the inwardness of faith there is such a thing as speaking with God.

In what sense the word of revelation can be said to concern man and to make man's understanding of God dependent on his original self-understanding is then seen expressly from the fact that the word with which revelation is completed is not merely a word through a man to men, but a word which, in its fullness of Godhead, its unity with God, is so human that it is one with man, that man is the word itself, and [51] the word man. Here again is a turning point where faith and knowledge, philosophy of religion and rational speculation seem to flow together.

That the doctrine of the Logos belongs to religion just as much as to philosophy has already been shown. In the eternal Logos no finite separation of essence and will, of nature and spirit, can possibly be thought; the Logos, the Word from the beginning, is, as the word of essence and of will, one and the same word. Now if revelation expressly teaches that the Word became flesh, and that the Word which became flesh and dwelt among us is the Word itself, the Word which in the beginning was with God and was God: does it not then follow that the perfect revelation must be assumed precisely to hold fast the unity of essence and will, necessity and freedom, life and light in its divine Word? "In it is life, and the life is the light of man"! But when the word of life is one with the word of light, and the word of faith consequently one with the word of knowledge, is it not then a self-contradiction to wish to separate faith and knowledge as heterogeneous, indeed as absolutely heterogeneous principles?

What is dazzling in this consideration is easily removed. For the principle of knowledge, which keeps to essence, ground and necessity, does not thereby mean to deny freedom; still less does the principle of faith, which keeps to freedom, mean to exclude necessity: faith and knowledge can in general easily agree in admitting an original unity-in-difference of necessity and freedom. But when a development is to take place, when it is a matter of method, when the question of the starting points decisive for cognition presents itself, the principles become heterogeneous. From necessity as starting point there is no way to a complete grounding of freedom, and from freedom as starting point there is no way to a thorough insight into necessity:

[52] both ways lose themselves in the Mystery. The divine word, whose validity is grounded in knowledge, is heterogeneous with the divine-human Word of which revelation speaks. The revealed Word, the Word which became flesh and dwelt among us, is, according to the grounds of knowledge, not credible at all. How indeed could it be credible, when the “assumption of flesh” is in its phenomenon so improbable, in its concept so contradictory! That the word of knowledge must deny the word of revelation is self-evident, since by virtue of the grounds of necessity it must deny the miracle. For that the Word became flesh is a miracle, not one among many miracles, but the miracle itself: the revealed Word is the revealed miracle. According to the grounds of faith, on the other hand, the Word is credible as the miracle; for the grounds of faith are grounds of freedom, and the revealed Word is in the very deepest sense revealed freedom. Contradiction of freedom is self-contradiction in the spirit; doubt of freedom is despair in the spirit. Faith in the revealed Word thus coincides with faith in revealed freedom: only the Spirit of freedom can bear witness to the credibility of the Word.

c) The Witness of the Spirit.

If the principal proposition of the philosophy of religion, that the principles of faith and of knowledge are absolutely heterogeneous, really needs a literary-historical proof, then a more striking one can hardly be given than that which emerges from the dispute for and against the credibility of the word of the Bible. Precisely those narratives on whose credibility the religious consciousness must lay the very greatest weight, because they present phenomena of revelation that are of the most essential significance for the understanding of the relation to God — the narratives, for example, of Paradise and the Fall in the Old Testament, of Christ’s birth and resurrection in the New Testament — precisely these narratives science denies all credibility, and

[53] does so, be it noted, not out of contrariness or ill humor, but by virtue of objective grounds of proof, in all soberness and after the most careful examination. Now in the assessment of historical facts a stronger opposition between two principles can hardly be conceived than when the same narrative which according to the one is declared absolutely credible must according to the other be regarded as altogether incredible.

For a true understanding of the historical foundation of revelation, however, it is not enough that faith free itself from objective science; what is required here is a deeper-going investigation of the relation between the outward and the inward, between the historical and the religious, the vanishing and the abiding, thus an investigation of the relation between the word and the Spirit.

To build one's faith on outward historical testimonies is spiritless; it is, in superstition, to cling to the outward and forget the inward. But to separate one's subjective faith from its objective presuppositions is also spiritless; for if disregard for the historical is to mean disregard for everything outward, then the hidden miracle is only an imagining when the revealed one is denied; and if conceit goes so far that the individual with his inward experiences regards himself as an isolated organ of revelation, then we have fanaticism.

In the Old and the New Testament there occur phenomena of revelation whose peculiarity corresponds so entirely to the notions and ways of thinking of particular ages that the forms of the divine's appearing must seem to be directly adapted to the childlike imagination and power of comprehension of the men of antiquity. Revelation in Holy Scripture is not confined to a proclamation of God's will through the word; it is pictures of the world in great and wondrous strokes that are unrolled before the sight. The events take place in two kingdoms, a natural and a supernatural. The supernatural kingdom is populated with angels, good and evil; here, in opposition to [54] the kingdom of light, is a kingdom of darkness, in which the devil with his demons plays the leading role, etc.: does this whole apparatus now belong to the essence of revelation, is all this taken up into what abides? Here critique is necessary!

But as the principle is, so must the critique be. The critique required here is not a critique of knowledge but a critique of faith: the difference is characteristic. In the first place, the critique of knowledge will lay weight on the outwardly objective in its separation from that part of the content which is assumed to derive from the narrator's subjective conception and presentation; in consequence of this there can then be a question only of the actuality of the natural, for all traits of the supernatural must be set apart by themselves and regarded as unactual. When a narrative from sacred history has thus been dissolved into its component parts, there can naturally

be no talk here of any revealing word: the word of God, which was to inspire the whole, sinks down to a plain narrative, an old legend of greater or lesser ideal value. The critique of knowledge is negative; it denies the word of revelation because it denies its spirit. In contrast to this, the critique of faith, which presupposes that the presentation of a content of the spirit must always and essentially be a work of the spirit, will grasp the narrative according to its inward totality; it will see the inward reflected in the outward, the supernatural in the natural, precisely in such a way that the presentation and what is presented fuse together into one single ideal and yet real actuality, actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit. Thus the word about Paradise is by no means the same as the narrative about Paradise; nor is the word, the word revealed in the Spirit, about Christ's resurrection to be confused with the collective result of all the Gospel narratives. By the word as God's word, emphasis is laid not merely on what is presented, but also on its being presented precisely thus in its fundamental character. That a narrative is to be subjected to a critique of faith will then mean: it is to be grasped in its entirety as the expression of a definite phenomenon of faith that reaches deep into the life of the spirit; and the question now is whether what according to the narrative is referred to an outward revelation can find confirmation in the inward one. The legend of Paradise, for example, is not to be believed as an outward history because it stands in the Bible; but the legend that stands in the Bible is to be believed because all the essential traits in the apparently outward history gather into a total expression of the word of the Spirit, into an inward history to whose validity the Spirit bears witness. Christ's resurrection is not to be believed because the Gospel narratives present it as an actual fact; but the word about the historical, actual and yet supernatural fact is to be believed as a revealed word because in the believer's inward being there is an actual and yet supernatural fact through which the Spirit bears witness to the word.

By putting side by side narratives of unlike kinds one will easily convince oneself of the necessity of critique. For no great acuteness is required to see that the word about Christ's resurrection stresses actuality in a different way from either the word about Paradise or the word about the devil, and yet all of this has its actuality. Now if the critique of faith, with the witness of the Spirit, is not to become arbitrary, it

must necessarily have its corrective. This corrective cannot immediately be placed in the believer's subjective consciousness; for when consciousness is held fast in its immediate state, then the one believes one thing, the other another; the one, for example, believes in the devil and appeals to the witness of the Spirit; the other, on the contrary, does not believe in the devil and likewise appeals to the witness of the Spirit; the one believes in the possibility of an eternal damnation according to the [56] witness of the Spirit; the other asserts its impossibility, naturally also according to the witness of the Spirit: where now is the corrective? In the principle of faith! For the principle of faith is one with the principle of the relation to God, is the Spirit's own principle, and only by virtue of its own principle can the Spirit bear witness.

The Principle of Faith: The Method of the Philosophy of Religion.

§ 5.

Religion is the work of the spirit. But, it is said, science too is surely a work of the spirit: can the spirit then be at strife with itself? We answer: the spirit as the Spirit of truth is not at strife with itself; the strife presupposes that besides the Spirit of truth there must also be a spirit of lies. This spirit of lies is just as powerless in science as in religion; its power is conditioned solely by the fact that the human spirit, in religion as in science, misunderstands and misuses itself. To assure oneself that science and religion belong to opposite spheres of spirit, one need only reflect on the difference in principle that obtains between the *knowing* and the *witnessing* spirit. The more the principle of knowledge prevails in all its rigor, the more unfitting it is to speak of a special witness of the Spirit. The Spirit does not bear witness with our spirit either that the square on the hypotenuse is equal to the sum of the squares on the legs, or that all bodies are heavy, or that Quirinius was not governor in Syria under the Emperor Augustus when the taxing took place. Impersonal truth transforms testimony into a ground of knowledge and is absorbed in the grounding. But with personal truth the case is the reverse; the relation to the Spirit is here not a relation of necessity but unconditionally a relation of freedom: in the relation of freedom the [57] Spirit is witnessing; its witness is in the hidden miracle.

It is easier to misunderstand the witnessing spirit than the knowing one. By grasping religious truth in a spiritless way, the believing consciousness comes to hover between two extremes, according as it places the personal decision chiefly in God's essence or in man's. If the decision is spiritlessly shifted over to the divine side, then the word of revelation is blindly a word of authority: God himself or his representatives must then expressly dictate to those under tutelage what and how much they are to believe; hereby faith sinks down to a passive, immediate acceptance of the articles of faith prescribed by a divine word of power: subjectivity is hollow, the believing soul in itself empty, a *tabula rasa*. If the decision is spiritlessly shifted over to the human side, then faith — whether its inwardness otherwise comes to rest in a mystical twilight of gentle feelings or is goaded in passion into an incessant running of one's head against "the paradox" — becomes a purely subjective matter; it is then more or less indifferent *what* is believed, the whole emphasis is laid on *how* it is believed: the finite, spiritless separation of *What* and *How* then leads to the well-known sophism of subjectivity, that everyone is saved by his faith. In order to draw the extremes mentioned under the principle of faith, and thereby under the witness of the Spirit, we consider separately how the content of faith proceeds subjectively from faith itself, how it is determined objectively by the Confession of Faith, and what then follows from this for the method of the philosophy of religion.

a) Faith and Its Content.

Faith is in the strictest sense determined by the relation to God. In the relation to
 [58] God man's freedom is one with his absolute dependence, and faith, the most decisive act of freedom, is in consequence the essential expression of dependence. In faith nothing can be accepted and nothing taken up except what the believing consciousness itself posits and presupposes: to believe in God is to posit and presuppose God; this is the inwardness of faith, its subjectivity and freedom, that the believer can believe only what faith posits. But when freedom is thus held fast in inward infinity, it is at the same time seen that faith itself and that in which it believes do not let themselves be separated: as faith in God is, so too is the God in whom one believes; the God of faith is, subjectively understood, a production of faith. It is to this side of the matter that

negative critique exclusively keeps; but in doing so it overlooks that the believer's infinite freedom is precisely determined by his absolute dependence. Were the God in whom one believes nothing other than a product of believing subjectivity, then it would quite rightly be the highest of freedom that both God and faith should vanish and man end by relating himself absolutely, through himself, to the Absolute. But this is the secret of faith, that with regard both to the hidden and to the revealed miracle it produces God only in that it is itself produced by God: that faith produces God denotes the infinite freedom, that it is produced by God the absolute dependence. So inwardly pervasive is the dependence that he whose faith is assailed by doubt must ascribe the doubt to himself and pray God for faith. The question of negative critique: whence do you know, you modern I, that all the good, all holy powers, all purity in the soul, all the love of the spirit and all its hope come from God, and only the evil, the weakness, the impurity, the selfishness from yourself? can then be rewritten thus: whence do you know, you modern I, even yet what faith is and what it is to believe, since the critique that dissolves faith does not know it?

What holds in the relation to God of the divine Self holds also of the human self. The [59] self which through faith is set in relation to God is not what religion calls "the sensuous man" (ἄνθρωπος ψυχικός), for "the sensuous man grasps not the things that belong to the Spirit of God": the sensuous man does not know what faith is and cannot believe. The self which in faith produces God is the spiritual self, the self which precisely through its relation to God is produced by God, and therefore infinitely needs God. The self that functions in knowledge has the certainty of knowledge and possesses itself knowingly; but the self that functions in faith has only the certainty of faith and possesses itself only believingly. By functioning in two absolutely heterogeneous systems of cognition, the one and the same human self becomes a double self, a knowing and a believing one. But the doubling is no self-division; it is a movement about two different centers, that of the necessity of the Idea and that of freedom; it would be self-division only if the content of truth that is to be sought in the one of the two spheres were also to be sought in the other.

Now in order to see more closely how the content of faith develops in and with faith itself, we fix our attention on the changes the relation to God undergoes as

revelation step by step assumes its three fundamental forms. It is self-evident that the development takes place by virtue of the principle of faith, and that the intellectual grounding must be turned against reason, thus inverted.

At the first stage of revelation the relation to God is to be characterized by the fact that the opposition between God and man is stressed abstractly as an opposition between Creator and creature. The Creator has to command, the creature to obey; that is the condition of the spirit. With the relation to God begins man's self-contradiction. [60] He cognizes that God is holy and his will righteous; he cognizes himself bound to unconditional obedience. But the spiritual man, the believing self that grants that God is right, is essentially different from the natural man, whose selfish will, bound by drives, does not grant that God is right; here are two men in one man, or rather: the one and the same man has from the ground up become divided against himself: this is the self-contradiction, and the self-contradiction is the negative mark of the relation to God. The immediate cognition of the self-contradiction, which is involuntarily felt as a contradiction against God, a violation of his holiness, is the cognition of sin. Faith as faith does not abolish the self-contradiction. On the contrary! The self-contradiction, and with it the cognition of sin, increases the more living and inward faith is. In the determination of man's essence one sees rightly how different the explanation of faith is from that of reason.

The man divided against himself reason must expressly refer to the universal human essence that holds in individuals; the contradiction between the spiritual and the sensuous man is a contradiction of concepts, which is to be resolved by bringing the necessary fundamental unity of human nature to clear consciousness. By virtue of the fundamental unity, the lower elements in man's nature must then be regarded as the spiritual life's own necessary presuppositions: drives, inclinations and passions are natural elements of reason; they are rational in their disposition, inasmuch as they are destined to be mastered by the rational will that cognizes itself as the universal and the universal as itself; the contradiction then comes about in that the sensuously individual, the lower, opposes itself to the higher, the universal of cognition, which alone ought to determine the rational will. The consciousness of the contradiction that obtains — a consciousness of the strife between the actual man and his ideal —

can now indeed in a certain sense be called a consciousness of sin, insofar as it is a consciousness that the ideal, the holy, has been violated: conscience, the involuntary rising up of the ideal nature against the encroachment of the selfish, shows this clearly enough. But this self-contradiction lying in the consciousness of sin dissolves and vanishes in proportion as the contradiction between the lower and the higher dissolves into an ever clearer, ever purer and stronger self-assurance of the inner harmony and fundamental unity of human nature. Without sin man, immediately regarded, cannot be, for sin and strife indeed arise precisely from natural immediacy, the particular selfishness which again and again would draw the individual away from what is in itself rational, from what is universally valid and necessary in self-consciousness. But once the essence of sin has in this way been seen through, the self-conscious man has taken sin upon himself, has essentially and from the ground up himself sublated sin, in that he has resolved to strive and suffer for the right of the ideal, has found and posited the ideal good in his own self, has thereby come to himself, is in truth reconciled with himself, and can by this reconciliation accomplish his own self-liberation, his true redemption.

But what is the consequence of this rational explanation? That revelation vanishes, that the divine will vanishes, that faith ceases to be a principle!

When the divine will vanishes, the principle of will ceases to hold unconditionally, and freedom perishes in a necessity developed into its concept. Instead of letting the self-contradiction fade away in an objective, scientific resolution of objective contradictions, faith lays redoubled weight on sin as sin and drives the self-contradiction to the extreme. The whole emphasis is laid on the divine will; only God is free in an eternal, unconditioned, blessed sense: only the eternally free God can and will set man free — yet, be it noted, on the condition, the inviolable stipulation of the Spirit, that man both can and will, in faith in God, do God's will. This man can now do in faith, and yet cannot; this man now wills in faith, and yet does not will it; this self-contradiction man understands in faith, and yet does not understand it: faith as faith testifies as loudly to the latter as to the former. If, then, the self-contradiction, so understood, is posited by a revelation, it follows that it can also be resolved only by a revelation.

What is characteristic of the second stage of revelation is that a new man enters into the relation to God; this, then, is the inviolable fundamental condition under which alone the self-contradiction can be resolved. In the eyes of reason the condition looks like an enormous contradiction. The new man is not an abstract ideal but a man in flesh and blood, an actual man. And yet this man is to differ from all other actual men in this, that he does God's will in each and every thing, that he is from birth pure and without sin; but an actual man without sin, what is that but an empty notion? According to the rational explanation, sin belongs so necessarily to the nature of man that only a fancy inflamed by ideal longings can form for itself an exemplar in whom there is no sin, and take this abstraction of the imagination for a sinless, an actual man. It is evident here how little reason is able to grasp the mystery of sin. If sin necessarily belongs to actual human nature, then by that very fact it must cease to be sin; it can then at most be only an imperfection. The imperfection necessary by nature can, under given conditions, become the occasion of transgression, guilt, crime; but sin in the proper sense it cannot be. For what is sin in the proper sense, if it is not the consciousness of the innermost contradiction of the self, the incomprehensible [63] self-contradiction that man both can and yet cannot do God's will? That sin must be a sickness in man's nature is recognizable from its being a sickness in the will.

By virtue of the principle of will, faith now reasons thus: if the sick human nature can exist, then the healthy must be able to all the more; if the old man is actual, the new must be so still more.

The new man, who in all things does God's will, is the object of faith, the exemplar of believers, but not himself a believer: this too gives offense. That the healthy one, it is said, is an exemplar for the sick is explicable, inasmuch as everyone who feels himself sick must reasonably wish to become like the healthy one; but that the exemplar for believers is not himself a believer, how can that be? We see it in the following way. There is in faith an approximation to absolute personal certainty, but the approximation is infinite; the limit, perfect assurance, faith can never reach, for when the limit is reached, faith is abolished. If, then, it lies in the nature of faith to strive toward sublating itself, it will be understandable from this that the exemplar for believers is not a believer but one who knows — not one who knows scientifically, but

one who knows personally. In order to be able to do God's will unconditionally, the exemplar must know God's will, must in every moment of life and on every occasion have an absolutely infallible certainty of what it is God wills; but such an infallible certainty points to a peculiar relation to God.

In the believer's relation to God, sin is an outstanding account between them; the nearer a man comes to God, the more immediately he feels sin. The consciousness of sin, which is a sign of the drawing near, is then at the same time an expression of the distance; the believer who becomes conscious of God's holy presence becomes by that very fact conscious of his distance, i.e. of his infinite difference from God in will and essence: it is sin that sets discord between man's self-consciousness and his God-consciousness. From the new man's relation to God sin is excluded; herein lies that the exemplar's human will must essentially and fundamentally be one with God's will. The exemplar's consciousness of himself is identical with his God-consciousness in the sense that he knows personally his essence to be the revelation of God's essence, his will the revelation of God's will: sin is taken away, and the relation to God posited in absolutely original purity. God is now revealed to men not merely through a man but as a man, as this man; not merely through the Word but as the Word itself, the Word that was in the beginning. [64]

The perfect man in divine self-certainty is absolutely different from all other men. Just as through sin a yawning abyss is set between God and men in general, so now, after the difference between the sick and the healthy one, between the sinful and the sinless one, has become manifest, a yawning abyss is in particular set between believers and the exemplar. The separation is here all the harsher, as it is now placed within human nature itself. That the exemplar is actual is seen from this, that he actually sacrifices himself, suffers, is crucified and dies; that the actual exemplar, by doing God's will, reveals God himself is seen from this, that, having suffered for the truth and given his life for righteousness, he rises from the dead and enters into glory. The believer cannot without self-contradiction give up such an exemplar, but neither can he without self-contradiction think of imitating such an exemplar: how is this contradiction to be resolved? The healthy one must heal the sick, the sinless one must come to the help of the sinful: revelation must, if the principle of will is not to be

given up and the whole end in meaninglessness, assume a new fundamental form.

[65] Only at its third stage is revelation completed; its distinguishing mark is completion itself: in completion it shows what it originally is, what it was from the beginning and will continue to be, a proclamation of will in the Word, a communication of freedom from spirit to spirit. How inwardly the Word of faith, the Spirit of faith, and faith itself are united in the principle may be briefly elucidated.

At the first stage of revelation the Word is still one-sided: it is a word from God to men about divine and human things; but the Word from God is not yet itself God, the Word to men not yet itself man. In a corresponding way the Spirit is one-sided. It is the Spirit from God that awakens the spirit in man; but the Spirit from God, “the power of God”, is not itself God; the Spirit over man works in man, but does not yet allow itself to be grasped as man’s proper self. Moved by the Spirit, man believes in God’s Word, cognizes his sin, and acknowledges that God is in the right. Forsaken by the Spirit, man is seized by doubt and, in despair at not being able to come to terms with the God of the Spirit, rebels against God. Then the Spirit returns, chastises man and brings him once more to cognize his sin. The movement from sin through sin to sin is essentially the circular movement in which the life of faith repentantly maintains itself; this circular movement takes up breakthroughs of hopeful bright moments, blessed understanding, tried faith and fulfilled promise as intermediate states, through which the educating Spirit of wrath and mercy leads its believers to an ever deeper cognition of sin. At the second stage the Word is present as God and actual as man. In this actual divine-human presence the Spirit is personally one with the Word. But the Word has become flesh; the inward of revelation coincides immediately, for the believing view, with its outward. He in whom “all the fullness of the Godhead dwells bodily”

[66] stands, for those who behold him and listen to his words, as the one who alone has the Spirit abiding in himself. The Spirit is in believers as if it were outside them; if it were not in them, they could not believe, and if it did not outwardly come to meet them, they could not make the exemplar the object of faith. But the Spirit as spirit cannot immediately be an object: the outward must be transfigured into its inward; therefore the exemplar, the Word revealed in the flesh, goes away, that the transfiguration may come. In the outward revelation the Spirit was personally one with the Word; in the

inward, therefore, the Spirit comes personally to believers by means of the Word. The coming of the Spirit is not an immanent metaphysical alteration of consciousness, but a divine act of will, a holy fact, whereby the outward miracle converts itself into the inward: the Spirit comes as “Holy Spirit”, as God himself, to stir and work in believing souls. In the new man the Spirit was personal; the new man went away in the outward, but in order to come again in the inward. Now the resolution of the self-contradiction can be accomplished. The self-contradiction is that the believing man is a double man, a sensuous one who cannot believe and a spiritual one who lives in faith. So long as the self is, so to speak, ambiguously divided between the two, so that it is continually drawn to both sides, man in his hovering unity of consciousness is a “wretched man”. Now, on the other hand, after the Spirit has come with the new man, and the unity of consciousness has been expressly posited in the spiritual self, the self that, though human, yet becomes and is transformed into unity with the divine, in the measure that the believer himself becomes and is transformed into likeness with the exemplar, the self-contradiction will vanish.

From these features it can provisionally be seen that the content of faith develops in and with faith.

[67]

b) The Confession of Faith.

The spirit in science, the knowing spirit, demands cognition but not confession; the witnessing Spirit of revelation, on the other hand, requires both cognition and confession. In laying emphasis on testimony and confession we lay precisely the emphasis of freedom on the personal. Confession too shows how categorically the outward corresponds to the inward. When the exemplar, or, to put it now plainly historically, when Christ had gone away and the Spirit had been poured out upon the apostles, they began to speak to the people about what had happened. Their speech was at once a testimony and a confession; a testimony inasmuch as they personally — even at the risk of their lives — explained and confirmed what they had heard and seen; a confession inasmuch as the confirmation was not placed in objectively universally valid proofs, but in a voluntary utterance, prepared for scorn and opposition, of what stirred within them. The apostles did not testify of themselves

but of Christ; the community whose founding they prepared was not to believe in them but, through their word, in Christ, was with them to confess Christ. But to confess Christ is impossible without knowing something about him and acknowledging him as something: for cognition in faith a confession of faith is expressly required.

The word in the Confession of Faith is not merely a word saying that a revelation has taken place, but the word of revelation itself, the word on which the life of the congregation is built, the word in which Christ still continues to reveal himself personally to each individual in particular who will enter the congregation.

The Confession of Faith presents what has been revealed in pure fundamental features; every article, every word has decisive determinacy and acts with divine [68] authority; the relation between Christ and the believer which is thereby founded is, in an eternal sense, a relation of selfhood, a relation of self to self. The question: whence is the Confession of Faith, and who prescribed it? is a question of life for the congregation. The question is historical; but there is a difference between the history of revelation and all other history: historical-critical inquiries into the origin of the Confession of Faith acquire religious significance only insofar as they are guided by the principle of faith. In this connection too it holds that historical actuality, seen in the light of revelation, is actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit.

If the matter is taken outwardly, it must seem a spiritless quarrel to want to wrangle over the historical origin of the Apostolic Confession of Faith: whether it was composed by the Apostolic Fathers or by the apostles or expressly prescribed by Christ himself; and equally spiritless is it to idolize an old formula to such a degree that, with a care as scrupulous as though it were a matter of salvation, one searches and searches in order to find out by written testimonies whether in all its several articles and parts, down to jot and letter, in all congregations and all translations through all centuries, it has remained unaltered. But why, indeed, is the quarrel spiritless, unless because one overlooks the Spirit, and overlooks the Spirit because one overlooks the principle.

In consequence of the principle the question must run: what does he believe and confess who believes and confesses that it is the teachers of the Church — the Apostolic Fathers or the oldest Fathers of the Church — who with the authority of the Spirit composed the original articles of faith and prescribed them to the congregation

for inviolable acceptance? And the answer runs: he believes and confesses that the priests of the Church are the spiritual lords of the congregation, and that Roman Catholicism is the only consistent ecclesiastical system. Further: what does he believe and confess who believes and confesses that the apostles, with the infallibility which [69] inspiration exclusively assured to them, gave the Confession of Faith that bears their name its literal expression and thereby founded the first congregations? The answer runs: he believes and confesses that the Spirit itself has raised a dividing wall, an insurmountable barrier between Christ and his congregation; for he believes and confesses that the apostles, by their exclusive inspiration, stand as mediators and middlemen between the congregation and Christ, so that the way to Christ goes, not through the Word of the present Christ himself, but, on account of his temporary absence, solely through the apostolic word. Finally: what does he believe and confess who believes and confesses that it is Christ himself who, as well through the apostles as through the spokesmen of the congregation in all subsequent times, utters the words of the Confession of Faith, so that in invisible yet living presence he reveals himself, not mediately and impersonally through the words of others, but immediately and personally through his own Word, the Word with which, in his own divine-human personality, he speaks to each one in particular who will hear him, invites each one who will come to him, accept his terms and make a covenant with him? The answer runs: he believes and confesses what, by virtue of the eternal principle of faith and confession, alone can be believed and confessed.

With the different points of view regarding the originality of the Confession of Faith there naturally follows a correspondingly different conception of the form and content of the confession. The *Catholic* view, which puts the priestly word on a level with the apostolic word, can — even if, following the legend, one has each of the twelve apostles insert his article and so produce the confession pieced together from twelve articles — regard the apostolic articles only as the first dogmatic draft, to which the whole series of dogmatic determinations and symbols owed to the infallibility of the councils and the popes attaches itself with equally indisputable authority. The [70] *Protestant* view, which, as regards infallibility, either breaks off with the apostolic age or, for the sake of catholicity, concedes to the oldest ecumenical councils, as

also to the age of the Reformation, a symbol-forming authority, but otherwise makes Holy Scripture the source, norm and touchstone (*lapis lydius*), must on the whole regard all confessions of faith and symbols as compendia of the doctrine of Scripture, so that only the word of the Bible and its right interpretation properly furnish the infallible, sufficiently comprehensive foundation on which the congregation can build its faith. Common to pope-believing Catholicism and Bible-believing Protestantism is the fundamental view that Christianity is a factual, juridical, objective doctrine, and faith the subjective acceptance of this doctrine.

If the Confession of Faith is considered from the point of view of an objectively juridical contract of doctrine, then there are certainly essential objections to be made against both content and form. The Apostolic Confession of Faith is a far too small dogmatics. Why keep exclusively to just these expressions, these formulas, when it is after all well known that many chief doctrines are not even touched upon in this extract? "As the Apostolic Symbol, historically considered, is a post-apostolic product, so too, by its whole inner character, it is insufficient to be the highest *critical* norm in the Church. Every one of its words would be unintelligible if we did not have a richer source to resort to in order to explain them. Hence we find, too, that the Fathers of the first three centuries never detached tradition from Scripture, and Irenaeus, so often appealed to for the rule of faith, himself calls Scripture *columna et fundamentum ecclesiae*. It is clear, too, that without Scripture we would be but poorly supported by the Apostolic Symbol. Although it is the baptismal symbol, it gives us not the slightest information about the sacramental significance of baptism; and with the complete [71] confession of the Apostolic Symbol a conception of baptism can very well be combined which sees in this sacrament a merely symbolic ceremony. Just as little does it give any information about the Lord's Supper. The same holds of the important doctrine of justification by faith, a doctrine whose fundamental significance surely no one among us has the courage to dispute. Even the doctrine of the person of Christ is set forth so indeterminately that both Arians and Socinians have been able to profess the words of the Symbol, as indeed the Socinians continually appealed to their agreement with the Apostolic Symbol in order thereby to legitimate themselves as good Christians".⁵

⁵Den christelige Dogmatik af Dr. H. Martensen. S. 43–44.

But the way of viewing the matter changes when the principle of faith is held fast and carried through. As regards, first, the assertion that the Apostolic Symbol, historically considered, is supposed to be a post-apostolic product, it will, by the nature of the case, be just as impossible to produce a positive historical proof of this as it will be impossible, from written testimonies, to produce a historically positive proof that the Symbol is word for word from Christ. The word of the Confession of Faith is what Grundtvig calls “a living word”, the word of life “from the Lord’s own mouth”. Oral tradition “is the way of the Word, a living stream from Christ through the apostles to the congregation”. To demand written testimonies for what is to be sought only in oral tradition is a contradiction; and to bring proof against an oral tradition by adducing the lack of written documents is likewise a contradiction. Both contradictions coincide in the one: *to want to build one’s religious faith on objective historical knowledge*⁶. If we seek the vital nerve of the Grundtvigian view, it must [72] unconditionally be placed in this, that faith in the Confession of Faith coincides in

⁶The impossibility of “building one’s blessedness” on objective certainty about anything whatever objectively historical S. Kierkegaard has strikingly shown in the first part of “Afsluttende uvidenskabelig Efterskrift”, where he treats the objective problem of the truth of Christianity. “Those who build on Scripture have in this respect no greater security than those who build on the Confession of Faith”. “When Scripture is regarded as the secure stronghold that decides what is Christian and what is not, then the task is to secure Scripture historically-critically. One then treats here of the several writings’ belonging to the canon, their authenticity, integrity, the authors’ axiomaticity, and one places a dogmatic guarantee in inspiration. When one sees the English at work on the Tunnel: the enormous exertion of force, and how then a small accident can for a long time disturb the whole — then one gets a fitting notion of this whole critical undertaking. What time, what diligence, what glorious talents, what distinguished learning have here from generation to generation been requisitioned for this marvel. And yet here a little dialectical doubt that touches the presuppositions can suddenly, for a long time, disturb the whole, disturb the underground way to Christianity that one has wanted to construct objectively and scientifically, instead of letting the problem come to be as it is: subjectively”. . . . “This”, he concedes, “Grundtvig had rightly seen, that the Bible could not possibly hold out against the intruding doubt”; but then he does Grundtvig an injustice when, misunderstanding the Grundtvigian talk of the historical, he supposes that Grundtvig too wants to have objective security beforehand, before he can believe subjectively. The historical of which Grundtvig speaks is not an outward objective to which a subjective can then without further ado be added, but the living unity of subjective and objective, thus, in the language of reflection, precisely the unity of principle. Characteristic in this respect, too, is that while S. Kierkegaard reproaches Grundtvig for taking the historical as objective, his other opponents reproach him, on the contrary, for taking it as subjective. The fact is that S. Kierkegaard, as Martensen has quite rightly felt but from his standpoint could not counteract, has, for all his dialectic, run aground in subjectivism: he has, as no one else, brought it to evidence that subjectivity in the believer is the truth, but, with his gaze incessantly fixed on the believer, has overlooked that faith has its intellectual principle, that this principle is one with the principle of revelation itself, and that the principle of revelation is just as originally objective as subjective.

principle with faith in its origin from the object of faith, thus with faith in the Christ personally present in the words of the confession.

- [73] That the Apostolic Symbol, regarded as a sum of objective doctrinal propositions, cannot be “critical norm in the Church” must be conceded; but that Holy Scripture, regarded as a document of revelation in the historically objective sense, cannot be critical norm either must surely also be conceded, in view of the phenomena of spirit that the controversies of centuries have brought to light. Or have Arians and Socinians perhaps not been able, for their one-sided doctrine of the person of Christ, to profess the words of Scripture just as easily as those of the Symbol? The indispensability of Holy Scripture for the development of doctrine surely no one will call into doubt; but the point is that the objectivity of knowledge can be reached just as little by means of Scripture as by means of the Symbol. In the feeling that what is objective for faith is essentially different from what is objective in knowledge, one indeed also demands expressly that the word of Scripture be taken up with a believing mind, that in the interpretation of Scripture a Christian consciousness must necessarily be presupposed. But the believing, Christian mind, the Christian consciousness, cannot be critical norm either; for, not to speak of each individual among believers having his own mind, every community of faith has its Christian consciousness, and this consciousness is in turn different at different times. It is of no help to refer the one who seeks a critical norm from the Symbol to Scripture, from Scripture to consciousness, from consciousness, by way of tradition and the impression of typically given differences in existing church communities, back again to Scripture: for where is the center, the point of departure, the point of conclusion, where is the corrective? It is, one says, the total
- [74] impression, which must be made clear through determinations of the particular, while the particular is in turn determined by the total: in totality the subjective coincides with the objective, in the total impression we have the testimony of the Spirit. But if the whole is now not to go round in circles before one’s eyes, and the total impression become just as indeterminable as the Spirit, and the Spirit in turn just as indeterminable as the total impression: then there must be in all this a principle: the principle is Christ himself, the Word from the beginning.

From the principle everything must be derived, by it everything must be deter-

mined, to it everything must be led back. The principle is not a confession of faith, but it bears the Confession of Faith and has in it its short, clear, pithy expression. The principle is not a holy Scripture, but it runs through the holy Scripture and furnishes the critical norm according to which Scripture must be interpreted. The principle is not a Christian consciousness, neither the individual's nor the community's; but it moves and determines the Christian consciousness, and consciousness must bow beneath it and let itself be corrected by it. Only gradually, as the various communities of faith learn to direct their faith by the principle of faith, and not the principle of faith by the diversity of the confessions, will religious life win self-conscious unity, form and shape.

c) The Method of the Philosophy of Religion.

That the content of the philosophy of religion must essentially be the content of faith is self-evident; but the content of faith is originally a content of life, and its forms are peculiar forms of life; whereas the philosophy of religion is able to develop the content only through intellectual forms: the question then is how the intellectual forms relate to the forms of life. This question, which has already been touched on, if from another side, at the beginning of the Introduction, is now at its close to be answered by a statement of the method of the philosophy of religion. [75]

The philosophy of religion cannot build immediately on any confession of faith; for the form of the Confession of Faith is a form of life, intended for the living congregation; but it can and ought to develop the concept of faith and thereby state intellectually its categorical significance for the life of the congregation. In the intellectual form the religious concepts are, one and all, concepts of confession, that is to say: concepts whose validity is personally decided by confession.

The three principal concepts of revelation, *the Father, the Son and the Spirit*, are not concepts of knowledge but concepts of faith, immediate concepts of confession. The philosophy of religion, which finds such concepts of confession present in the congregation, then has the task of translating them into the intellectual form and, by virtue of the principle, of developing them to clarity and full transparency. The clarity to which the religious concepts can be developed depends methodically on

the certainty with which the separation of the two spheres of cognition, that of faith and that of knowledge, is maintained, and on the deduction and grounding which is determined exclusively by the relation to God. God's essence in itself the philosophy of religion cannot clarify, for "God dwelleth in the light which no man can approach unto"; but God's essence reflected in and through the relation to God (the relation to men) it ought to strive to clarify, for in the revealed relation to God no ambiguity can be thought.

The relation to God is, as we have already seen, a relation of will; the philosophy of religion, as philosophy of will, is absolutely heterogeneous with the philosophy of reason, the philosophy of essence necessitated by the Idea. But cognition of will does not exclude cognition of essence. Now since will always presupposes essence, and essence in the highest sense is will, it is seen from this that the opposition of the principles must rest exclusively on the method. Just as the philosophy of essence everywhere [76] proceeds from essence and through everything returns to it, so the philosophy of will, in all problems, proceeds from will and returns to will. The same holds of the opposition between conceptual contradiction and self-contradiction; this opposition likewise gains its significance solely through the method. Seen *in abstracto*, any conceptual contradiction can easily be presented as a self-contradiction, and conversely; but according to the methodical separation between the two regions, the principle of self-contradiction becomes decisive for faith, that of conceptual contradiction for knowledge. Where, then, there is a choice between one of two things, either to place the corrective in the conceptual contradiction without heeding the self-contradiction, or conversely, there the necessity of a methodical orientation shows itself. If a problem is solved in such a way that the conceptual contradiction, contradiction in the objective sense, is normative, while the self-contradiction recedes and loses itself in the Mystery, then the solution belongs to science; if, conversely, a problem is solved in such a way that what is normative lies in the self-contradiction, contradiction in the subjective sense, while the conceptual contradiction is resolved only by a resolution into the Mystery, then the solution belongs to religion.

Only in the method can the opposition between rational and antirational, between direct and inverted grounding, find its application and its proper significance. We

illustrate this by some examples. There are found in “the Christian Dogmatics” numerous statements of which we may say that in and for themselves they could be both true and untrue, so that their truth or untruth depends solely and entirely on the grounding.

It is said of creation: “The world has a double beginning, a cosmogonic and a creative, a natural and a supernatural. — The world must therefore in every moment of its existence be regarded as *natura* or as organic self-development, and as *creatura* or as progressive revelation of the divine *will*, and it is the one only because it is the other.” This statement is ambiguous insofar as there is presupposed in human knowledge a point of unity in which the two dissimilar concepts, creation and nature, find their grounding equally. Such a point of unity is not given. Between creation and nature lies a dark, unfathomable deep; here lies the Mystery. The concept of creation is originally a concept of faith, an unconditioned concept of will, and as a concept of will it cannot possibly furnish the basis for a rational development of the concept of nature. The concept of nature is originally a concept of knowledge, a concept of necessity resting in the Idea as Idea, and as a concept of necessity it cannot possibly furnish the basis for the antirational development that belongs to the concept of creation. [77]

It is said of the Son: “As the Mediator between the Father and the world it belongs to the Son not only to live his life in the Father, but also in the world. As ‘the heart of God the Father’ he is at the same time the eternal ‘heart of the world,’ through which the divine life streams into the creation. As the Logos of the Father he is at the same time the eternal world-Logos, through which the divine light streams into the creation. He is the ground and source of all reason in the creation, be it in man or angel, in Greek or Jew.” This statement is ambiguous insofar as it is presupposed that from a cognition of faith of the Logos, supernatural in God and as God, there could be given a direct transition, necessary to reason, to a cognition of knowledge of the natural world-reason immanent in things themselves. Such a transition is not given. Between the Logos in revelation and reason in the world lies the Mystery, the great riddle of the world, in which the actual reciprocal determinations of freedom and necessity are hidden from the eye of man.

It is said of the Spirit: “The Holy Spirit is distinguished from all world-spirits not

[78] only by the fact that all world- spirits are shut up under sin, but also by the fact that the world-spirits, according to their original determination, pursue wholly other ends. The cosmic spirits, be they the spirits of peoples or the spirits of the state, be they the spirits of art or the spirits of science, have only the end of founding and spreading their *kingdom*, while human *individuals* count with them chiefly as mere means to this end. The Holy Spirit, on the other hand, will create a kingdom of sanctified, of blessed *individuals*; its end is the salvation of the soul.” This statement certainly gives the impression of being both clear and true, so long as we consider it in general without asking about the grounding. But when the question of the grounding is methodically set in motion: how does the statement look then? Is it really true — and it is indeed really true — that “the world-spirits,” to which “the spirits of science” also belong, according to their original, mark well: their original determination, pursue wholly other ends than “the Holy Spirit,” ends so opposed to those of the Holy Spirit as are the making of human individuals into means for an objective, impersonal kingdom, and the creating of a kingdom of sanctified, of blessed individuals, hence a kingdom personal in the eternal sense: then it is indeed hereby stated that “the Holy Spirit is not merely something different from, but heterogeneous — absolutely heterogeneous with the world-spirits, heterogeneous — absolutely heterogeneous with ‘the spirits of science.’” But when a content of the Spirit is to be methodically developed, then the proposition holds irrefutably: as the spirit is, so must the principle of development be; and as the principle of development is, so must the grounding be.

If it is held fast unconditionally that the relation to God is a relation of will, then a methodical separation of the philosophy of reason and the philosophy of religion can never be avoided. We see this from the doctrine of the Trinity. The development of
 [79] this doctrine in the philosophy of religion must correspond exactly to a development of the relation to God as determined by revelation; by departing from this principle, by wishing to regard God as God in objective relations, partly inwardly in the eternal deep, partly outwardly in interaction with nature and the life of the world, one comes at once outside the boundary of faith, is dazzled by science and goes astray in speculation. Within the categorically determined boundary of faith, on the other hand, it will become apparent that God’s relation to man also sheds a light on his relation to

himself, that the relation of will gives a mirroring of the relation of essence, and that it is precisely a methodical misreading of the reflection of essence in the revelation of will that has occasioned so many broodings and confused so many heads.

In the relation to God we have three terms: God in his relation to man, man in his relation to God, and the world, the actual middle term between God and man. Now insofar as each of the terms of the relation can be illuminated by the whole relation, the manifoldly nuanced relation of will in which God, through the world, relates himself to man may well be able to cast an illumination back upon God's inner essence. But the main thing is that the principle of will is and remains the decisive one.

In the doctrine of the Father, God is conceived as the author of all existence, as the being on whose will all things are absolutely dependent. It is the opposition between God in himself and all else that is not God on which the emphasis falls. Now if this opposition is considered objectively in general, conceptual propositions arise of which it is not easy to say whether they have their origin from religion or from speculation. That God in himself cannot with full freedom have the world for his opposite unless he thereby at the same time has himself for his opposite must be granted. The divine self-consciousness requires not only its own I but also its own [80] Thou, and can be thought to objectify its world only in such a way that therein it at the same time objectifies itself. Now if God's objectification of the world has his own self-objectification as its presupposition, then it follows quite correctly from this that God's free, conscious unity with himself must be an inner, infinite unity of opposition, a unity developed in spirit as spirit. The proposition: *God is spirit*, can to that extent, in a formal respect, very well be developed into the proposition: *the divine essence is trinitarian*.

But is this, then, the religious Trinity of the Confession of Faith? To make each of the three moments in the concept of God's self-objectification into a person by itself, the divine I into the Father, the divine Thou into the Son, and the divine unity of both into the Holy Spirit — what is that but an unclear confusion of subjective representations with objective concepts, a personification of universal forms of essence, of which one may with reason say that the images belong to faith, but the thoughts

are borrowed from knowledge: the voice is Jacob's voice, but the hands are the hands of Esau.

If the unclarity is to be removed, it must be removed methodically. Faith in the triune God is of a wholly different origin and has a wholly different character from the objectively metaphysical doctrine of the Trinity. The religious concept of the Trinity is a concept of faith, to be determined expressly by the moments contained in the revealed relation to God: the principle of faith is itself a principle of the Trinity. Herein lies this: that no moment in this concept can gain significance for doctrine if it does not prove to have significance for life. Could anyone show that a faith in the only true God, with all the demands, presuppositions and consequences contained in the essence of faith, were possible without faith in the triune God, then the doctrine [81] of the Trinity would once and for all have to be regarded as abolished. But if now the converse holds, that faith in the true God, when the relation to God is developed on all sides to full clarity, is and must be one with faith in the triune God: then the doctrine of the Trinity is typical of the method of the philosophy of religion. To forestall a confusion of scientific and religious objectivity, we therefore take the *doctrine* of the Trinity expressly in the sense of *faith* in the Trinity, and state the division of the philosophy of religion as: *Faith in the Father, Faith in the Son and Faith in the Spirit*.

[82]

Faith in the Father.

A.

The Essence of the Father.

§ 6.

When the question is of the author of all existence, science and religion at once turn in different directions: science looks down into necessity, downward into the ground, and demands of reason that it comprehend the Absolute; but religion looks up toward freedom and enjoins faith in the heavenly Father. In order that true understanding between faith and knowledge may be attained, the conflicting views must first of all be brought to so complete an expression that the heterogeneity of the principles can thereby come to light, and the opposite results show themselves to proceed from opposite presuppositions. The conflict will concern the interior of the divine, its immanent moments, and the peculiar conceptual form of the self-subsistence developed through the moments. Against the impersonal universal of knowledge, faith then sets the fatherly Self; against knowledge's dissolution of all determinations of inwardness in the undifferentiated Absolute, faith sets a living sum of fatherly attributes; against the negative form of the Absolute, faith sets positively the personality of the Father. Since, however, the conflict is waged, not between a knower who denies faith and a believer who rejects knowledge, but essentially [83] between faith and knowledge, in other words: not between individuals but between principles, then — as each of the principles develops and moves freely in its own sphere, and the boundary lying in the Mystery is acknowledged from both sides — the conflict, carried through, will be able to lead to a reconciliation.

a) The Self in the Father.

§ 7.

In practical as well as in theoretical respects a great many deliberations have been undertaken for and against the possibility of proving God's existence. He who is to prove that God exists must surely know beforehand what God is; for to wish to prove of something, one knows not what it is, that it exists, is thoughtless. Now since God is not recognizable by anything other than himself, and cannot be known by himself without being cognized as existing, the cognition of God is surely immediate, and every attempt to prove his existence must then seem to be as superfluous as it is meaningless. And yet the certainty of God's existence is by no means immediate; it is, on the contrary, infinitely reflected. This will become evident when we consider that a man can cognize God only in proportion as he cognizes himself: as the man is, so is his God. The proposition that every judgment about the divine Self, however objectively it may sound, is essentially reflected in a judgment about the human self, is a main proposition which sets a separation between faith and knowledge. We hold fast to this main proposition in that, as regards the reality of the representation of God, with reference to the so-called proofs, we conceive *the divine Self* first from the standpoint of knowledge, then from that of faith, and determine the category of the

[84] Mystery as the boundary of faith and knowledge.

α) The Divine Self Conceived from the Standpoint of Knowledge.

If it stands firm that the judgment about the divine Self depends on the judgment about the human self, then the question of how the knowing subjectivity conceives and must conceive itself in science is surely one of the first and most important questions. That in all objective knowledge the essential thing is to cognize the universal, the necessary, what is independent of all subjective individuality, has often been emphasized. But the self that in the form of knowledge is to cognize the universal must through abstraction, so to speak, die away from its individuality and make itself one with the universal; in order to grasp the matter in its purity, it must transform itself into a mirror for the matter. The contemplating self is then absorbed into universal thinking; the contemplating, thinking, judging self becomes, in its contemplating, thinking and judging, lost to itself to such a degree that it determines nothing, can determine nothing and dares determine nothing except that to which it is necessarily determined

by the nature of the matter. Lost in the matter, absorbed in the inquiry, the investigator may even be seized by so complete a self-forgetfulness that he has at last forgotten both the time and the place and contingent actuality, just as Archimedes, absorbed in his problems, had indeed forgotten both the time and the place and contingent actuality when he said to the Roman soldier: *noli turbare circulos meos*.

It is the first inescapable demand of knowledge that the knowing self must transform itself into abstract essentiality, into intellectual selfhood; selfhood is the reflected unity of the individual and particular with the universal; only in the universal form of intellectual selfhood can the self identify itself with the objective and think objectively. He whose principle of life is to be absolutely objective, then, knows nothing else than [85] that the self itself is the objective, “the universal,” “the free universal being for itself,” and whatever else the phrases are called with which empty verbal philosophy can dazzle an abstracted, abstracting subjectivity.

As it goes with the determination of the knowing self, so also with the determination of the content of knowledge. Here the question is not primarily what, in a finite sense, can become the object of scientific investigation, the many outward or inward facts; here the question is of the absolute content of knowledge, i.e. of the Idea as Idea. That the Idea, in all its objectivity, is also selfhood and has in itself the moment of subjectivity, is expressed in the concept by its being said to be subject-object, the absolute unity of the subjective and the objective. In immediate objective form the Idea is nature, in subjective form it is spirit: the absolute identity of the subjective Idea with the objective is God. The proofs of God’s existence now have this significance: to set the Idea in motion and to show through what transitions and “mediations” the thought of God gives itself reality.

These proofs, whose number modern philosophy in particular has reduced to three: *the cosmological*, which infers from “the contingent being, which cannot bear itself” to “the true being, necessary in and for itself” — the proof *ex contingentia mundi*; *the teleological*, which proceeds from the purposiveness of the world and infers its wise author; and finally *the ontological*, which proceeds from the concept of God itself and infers its reality — these proofs, as they are found treated and developed especially in

Hegel,⁷ serve, each by itself as well as in systematic connection, to confirm what was
 [86] said above, that knowledge determined by the Idea is as little able to raise itself from the world to God as from necessity to freedom.

The thought in the cosmological proof is this: not because the world is must we think of God as being, but because no true being belongs to the world must we seek the true being above the world, in God. To think finite being is to free it from the form of singularity and contingency and to comprehend it as a universal being, necessary in and for itself, which is distinct from that first: as God. That this necessary being, however, can be separated from the contingent only by abstraction, negative critique has quite rightly seen. “What does this mean other than” — observes Strauss⁸ — “that the world shows itself to ordinary representation as an aggregate of finite things, contingent to one another, and then as similar laws; comprehending cognition negates these things as singularities subsisting for themselves, and rises to the universal unity which just as much posits them out of itself as it takes them back again into itself, i.e. which relates to them as substance to accidents”? Thus: God is the substance of the world, its own indwelling necessity.

With the teleological proof, according to Hegel, substance was to develop itself into the free concept, and the light of freedom to rise over necessity; but the freedom that is won through the immanent dialectic of means and ends is only necessity explained by its own concept. It is organic nature, the organizing principle, the end of ends, the life in all that lives, that is conceived as God; but such a God is indeed precisely one with the world, is the life of the world, the indwelling necessity of living nature.

[87] As for the ontological proof, finally, its result is plainly enough stated. “Those who are convinced”, says Hegel, “that the absolute essence in thought is not thought itself, speak constantly of God as a beyond for consciousness, and of thinking him as having a concept of him whose existence or actuality is something distinct from that concept; just as when we think or represent to ourselves an animal or a stone, our concept of it or our representation is something quite other than the animal itself”. The result is that God thinks himself only as he is thought by man, that God is the spirit in all spirits, the concept in all who comprehend, the thinking in all who think — not the

⁷Vorlesungen über die Beweise vom Daseyn Gottes.

⁸Troeslære I. S. 334.

willing Self, but only a universal selfhood, the logical necessity of the thinking being.

The worldview that corresponds to the concept of God developed by these proofs is, as is well known, pantheism: in pantheism God, without a self, is only universal selfhood. However much Hegel labors to get beyond Spinozism and pantheism, in this sense he nevertheless does not get from the spot. True enough, his concept of God is far more richly developed than Spinoza's; but the principle is the same; the development is formally logical; the whole logical development of the Idea takes place within the bounds of pantheism. As man's self is, so is his God; the knowing self dissolves itself into the selfhood of the Idea, for the God of knowledge is the selfhood of the Idea. But this intellectual dissolution of the self has yet another consequence. Once the divine Self has been dissolved into the Idea of knowledge, the Idea immediately coincides with natural actuality and is lost, in this its immediacy, as Idea. "Only the actual, the sensuous, is; the Idea as Idea is not; universal selfhood is the empty, selfless universal": this is the watchword of atheism. For atheism the selfless object, the atom in material immediacy, is the eternal first, the unoriginated. Atheism is a [88] kind of naturally necessary consequence of pantheism, a dispiriting, but scientific consequence.

"It is", says Martensen, "the sorry fame of Young Germany to have brought the negating consequences of pantheism into a system, for which they have sought to gain entry among the multitude. Instead of the intellectual-poetic, logical-mystical worldview of Schelling and Hegel, we have now of late obtained a quite ordinary *système de la nature*. Under the hands of this generation the mystical-poetic dust has gone from the wings of the pantheistic butterfly; the once so glittering creature now shows itself only in a prosaic nakedness, or at least only with a death's head on its wings. For it is now proclaimed without circumlocution: there is no God; the name 'God' is a tedious name by which nothing clear can be thought."

β) The Divine Self Conceived from the Standpoint of Faith.

There is much talk, far and wide, of the necessity of sublating the dualism of the soul and securing the unity of human self-consciousness from the ground up: this talk is empty so long as it is not made evident whence the dualism springs, how essential

it is, and on what conditions it can be sublated. Can the self that denies God, and the self that puts the Idea in God's place, and the self that believes in God, really be said to be three modifications of one and the same human self, or have we here three kinds of men, each with his own self, or can the three kinds of self perhaps exist in one and the same man? The question may perhaps seem strange; but its answer is necessary to the elucidation of the matter. Man's judgment about God is essentially a judgment about his own self; only in himself, within himself and from himself can he know God. The [89] sensuous self denies God; the rational self dissolves itself into selfhood and transforms God into Idea: only the spiritual self can believe in God. When three different kinds of self are spoken of here, it will readily be understood that the talk here is not of three immediately existing things, but of three possible points of concentration for self-consciousness, three centers decisive for the life of the will.

The unity of the human essence is originally a unity of self. All typical, organic formative drive in all living organisms points to a forming and working that is subject to the law of selfhood, the fundamental law of self-development. But self-development is impossible without a self-determining, however wholly unconscious. Every self-determining indicates a willing, but such a willing is not yet will. Only in the ensouled organisms, the animals, does the fundamental willing indicated in the formative drive begin to take on the stamp of instinctive will. The higher concentration is so far from being a consequence of animal sense-consciousness that the latter, in its peculiarity, is on the contrary a consequence of the former. By nature, i.e. in the first immediacy of his existence, man certainly has instinctive will in common with the animals, just as he indeed also has senses, the rudiments of understanding, etc. in common with the animals; but since the principle of soul in man expressly distinguishes itself from the animal one in that it is, from the very first beginning, a principle of self-consciousness, so too the instinctive will in man is from the beginning a will of self-consciousness, a fundamental will that produces itself by producing its consciousness. Self-consciousness filled with sensuous representations has in the instinctive will its selfish center, its first governing point of unity: to this corresponds the sensuous self.

By acknowledging the universal and being moved by the Idea, human life under-

goes an essential change, which consists chiefly in this, that the governing point of unity, so to speak, moves and places itself within the Idea: the instinctive will does [90] not exactly disappear, but it is taken up into the will of the Idea, and man appears as a rational self. But the will of the Idea is ambiguous; the universal fills the self and consumes the self, dissolves it into selfhood. Only when such a self-concentration takes place that the governing center is placed in God, so that man's will becomes the organ of God's will, is man transformed: he has become a new self, a spiritual self.

Now, that man's consciousness cannot at one and the same time revolve about three equally fixed centers is understandable; but that one and the same man can find himself in transitional states in which the life of the soul divides itself so that now the instinctive will, now the will of reason, now the will of spirit has the upper hand either wholly or in part, is a fact. We see it in "God-consciousness".

Everywhere, in all lands where revealed religion has exercised any social influence, there will be a great number of people who fancy that they really believe in God's existence, and yet this faith of theirs is not much more than a pious fancy. The open assertion of atheism: there is no God, they reject with horror and aversion; it seems to them as though such an assertion offended the dignity of man and made existence meaningless. Whence does this come? It is the half-rational, half-spiritual self that feels offended. But do they not, then, really believe in God's existence? By no means! It is only so long as the representation of existence can coincide with a hazy representation of absence that the existence of God hovers before them. "God exists, but he is in heaven"; that is to say: God is existent, but infinitely absent. If, on the other hand, the representation of the existent God is to be put into force, if his existence is to mean his inner immediate presence, how many will not then fall away? [91] That the divine Self, the willing God, is actually immediately near to every single man, that a man in the midst of the thousand concerns of existence shall not be able to stir, not have a single feeling, not a thought so hidden, not a desire so secret, but that the existent and precisely therefore infinitely present God has at every moment his eye fixed on this single man, and in every single concern asks in silence whether he will do his will: such a representation is not to be endured! The natural self reacts from the natural ground of the mind, and the natural self has the support of "sound reason".

Man's half-sensuous and half-rational self here fuse together into a doubting self, and this doubting self, otherwise at odds with itself about life's highest concerns, is now at one with itself on this, that the divine Self is far too importunate.

What then does religion want? Does it want to root out human nature, condemn reason, tear up the sensuous and rational self by the roots, in order to plant a nature-less, unnatural and reason-less self in its place? Far from it! Such an interpretation is no explanation; it is a slander. What religion demands is faith, faith in God, and first of all faith in his existence. The sensuous self cannot believe; and therefore religion demands that the sensuous shall, by strengthened will, be mastered by the spiritual. The universally rational self cannot believe; and therefore religion demands that man shall, in the unconditionally decisive concentration of the will, set his spiritual, eternal self higher than the universal selfhood of the Ideas of reason: faith in God's existence is exclusively conditioned by the concentration of consciousness in the eternal self.

So then — it is said — from the standpoint of faith no proofs at all are needed for [92] God's existence: God has revealed himself, has shown himself to man as he is; with this an end must once and for all have been made to the otherwise endless proving! — Yet it depends on how one understands the matter. For although revelation has its immediate just as well as faith does, this immediate is in its ground infinitely reflected. We see this from the essence of the Word and of the Spirit.

Proof from the Word. When, in the scientific sense, there is talk of offering proof of something, be it a fact, a doctrine or any universal truth whatever, the conduct of the proof falls essentially within the subjectivity of the one who proves. The matter to be proved is objective, rests in objective being, behaves passively and is in so far indifferent to its proof: this holds even of the so-called self-movement, the dialectical movement of the matter itself, which is especially, and with reason, commended as an advantage of Hegel's immanent method. It is otherwise when the talk is of God and God's existence. Here it does not hold that what is to be proved is, in objective being, indifferent to its proof. The thinker in the philosophy of religion cannot treat the divine Self as one treats an immanent Idea in science; he cannot, by any dialectic whatever, conjure this Self forth from its eternal concealment, charm it into an irresistible movement of thought and place it under the necessity that it must

absolutely show itself openly. It is not man who proves to himself and others that God must necessarily exist; no, it is God himself, the free God, who proves his existence to man. The proof is that God speaks to man: the proof is God's Word. The Self and the Word correspond to each other, reflect and explain each other: take the Self away, and the Word will vanish; take the Word away, and the Self will vanish. In his Word, and only in his Word, has God expressly, unambiguously proved his own existence. To believe in God's existence is to believe in God's Word; to doubt God's Word is to doubt God's existence. What God "spoke unto the fathers by the prophets" is not, in [93] this connection, the decisive thing; the decisive thing is that God has spoken.

Proof from the Spirit. From the reflected unity of the Word and the Self it follows that the Word from God can as little be held fast in objectively existing immediacy as God himself. The human word, once it has been uttered, has an objective existence independent of the speaker, an existence which, even if the speaker afterwards regretted his word, cannot be recalled. But it is not so with the divine Word; it does not tolerate outward facticity: it dies in immediacy; its objective existence in Scripture and tradition is without significance when it is separated from the speaking God. Once a man has clearly uttered what dwells in him, and in what is thus uttered has given his self a spiritual presence, that is enough: then let him keep silent, let the word go its way and do its work. With the Word of God it is another matter: the divine Word cannot work, cannot be read, cannot be heard, cannot be grasped or understood except in and through and with the divine speaking.

As regards the manner of revelation, a distinction must certainly be made between the outward and the inward, between the audible and the inaudible Word; but it is a distinction between the form of immediacy and that of reflection, which in no way entitles us to separate the Word from the speaking. In audible speaking the Spirit is Word; in silent speaking the Word is Spirit. If the same Word that comes to consciousness from without through Scripture and tradition does not, in the moment of apprehension, come forth in consciousness from within, so that from both sides it is cognized as coming from God, it cannot possibly be apprehended as God's Word: the emphasis falls not on the Word but on the Self that speaks the Word.

From this it is seen that the proof of God's existence must be absolutely heteroge- [94]

neous with any scientific proof whatever of any scientific truth whatever. Scientific truth is understood from the word, and it is in so far indifferent who speaks the word. Once a doctrine has been proved once and for all, then it is proved, and the matter is settled: the proposition stands fast, and one can, when occasion arises, point to the proof. But the proof of God's existence cannot be concluded in this way; it is a proof of the Spirit; it lives by the Spirit in the Spirit, and inspiration must, like respiration, be ceaselessly continued. If we now call the proof of the Spirit, in its inner infinite continuation, a proof of reflection, then what is peculiar in the reflection is recognizable in the infinite reciprocal determination of the outward and the inward, the audible and the inaudible Word. Without the outward, audible Word, the Word God spoke of old "unto the fathers by the prophets", the existent God would transform himself into Idea, and the divine Self be dissolved into metaphysical universal selfhood; without the inward word of thought, inaudible in itself, the outward Word would be obscure and dead, God's existence immediate absence, and assurance lacking. The assurance that there is in truth an outward Word from God is, in every moment of reflection, inseparable from the assurance that there is in truth an inward Word from God, and conversely; the assurance of God's existence is conditioned by self-assurance, an inner assurance of one's own existence, and conversely.

The Proof of Faith. "I know that God exists, as surely as I know that I myself exist"; these words can be uttered with so immediate a strength of conviction that they make an impression as though the speaker really had a perfect assurance and were, as regards God's existence, entirely and wholly clear with himself. Nonetheless the [95] utterance is ambiguous, and that both when the question is of the kind of conviction and when it is of its degree. F. H. Jacobi's assurance: "The watchword of myself and my reason is not I, but more than I, better than I, an entirely Other, God — I am not and will not be, if he is not", furnishes a telling example. For reason is not, as Jacobi supposes, a peculiar immediate sense for the personal God. In order to make this view prevail, he had to set a divorce even between reason and science and show the impossibility of bringing the understanding to reason. By this nothing is accomplished. The immediate certainty of God's existence is not a certainty of knowledge but of faith; nor is the assurance, in its immediacy, as decisive as the lyrical-pathetic expression

leads one to suppose. About sensuous objects the one who senses can say: I am as sure that these things exist as that I myself exist; if one cannot believe one's own eyes, what then can one believe? The assurance is immediate.

About universal truths of reason the thinker can say: I am as assured of the truth of this proposition as of the truth of my own thinking; he who doubts thought must doubt thinkingly, and precisely thereby acknowledge thought: the assurance is reflected. Should anyone be able to endure doubting the reality of sensuous things in general, he would have to contradict ceaselessly the testimony of the senses; but so monstrous a contradiction in the sensuous self is unnatural and intolerable: positive immediacy will soon gain power over negative reflection, so that the doubt must stop and the senses hold good with assertoric certainty. In expressions such as: to believe one's senses, to believe one's own eyes, etc., the word 'believe' is taken in a meaning which is as different from the religious one as a sensuous thing is different from God. As regards the truths of reason, a reasoning understanding will easily be able to raise doubt about the validity of thought; a man of sound sense can then, without refuting [96] the skeptic's objections, well say: I believe, i.e. I rely immediately on the reality of thought. But faith in thought is only a provisional faith, a faith that thought itself will sublate; for scientific thought is not content with faith, it demands knowledge. Faith in science is as different from faith in religion as the fulfilling of a law of nature is different from a miracle.

If, then, it is to hold in principle that a man in faith always has the same certainty of the divine Self as he has of his own, it must above all not be forgotten that the human self spoken of here is not the sensuous, nor the rational, but the spiritual. The spiritual self has an existential immediacy, in which it resembles the sensuous, but a reflected essentiality, in which it resembles the rational. Now if a man could be as immediately sure of his spiritual as of his sensuous self, he would also have as immediate an assurance of God's existence as of the world's: the cosmological and the teleological proof could, on this presupposition, obtain full validity for the believer too. But that is impossible. For whereas the concentration into the sensuous self takes place as of itself, the concentration into the spiritual demands, on the contrary, the very utmost exertion. Could reflecting subjectivity concentrate itself in the reflection

of faith with the same incontrovertible assurance of its spiritual self as it can, in the reflection of knowledge, expand itself in an assurance of selfhood saturated with the content of the Idea: then the proof of faith, which proceeds from the self-revealing God, would stand on an equal footing with the ontological proof, which proceeds from the universal concept of God. But neither can this parallelism be carried through, [97] unless it is conceived antithetically; for whereas scientific consciousness surrenders itself in self-expansion in order to be filled, determined and moved by the Idea in its objective universality, the religious consciousness must on the contrary summon all its strength of will and collect itself, so that in unconditional concentration into a willing self it may be touched and inspired by God's will. The rational self can certainly fix itself in the service of the Idea so as to live for the good; but that this self-fixing, corresponding to rational ethics, is heterogeneous with the religious is seen expressly from this, that the relation to the Idea in which it places man to himself is so one-sidedly absolute that at its maximum it excludes God.

The spiritual self, the self that alone can, will and must believe in God's existence, is the self that cognizes that it owes its existence to God, the self that understands in faith that, with its hope of life and of blessedness, it would sink together and vanish like a dream if God were not. The assurance of God's existence and the assurance of the absolute validity of the self are in principle one and the same assurance.

γ) The Fatherly Self: The Mystery.

That science begins by proving God's existence and ends by proving that God's existence does not admit of proof is, of course, quite in order. But when, instead of seeking the reason in the natural limitation of human knowledge, one flatly declares the first and most essential principal proposition of religion to be untrue and misuses science to prove God's non-existence, the presumption is conspicuous. That God exists expresses briefly and definitely that the self is absolute, or that the Absolute is a self. If we gather what has been said above about selfhood and knowledge into one survey, it becomes evident that science is as little able to prove the impossibility as [98] the necessity of an existing God: by proving the necessity, it dissolves the self into selfhood, transforms God into Idea, and thus proves the necessity of a God who is not

God; by proving the impossibility, it entangles itself in the contradiction that God, whose existence, as surely as he exists, must necessarily fall outside knowledge, cannot exist because his existence does not fall within knowledge. How far the philosophy of reason is from being able in truth to disprove God's existence is seen from the ambiguous position of pantheism within science itself. What holds of rational ethics holds of pantheism: it is a spiritual half-measure. Pantheism makes the Idea into God; that is both too much and too little. Too much! For the pure Idea cannot be God. The Idea has in nature no self-reflection; it cannot think its own thoughts, cannot comprehend its own working. Its being and working in actual nature is the being and working of the forces of nature: nature is actual, the Idea is only a metaphysical abstraction. Materialism is wrong when it attacks religion, for religion lies outside science; but it is right when it attacks formal idealism, and with it pantheism, with sharp weapons, for idealism and pantheism fall within science. Too little! For if the Idea is to be able to work as Idea in its own form and to master the material, its divine selfhood must be concentrated into ontological subjectivity, and then we have a logical theism.

That the Idea, when it is developed on all sides, takes on a logical-theistic form,⁹ is a proof that the conflict between philosophy and religion is not a conflict between the laws of thought but between the principles. The divine Self in the ontological subjectivity of the theism of knowledge is one with, and yet absolutely different from, the fatherly Self of religious theism that is confessed by the believers. Where [99] does this leave us? That the divine Self both admits of acknowledgment and yet does not admit of acknowledgment in science; that the Self that is comprehended in knowledge and the Self that is confessed in faith are both the same and yet not the same; that the same divine Self is thus both homogeneous and yet heterogeneous — absolutely heterogeneous! — with itself: herein there is certainly contradiction, indeed contradiction upon contradiction, when we detach the word from the matter. By clinging to bare words the emissaries of verbal critique could here, no doubt, look forward to a rich harvest. But the point is that the word cannot be separated from the matter. From the standpoint of the development of the matter the contradictions at

⁹"The Logic of the Fundamental Ideas" is laid out on that basis.

once take on another aspect. The ontological Self is the limit of knowledge, the fatherly Self the limit of faith; the fixed point from which faith goes out and the highest point to which knowledge can reach here coincide in one point, and the contradictions signify that this point, which in separating unites two heterogeneous spheres of cognition, is a limit-point. That the contradictions both proceed from the limit and dissolve in the limit signifies that the limit is absolute, that here there is a Mystery.

And what, then, is the Mystery? If we could content ourselves with abstract determinations of the abstract, general explanations of the general in all generality, then it would be an easy matter to get the Mystery explained. We would then need only to turn to Hegel: Hegel, after all, has already explained the Mystery and dissolved it in the objective concept. God in the concept is the speculative Idea. "This speculative Idea is opposed to *the sensuous*, and then also to *the understanding*: it is therefore a *secret* for the sensuous mode of consideration and also for the understanding. For both it is a *μυστήριον*, namely with respect to what is the rational in it. The nature of [100] God is not a secret in the ordinary sense, least of all in the Christian religion; there God has made himself known, shown what he is, there he is revealed; but it is a secret for sensuous conceiving and representing, for the sensuous mode of consideration and for the understanding."¹⁰

If we could content ourselves with a mystical notion of the inconceivable, the unnameable, a *ὑπερουσιον* that withdraws itself from every possible determination of thought, then we would soon be finished too. But with such a thing, indeterminable in itself, revelation, and with it the relation to God, is dissolved. The relation to the unnameable would then itself become unnameable; the Mystery is faith itself and faith the Mystery: this is meaningless.

But if the philosophy of religion is now set the task of determining what the Mystery is and what is in the Mystery, the contradiction seems to be insoluble. To determine what the Mystery is is, after all, precisely to abolish the Mystery. "Insofar as the Mystery is, it cannot be determined; insofar as it is determined, it cannot be": such a contradiction may well amuse a beginner in dialectic; for it takes little to amuse children. But now to the matter!

¹⁰Religionsphil. 2. Thl. S. 253.

The Mystery is, in the fatherly Self, the original, unoriginated unity of essence and will, of necessity and freedom.

The unity itself in abstract generality can be seen and comprehended from the standpoint of knowledge as well as from that of faith; in the general unity there is nothing mysterious. But when the unity is to have a content — and it is the development of the content on which everything depends — then knowledge begins with essence and faith with will, knowledge with necessity and faith with freedom; from the two different points of departure the two methods move in two converging lines. That the converging lines must have a point of contact is incontestable; but that the point of [101] contact falls on the other side of the limit of knowledge as well as of the cognition of faith can be proved: it falls in the Mystery.

Between essence and will, more precisely, between necessity and freedom, there lies a limit which only the self, the fatherly Self, alone can posit and remove. Were the limit to be determined from essence, by developing the grounds of necessity, then the grounding would have to end by making the determination of will a necessary determination of essence; the will would in this way become only a semblance of essence, freedom a reflection of necessity. To ground freedom and will would then be the same as to explain away both will and freedom. Were the limit, conversely, to be determined from the will, by developing the grounds of freedom, then the grounding would have to end by making the determinations of essence themselves into determinations of will; but what then becomes of necessity? It vanishes in freedom, is consumed by freedom: the ground of essence is hollowed out, and arbitrariness becomes absolute. What good does it do, then, to appeal to the trivial commonplace that in the divine will there is no difference between essence and will, in the divine freedom no difference between necessity and freedom? The philosophy of reason, which in all its groundings must on principle use grounds of necessity, oversteps its limit and makes itself ridiculous by inserting immediate notions of free actions and adding assurances that many of the divine manifestations of essence are at the same time manifestations of will, that the will as unconditioned self-determination necessarily belongs to the higher necessity, and so forth. In a corresponding way the philosophy of revelation, which in all its groundings must on principle use grounds

of freedom, would overstep its limit if, instead of contenting itself with the general
 [102] presupposition that the moments of necessity belong essentially to freedom, it began to go into particulars and to make distinctions between what God does out of pure freedom, what he does out of pure necessity, and what he must do half out of freedom, half out of necessity. To add grounds of necessity to grounds of freedom is equally unreasonable in religion and in science; to identify grounds of necessity with grounds of freedom is equally ruinous for religion and for science. But when the distinguishing, the inner articulation, of the grounds of necessity and of freedom is determined solely by the divine principle, the fatherly Self, and is and must therefore be equally inaccessible to science and to religion, then there is given herewith both what the Mystery is and what is in the Mystery.

The Mystery is, in the fatherly Self, the original, unoriginated unity of the Idea in the form of necessity and the Idea in the form of freedom, the original, unoriginated unity of nature and spirit.

That nature and spirit must presuppose each other ad infinitum is easy to comprehend as long as there is talk only of the general; it follows directly from what has been said about the relation of freedom to necessity. The ground of the all-unity of God and the universe, of spirituality and corporeality, which speculation has now so often ploughed through lengthwise and crosswise, was already unfolded in a naive and vivid manner by Jacob Böhme. "When man sees the ocean of air above the earth, he sees only stars and clouds of water, and then he thinks that there must be another place where the Godhead shows itself with its heavenly and angelic regiment. He will absolutely separate the ocean of air with its regiment from the Godhead; for in it he sees nothing but stars, and the regiment between them is fire, air and water. So he thinks: this God has created thus out of nothing according to his purpose; how could
 [103] God be in that being, or how could it be God himself? He constantly imagines that it is only a house in which God rules and dwells with his spirit. There might well be many who would say: what sort of a God would that be whose body, being and power consisted in fire, air, water and earth? Behold, you incomprehending man, I will show you the true ground of the Godhead. If all this being is not God, then you are not God's image; if there is a foreign God, then you have no part in him. For you are

created from this God and live in him, and he constantly gives you of himself power, blessing, food and drink; all your knowledge, too, rests in this God, and when you die, you are buried in this God.”¹¹ It is this theme that more recent philosophy has worked through and richly varied in the doctrine of the Absolute; but speculation has not been able to bring it to an actual unveiling of the “*Mysterium magnum*.” The task is to deduce: either spirit from nature or nature from spirit; but whichever of the two ways one chooses, it ends — in the Mystery.

The philosophy of reason strikes out on the first way; it wants in actuality to derive spirit from nature. The All, the Absolute, the Idea indicates the point of departure. First the whole totality of determinations of essence is developed to its concept in the logically absolute Idea. The logical Idea is the unity of essence of nature and spirit. The universal, which includes within itself all differences, separates itself from itself, releases its elements of difference and converts itself into the particular: herewith natural existence is preformed. The particular, however, is no parceling out; the difference is posited in order to be sublated again; it is posited as a difference that is yet no difference, it is posited as sublated. The totality in the particular and the totality [104] in the universal are the same totality. The universal, which primordially divides itself into the particular, then sublates the primordial division again and closes together with itself in the individual: herein is seen a preformation of spirit. The next thing is that the unity of nature and spirit preformed in the logical Idea is developed into actual opposition. This happens through particularity breaking through, through the separating-out becoming earnest. The kingdom of nature is the kingdom of otherness, and just for that reason of externality and particularity. The Idea begins in immediate existence with scattered elements, moments cast outward, and only by passing through the various intermediate stages of mechanical, physical and organic formations can it gradually gather itself out of dispersion and concentrate itself into individuality in man. In human self-consciousness the light breaks through; in and with man the Idea is posited as spirit; yet still only in finite opposition to nature, thus still only as finite spirit. Nature and finite spirit stand opposed to each other as particulars; here is a primordial division which the universal must again sublate. But the universal that

¹¹Aurora c. 22, 35, 23, 1 fl. Jvnfr. Strauss. Den christel. Troesl. I. S. 481–82.

sublates the primordial division has now itself been developed and articulated through the primordial division. The concrete universal, which has originally presupposed the opposition of particulars through which it closes together with itself into the individual, is spirit as absolute spirit: God. The development of the world, “regarded *sub specie æternitatis*,” is thus God’s self-development; for the development of the world is nothing other than the Absolute, the spirit, which “eternally beholds itself in the mirror of all the finite spirits that arise and pass away again.”

If the philosophy of religion chooses the other way, begins with the priority of spirit and seeks to derive nature from spirit, then other difficulties tower up. God as spirit is
 [105] God in the eternal, pure light of his self-knowledge and will. As the spirit absolutely free in itself, God is *actus purus*, a thinking that thinks itself, a willing that works itself, a comprehending that eternally comprehends itself. But this thinking of thinking, working of working and comprehending of comprehending is altogether empty if in God’s essence there is nothing determinable either to think or to comprehend. One then supposes in God’s being a ground, so that his thinking and working can get a content; herewith a being is introduced over which God does not dispose. Just as God has not been able with free will to make himself God, but must from eternity have found himself as he is and taken himself as being, so God cannot himself dispose over the promptings that come from the ground of his essence, the visions, images and representations that involuntarily rise up and present themselves before his gaze. God is, humanly speaking, infinitely gifted; but he finds the gifts — wonderful gifts! — in his interior, and has not arbitrarily endowed himself; in other words: the divine spirit, from which all nature was to be derived, is itself dependent on a divine nature.

If one now tries to explain the absolute dependence of the divine nature on spirit by letting the immediate determinations of nature, the inner material, if we may so say, of immediacy, be for God as real possibilities, a stuff of ideality which the will can arbitrarily shape, from which it can at pleasure choose what it will, repress what it will, organize and develop what it will: then the last state becomes worse than the first. For if weight is seriously to be laid on the reality of the possibilities, then no possibility in nature can be real without having its immediate being in a totality of previously existing elements. Thus in outer, actual nature water has its possibility in oxygen

and hydrogen, the plant its determinate possibility, its germ, in the seed, and so forth. The possibilities in God's spirit would thus have to presuppose in this way a nature [106] already existing behind spirit; and yet this nature, with its preformations, was to be derived from spirit? If one evades the difficulty by urging that the possibilities are only divine representations, ideal productions of spirit itself, then these productions are at once reduced to being represented representations, empty, imaginary imaginations, natureless possibilities; but from natureless possibilities no nature can be derived.

Thus the matter stands. From the opposition between actual nature and finite spirit the philosophy of reason wants to derive the actuality of absolute spirit; but that is impossible. Absolute spirit is essence and remains essence; an abstract essence, for all its concretions belong to finitude; an unfree, metaphysical essence, for it lacks the eternal Self, in which alone it can centralize itself into will and freedom! that is, into actual spirit. That negative philosophy knows, with a certain cleverness, how to veil the contradiction by pregnant phrases is certain; but that it is not able to derive spirit from nature is also certain.¹² In order to assert the independence of finite [107] spirit, to raise it above perishability and assure it of an eternal life, religion makes the absolutely free spirit, exalted above the kingdom of nature, into the eternal prius.

¹²The following statement of Strauss (*Den christl. Troesl. I. S. 452 flg.*) is characteristic in this respect. "One will not," he says, "be able to do other than praise the account which the younger Fichte sketches of the Hegelian doctrine of God, when he says: Hegel does not teach that God is mere substance, nor that he is the colorless indifference of the subjective and the objective . . . the absolute fluctuation of the opposition eternally posited and at once sublated and reconciled again. He is never exhausted in one of these self-formations, but has infinite superiority over each of them, which are thus posited in him as something ideal. God is thus here the eternal intuition of himself in the other, the infinite creation as infinite subject-objectivity. As I said, this account must be called correct, and Hegel himself expressed himself in almost the same way when he wished to present his doctrine of God in popular form. But all the more must one wonder when Fichte continues: just because the Hegelian Absolute is the actuality and unrest of the absolute process, it still lacks the kernel, the resting center, the inner unmoved clarity of identity, the eternal bond of the self-grasping unity — the calmly resting eye must first be implanted in the progressing process. Has not Fichte himself said immediately before, of the Hegelian Absolute, that just in its infinite becoming-other it is one and self, subjectivity; that in the eternal positing of itself the opposition was just as eternally sublated, or, in Hegel's words, that its movement in itself is just as much absolute rest? How then should the Hegelian Absolute first be able to receive unity, rest, selfhood from Fichte the Younger, when by his own admission it is already in possession of all this? To what end the artifice of wanting, although it has natural eyes, to set some more into it, which, once they are set in, can after all only be glass eyes?" — In order that spirit should not need glass eyes, "God's personality must be thought not as individual personality but as all-personality; instead of ourselves personifying the Absolute, we must learn to comprehend it as that which personifies itself in the infinite."

But if the philosophy of religion, on this account, were to aim at deducing nature from spirit, it would have to end by transforming nature into a semblance and making spirit natureless. The principal unity of nature and spirit is a divine unity of self. That the unity is, is not the Mystery; but the unity itself in its peculiarity, the unity of determinations of nature that can only be in God's nature, as surely as the Absolute itself is God, and of determinations of spirit that can only be in God's spirit, as surely as God is the absolute Self, the unity of origin, the primordially fatherly unity of nature and spirit, is the Mystery.

b) Fundamental Determinations in the Self of the Father.

§ 8.

That the Mystery lies in the divine Self seems at first glance bound to make all true cognition of God impossible. How, one asks, should it be possible to develop any concept of God when that which is to constitute the pervasive unity and center of the determinations of the concept is an unknown X? How, indeed, should a concept of the self be separable from the self's own concept? The self, after all, does not sit hidden behind its marks of essence, as that Greek painter sat listening behind his pictures, waiting for the judgments of others; nor is the self a subject on which one who reflects can hang predicates, as one can hang titles on a man or clothes on a pole. What the self is in itself, that it is in its self-manifestations, its essential functions: the thinking self in its thinking as thinking, the willing self in its willing as willing, and so forth. The self has only predicates that it gives itself, and in which it gives itself: if the self is mysterious, the same holds of the predicates, and conversely.

There is in this consideration a mixture of the true and the false, which we shall throw light on in what follows. In the first place, we must then remark that the unity of the self and its functions that is appealed to is ambiguous. Certainly the self as thinking is one with its thoughts, as willing one with its acts of will; but the self concentrated in itself is nonetheless a being different from its thoughts, manifestations of will, and so forth; if the thinker were nothing other than a thinking, the one who wills nothing other than willing, then the thoughts would have to be able to think

themselves, and the manifestations of will to will themselves, as when in objective logic the concept is said to comprehend itself. The next thing to be emphasized is this: that the unity-in-opposition of the self in itself and its forms of appearance grounds a distinction between the inner unity of the predicates and their differences corresponding to the forms of appearance. In order to clear up the opposition between the philosophy of reason and the philosophy of revelation on this point, we first direct attention to the reduction of the divine attributes which “modern science” has carried through with a peculiar consistency, and then pass on to develop the fundamental determinations in the divine Self that follow directly from the principle of faith. [109]

α) The Attributes of the Absolute: Dissolution of the Divine Properties.

The scholastic treatment of the doctrine of faith is distinguished by an acute use of formal logic, insofar as the principle of contradiction can subsist with a finite combining of representations and concepts and a corresponding distinguishing between pure identity and abstract difference. But precisely the one-sidedness of the understanding with which the principle of contradiction is held fast, where what is at stake is the development of an absolutely divine content, brings it about that the principle comes into conflict with itself on essential points. We see this in the treatment of “the properties of God.” The finite is both to hold its ground against, and yet to dissolve itself in, the infinite; the properties are to be both mutually different and yet without difference one in the divine One; in their mutual difference they are both to hold (realism) and not to hold (nominalism) for God himself: the contradiction is glaring.

Already the category of *property*, applied to God, makes the treatment precarious; for property corresponds to thing, just as thing to property. The thing that has several properties is itself the existing unity of the properties, and the properties are the inner constitution of the thing, laid out in existing difference. If the thing is extended, red, hard, square, etc., then extension, color, hardness, figure appear, despite their union, as different properties; the thing is one, the properties another: the immediate plurality is resolved into the equally immediate unity. This immediacy is nonetheless reflected; as soon as the reflection is noticed, the contradiction sets in. It is the same thing, namely the thing, that is extended, red, hard, etc.; thus: this extended thing is red, is [110]

the red; this red is extended, is the extended; the red is — in the thing — the same as the extended, and yet — in the thing — different from the extended; the same is and yet is not the same: the contradiction is in full swing. And yet the natural understanding does not notice the contradiction; this comes from the fact that the immediate glance at the thing so easily discovers: in the difference the unity, in the unity the difference.

But when the talk is of God and the divine properties, there is no supporting immediacy; identity and difference go to infinity, and the finite understanding is confounded by the contradiction. We shall now see how the negative critique, the Straussian in particular, has made use of the contradictions in the concept of God and dissolved the properties.

Attributes of the divine being: omnipresence and eternity. As the one unrestricted by space, God is omnipresent. That God's being everywhere must not be conceived as bodily extension, so that half of God was in half of the world and the whole God in the whole, is self-evident. Concerning the manner in which the divine essence is in all things, it is taught: "not as a body, nor yet as a spirit, but in a divine, wholly [111] incomprehensible manner"; to which Strauss remarks: "The alleged incomprehensibility is as a rule the ecclesiastical embellishment of a contradiction. Either — it might be objected — the world and every part of it is outside God, and he is then limited; or, if in its individual parts it is not outside God, then it is mingled with him and is itself God, or at any rate God's body." If, in order to avoid so pantheistic a conclusion, one would, with the Socinians, separate God's *præsentia operativa* from his *præsentia essentialis*, restrict the latter to heaven and conceive the former as *actio in distans*, then a new contradiction arises: instead of an actual, God now receives only a possible omnipresence. The possibility is that God can act immediately where and when he will; but the possibility itself is impossible to comprehend. In order to be in all places, God must be in space, for all places are in space; in order to be in all places in space, the divine being must be exalted above space, independent of space, nowhere in space: the contradiction is that omnipresence becomes a nowhere-presence, and conversely.

The resolution of the contradiction is sought in a causality that conditions both space itself and everything in space and is absolutely spaceless. This causality is, according to the speculative view, not God but the Idea. The Idea "makes space and

everything in space its presupposition in order to issue from it as spirit; the Idea is omnipresent in all spaces and in everything that fills space, by virtue of its immanent dialectic as life and law.”

Exalted above the bounds of time, God is eternal, his being therefore without beginning and end. To bring out the difference between eternity and endless time, one lets succession vanish for God, so that he is thought to unite past and future in an eternal present. Eternity is wholly present at once, but time is not. But now the contradiction breaks through. For if God’s eternity “has no parts,” nothing preceding and nothing following, then God must of course constantly do what he has once done, and must already have done what he will do in the future. If he has once created the world out of nothing, then he will go on continuing to create the already created world out of nothing. Indeed, he must even create it and destroy it at once. For if he will one day in time destroy the world, then he has of course already destroyed it; he destroyed it when he created it. [112]

The contradiction is resolved when the attribute of eternity, instead of being referred to a personal God, is referred to substance. “Eternity in itself, or the eternity of substance, is nothing unthinkable, but on the contrary a necessary concept: it is the unity in the difference of the moments of time; when time in thought is deprived of beginning and end as its represented points of support, it collapses of itself into the indifference of eternity, as the ground from which it just as constantly issues without end; eternity and time are related as substance and its accidents.”

Attributes of the divine understanding: omniscience and wisdom. God’s properties are conceived in likeness to the properties of the human soul, and yet the unlikeness is greater than the likeness. At the very question of the divine understanding we come up against the dilemma: “Are consciousness and will to be different in God as in human beings, or are they to be the same? It does not satisfy to say, with the popular dogmaticians, that understanding and will in God are not different powers but one and the same infinite power, which expresses itself partly in cognizing, partly in acting according to that cognizing: this is still entirely the relation between human faculties of the soul, which likewise issue from one fundamental power into different activities. [113] But such a difference between thinking and willing and acting is a relation of finitude,

which cannot be assumed to take place in God.” By extensive acquaintance with the given, the human spirit is *knowing*; by purposive use of the given, it is *wise*. Were it possible to distinguish in God between omniscience and wisdom, then it would also have to be possible to distinguish between something that God found given and something he has himself produced; but such a separation does not hold. Were God to be said to be knowing, then within God’s knowledge a difference would have to be made between the discursive and the intuitive, indeed between the faculty of cognition and the act of cognition, between an intuiting of the present, a remembering of the past, and a foreseeing of the future, between a knowledge of the actual and of the possible; but the more one strives to make these differences clear to oneself, the clearer it becomes that they vanish in the undifferentiated One, the eternal Now, in which the Absolute is. How little wisdom befits God Spinoza has already shown when he says: “If God acts for the sake of an end, then he desires something that he does not have. If God has once created the world, be it for whatever end it may, then he has beforehand lacked that which he intended to attain by the creation of the world.” Wisdom is moreover halved in that it must leave it to another property, namely love, to determine the final end, so that it can reserve to itself alone the determining of the means. “But the means is something that is not willed for its own sake but merely for the sake of the end, something that would not be willed if another thing, which is willed, could have been attained without it; since, then, to attain the end by a means is the same as to attain it by something in which it is not attained, or by not attaining it, [114] it follows that having to use means for the attainment of ends is a manifest limitation and finitude.”

Attributes of the divine will: omnipotence, holiness, righteousness. An absolute will is posited in God over against an absolute understanding; but two such absolute concepts must, whether they are otherwise represented as falling outside each other or as coming together into unity, absolutely annihilate each other. What is will? A striving after something one does not have, thus a determination of finitude which presupposes a limit, a negation. Were God now to have a will, it would have to be thought of as “a craving that is eternally stilled, a seeking that has always already found, a desire that is inseparably one with the attainment,” i.e., as a will that is no will.

The contradiction leaps to the eye when one reflects on the difference between power and will. God is almighty and can do everything he wills, but cannot possibly will everything he can do, e.g., not what is bad. Can God, then, choose between different possibilities? God could, it is said, have created infinitely more than he has actually done; for all possibilities cannot possibly become actual. "But if it is to be incompatible with God's omnipotence actually to will and to create everything he can, then he not only does not will everything he can, but he cannot will everything he can will, a contradiction to which Spinoza has already drawn attention." God is *holy*, that is, "he wills what he ought, and ought what he wills." The relation between the will and the law is essentially to be expressed by an ought. When one speaks of God's unchangeable resolve to will to act in accordance with his perfections, the possibility is manifestly implied that God could also will and act otherwise. "God himself could not be called good if evil were not for him too a metaphysical possibility." But a possibility of evil is incompatible with the concept of the Absolute. "For," says Strauss, "if evil is [115] nothing other than a being's reflection into itself and not at the same time into the Absolute, then the possibility of evil is consequently present only in a being that is not the Absolute; for in the latter, reflection into itself is of course at the same time reflection into the Absolute. The case is similar with that ought; for it enters only for a being that merely has the Idea of the good as an other without being it itself. Thus the concepts 'the Absolute' and 'the Holy' will not let themselves be united; but he who holds fast to the Absolute dissolves holiness, which is something only in a being placed in relations; and he who takes holiness seriously encroaches upon the Idea of absoluteness, since it is obscured by the faintest shadow of a possibility of being otherwise than it is."

God is *righteous*, that is, the divine essence is a contradiction. Owing to the transitive side of the concept of holiness, the concept of God's holiness is easily confused with the concept of God's righteousness, which in turn is usually divided into legislative (*justitia legislatoria*) and judicial righteousness (*justitia judicialis*). But the divine holiness, which demands the good of human beings, and the divine righteousness, which prescribes to them the laws for what is good, cannot with reason be kept apart from each other. We thus retain only the judging or retributive

righteousness, and the question becomes: partly, how the divine essence is determined by this property; partly, how that is determined which God ordains on the ground of it. As regards the first, both punitive righteousness in itself and in particular the manner [116] in which the Old Testament speaks of God's wrath, indignation, and vengeance have aroused such offense that many Gnostics have even regarded the righteous God of the Old Testament (*δημιουργὸς δίκαιος*) and the good God of the New Testament (*θεὸς ἀγαθὸς*) as two different gods. As regards the second, namely the rewards and punishments that God ordains according to his righteousness, the conception of them proves to stand in remarkable agreement with the naturally advancing course of development of the human spirit. It begins with a childlike belief in finite retribution, reward and punishment in the external, and it ends with the rational insight that God himself cannot be righteous, but that the divine righteousness must be conceived as "the causality according to which there is posited in the intelligent individual a connection between its acting and its feeling, which neither the opposition of another's acting nor a contradiction between the outward condition and the mode of action is able to dissolve. That every individual's outward condition, too, comes to correspond to his moral acting is a task whose solution humanity always accomplishes only approximately; but that too is only the accidental, and the remainder of inequality that always remains cannot be separated from the concept of the finite." (Strauss).

β) The Significance of the Dissolution for Science.

If the critique's dissolution of the divine properties had been aimed exclusively at showing the insufficiency of the formal application of the principle of contradiction in a comprehending of the Absolute, and thus at establishing the invalidity of the objective, scholastic theories, no objection could with reason be made against it. But the critique is not held to this character: it is not the form of the development but the reality of what is developed, not the theoretical concept of God but God himself, whose [117] dissolution is here expressly aimed at. The critique is evidently a tendentious critique, and the tendency has a perceptible influence on the method. Far from consistently setting speculative thinking against unspeculative, the critique avails itself of two kinds of thinking, a speculative and a ratiocinative, two kinds of logic, according as it

can best use the one or the other. Everywhere that the Absolute's own metaphysical self-opposition is in question, it is excellently at home with the unity of identity and difference and lays the greatest weight on the dialectic of the determinations of difference; but in the analysis of God's properties it introduces another standard, makes a formal use of the principle of contradiction, denies the determinations of difference validity, and reasons scholastically. The divine understanding and the divine will are either identical or different; if they are identical, they are not different; if they are different, they are not identical: this is so unspeculative a piece of reasoning that it can be applied with just as good effect to a dissolution of the concept of the Absolute as to a dissolution of the concept of God. In one place we hear Strauss assure the younger Fichte that the Hegelian Absolute does not first need to acquire unity, rest, selfhood, since it is already in possession of all this; it is merely a matter of "comprehending rest in motion, the abiding in change," in other words: "thinking speculatively." In another place, however, where the talk is of God's eternity, the same author assures us, on the basis of an entirely different logic, that "the unity of self-consciousness, conditioned by the alternation of outer objects and inner states, is necessarily itself drawn into time," that "a self-consciousness that always remains equal to itself" can as little be "an actual self-consciousness as a single unchanged tone could be heard." What now becomes of the rest, the rest that was to be comprehended in unity with motion? What becomes of the abiding, selfhood itself, which was to keep itself unchanged in [118] all changes?

By the arbitrary, uncritical manner in which the critique of dissolution at its pleasure identifies changes in the self with the self's own change, it undermines the logical foundation of selfhood, abandons ideality, and violates the Ideas, first the metaphysical and then the ethical. Divine knowledge falls away; the Absolute may not, as an absolute, have any knowledge of itself, since knowledge categorically falls under relations and belongs to finitude; but how, we ask, can there then be a true knowledge of the Absolute? One of two things: either the knowledge that is to have the Absolute as its content must itself be absolute, and the Absolute consequently be able to have a knowledge of itself; or, if the form of knowledge is relative but the content of knowledge absolute, then there is of course a conflict in knowledge

between form and content. If the eternal essence has no knowledge of itself because there can be no eternally knowing selfhood, how then does it stand with the eternal thinking, the eternal understanding, and the eternally working concepts? A thinking that precedes all thinking, an understanding that has not understood itself and that no one has yet understood, a system of world-concepts, active, operative, realized in actual things, concepts that cannot have their origin in an infinite comprehending, since the Absolute neither knows of itself nor understands nor comprehends itself, and still less in any finite comprehending, since they work independently of and prior to all comprehending individuals — such conceptual fantasies from the twilight of speculation endure no critique; they vanish before science like creatures of the underworld before the light of day.

If every knowing subjectivity is temporal, and consequently all knowledge temporal, what then becomes of eternal truth? As little as truth in itself is a knowledge [119] without being, just as little is it a being without knowledge. To make being eternal but knowledge temporal, being absolute but knowledge relative, is to violate and deny the Idea of truth. The critique's Absolute does not have truth in itself, is not itself truth; for it does not have knowledge in itself, is not itself knowing. Once the Idea of truth has been denied from the ground up in metaphysics, it is easy to foresee what fate awaits such religious-ethical Ideas as goodness, holiness, and righteousness. Since the selfhood in the Absolute, the selfhood that was to be comprehended as rest in motion, as the abiding in change, has become so watered down in abstraction and thinned out in speculation that it cannot even bear a knowledge, how then should it be able to bear a willing and concentrate itself in eternal will? But when all will is relative, and the Idea of the good is an Idea of will, then it of course follows incontestably that the Idea of the good is itself without eternal validity. The critique's Absolute is therefore not the good; it does not have the good in itself, for it has no will in itself; for the same reason, then, it does not have evil in itself either: it is as exalted above good as above evil, an indifferent abstractum that does neither evil nor good.

Under these presuppositions it can be understood that an abrupt transition can be made from pantheism to atheism, from objective idealism to materialism. In the ethical sense the pantheist and the atheist stand at roughly the same level; the latter can be

just as great an ethicist as the former. The pantheist becomes virtuously indignant when one reminds him that human virtue is too weak if it is not strengthened by the consciousness of God's holiness, that the wavering righteousness of human beings cannot do without the point of support that lies in the thought of God's eternal, retributive righteousness; the Idea-intoxicated pantheist will hear nothing of a need for divine assistance. The good is to be done solely for the good's sake — strange, [120] since the good has ceased to be absolute. "Happiness is identical with virtue and only the other side of it; to be unhappy, i.e., to feel oneself unhappy, is the true immorality." But the atheist can of course speak just as forcefully, just as urgently, of the worth of virtue. The atheist too does the good solely for the good's sake; he too recognizes that happiness is identical with virtue, etc. The difference between pantheism and atheism is *in abstracto* merely a logical difference of modification, *in concreto* a difference of mood dependent on individual dispositions. The pantheist prefers to conceive existence from a metaphysical, the atheist from a physical standpoint; ethics acquires a finer, religious-mystical tinge when it is presented in the light of pantheism, a bolder and more immediately practical cast when it is set forth atheistically; that is the whole difference.

Insofar as pantheism and atheism appear with scientific energy and are phenomena within science, they have scientific justification and can, by their vigorous one-sidedness, contribute mightily to furthering the development of the Ideas. For the Ideas will not be cowed; they react with heightened strength when abstract thinking would rob them of the self-validity which they owe solely to the eternal, knowing and willing Godhead: pantheism has its scientific counterweight in logical theism. But the correctives in science are and must be scientific: logical theism has no immediate point of support in religious theism.

γ) Religious Theism: Fundamental Determinations in the Fatherly Self.

If a smooth, continuous transition from logical to religious theism were possible, then we would indeed have to regard science and religion as different in kind, since in religion a weight is laid on the self that does not acquire significance in science; but there could be no talk of absolutely heterogeneous principles. But the matter stands [121]

otherwise. Let one lay as strong an emphasis as one likes on the selfhood concentrated in ontological subjectivity, the ontological concentration will never be able to give us the unconditionally free self, centered in absolute will, that is the God of religion and the object of faith. When the self is posited with divine freedom, everything is changed. Between essence and will, necessity and freedom, a chasm opens that cuts off the way from knowledge to faith and from faith to knowledge: the union is in the Mystery, in the unfathomable depth: every mother's soul that leaps into the depth perishes. "And yet God has revealed himself!" Yes, by positing the relation to God in faith. When the relation to God is given, then a possibility conditioned by it, of the cognition of God, of the development of the concept of God as a concept of faith, is given at the same time. It is these conceptual determinations that we here conceive as fundamental determinations in the fatherly Self.

The objections of critique against the divine attributes, that they presuppose at one and the same time both a likeness and an unlikeness between God and man, are meaningless from the standpoint of faith. Nor can it be said with good reason that the Mystery brings either obscurity or uncertainty into the cognition of God; for the boundary between what can and shall be cognized and what neither shall nor can be cognized is determined categorically by the principle itself. As regards the mutual connection of the fundamental determinations, it must be expressly emphasized that they cannot be derived from one another in the same way as immanent determinations in a concept of knowledge; they must, each of them, be deduced from the relation to God; the deduction is conditioned by self-cognition, and the grounding conversely.

[122] The fundamental question of faith, what we must in the proper sense call its vital question, is the question of *eternal life*. It is not the concept of eternity in objective metaphysical essentiality, not a logical insight into the universal relation between selfhood and eternity, that matters here: here eternity is thought of only insofar as what is expressly thought of here is the eternal in the self, the eternity of the self. In the light of this eternity the reciprocal determination of the divine and the human is seen in inner infinity. The cognition of faith is not grounded by man first assuring himself in one objective way or another of God's eternity, the eternity in the divine Self, and inferring from there to a disposition for eternity in the human self; for this

is the condition of faith, that all cognition of God is conditioned by self-cognition. Nor is the cognition of faith grounded by man assuring himself in an exclusively subjective way, in himself and by himself, of his disposition for eternity, and inferring from there to God's eternity; for this is the condition of faith, that true self-cognition rests originally and essentially on the cognition of God. Not in God's essence by itself, not in man's essence by itself, but in the relation between the essential will of God and of man, in the relation to God, must the thought of eternity be grounded. *God is eternal.* But the fundamental determination of eternity in the divine Self cannot present itself to faith as a resting determination of essence; it contains a demand: that what is eternal in the absolute sense is the Self, that the Self is the eternal, this *shall* be believed, for it *cannot* be known.

Over against eternity in the self there presents itself to objective contemplation another eternity, that of the world, the selfless eternity of temporal nature, an eternity for knowledge. The strife between the perishable and the imperishable which thereby arises in man's consciousness is well suited to show what it means that the true thoughts of eternity are essentially thoughts of will. If the thought becomes objective [123] and the will weak, then universal reflection goes into league with sensuous immediacy, then the improbable becomes the measure of the impossible, then the eternal is not God, God not eternal, then the selfless eternity triumphs. In the strife of the self with the selfless, the believer comes to reflect deeply on his own impotence, but precisely thereby also comes to believe in God's omnipotence. *God is omnipotent.* Herewith the actuality of the world and of nature is neither denied nor reduced to semblance. On the contrary! Increased weight has, if possible, even been laid on actual nature, since its existence is, so to speak, sanctioned by omnipotence itself. Independence is ascribed to the world; but the independence is derived: the actual world subsists before God by God's power; posited by this power it is something, but over against this power it is essentially nothing. Omnipotence is self-power, the Self is omnipotent: with this presupposition life in the temporal can be lived for the eternal. Since omnipotence is posited as divine self-power, hence as ideal, spiritual power, the law of selfhood, the law of self-development, is in the deepest sense cognized as the fundamental law of existence: herewith eternity has triumphed. The believer must indeed know

God's omnipotence by his own impotence, but in such a way that this impotence, which in the inwardness of faith nevertheless has omnipotence itself as its principle, is transformed into a becoming, ever-growing self-power.

As a life of the spirit which wrestles with actuality and fights its way forward through temporality, eternal life is a life in becoming consciousness. Restriction of consciousness is restriction of spirit; development of consciousness is expansion and elevation of spirit: understanding of the conditions of life presupposes self-understanding and conversely; cognition of the conditions given for development is conditioned by self-cognition, and conversely. The more living, inward, energetic [124] self-development is, the more painfully will the darkening of consciousness be felt. The limits of nature show themselves here from a new side: the dark, unconscious powers stand threateningly against the becoming, easily darkened self-consciousness. This contradiction is resolved when the self, with its finite knowledge, presupposes in faith the eternally Knowing One as its principle: *God is omniscient*. That God's omniscience must also for faith be a knowledge of the essence of things, hence an objective, all-embracing knowledge, is self-evident; but in this generality the thought is unfruitful. That God knows all and is acquainted with all things, the past and the future as well as the present, is in the philosophy of religion an assertoric proposition. Such a proposition can first set thoughts of doubt in motion when it is carried over into direct science, where it gives occasion for critical and dialectical discussions. What is decisive for religion is that faith in God's omniscience, determined by the relation to God, expressly aims at the believing self. In states where the individual finds himself forgotten by others, overlooked, misjudged by others, the consciousness of God's omniscience comes into force: "no one is forgotten, for the Omniscient forgets no one; no one is overlooked and no one misjudged, for the Omniscient overlooks no one, misjudges no one"; but chiefly, however, in such crises where man strives with himself in order to come to self-understanding: to examine oneself by oneself, to judge oneself and become completely manifest to oneself is in the finite sense impossible; but to have the Omniscient as one's co-knower, to examine oneself before God, to judge oneself as one who is judged by God and to become completely manifest to God, is in the spiritual, infinite sense possible, for God is omniscient.

The life of faith, with its immediate presuppositions, is infinitely reflected; the reflected unity of reflection and immediacy is seen in the relation to God. In the relation to God, God is present. The presence is immediate and real, for it is God himself, not [125] the concept of God, to which the religious person stands in relation; but the presence is nonetheless reflected and ideal, insofar as the divine Self is not seen as a finite object but is cognized as the principle of the self, the principle of the believing self. In the relation to God the world is the great, far-reaching matter outstanding between God and man. Since man's relation to the world must everywhere be determined by his relation to God, God's relation to man must itself contain determinations of God's relation to the world. Immediately it looks as if only the world were the eternal; but faith sublates the immediacy and sets God, the Eternal One, himself above the world. Immediately it looks as if nature were the omnipotent; but faith sublates the immediacy and sets God, the Omnipotent One himself, above nature. To finite reflection it appears as though all actual cognizing and knowing must have finite conditions and belong to finitude, but faith transforms finite reflection into infinite, and sets God, the Omniscient One himself, exalted above all finite knowledge. Immediately and to finite reflection it looks as if the world, and only the world, in all things in all places were the only thing present, but faith, which sublates this finite both in immediacy and in reflection, discovers the God present in the world; for *God is omnipresent*. God's omnipresence expresses the infinite reciprocal determination of ideal and real presence which gives the relation to God its ideal reality. The ideal reality consists in this, that the divine Self is the principle, and the principle in turn the divine Self. That ontological subjectivity is everywhere effectively present in its other can, from the standpoint of knowledge, be made evident in logical theism; but this metaphysical omnipresence the philosophy of religion is not to develop. The presence as principle with which we are dealing here is the presence of God as the principle at work in all believing souls: it is the [126] principle of God itself that is the principle of faith, and as principle has ideal presence in the human self and, for the self, in the world. Different from and yet identical with the ideal presence is the real presence, which shows itself in this, that the principle which awakens consciousness of God does not awaken a thought of God in general, but makes the living God himself present in thought. "Whither shall I flee from thy

presence?" As little as a man can flee away from himself, just as little can the believing self either flee away from, or by any finite change of place find itself removed from, the Omnipresent One. If the ideal presence is one-sidedly held fast by itself, then the relation to God loses its energy: faith loses its immediate presupposition, and the relation to God is transformed by reflection into a relation to the thought of God. If the presence is held fast in immediate, unreflected reality, then the Spirit is offended against. Faith is transformed into superstition; superstition makes an appointment with God or, what is the same thing, imagines that God makes an appointment with man at a particular place, is to be found and worshipped only at some external holy place or other, be it on Gerizim or in Jerusalem.

That the divine Self is principle means, in other words, that it is causality, infinitely free causality, absolute will. The pantheistic-atheistic critique, which denies the Godhead all immanent determinations of relation and places the relative outside the absolute, treats the absolute and causality in a very ambiguous manner. This becomes especially noticeable in the treatment of the attributes that correspond to understanding and will, wisdom and goodness, holiness and righteousness. Although the absolute itself is too absolute to have either understanding or will, either wisdom [127] or goodness, it is nonetheless to be the principle of understanding and will in man, the cause of all the wisdom and goodness, the holiness and righteousness, that is in the self-consciousness of finite beings. But when the absolute is thus held fast as a causality to which the categories that determine its effects cannot be applied, then surely the effects become so heterogeneous with the cause itself that this cause, as a Kantian "Ding an sich", must fall outside all comprehension. The understanding is finite, but the principle of the understanding is infinite; the principle of the understanding cannot itself be understanding; wisdom, goodness, holiness belong only to relativity and finitude, but the absolute causality whose effects they are belongs to infinity: the cause of wisdom is not itself wise, the cause of goodness not itself good, the cause of holiness not itself holy, etc. And what then is the reality that is thereby violated? It is the self, the human as well as the divine! Such Ideas as wisdom, goodness, holiness and righteousness are, in the very strictest sense of the word, Ideas of the self, Ideas of the will, every determination in them originally a self-determination, every thought a

thought of the self, a thought of the will.

Nothing more thoughtless can be conceived than a half-ethicizing metaphysics that would give the categories of the will a religious tinge by letting the finite self assimilate the absolute and yet have its existential root in the relative; one might just as well try to let the square assimilate the circle and yet remain a square. How should the finite self, bound to sheer relativities, be able to appropriate the absoluteness of essence! If the assimilation is to consist in the finite self more and more putting off finitude, being sublimated into selfhood and being absorbed into the infinity of pure thought, then surely it ends in a metaphysical suicide. If the assimilation is to consist in the relative subject, with ever-growing energy of self-determination, drawing the absolute into [128] itself, so that this at last pervades all feelings, thoughts and actions: what then has happened? If the assimilation has actually been carried through, then a metaphysical miracle has happened: then the absolute has become a self, and the self absolute. But the absolute must, according to the presupposition, remain heterogeneous with the relative, and the relative with the absolute: the assimilation cannot be carried through. Without being able to be carried through, the assimilation is thus to be striven for; it is a striving toward an unattainable end: the assimilation itself is this striving. This striving then perhaps has its bright moments, when the self is near, quite near to being the absolute, and the absolute near, quite near to being the religiously ethicizing self, and then again its equally black moments, when the one striving perceives that the eternal and the temporal must part, because they can never be united. What contradictions! The deeper one penetrates into the fundamental relation between the absolute and the self thus determined, the more clearly the irreconcilable discord shows itself.

From the standpoint of religion the discord is removed. The divine causality, the principle of all understanding and will, all wisdom and goodness, all that is holy and righteous in the finite, is in inner infinity itself understanding and will, is wisdom and goodness, holiness and righteousness themselves. Thus determined, the principle is one with the Self, the fatherly Self, from which all selfhood and self-development has its origin. This fatherly Self is not an externally represented subject that keeps itself behind finite predicates; its predicates are determinations of totality, concepts

rich in content, fundamental forms filled with the Idea. The totalized unity of the fundamental determinations is not the difference-less and yet difference-pregnant, grayly ambiguous absolute, which is capable of nothing and yet is to be capable of
 [129] everything; understands nothing and yet is to give understanding of everything, does nothing and yet metaphysically gets the blame for everything. The identity of the predicates, the unity that comprehends itself in all concepts, wills itself in all acts of will, is at one and the same time different from and identical with its own fundamental determinations: the fatherly Self is personal.

c) The Personality of the Father.

§ 9.

The concept of personality is in the absolute sense a concept of faith, not a concept of knowledge. To judge by everyday experience it might well seem as if the cognition of personality concerned faith and knowledge in equal degree. Human individuality, which is to make its self count *in concreto* as personality, must surely above all have confidence in itself, strength of will and courage for life; but self-confidence, courage, resoluteness are categories that recall faith, immediate and practical assurance. Further, the individuality that relies on itself must know itself and the conditions of its life. Self-cognition presupposes and demands cognition of the actual surrounding world, of the essence of things, the course of events, etc. The completed reflection of self-cognition and cognition of the world perfects itself in theory and becomes a cognition of knowledge. Personality knows with itself what it itself is; it will thus not only be able to comprehend what personality is, but even to cognize the concept of personality as the highest and richest concept, uniting all concepts in itself. — This obscurity ceases when the question of the unity of personality with the absolute, of the absolute personality, is to be answered.

It lies in the nature of the case that science, when it is to develop the concept of personality, must seek its elements in the individuality of man and lay out the
 [130] development psychologically; but from this it follows in turn that a concept of personality which is originally laid out on psychologically restricted presuppositions

cannot possibly be driven beyond the limitation lying in its outline without being dissolved. The contradiction hidden in this the elder Fichte has completely exposed. “You ascribe to God”, he says,¹³ “personality and consciousness. What then do you understand by personality and consciousness? Surely that which you have found in yourselves, learned to know in yourselves, and designated by this name? But that you in no way think, or can think, this to yourselves without limitation and finitude, the slightest attention to your construction of this concept can teach you. By ascribing that predicate to this being you therefore make it into a finite one, into a being that is like you, and you have not, as you wished, thought God, but only multiplied yourselves in thought.” — Hegel, it is true, has sought to develop the concept of personality into a concrete concept of infinity; but the development is ambiguous: according to its universal essentiality personality is infinite and absolute, but in actuality finite and relative. “A new epoch” — so it runs — “has begun in the world; it now seems that the world-spirit has succeeded in freeing itself from all alien objective essence and in at last comprehending itself as absolute spirit. The struggle of finite self-consciousness with absolute spirit, which appeared to it to stand outside it, is nearing its end. Finite self-consciousness has ceased to be finite, and thereby, on the other side, absolute self-consciousness has attained the actuality which it did not have before. The whole previous history of the world in general, and the history of philosophy in particular, present merely this struggle, and seem to have come to the goal where the absolute [131] self-consciousness, of which it is a presentation, ceases to be an alien one, where therefore spirit is actual as spirit.” From this concept of spirit, which is now for the future to count as the absolute concept of personality, it shines forth clearly enough how matters stand with the personal in the concept of personality.

The unreasonableness of wanting to develop the religious concept of God’s personality metaphysically strikes the eye when one reflects on such immediate categories of selfhood as “God’s heart”, “God’s wrath”, “God’s mercy”, etc. Such pathological, anthropopathic fundamental categories belong originally to religion, but they cannot be developed and grounded in science. The absolute of knowledge, which is to be the principle of all that lives, is not itself living, does not have life in itself; it is to express

¹³Ueber den Grund unseres Glaubens an eine göttliche Weltregierung. (Fichtes og Niethammers phil. Journal VIII, I. S. 16).

itself in pious feelings, stir in all hearts, but itself it is without feeling, without heart, absolutely heartless. The ground that knowledge offers for the concept of personality is, when the anthropological vanishes, in itself impersonal; from this fundamental contradiction descend all the particular contradictions that are adduced as proofs against the personal God. The fault lies not with science, but with the knower who demands of science what is against its essence.

As a concept of faith the concept of God's personality must necessarily presuppose the Mystery. The God of religion is the God of life, a living God in free inwardness. The personal in God is the Self; as a living, feeling, seeing, hearing, thinking, willing Self, this personal element is, in the totality of immediately reflected moments of selfhood, infinitely concrete. It looks human and is yet absolutely superhuman; here is a contradiction for knowledge, a conceptual contradiction. What does religion now [132] do with this contradiction? It does not defy the contradiction; it resolves it, but on the terms of faith. In the relation to God the divine must be known by the human: the concepts of revelation are divine-human. In the divine-human concepts the unity of divine and human is a unity of opposites; thus, for example, the concept of sin is determined by the concept of holiness: *sin* is in man, not in God, and yet the concept must be determined divinely; *holiness* is God's, not man's, and yet holiness, insofar as it is to be determined in relation to sin, must be determined divine-humanly. From this standpoint the anthropopathic categories that hold for God's personality must be conceived. That the living God personally has feeling for man, religion expresses by saying that God has a heart; this is the most inward and richest expression of fatherliness. Immediately man knows no other heart with personal feelings than his own: here, then, the beginning is made entirely humanly. Reflection, however, soon discovers that God cannot possibly have a heart like a man; the expression God's heart then becomes a figurative expression. God really has no heart, reflection then says; but the strife of immediacy with reflection is sublated in faith; for faith, with all its immediacy, is infinitely reflected. That the expression is figurative must be granted: God's fatherly heart is an image of reality, drawn upon the background of the Mystery. The organ of divine feeling is, like the unity of nature and spirit, uncognizable, and veils itself from man's gaze in an impenetrable darkness. Thus:

how God can personally feel, can be moved to compassion and kindled to wrath, of this revelation gives no enlightenment whatsoever; all questions belonging here are dismissed in religion as irrelevant to faith. But that God can feel, can be moved, can personally be stirred for man's sake, that is the fundamental thought of revelation, the thought of life that breathes in religion. The assurance is in faith. The more living [133] faith is, the greater is the warmth of inwardness with which the relation to God is cognized. The feelings that are awakened in the believing self are in the personal sense divine-human: to the strong feeling of guilt and transgression corresponds an equally strong feeling of God's punishing righteousness and wrath. The strong feelings express the living personal interaction between the human and the divine Self in reflected-immediate inwardness. Here the question is not of the difference between the figurative and the non-figurative; here the question is of the personal reality of the feelings, of the truth and strength of inwardness. That the images under which the now stern and wrathful, now mild and gracious Judge can show himself personally to the penitent are manifoldly colored and changed in the moved mind is a matter of course.

If we disregard the individual and reflect on the relation to God in its generality, the concept of the all-fatherly personality will be seen to develop along with the great phases of revelation; with regard to this development we may conceive the ideal of personality as the ideal of majesty, of love, of blessedness.

α) The Ideal of Majesty.

It cannot be sufficiently repeated, stressed, and impressed upon the mind that the doctrine of religion is from first to last, in the sense of the will, a doctrine of selfhood, a doctrine of the self; the relation to God is a relation of selfhood, a relation between the absolute and the relative, the original and the derived self; its grounds are grounds of selfhood, its assurance self-assurance. Only under this presupposition can there be talk of God's personality. The kernel of personality is the self. If the self is finite, relative, and perishable, then so is the personality. The finite personality may well have, in the finite world, a relatively higher worth than other finite things; but unconditioned [134] self-worth it cannot possibly have, inasmuch as it has no unconditioned self. The self

that in the relation to God is absolutely unconditioned is God himself in eternal might and majesty; the world in all its greatness is only a revelation of the sole might of the Eternal, the infinite self-might of the fatherly Author. As the one who holds the whole world in his power, the divine Self is infinitely opposed to the existing world, and in this opposition is raised above the world: God's personality, in the relation to God the ideal of all personality, is seen in the light of this its revelation as the ideal of majesty.

As the ideal of majesty, God with his personal sole might does not stand in the first instance in relation to the individual human being or to the individual things in the world; for the individual things and the individual human being vanish before his gaze as a nothing. "What is man, that thou art mindful of him?" It is the universe, the immeasurable whole, that presents itself to God. And yet this is still only the one side of majesty. If God, as he surveys the world, were so lost in the contemplation of the whole that for the whole he forgot the individual, then he would after all be, as it were, absorbed and impressed by outward greatness, and would not be the absolutely Exalted One. From the other side, then, majesty shows itself in this, that the great infinite whole is itself a nothing to the Almighty. But when the greatest is a nothing just as much as the least, then God's eye can rest on the least as well; when the total is something vanishing just as much as the particular and individual, then the Eternal in might and majesty can be mindful of the particular just as well as of the universal, of the individual just as well as of the total. Thus the divine Self fixes its gaze on the human; thus God's personality becomes the principle of man's personality; thus God is "mindful of man, makes him a little lower than the angels, crowns him with glory and honor."

- [135] It is not thoughts of knowledge but thoughts of faith, personal thoughts of impression, that the ideal of majesty will set in motion. The human consciousness that gets no further than bowing before the powers of nature is overwhelmed by outward greatness, loses the impression of itself, intoxicates itself with fantasies about the infinite, and dreams of liberation in the great nothing. This is the Indian pantheism of nature, a standpoint where individuality is a barrier and the self a torment; the thought of personality has not yet come into being. Different from the oriental pantheism of nature is the pantheism of spirit in the Occident, a fundamental philosophical view

that is just as pervasive in the present as it was in antiquity, and can develop just as well out of the dissolution of monotheism as out of that of polytheism. At this stage the self, by virtue of the absolute, will be sufficient unto itself; the thought of independence has been awakened; man cognizes himself as a personality coming into being, an actual one. But this personality is kernel-less, hollow, and false; for the self is the kernel of personality, and the pantheistic self, which can be blown out like a candle, is vain. Only impressions of the ideal of majesty can in faith awaken the human self and give its personality uprightness. It is a peculiar stamp that the ideal of majesty impresses on the relation to God. The believing self has, superficially seen, a deceptive likeness to the egoistic self; they resemble each other in all immediacy in this, that both love life and fear death. But the superficial likeness turns into decisive unlikeness when we consider that the life the believer loves is not the temporal but the eternal life, and the death he fears not the natural but the spiritual death. This must be held fast if we are to understand the personal thoughts of impression.

The pantheistic self immerses itself in the universal; it develops personality in the temporal on temporal terms; through this self-development it wants to be filled with the absolute; with a transitory eternity in the Idea it wants to satisfy itself and [136] prepare its self-dissolution. In conflict with the great life of the world, i.e. with actual events and laws, it practices resignation, and can practice resignation on a great scale. Resignation is this, that the individual will makes itself into the universal will, so that it essentially wills only what is universally necessary, universally rational. Since now the objectively universal, according to the fundamental view, is the selfless impersonal, the pantheistic self is from the ground up prepared for its dissolution and reconciled with objective necessity.

It is otherwise with the believing self. It is indeed prepared for death, natural death, but it is so far from being prepared for an essential and eternal self-dissolution that the thought of such a dissolution must appear to it the deepest self-contradiction. In order to cancel the self-contradiction it then raises its gaze toward the ideal of personality, and receives an impression that there is in the self a power that overcomes death. Thus the religious person develops a disposition to eternal personality. Instead of proceeding to self-dissolution he proceeds to self-affirmation; but it is a self-affirmation

that must stand its test.

For the sake of personal self-affirmation the believer will see the finger of God in all dispensations, and in all dangers trust in God's aid. But by virtue of the ideal of majesty something else befalls him. God's thoughts are far above man's thoughts, his will infinitely exalted above man's will. Far from finding either the way as he had imagined it, or help such as he had pictured it in human fashion, the believer finds barriers everywhere and the way out blocked. Necessity reigns; no regard is taken for the freedom of the individual; help from God fails to come; the one who struggles [137] in powerlessness must help himself as best he can: here all goes dark before the eye, here the believer must learn to resign himself.

Infinite resignation is at this stage doubly difficult to practice. The presupposition is that nothing, not even the most insignificant, happens without God's will, and yet the effects of this will are not immediately recognizable; the presupposition is that the Almighty can help in all dangers, and yet even in the extremity of mortal danger not a trace of personal help is to be discovered. It is as if God in all his majesty found this present actuality too mean, far too insignificant to concern himself with. Here resignation is what is called for. If the believer cannot carry resignation through, then he is lost, then doubt triumphs; faith turns over into unbelief, and it ends in despair. But if he can carry resignation through, then he triumphs doubly; for then he understands that the deepest self-affirmation can demand that the finite personality succumb sensuously, that a pressure in the temporal conditions an impression of eternity from the Eternal. Resignation is then not a compromise with necessity but a consecration to freedom. The expression of the fact that the consecration takes place, that the self rises up under the heavy pressure, is a distinguishing mark by which religious resignation differs essentially from merely rational resignation. Rational resignation ends in silence, in mute submission; but religious resignation, which in its relation to God has the impression of personal majesty, ends in adoration with thanks and praise.

As the ideal of personal majesty, the Almighty is the object of fear and reverence. The self that fears the impersonal powers of the world is cowed and unfree; it gives up its personality by bowing before the impersonal: the greater the fear, the greater

the subjugation. But the believing self that fears God gains in fear an impression of the ideal of personality and feels itself set free, liberated from selfish, finite, temporal [138] fear: the more inward the fear, the greater the liberation.

One human being may well look up with admiration to another, and recognize that the impressions owed to a noble, great, superior personality are beneficial. But if the person who, for all his superiority, is still finite becomes the object of unconditioned reverence, deification, and adoration, then the adorers have in the personal idol an essential barrier to their own personal self; the blinder the deification, the more fatal the barrier: it is slavish and degrading to place the ideal of personality in something external. It is otherwise when the human personality bows with holy reverence before God. More unconditionally than an oriental slave can cast himself in the dust before his mighty, silent despot, must the believing self bow before the high "All-disposing One, Creator of heaven and earth"; but religious reverence is, in its inner boundlessness, infinitely different from slavish reverence. In slavish reverence the unfree self succumbs to an alien, arbitrary power, and thereby proves that it has its ruling principle outside itself, that it has lost its personality; but the believing self that in adoration bows before the Father in heaven gains itself by giving itself up; for it bows humbly and yet personally free before the Author of its own personality.

***β*) The Ideal of Love.**

Judging by the ideal of majesty, however, the opposition between God and man is so great that the distance becomes infinite. The unity of essence that expresses itself in the relation to God, the relation of selfhood determining from both sides, is so abstract that a personal understanding must seem unattainable. Man indeed has self-being in likeness to God; but the self in almightiness and the self in powerlessness do not agree. The personal self must have a natural foundation; this holds just as much for [139] the divine as for the human personality. But that God's nature is other than man's shines forth clearly from the fact that in actual life there is ceaseless strife between God's will and man's. The relation is always strained: God and man stand, so to speak, on strained terms with each other. God is wroth with man, and man trembles before the wrathful God; it is a painful relation. So in the Old Testament: Jehovah's

countenance is terrible, whoever sees this countenance must die; Jehovah's judgments are terrible, he visits the iniquities of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation, his righteousness is as a flaming sword, his wrath a consuming fire. The true personal relation is a relation of love; but between sinful man and the holy God a relation of love is impossible.

According to the ideal of majesty, considered by itself, man relates to God as creature to Creator; at this stage the Mystery of love cannot be revealed: the relation of nature, the holy fundamental relation, is hidden. God cannot love man when he cannot recognize himself in man, his own true image, and man cannot love God when he cannot cognize in God his personal nature, the exemplar of his essence. With the actual, true man comes understanding. The true man has human nature, is of human descent, "born of a woman"; this self stands, according to its origin, to that extent on an equal level with the human self in general. But the true man is, in an exclusive sense, also of divine origin, has as God's Son divine nature: in this self God truly sees himself, the brightness of his glory, the express image of his essence (*Alter Ego*): the [140] true man is personally one with the true God. In the true man, then, God can love human beings, as in his own Son he originally loves himself; and human beings in turn can learn to love God, inasmuch as in the Son of Man, who is eternally God's Son, they can recognize and love the true divine-human Self.

This is the Mystery of all-love as of all-personality: that God the almighty has as his opposite not merely the world, the selfless other, and within it man, the powerless self, but has, in eternal self-opposition, himself as his opposite. If this self-opposition were only abstract and formal, then God's self-love would be only a divine self-seeking love, and self-seeking love would thereby be set up as the supreme principle of personality. But the self-contradiction in this is as glaring as the blasphemy. For the self-seeking one, who makes not only things but every self outside him into a means, into an impersonal other, has precisely in the impersonal other a barrier to his personality. The Mystery is that what from eternity constitutes the otherness in the divine self-opposition is not a merely outward world, for that is too little; not a finitely becoming humanity, for that is too little. Even an inward world, a world of Ideas in which the Idea of humanity forms the center, is too little, far too little: *the self-opposition requires*

a self. A divine one! Yes, but not tautologically, for then the opposition becomes formal and love egoism. A human one! Yes, but not a finite, powerless one; for in such a one God cannot cognize himself as God, cannot love himself. This is the Mystery, that only the divine-human Self, God's other Self, can express the unity of love in the one personal God: God is love.

To see what lies in this, we need only reflect on the self-contradiction in which the essence of love is dissolved when God's personality is denied, and the physiologically [141] limited individuality of human nature is to constitute the sole foundation of personality. This is not now to be understood as though the personal were to coincide immediately with the merely natural. On the contrary! The self that is disposed for free self-development is spiritual, its nature not merely sensuous but also spiritual: it has within it a lower and a higher nature, and personal development is determined precisely by the higher nature coming to master the lower. The self with its natural spiritual individuality stands originally in individual relations to other individualities likewise naturally spiritual; it has within it a double natural impulse: to hold on to itself and to give itself up; both are united in love. Thus the love between man and woman is natural and yet spiritual. It is the self's deepest need to give itself up in another self, unequal and yet of like kind; for through this self-surrender it gains itself in the full sense: it gains personality. Those united in love cognize that their individual union is borne by the personally universal, that this universal is something divine; they cognize that Eros is a deity, i.e. they cognize the Idea. From the spiritual natural love in the erotic, personal self-development advances further to free, conscious love of the Idea: personality is filled and moved by the concretely universal Ideas of art and science, of the state and the fatherland. The more vigorously individuality lives for the universal, the greater is the self-affirmation of its inner individual independence. But the demands of personality are first satisfied in the proper sense only when the individual learns to cognize the Idea of the good as the universally valid Idea of its essence, of its own better nature, and so learns to love the good. In love, the true, active love of the good, personality and the personal life then find their highest consummation. Not good actions singly, but the love of the good expressed in good [142] actions, love of what is in truth the absolute, consummates personality. Just as man

can love the good inwardly, in spirit and in truth, because the good is one with his ideal nature, so he can also love righteousness inwardly, in spirit and in truth, and through his love of the absolute in righteousness become righteous; can love holiness, and through his love of the absolute in holiness be sanctified. Only by letting go of God and grasping the absolute can the human personality be perfected in love.

The hollowness of this whole way of looking at things catches the eye once the gaze has fixed itself on the essence of love, the naturally determined spiritual relation of self to self. The goal of love is the most inward, deepest self-satisfaction. The more inward the need and the stronger the desire, the richer, warmer, more blessed the satisfaction. What, then, does the self need? Another self, equal yet unequal, with a nature of like kind, yet of unlike kind! The more essential the likeness within the pervading unlikeness, the more opposed the two natures are within the fundamental unity, the richer the satisfaction. The temporal self cannot love cold eternity; the relative subject cannot love the subjectless universal; unless it were to be a thinned-out love such as that with which the pure thinker loves the absolute in pure thinking with pure being. Personality can, in the absolute sense, love only the personal. The universal love of the Idea is ambiguous. It indeed stands higher than the immediate, instinct-bound love of an individual, insofar as it is spiritual and free, reflected in knowledge and will; but it stands lower insofar as the Idea, this universal selfhood without a self, cannot return love. Satisfaction in love is conditioned by love returned: [143] only in the inner infinitude of love returned, of mutual love, is love perfected. From this can be seen the difference between loving God and loving an Idea. To love the Idea as Idea is to love the impersonal, whose secret is that love, without love returned, ends in the dissolution of the self; for the Idea as Idea and the self as self are, in their opposition, not of the same nature. But to love God as God is to love the eternally rich personal Self, the fatherly Author of all personality; it is to love, in love returned, him who first loved us; it is, in spirit and in truth, to love oneself.

γ) The Ideal of Blessedness.

It will always appear to the consciousness that reflects on the universal as though it were at bottom more rational to think of God according to the ideal of majesty

than according to that of love. As love itself, the all-good God is surely the God of the heart, and as the God of the heart the heavenly Father. But when the heavenly Father is to be conceived as Lord of all the world, the almighty Creator of heaven and earth, and thus in truth as the God of the spirit, then the spirit is cold, and it seems as though the representations of the God of the spirit and the God of the heart would not let themselves be united in one concept. The reason for this is, after what we have elucidated concerning the Mystery, explicable enough. As the unity of will of might and knowledge, God according to the ideal of majesty is the Eternally High, the Father of lights, "with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning." In the God of the spirit not even the remotest hint of natural oppositions is to be discovered. As the unity of love of Father and Son, on the other hand, the divine essence is an essence doubled in its holy ground of nature; from this doubling spring countless oppositions: it is as though the naturally necessary oppositions overwhelmed the free unity. If it were now possible to begin with the spirit itself and develop nature from it, or conversely to begin with nature in God and from it develop the spirit, then it would also be possible [144] to develop the ideals of majesty and of love from one and the same concept; but both are, according to the Mystery, equally impossible. For the same reason a rich, intuitive development of the ideal of blessedness is then also impossible. To say in few words what blessedness is, or rather what is to be understood by the word blessedness: that by it is to be understood the life perfect in itself, the life of all-love in its inner, holy light, its eternal peace and rest, is an easy matter; but what is then gained by this? In the essence of blessedness the deepest oppositions, the strongest tensions, are at once both posited and yet equalized. What, humanly speaking, is a blessed moment? To grasp the moment itself we must consider what goes before it. It is a need so strong, a thirst so burning, a longing so inward, a desire so irresistible, that if satisfaction failed to come the torments of hell would be unbearable: that the need is sated, the want stilled, and the delight of refreshment drunk in deep draughts, that is precisely the blessedness of the moment. This holds not only of the sensuous-psychic but also of the spiritual. There is a sensuous hunger, but there is also a spiritual hunger. If there were no spiritual hunger, there would be no spiritual satiety either, and if spiritual hunger could not be still more tormenting than sensuous hunger, then satiety would

be dull and flat, and there would be no blessedness in the spirit.

But to make the ideal of blessedness intuitive on such a foundation is equally impossible in faith and in knowledge. If all tensions are equalized, all oppositions leveled, then eternal peace comes with eternal stillness; but this stillness is without movement, in the infinite peace there is no life, in the boundless uniformity no warmth, [145] no riches of inwardness. If, conversely, emphasis is laid on the immediate elements of difference in natural oppositions, then there comes not only life and stir but also, what Jacob Böhme saw in powerful intuition, ferment and strife and torment and wrath and anguish and tension into the eternal essence of all-love; but where then is blessedness?

The ideal of blessedness is categorically an ideal of revelation or, what expresses precisely the same thing, an ideal of faith. Of what in the human sense we must call a blessed moment, everyone knows, after all, that it can be cognized only either by being immediately experienced and thus enjoyed really, or, if without actually being experienced it is to be enjoyed ideally in a vivid presentation, that it is then not science but poetry that is able to do it justice. On the other hand, it now seems to have been entirely forgotten that the concept of blessedness in the religious sense cannot be a concept of knowledge, but belongs to faith alone. And yet it is surely explicable enough that the ideal of blessedness, the ideal of perfect personal life, is not capable of making an immediate impression on the merely knowing consciousness — of metaphysicians who become blessed in the Absolute we will not speak — but for the life of faith in struggle and suffering the ideal has the most decisive significance.

Faith is, as now sounds almost like a figure of speech, a matter of blessedness. That blessedness is the goal can then also be expressed by saying that life in God is the goal. The ideal of blessedness thus coincides with the ideal of God, i.e., with the perfect ideal of personality. It is again the fundamental relation between nature and spirit on which everything depends. Personality can as little be perfected in natureless spirituality as in immediate naturalness; all essential misjudgments of the ideal of blessedness accordingly also show themselves as practical deviations from the ideal of [146] personality. We see it both in moralism and in mysticism. “Two things,” says Kant, “fill me with the highest admiration: the starry heavens above my head and the moral law

in my breast.” In that the moral law is referred to the lawgiver, the ideal of majesty is made to count, but in an entirely one-sided way. How one-sided the conception is can be seen from the fact that the moral law, the law of freedom, of personality, is set in so original a conflict with the promptings of nature, the higher as well as the lower, that the universal must in principle consume the individual; the “happiness” which is to be attained in a life to come, when God’s justice at last evens out the disproportion between worth and fate, is owed to an arrangement which concerns personality itself only insofar as, according to the principle, it must necessarily end by annihilating both duty and virtue. To an opposite extreme the mystics have gone, especially those who, in an overflowing feeling of the unity of essence of God and man, have quite forgotten the ideal of majesty over that of love; in the mystical relation of love man has in this way become as indispensable to God as God to man; here the well-known verse fits: “Ich weiss, dass ohne mich Gott nicht ein Nu kann leben; Werd ich zu nicht, er muss von Noth den Geist aufgeben.” In this twilight of inwardness, nature and spirit have then so completely dissolved each other that the light of freedom, and with it of personality, has gone out both for God and for man.

In order to grasp the reciprocal relation between love and blessedness, we must lay weight on freedom. The goal of personality is freedom; but man’s freedom demands self-development, and self-development demands struggle. While reason and humanity will always secure for themselves the highest thing of freedom by setting the Idea above the struggling self, religion reverses the relation and sets the struggling self above the Idea. By setting the self above the Idea, religion by no means wishes to flatter human self-love; on the contrary! it wishes precisely to make an end of self-love; [147] it wishes to purge egoism out from the root. In that it lays decisive weight on the eternity of the self and sets up the blessed God as exemplar, it can rightly demand a thoroughgoing sacrifice of the temporal. Self-sacrifice through renunciation, pain and death is then an actual testing of the freedom of the self, a confirmation of its personal, indelible independence, a preparation for blessedness. “Be ye perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect”; the perfect life of personality is blessedness: be ye blessed!

But the struggle of temporality stands sharply against the peace of eternity, natural

life against spiritual. If this opposition is now conceived in such a way that the natural is without further ado identified with the sinful, while natureless spirituality is made one with the holy, then we have asceticism. The ascetic, in blind zeal for a natureless spirituality, will break the staff over nature as nature. The rich immediacy of existence, what delights the eye and refreshes the mind and gladdens the heart, yes, the heart itself, if it were possible, he would gladly see uprooted, extirpated, annihilated, for the sake of blessedness; but what sort of blessedness is that? The natureless spirit never becomes blessed. And wherein lies the sinful? It is in the strictest sense not nature that has made the will sinful; it is conversely the will that has made nature sinful. Spirit as spirit is not the enemy of nature; were spirit the enemy of nature, then there would be no hope of blessedness, then the Father in heaven would himself not be blessed.

Just as blessedness presupposes love, so it also presupposes personal independence: love and independence are united in the Spirit. This again throws light on the relation of love to freedom. If love is considered one-sidedly by itself, then the opposed personalities stand, as it were, on the point of dissolving and melting together in [148] immediate devotion; if freedom is considered one-sidedly by itself, then independence becomes so hard that the independent ones, like monads, close themselves off from one another. The intensified opposition is a hint that in freedom itself there must be a need for a strong uniting middle. If each of the independent ones is free and strong by personal will, then the higher power that is to unite them must also be free and strong by personal will: this power is the Spirit. As merely universal, even if rich in Ideas, selfhood, the Spirit cannot possibly unite self with self when each self, in its wealth of inwardness, is unconditionally independent. If the particular wills have a stronger self than the will of the Spirit, then the opposition will also be stronger than the unity: each individual will then retain a surplus of isolating self-will, a doubtful remnant of Idea-egoism, which brings freedom into conflict with love and disturbs blessedness. Weakness in the Spirit is inseparably one with a weakness in freedom, an enfeeblement in personality. The power of the Spirit is in the will; its blessedness is to found a kingdom of personally opposed wills upon the difference of freedom in the unity of love. For the will of the Father and of the Son are in the Spirit one and

the same will, and precisely thereby two wills opposed in love itself: they could not be one true free will if they were not two, and they could not be two if they were not one in the Spirit's own absolute self-will.

That God, according to the ideal of majesty, is raised above all oppositions means in the language of religion that he masters all oppositions; but that he masters all oppositions means in turn that with freedom in love he enters into all the oppositions, those of temporality and sinfulness as well; that he, in other words, "lives a double life, a life in himself in undimmed peace and self-sufficiency, and a life in and with his creature, in which he submits himself to the conditions of finitude, yes, lets his power be restricted by man's sinful will. In this life of God together with his creature, the [149] biblical concepts of a divine sorrow, wrath and other determinations which manifestly place a restriction on the divine blessedness find their application. But this restriction is sublated in his inner life of perfection, wholly independent of the creature, and in the victory-assured foresight of the fulfillment of his counsels. In the outer chambers — we therefore say with the old theosophers — there is sorrow, but in the inner chambers there is nothing but joy."¹⁴

B.

The Works of the Father.

§ 10.

To speak directly scientifically of the works of the Father is in itself just as contradictory and meaningless as to speak directly scientifically either of the Trinity or of blessedness or of the personality of the Father. But just as rational science must be said to be within its good right when it declines to treat the concepts of faith, so the philosophy of religion, the inverted, antirational science, must be said to be within its good right when, in consequence of the principle of faith, it expressly aims at putting the categories of revelation into force. The philosophy of religion can to that extent at its ease, without any particular exertion, continue the fight against a marrowless, immature metaphysics which has not yet learned to heed the limit of knowledge and

¹⁴H. Martensen. *Den christelige Dogmatik*. S. 105.

[150] acknowledge the Mystery; but in its endeavor to keep the principles of religion and of science apart, the inverted science must take good care that it does not itself, in the struggle against the encroachment of scientific thinking, come into conflict with the laws of thought.

There is a law of thought that forbids placing determinations of finitude in the Absolute. From this it has then been derived that, since God is the Absolute and determinations of finitude cannot be transferred to God, God cannot be said to act or to do definite works either; particular actions, definite works are determinations of finitude: from this standpoint, then, it would be a pure self-contradiction to speak of God's works.

What is logically groundless in this objection is easy to make clear. Without determinations of finitude there could be no determinations of infinity at all: every determination of the infinite is a reflex of a corresponding determination of finitude sublated in reflection. That God stands in a relation of infinity to the world thus by no means excludes the moments of finitude corresponding to this relation, but on the contrary takes them up into itself. So much as regards the abstractly logical. If we next lay stress on the fact that the God of religion is not a selfless absolutum, but the absolute Self in the unity of will of knowledge and power, of power and wisdom, then the determinations of finitude contained in the relation of infinity will expressly correspond to such categories of personality as action and work. The personality that acts works, after all, out of its inner totality and concentrates its essence in the single, definite act of will. God's works reflect at one and the same time the inner, infinite totality in God himself and the outer infinite, and precisely thereby finite, totality in [151] the world. Such works of totality are: *creation, preservation and governance*¹⁵.

¹⁵The formal reciprocal determination of finite and infinite can best of all be made clear by a philosophical elucidation of what in mathematics is called the analysis of the infinite. (Cf. "Mathematik og Dialektik.") But once insight into this reciprocal determination has been won, it can in turn contribute from many sides to clearing up the relation between necessity and freedom, nature and spirit, the world and God. The interconnection of the world (the expression of necessity) is infinite; the working of the divine will (the expression of freedom) is infinite. But if one then wishes to conclude from this that necessity and freedom are, without any difference, one in the Absolute, one concludes in philosophy just as falsely as if in mathematics one assumed without further ado $\frac{\infty}{\infty} = 1$ and $\infty - \infty = 0$. He who, from the circumstance that we are not able to demonstrate the reciprocal action between natural causes and God's will in the particular case, would conclude that there is no reciprocal action, that the divine causality of will must consequently drop out, concludes in philosophy just as rashly as he who, from the

a) Creation.

§ 11.

The worldview according to which alone there can be talk of creation is the one taken up into the relation to God itself, the religious one. Herein lies the fact that there can and must be another view of the world, falling outside the relation to God, namely the empirical-rational one, according to which there is not in the proper sense talk of creation, but only of nature. Nature is a concept of knowledge, creation a concept of faith: between nature and creation lies the Mystery. An objection such as this — [152] that in religion there is also talk of nature, both of the nature of the world and of God, and in science of creation, in geology, e.g., of periods of creation, and that the concept of nature must consequently just as well be capable of being called a concept of faith as the concept of creation a concept of knowledge — is without significance. What matters here is not words and designations, but the methodical development and grounding of the content of the real concepts. In what now follows we shall treat first the scientifically naturalistic view, then the immediately religious view, and finally investigate how matters stand with the question of principle on both sides.

α) The Scientifically Naturalistic View: Cosmogony.

From nothing comes nothing: this universally logical proposition receives in the doctrine of nature a confirmation of its own through the rational-empirical consideration of the coming to be and passing away of things. Anaxagoras already pointed out to the Hellenes that they wrongly assumed a becoming. Things form themselves by combinations of eternal fundamental parts, and they are dissolved again when the fundamental parts are separated. The old doctrine of eternal fundamental parts, atoms,

indeterminacy of the forms $\frac{0}{0}$, $\infty \cdot 0$, 0^0 , $\infty - \infty$, would conclude that these indeterminate forms cannot be transitional forms of determinate functions and as such have determinate values. In all natural effects there are differential effects of divine will; but it is one thing to acknowledge the cooperation of the preserving and governing will in general, another to be able to determine the functions.

The scholastic perplexities with *concursus*, *gubernatio* and *conservatio* spring from two mistakes: 1) unknown functions are treated as known, and 2) it is forgotten that the continuous transition from finite natural effects to finitely determined effects of freedom takes place through differential effects.

has found recognition and further development in modern science: the doctrine of the eternity of atoms, i.e., of matter, must now presumably be regarded almost as an axiom in the natural sciences. With this the doctrine of natural forces and causes stands in the closest connection. The atom acts; matter has force; force and matter cannot be separated: the material forces have their possibility in the properties of matter. From this it follows that everything produced in nature must have natural causes; the realm of nature is an infinite system of presuppositions, conditions and consequences; possibilities, dispositions, real grounds are, in their manifestations and [153] modes of appearance, subject to unchangeable laws: everything that happens happens solely through the fulfillment of the laws; this holds just as inflexibly of the formations in organic as in inorganic nature.

In organic nature the formations do indeed assume a peculiar stamp of self-formation, and philosophy has to that extent reason to characterize the cause of life as an Idea-cause, a self-cause working in matter. But while it is still unclear to the physicist how something that in itself is as immaterial as an Idea-cause must be can act upon matter and subject to itself the elementary material causes, it is on the other hand both clear and certain to him that the living organism rests on a peculiar cooperation of a system of physical forces. That plan and type show themselves in organic dispositions and formations must be granted; the living organism presents a totality of means and ends. But the teleological points at no point beyond necessity; here in this ingenious order there is no thought of consciousness, in the many works and mysterious workshops no trace of any free master-workman; no spirit and will, no fatherly Self does any work here: motherly nature does everything from blind and yet never erring drive, with wonderfully sure instinct. Only when every notion of the cooperation of a free, creating will has been removed will one understand that the world cannot have any finite beginning in time, that its natural self-formation can, by filling out an eternal time, unite time with eternity. Natural development proceeds on the whole slowly: no intermediate link may here be skipped, no secondary causes, however insignificant they may seem, be lacking with their conditions. The developmental history of the terrestrial globe must be reckoned in billions, and the formation of our planetary system perhaps in billions times billions of years. An almighty Creator

could well have finished all this in less than six days; but a miraculously accelerated production would then also have reduced the whole natural development to semblance. [154] How should natural seed be able to come forth from created, i.e., not natural, plants, or natural offspring from created, i.e., not natural, animals? The natural must have a natural origin: to wish to derive the natural world from a non-natural cause is a contradiction.

We have in these few strokes indicated the character of the naturalistic extreme, and shall now briefly give a characterization of the supranaturalistic or biblically religious one.

β) The Biblically Religious View: Creation in Six Days.

“In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth”; herewith it is declared: partly that the production of the world is an absolute act of freedom, an actual work of God; partly that the coming into being of the finitely determined world is to be referred to a definite point of beginning lying in time. It is the finite determinateness of the representation, the immediately intuitable, on which weight is laid here. “And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.” In an entirely childlike, naive manner the waste and empty earth is here set, as a foundation already produced by the creation and yet natural, elemental, externally over against the Creator, while the externality in this opposition is again sublated by the fact that the Spirit, the substantial unity of the almighty thoughts and forces, moves upon the waters. “And God said, Let there be light: and there was light. And God saw the light, that it was good.” This presentation is characteristic in its particulars. The almighty, fatherly Self reveals itself in this work acting with free inwardness; it appears human and is yet in essence divine. That the creating will must work in unity with thought and the word is, as surely as the act of creation is to be a true act of freedom, understandable. First, [155] then, light exists in God’s inner being, according to its concept in thought through the word; next the word passes from the inner as a word of almighty power over into outer actuality: the actual light, the realized concept, is also a word of God, a word of power in the external. Finally — so finitely are the moments distinguished — God

looks and sees that what has been produced actually and completely corresponds to what was thought; herewith the beginning has taken place: the morning of creation has dawned.

In agreement with the act of creation here described all the following ones take place. Step by step the work advances, and it is completed with the creation of man. Since man, created in God's image, is the crown of creation and destined to rule over the earth, it is a matter of course that the earth is regarded as the center of the universe, and that sun, moon and stars are created to shine over the earth. This conception of the structure of the world and its purpose, certainly very restricted compared with the widened horizon of the present, is from the standpoint of religion nonetheless perfectly correct insofar as it is essentially determined by the relation to God: the cognition of the world and the cognition of God intervene in each other in an infinite manner. But no further than that.

From a Bible-believing standpoint much has been made of the fact that the order in which the work of creation advances agrees on the whole with the natural sequence of stages for the lower and higher, elemental and organic productions, and it has thus been sought to vindicate historical truth for the narrative. But already Celsus found it unreasonable that the Mosaic history of creation spoke of days before the sun was created, so that the interpreters had to help themselves as best they could, either by assuming an alternating expansion and contraction of the light, which before its concentration into firmly bounded luminous bodies was still an ether, or by taking refuge in allegories. — The description of Adam's creation, that he is formed of clay [156] (red earth), that Jehovah breathes the breath of life into his nostrils, etc., cannot give any picture belonging to natural history, any more than the later narrative of the creation of woman from the man's rib. It must indeed be granted that the doctrine of nature is not itself able to set up any probable hypothesis about the appearance of man on earth; but it may for all that be fully entitled to reject a mode of presentation that is incompatible with its scientific character. In order to defend themselves against the objections of critique on the ground that God, according to Gen. 1:27, creates man and woman at the same time, but according to 2:7, 21 ff. first the man alone and later the woman, the apologists had either to assume that the first account was merely a

summary statement of what is depicted more circumstantially in what follows, or, with Augustine, to distinguish between the production of man according to possibility and his actual appearance. This shows sufficiently that the literal interpretation cannot be carried through.

That the historical here does not belong to the essence of faith is seen from the fact that the particulars, represented one by one, cannot possibly acquire any influence on determining the relation to God more closely. The Creator does not become more almighty because he uses only six days to create the world in than if he had used six thousand years; the decisive thing is that he creates. The Creator does not become more free, not more loving and good, because he creates the man first and the woman afterwards, than if he had created them both at once; the decisive thing is that God created man in his image, that he “created them male and female.”

Yet one misgiving still remains. “Whence do we know that God has created the world, except from God’s word? But God’s word about creation is, after all, precisely inseparable from the history of creation. If we cannot believe the history as actual, then neither can we believe in God’s word; if we can believe in God’s word, then [157] we can also believe in the historical actuality of the account.” To meet misgivings of this kind we need only recall the distinction developed in the Introduction between profane and sacred history. The history of creation is surely not to be conceived as a piece of supernatural natural history: for if it really were to be so, then we should ask in vain for the testimony of the Spirit. All natural history is profane history, just as much as general world history; concerning the visible things of natural history the Holy Spirit gives no testimony. But the history of creation is history of revelation; the actuality of the history of revelation is actuality of the Spirit, actuality for the Spirit.

γ) Creation and Cosmogony: The Mystery.

That the existing world is a work of God’s unconditionally free omnipotence is the fundamental thought of revelation, the kernel of the whole doctrine of creation, the one thing that can be believed and must unconditionally be believed. The assurance that God has actually created this world does not depend on the accounts in the first book of Moses; it stands and falls with the relation to God, it lies in the essence of

faith. Here again it holds: the improbable must be believed, but the impossible cannot be believed. Could science in truth prove the impossibility that the world actual in nature can have been created by God, then faith and knowledge could not be united in one consciousness; then it would be impossible for the one who knows to believe. But knowledge with its cosmogonic concept of nature is just as little able to disprove creation as faith with its religious concept of creation is able to infringe upon the concept of nature. From this standpoint we continue the negotiations between religion and science.

[158] As regards, in the first place, science, it is not physics — physics is within its good right — but metaphysics, the one-sided and false metaphysics, that has done its part to undermine faith in creation. It is chiefly three categories, *power*, *matter* and *disposition*, about which the investigation turns.

Power. In his presentation of “the religion of majesty” Hegel¹⁶ has apparently asserted and acknowledged the creative power in its unity with goodness. “God can in the true sense be creator only as infinite subjectivity; thus he is free ... only what is free can have its determinations over against itself as something free. ... This going-forth from one another, whose totality is the world, this being is goodness. But the being of the world is only the being of *power*, or the positive actuality and independence of the world is not its *own* independence, but *the independence of power*.” — One would now suppose that the independence of power must be sought in the divine Self exalted above the world, that is, in the free, willing God himself; but no! “The world must ... with regard to power be represented as something *broken* in itself: the one side is the manifoldness of difference, the infinite richness of existence; the other side is then the substantiality of the world; but this does not belong to the world itself, it is *the identity of essence* with itself.” This essence, whose identity with itself is nevertheless not supposed to be the world itself, is, when we look more closely, none the less the world’s own essence, the form of its own being existing for itself. The pantheistic mark is that the Self, the creating Self, “the infinite subjectivity,” is posited only in order to be extinguished again, comes only in an intimation only to vanish again into the universally necessary “identity of essence with itself.”

¹⁶Philos. d. Relig. II Theil. S. 55–56.

The ambiguity is removed in logical theism¹⁷. Here the ontological subjectivity, the substantial selfhood, is reflected into itself in such a way that the infinite power [159] can be seen to be centralized into self-power. Just as otherness stands against selfhood, so power-of-another stands against self-power. There is in the essence of power a doubling which must be rightly impressed upon us. Actual power must have an opposite, something that it can master: the weaker that is which is mastered, the weaker is the power; the stronger that which is mastered, the greater is the power. Already from this one sees how matters stand with God's omnipotence and the actuality of the world. It is not the case, as a metaphysics enervated by abstractions supposes, that the divine self-power would make the independence of the world into semblance; for if God's power had only a world of semblance to master, it would sink down to a mere power of semblance. But the fact is that the relative independence of the world is posited by the absolute self-power as the latter's own immanent opposite. Instead of standing as an external resistance, a limit to omnipotence, the actual independence of the world over against God expresses, on the contrary, its absolute dependence on God. The identity of this dependence and this independence gives us the concept of God's infinite over-power: God's infinite over-power is one with his unconditioned self-power.

Matter. The most essential hindrance to assuming a creation would presumably lie in the doctrine of the acknowledged eternity of matter. Could science actually prove that the atoms with their present properties are in themselves absolutely independent, then faith in creation would undeniably have to be given up. But what science would conduct such a proof? Natural science, which is now properly the one that holds to the atoms and makes the atomic theory fruitful, cannot conduct the proof. What does the empirical doctrine know about the atoms? It knows that they are the ultimate limits which scientific analyses have so far reached; it recognizes that these limits are movable, that substances formerly regarded as indivisible have since proved to [160] be divisible; it shows the atoms, not in hard, absolute closedness, but in relations that amply demonstrate their mutual infinite relativity. It is not the material point in its material immediacy that is the unchangeable; its unchangeableness lies in its

¹⁷Cf. Grundideernes Logik I og II.

substantial character as a point of function; through their interaction the discrete points of function become moments of bodily continua.¹⁸ The rapidly advancing science of chemistry is precisely in the course of leading the expert, through an atomic theory distinctly developed in all directions, back to the old assumption of the infinite formability of matter, of its being according to possibility; but, to be sure, in such a way that this formability conditioned by discreteness, this law-determined being according to possibility, is essentially different from the Aristotelian. No, it is not physics but an extremely crude, superficial metaphysics that postulates the eternity of the atoms.

To get the atoms reduced to moments of discreteness is, however, not enough: we must further consider the relation of the atoms, and thus of matter, to power. The old dispute for and against a creation out of nothing betrays in equal degree an unclarity in the disputants about the essence of matter as well as of power. God can just as little be thought to have created the world out of a pure nothing as out of a matter found ready to hand. Instead of nothing and matter we posit the reality of omnipotence. The nothing of which there is talk here is matter, conceived as the immediate other of power, as the first universal and yet finite opposite within power itself: that matter is nothing means that it has not a glimmer of independent being from itself, but that [161] all its being is from God's power; that nothing is as a stuff, a matter, means that the opposite which self-power has posited as its other has immediate existence precisely through power and from power. Immediate existence in the form of otherness is the issue of power in an infinite swarm of discrete points, and thus we have the atoms.

Disposition. The mythical cosmogonies of antiquity are in general so grown together with corresponding theogonies that the latter even play the chief role; these speculative sketches of fantasy explain to us neither nature nor creation. It is otherwise with the cosmogonic hypotheses of modern science; they are grounded on observations, they are strictly naturalistic. When Kepler had discovered the great laws of the universe and Newton had developed "the mathematical principles of natural philosophy," the foundation was given. It is characteristic, however, that Newton for his own person, without a trace of skepticism, united the physical and the religious, the naturalistic and

¹⁸Cf. Forelæsninger over "Philosophisk Propædeutik" fra Universitetsaaret 1860–61. S. 143–177.

the supranaturalistic, conception with one another in an entirely immediate, almost mechanical way, without wavering in faith in the omnipotence of the Creator. There is in this personal phenomenon, no doubt, something more than the merely personal. If we consider the system of the world, most immediately our solar system, in Newton's theory, then it is indeed so that all motions can be derived from the two fundamental determinations, the inertia of matter and the law of attraction; but in order to explain the system in its given actuality, a plurality of particular presuppositions and conditions was nevertheless necessary. These particular conditions — the initial velocity, the intensity and direction of the impulse, etc. — were apparently independent of one another; the wonderful concurrence of the conditions, although from the standpoint of mechanics it looked like pure chance, gave a reflection of plan and purpose and eternal wisdom and still left a place for the religious conception. This place, however, became ever narrower as the surmise of a fundamental presupposition enclosing all particular presuppositions grew and at last found an expression in the Kant-Laplace hypothesis. According to this hypothesis, the primal nebula, contracting and rotating as it contracted, contained all the presuppositions requisite for the natural self-formation of the solar system. How satisfactory the hypothesis has been in a cosmogonic respect for the author of *Exposition du système du monde* is expressed tellingly enough in the answer he is said to have given Napoleon when the latter asked why he had not taken creation into account: *Sire, je n'avais pas besoin de cette hypothèse.* [162]

Can the Laplacean hypothesis now demonstrate the impossibility of a free creation? Far from it! There are ambiguities in the primal nebula that easily escape the physicist's attention. The hypothesis presupposes that the formation of the world-system in question has a definite beginning in time. What, then, precedes the formation beginning in time? The matter distributed in immense space! But if this matter is to have existed from eternity, then it becomes inexplicable how, after having been in an eternal rest, it has at last come into motion. Further, the rotating primal vapor must not only have contained the mass out of which, besides the sun as central body, planets and satellites could be formed so that the purely mechanical laws of motion were fulfilled; it must also, as a glance at the history of the earth teaches, have contained

in proportionate quantities all the diverse substances on whose physical, chemical, physico-chemical and organic interactions all subsequent formations, organic as well as inorganic, depend, and from which they can be derived with necessity: the primal nebula must, in other words, have contained a closed system of world-possibilities, an inner manifoldness of dispositions toward dispositions toward a progressive total development. But this looks all too nebulous. To explain such a disposition there is [163] required in truth more than nebula: a rich sum of real principles and Ideas must be hidden in this nebula. But Ideas and nebulae are incompatible unless they are united in the ideal-real power of the Godhead, in the ontological subjectivity, the self-power rich in Ideas, which according to the logic of theism alone can ground a disposition of the world.

Through the categories power, matter and disposition we are thus led to one and the same point of selfhood; but here too is the outermost limit of knowledge: the articulating determinations of selfhood lose themselves in the Mystery.

If we next proceed from the presupposition of religion and begin with the creating will, then there is in the concept of creation, conceived as a concept of faith, certainly nothing that stands in conflict with the knowledge that cognizes its limit. The free beginning, the free disposition of the world corresponding to the Idea of wisdom, goodness and love, and therewith God's free power over this present world, faith can unconditionally assert without in any way encroaching upon science. But from the ideal presuppositions of freedom it is impossible to develop and ground the corresponding formations of nature, impossible to make any rational transition from creation to cosmogony: all the intermediate determinations necessary for articulation lose themselves in the Mystery.

"Could God have refrained from creating the world?"¹⁹ "Can the whole universe be thought to have a beginning in time?" "Is one to think, in the creation of the heavens and the earth, of the whole universe or only of a part of it?" Such questions betray themselves plainly enough as boundary questions for science just as much as for religion.

When it is asserted in the name of religion that God could have refrained from

¹⁹Dogmatics has done ill to take up such problems of knowledge.

creating the world, then no other thought can be connected with this than that God [164] has brought forth the world with freedom (*solo liberrimæ voluntatis suæ imperio*, Quenstedt); but the grounds of freedom, as we have seen, do not exclude the necessity of the Idea, only that the necessity has been taken up into the self-determination of the will. When science emphasizes that the concept of God becomes empty if the content of the world, the inner together with the outer, is thought away, that God's omnipotence must necessarily presuppose an actual world, since the real revelation of power must necessarily posit and presuppose the other in which power can be revealed: then this necessity cannot possibly exclude freedom. Necessity states only the universal, that a world must be presupposed; but *which* world? That depends unconditionally on freedom.

The question of the beginning of the world, the universal, first, very first beginning, is in itself a nebulous question, just as nebulous as the notion of the boundless universe. The universe is not a finitely determinate world, but a system of worlds, or rather a system of world-systems. If we now say with Augustine: *Deus fecit omnia simul*, then this timeless *fecit* cancels every finitely determinate act of creation and shows us the relation between God and the universe as a universal fundamental relation. Against such a fundamental relation nothing can be objected from the standpoint of knowledge. Now inasmuch as science lays weight on the inner necessary connection of the world-systems, so that each system, and each world, comes into existence in its time and in its place precisely in accordance with the conditions lying in the infinite whole, it must expressly lay weight on the fact that every particular world has its particular beginning, a beginning with a particular disposition. But, religion adds, a particular disposition is a disposition of the Idea determined with divine freedom; thus nature, the nature of this world, with its ends, conditions and means, is originally [165] subordinated to the spirit, and the blind selfless powers are dependent on the eternally seeing self-power.

And where, then, is the limit of the world of which religion speaks? In the outward there is no definite limit; the limit is in the inward. The difference between the religious and the scientific picture of the world is, in brief, this: that the one who knows sees nature everywhere in the creation, while the believer sees the creation

everywhere in nature. The religious gaze would go through the heavens, yes, through “the heaven of heavens,” were it possible, just as much as the scientific; but while the knowing contemplation goes from the natural to the natural, from the necessary to the necessary, out into the boundless, the believing view goes through the natural to the supernatural, through the kingdom of necessity to the kingdom of freedom, through the creation to the Creator. In the relation to God the outward greatness of the world’s power is reduced to a sensuous measure for the inward greatness of self-power, and the heaven of nature to a symbol for that of the spirit. Therefore the language of religion speaks of God in the heavens, of the Almighty, Creator of heaven and earth, of angels and powers that surround the Creator’s throne.

Here, then, there is no conflict between faith and knowledge, but there is indeed a conflict between believers and knowers, when both, each from their own side, disoriented as much in the fundamental requirements of faith as in those of knowledge, confuse what is absolutely heterogeneous and by this confusion bring about a confusion of thought most ruinous and deplorable in theoretical as well as in practical respect.

b) Preservation.

§ 12.

[166] The one-eyed consciousness which, if it gets sight of knowledge, will explain everything, faith too, scientifically, or, if it has turned toward faith, will derive all truths, the scientific ones too, from the presuppositions of faith, can never come to true insight into the relation between nature and creation. What can be seen in this relation must be seen in preservation. The religious view is that the Creator preserves his creation; the scientific, that nature preserves itself. Religiously understood, preservation is to level out the chasm between nature and creation; but regarded in the light of science, preservation in this sense is just as incomprehensible as creation. So-called sound human understanding is inclined to separate creation from preservation in such a way that creation is a miracle, preservation on the other hand a natural matter. The first

origin of the world, of all things, no one can explain; here it is permissible to assume a miracle relegated to primeval time; but once the world has come into being and been wisely arranged as a great, well-ordered whole, things act by their own powers; everything then goes its natural course, so that no continued divine cooperation can be thought of, still less an immediate and arbitrary intervention on God's part. That such a separation between a miraculous beginning and a natural continuation of the life of the world is thoughtless must be admitted. As the beginning is, so must the continuation be; as the origin is, so must the development be. We convince ourselves of this by considering *creation* and *preservation*, *preservation* and *natural process*, and *the Mystery of preservation*.

α) Creation and Preservation.

The unity in principle of creation and preservation has been developed from the standpoint of knowledge, in a manner as forceful as it is one-sided, by Malebranche. The fundamental thought of faith, that God is the free, almighty cause of the world, Malebranche transformed into a thought of knowledge, with the consequence that in the world of things and causes God is the only efficient cause (*causa efficiens*)²⁰. That [167] finite things are taken for efficient causes happens through a deception of the senses, or rather through a deception of the understanding brought about by sensuous will. The one thing cannot of itself effect changes in the other: the ball that strikes another, so that motion arises through the impact, is not in truth the efficient cause of the motion; the will that seems to move hand and foot is not in truth the efficient cause of the movements. And why not? Because an efficient cause, according to Malebranche, can be thought only as a creating cause. A creating cause is a god. Were created things to be efficient causes, they would have to act as created gods; but created gods are impossible: God cannot create efficient causes, for God cannot create gods. When it nonetheless appears to the natural understanding as if the world of things were a world of naturally efficient causes, this phenomenon undeniably requires an explanation. The explanation is that natural causes are only apparent causes, finite transitional links for the true divine cause, and thus, for God, sheer occasional causes.

²⁰Similar views occur already in the Middle Ages, e.g. among the Arabic philosophers *Meddaberim*.

When the one ball strikes the other, God takes occasion from the impact to call forth a motion; when the will wants to move hand or foot, God takes occasion from this to effect the movement. That the one efficient, almighty cause is perfectly independent of all occasioning causes is expressed thus: God can, when he will, refrain from using the occasion, so that the natural cause calls forth no effect at all, or even use it so arbitrarily that an effect arises which seems to stand in open conflict with the nature of the cause.

[168] That a world of such occasional causes is not able to subsist by itself or preserve itself is comprehensible. Created out of nothing, the occasional cause is in itself a nothing; it is not enough that it cannot act without God, it cannot even exist without God: in the moment God withdrew his preserving power from it, it would vanish into nothing. What holds of the individual holds of the whole; created out of nothing, the whole world, if the creating omnipotence withdrew, would instantly collapse into nothing; creation and annihilation (*creatio rerum* and *annihilatio rerum*) correspond exactly to one another; preservation is in this sense just as miraculous as creation: preservation is a continued creation.

By transforming concepts of faith into concepts of knowledge, Malebranche has, to be sure, with a certain consistency asserted the metaphysical reality of creation and preservation; but that this reality, so asserted, far from satisfying science, undermines the foundation of science is self-evident. In preserving the world, God undeniably observes the laws his wisdom has found serviceable; the preservation of the order once introduced depends on the whole on the observance of law. But the observance of the laws depends solely on God's will. Although God only seldom departs from what has once been established, since his thoughts are unchangeable and his wisdom perfect, yet the Almighty can, at whatever moment he will, abolish any law whatsoever when higher considerations require it; in other words, the world order that is maintained is maintained solely and alone by God's arbitrary wisdom. Such a world may with a certain right be called actual, since it is posited and preserved by divine power; but its actuality is groundless; it has no ground in itself, since it has no efficient causes in
[169] itself: groundless actuality is natureless. But a natureless actuality, an actual world without nature, is to science an intolerable contradiction.

But does the concept of preservation, developed in this way, then satisfy faith? If that were the case, we should here find ourselves in a very grave conflict between faith and knowledge. The reckoning would then be this: it is here shown that a clear, unambiguous and consistent development of the concept of preservation stands in open contradiction with the concept of nature. Faith in preservation, as irreconcilable with the acknowledgment of an actual nature, is thus contrary to nature. But faith in preservation is inseparable from faith in creation, and the concept of creation is consequently also contrary to nature. What is contrary to nature is identical with the impossible; to believe in creation and preservation is thus the same as to believe in what is in itself impossible, the absurd.

The whole difficulty vanishes, however, when we bethink ourselves that a concept of faith developed in the form of knowledge can never satisfy faith. Faith does not engage with the consequence that a creation out of nothing should make nature into a semblance; the religious consciousness cannot, without self-contradiction, own a metaphysics which, on the occasion of the murderer's will, makes God the actual murderer, and in the sinner's carnal lust regards the Holy One himself as the immediately operative cause. The religious consciousness acknowledges the reality of nature and distinguishes between a corruptible and an incorruptible, a sinful and a holy nature; but between nature and omnipotence lies the Mystery.

In his zeal to get something scientific out of faith in God's omnipotence, the pious Malebranche neglected to develop the concept of omnipotence in logical theism. The self-doubling that lies in power entails, as we have seen, a discharge into immediate discreteness, from which the existence of the atoms can be explained. Although the [170] atoms are only punctual negations in the infinite sole power, and thus a nothing over against the self-power, they are nevertheless, as the over-power's own elements of opposition, actually something, so that the derived reality which must be ascribed to each individual atom is an immediate, material reality qualified by the self-power. But that every atom has its qualified reality means, in other words, that it is acted upon by other atoms and in turn acts upon others. To ascribe punctual actuality to the atoms without acknowledging their active relations and mutual interaction is meaningless. With the interaction of the atoms the reality of nature is founded. Every

acting atom is a thing-cause: the infinite self-cause acts point by point through nothing but conditions and thing-causes. From this are explained conditioned necessity, the validity of the laws of nature, and the established order of the world.

***β*) Preservation and Natural Process.**

For the physical view, the atoms are the last or, if one will, the first causes of all natural things. From the properties, forces and interactions of the atoms the formations of nature can be sufficiently interpreted, all composition and separation, all coming-to-be and passing-away exactly explained. In what does the nature of a thing consist, if not in the conditioned necessity with which it expresses itself through its properties, maintains itself in interaction with other things, is dissolved into its elements and again proceeds from them? What is the nature of granite? Its consisting in a mechanical composition of quartz, feldspar and mica. Granite cannot come forth immediately at omnipotence's bidding, because the mediatedness of its coming-forth belongs precisely to its nature; nor can it be preserved immediately by [171] divine omnipotence, because it lies in its nature to endure as long as its constituents endure in their mechanical combination, but not a moment longer. What is the nature of water? To come forth through the chemical combination of oxygen and hydrogen. Water arises naturally, maintains itself naturally, and passes away, that is, is dissolved, naturally. If the chemist has oxygen and hydrogen with the requisite conditions, then no creative omnipotence is needed to produce water; if the chemist has the conditions for separating the water, then no preserving omnipotence can save it from destruction. What holds of chemical formations holds also of organic ones: oxygen, hydrogen, carbon and nitrogen act just as surely in accordance with their nature when a formation of cells takes place as when a formation of water, of carbonic acid, of ammonia, etc. takes place. It is true that the chemist does not command the conditions for a formation of cells as he does those for a formation of water, and that the living organism cannot be produced from elementary constituents as one can produce a salt from an acid and a base; but it stands no less firm for that, that the organic processes are natural processes just as much as the chemical ones. Formation, maintenance and

dissolution, or coming-forth, preservation and destruction, are only different sides of one and the same process.

It is clear from the above indications that there is no scientific means of bringing the physicist beyond the position he has chosen. Objections such as these: that physics cannot explain the origin of the atoms, and thus not the unchangeableness with which they are maintained either; that from the physical interaction of the atoms one cannot explain the formation of cells, and thus cannot explain either the origin of life or the division of living organisms into species and genera, and so cannot explain either the emergence of the species from the genus or of the genera from still more general forms, and consequently cannot explain the ground and the limit of the preservation [172] of species and genera, and so forth — such objections do not touch physics and make no impression whatever on the physicist. The standpoint of physics is essentially empirical; the peculiar phenomena, the existing formations, are not to be constructed *a priori*; they are to be taken as they occur in nature. It is enough for the physicist that he finds nature before him; he does not deduce it: it is because it is, it is of necessity; he reduces bodily formations to atoms, but the atoms themselves he does not deduce: they are because they are; they are in nature. The same holds of living organisms. The physicist does not explain either why or whence life is; he finds life before him, he investigates the living, searches out the conditions and laws of the phenomena of life, and assures himself that life is natural, is in nature, from nature. — Beyond the limits of the inquiries determined by the empirical standpoint physics does not go and will not be able to go, even if it continues them for millions of years.

The certainty and definiteness with which physics everywhere brings forward physical causes easily gives it the appearance that this science stood in contradiction with religion. In principle this is a misunderstanding. Physics says that all effects of nature pass through natural causes; it keeps to the material side of causality, but it does not say that what is material in the causes is the only thing operative; it says that all vital functions depend on material causes, but it does not say that the cause of life itself is a material cause. Although physics itself has to do only with material causes, their interactions and productions, it naturally cannot have anything against metaphysics introducing other, more spiritual, immaterial causes (principles, Idea-causes); only

[173] that this take place in such a way that none of the physical presuppositions is violated. If someone, for example, were to assert that the principle of life, as an Idea-cause independent in itself, was able to dispense with the material causes, or to take the materials by force and, in defiance of chemical affinities, use them in the service of the organism: then physics would have to protest; but that the principle of life can, as an Idea-cause, so work through the material causes that it develops the possibilities lying in the affinities of the materials into organically living interactions — against this it can object nothing. When the spiritualist assures us that matter is only a semblance and atomic theory a fiction, the physicist steps forward as a naturalist; but if it can be proved in logical theism that the acting atoms in all their actuality are originally posited by omnipotence, and must, in order actually to function as actual atoms, be borne and preserved by omnipotence: then physics cannot have the least objection to this.

The proposition of natural science, that the world preserves itself, thus does not, when the spheres of cognition are duly kept apart, stand in contradiction with the religious proposition that the world is preserved by God: the natural process, conceived as a concept of knowledge, does not exclude faith in preservation, any more than the concept of faith, preservation, excludes scientific insight into the natural process. What is it that physics wants to investigate? All natural causes, all thing-causes and conditions actual and possible in nature! But that nature is a system of causes and conditions running on to infinity is surely presupposed by religion too, as surely as it presupposes nature at all. And what is it, then, that religion wants to hold fast? It is surely the truth that the Creator's all-preserving power acts in, by and through all possible natural causes, all material causes with conditions, intermediate causes and intermediate causes of intermediate causes to infinity. Faith in the preservation of the

[174] world by God can thus no more restrict the scientific cognition of natural causes or set these any finite limit, than an investigation of natural causes continued to infinity can restrict the assurance of the preserving self-power or set any limit to the inwardness of faith in this sense.

γ) The Mystery of Preservation.

That we speak here of a Mystery of preservation must not be understood as though this were something particular by itself in opposition to the Mystery in the fatherly Self, the Mystery of the Trinity, the Mystery of creation, and so forth; the Mystery of revelation is in itself only one: the Mystery is the absolute limit of knowledge and faith; the Mystery is the hidden unity of the absolutely heterogeneous principles; the Mystery is the dissolution of dualism. As the content of faith develops from the principle of revelation, it meets with a corresponding content developed from the principle of reason; it looks as if religion and science once more had a common subject, a common task, so that the contradiction and the strife threaten each time to begin all over again. The science of reason has its judgment about God and God's works just as religion does; so long as the heterogeneity of the principles has not been made clear and the circles of cognition kept apart, the judgments must conflict and the contradictions be glaring: reconciliation is brought about only by the demonstration of the determinations of limit, so that the contradictions dissolve in the Mystery.

What holds of God's personality, his freedom reflected into itself, holds naturally also of his freedom as the causality of the world, i.e. of creation, and of the same freedom as the bearer of the world, i.e. of preservation; but since the movements of thought on both sides receive a relatively new point of departure, and the untying of the knot a new tinge, the Mystery is reached by relatively different paths, and for that reason it also appears each time in a corresponding light of its own.

To the scientific view, the world presents itself, as regards both its origin and [175] its maintenance, in quite another light than to the religious. Science knows no free creation, but only a maintenance necessary by nature. Great and mighty facts, impressions of experience, laws, causes and intermediate causes to infinity unite to confirm the fundamental scientific view and to make everything that religion teaches about creation and preservation as improbable as possible. In order to disarm the misunderstanding that improbability should be the same as impossibility, so that faith in creation and preservation came to be understood as faith in what is in itself impossible and absurd, logical theism has stepped in between, and by transforming the conceptual contradictions into determinations of limit has dissolved the impossibility into the Mystery. To believe in creation and preservation is thus not to believe

in impossibilities and absurdities, but in the manifestations of the self-power, such works of God as have for their grounds grounds of freedom, grounds of will from the unfathomable depth of the Godhead.

Without regard to the possible objections of science, and long before these came into being, revelation has spoken its word about creation, and the religious consciousness, in the inwardness of faith, has found inspired words for the praise of the all-preserving power, which can shake the mountains in their foundations, can roll up the heavens like a garment, can draw back its breath so that everything living dies. What is peculiar to the religious view of the world must in this connection be especially emphasized. It surely looks almost as though the religious view of nature were just as sensuously objective as the observation corresponding to science; it looks as though the believer saw God himself in outward nature, in the mighty sea, where he lays the beams of his chambers in the waters, saw the flash of his eye in the lightning, heard [176] his voice in the thunder, his rolling chariot in the storm- clouds, when he “rides upon the wings of the storm”. This, however, is not so; the objectively natural is everywhere only an occasioning cause, only a means and point of transit for what is subjective in the spirit. That God does not leave himself without witness, in that he “gives us rain from heaven and fruitful seasons”, is a proposition of faith which does not rest either on a meteorological consideration of the rain or on an agronomic calculation of the crop of the field: the assurance is unconditionally a self-assurance in faith. That the principle of faith, conceived as a principle of cognition, is heterogeneous with the principle of knowledge must strike the eye when we consider how impossible it is to make any transition from the representation that it is God who gives rain to a scientific explanation of the formation of rain, or to make the cognition that God “causes the grass to grow for the cattle” the basis of a further-reaching botanical interpretation of the growth of plants. The religious view, which everywhere in nature discovers “the Father’s works”, is absolutely heterogeneous with the scientific, which discovers “the unchangeable laws”.

That it is, however, not knowledge alone but faith also that finds its absolute limit in the Mystery of preservation is self-evident, and can, for further confirmation, be seen from a host of questions which must be left unanswered from the side of the

philosophy of religion as well. How the creative and the preserving power are properly related to each other in God himself cannot be fathomed. Doubtless it is at bottom one and the same power; but this one and the same power nevertheless acts in two entirely different ways: in creation, to produce the world; in preservation, to let what has been produced develop and produce itself. Where, now, does the creative activity end and where does the preserving activity begin? The creative and the preserving will is quite certainly at bottom one and the same will; but it acts actively in creation, passively in preservation. That the active has a moment of the passive in it, and conversely, there is no doubt; but where is the limit between the active and the passive, between the producing and the bearing energy of will? It is said expressly in the history of creation that God rested on the seventh day. That the finite specification of time cannot be derived from the principle of faith has already been made clear; but the difference between creation and preservation as two divine works, indicated by the rest, has validity for faith. That there is a limit, and thus a difference of essence, between creation and preservation must be presupposed; but where is the limit? The doctrine of the relation of creation to preservation has been connected, and with good reason, with the doctrine of the relation of individuals to the race, a relation which is of pervasive significance in the determination of original sin. "It is" — so it runs²¹ — "the truth of traducianism that every human individual is an offspring of the natural activity of the race, as this is conditioned by the peculiarity of peoples, families and parents. But it is the truth of creationism that the general natural activity by which the race propagates itself and new souls are formed, that this mysterious natural activity is the organ and means of God's individualizing creative activity, that every human individual being is thus a new revelation of the divine will, which here prepares for itself a peculiar form for its image ... Even if it remains a mystery how, in the secret workshop of human formation, nature and creation pass over into each other, how the creative activity and the natural conditions mutually limit each other ... yet every individual must be regarded at once from the point of view of traducianism and of creationism, or as continuation and link in the series and as a new, original point of beginning". If this is to become science, such a conception of the Mystery is altogether [177]

²¹H. Martensen. *Den christelige Dogmatik*. S. 146–47.

too vague.

If it actually stood firm that the difference between being “continuation and link in the series” and being “a new and original point of beginning” corresponded exactly to the difference between the preserving and the creative activity, then a determination of concept fruitful for objective knowledge would have been discovered in the Mystery: we should then be able to develop new concepts of knowledge from a concept of faith; but that is impossible. Of animal individuals too it holds, surely, that the living individual is both formed from a new point of beginning and at the same time as continuation and link in the series. If the animal individual can come forth without the individualizing principle of life entering into activity, then — the matter regarded in the light of knowledge — a new animal species must also be able to come forth without a special principle of species (Darwin’s hypothesis). If it stood firm that the relation between natural and creative activity could be determined by the relation between less and more gifted individuals, then the Mystery of creation would be reflected in so many rays of light from anthropology, history and psychology that the mysterious would sink down to a vanishing obscurity, a pure relativity. But the individual richly gifted by nature is not in a deeper sense a creature of God than the less gifted one. If the genius of a general, combined with political genius, is to be a fruit of God’s special creative activity, then the same must hold of mathematical genius, poetic genius, the genius of an actor, etc. When the great gifts of nature are without further ado regarded as great gifts of creation, the small gifts of nature must of course be regarded as small gifts of creation; but to make all gifts of nature into gifts of creation is precisely to efface the limit between natural and creative activity. To regard the

[179] difference between worldly and religious natures as the distinguishing mark is just as unreliable; for if an inborn difference between religious and non-religious natures could actually be conceived, then the Creator would surely exclude from religion those who did not have an inborn religious nature. The marks of difference that faith sets in this respect are subjective, not objective. The Mystery effaces all marks of knowledge, all objective limits, and precisely thereby designates the absolute limit between faith and knowledge.

c) Governance.

§ 13.

Preservation is the divine function of power which furnishes the middle between natural and creative activity. Between the three different functions the difference is essential, and yet every finite limit has vanished. "God creates all things", "Nature produces all things", "God preserves all things": in this threefold generality the functions melt together. On what the fusion rests, and how the determinations of difference develop out of the mysterious fundamental unity, is now to be more closely investigated. Attention fixes first on the thing-causes, then on the Ideas, but yet first and last on the almighty will. Of the thing-causes we saw in the foregoing that they are originally moments for omnipotence, realities within its own self-doubling, that they are, in other words, all created. Further, we saw that the atoms, these original thing-causes, are on the one hand points of transit for omnipotence and to that extent occasioning causes, on the other hand existing realities, and thus operative causes. If now the thing-causes are posited in the moment of points of transit, the emphasis falls [180] on creation; if they are posited in the moment of operative causes, the emphasis falls on natural activity; if, finally, they are posited in the moment of created independence resting on omnipotence, the emphasis falls on preservation. In preservation the divine power is posited as the medium passive with respect to the natural causes, a medium which, as regards essence, can in a certain sense be said to be what space is with respect to the phenomenal. Just as space does not itself act to change the distances or dimensions of bodies, and yet is absolutely indispensable in the determination of dimensions and distances, so the preserving, all-bearing power, the medium of the real concepts and of the forces, likewise does not change the reality and mode of action of the natural causes, but is nevertheless, as the all-inspiring, all-pervading medium of the concepts and forces, absolutely indispensable to the activity of the natural causes.

If, now, the preserving activity, which keeps to the universal, cannot decide anything regarding the individual and the particular, then the determinations of particularity must, so to speak, be divided between the thing-causes and the creative will. "If something new is to be produced, the creative will must set itself in activity; if special formations are to take place, special causes and conditions must be presupposed". But a finite division in this sense is only a parceling-out and piecing-together of what

is in itself infinite, and thus a contradiction. The contradiction is resolved by the intervention of the Ideas. The creative will produces everything through Ideas; the finite natural causes point back to the generative, forming ground of nature, the *natura naturans* impregnated with Ideas: the concrete unity-in-difference, rich in content in itself, of creative will and conditioning natural causes must, as regards the great whole, be sought in the Idea of the world. The Idea is in principle a teleological uni-
 [181] ty of means and ends. The Idea of the world unfolds its content in a system of Ideas, in the plan of the world; the creative will, acting through the Ideas, and thus in the form of wisdom, aiming at the goal, then reveals itself as the governing will.

It is, however, so far from being the case that faith could give any objective knowledge of the divine governance that the opposition of the principles shows itself the moment the development begins. It is a fact that the governance of the world proceeds through a system of Ideas; in the system of Ideas there is unity of necessity and freedom; but when it is expressly asked in which form the unity is to be held fast, in that of necessity or that of freedom, then faith and knowledge stand sharply against each other; for knowledge holds to the identity of necessity and freedom in necessity, but faith in freedom. The consequences of this appear when we consider, from the standpoint of science, *governance and the course of the world*, and, from the standpoint of religion, *the providence revealed in governance and the personal faith in the governing providence*.

α) Governance and the Course of the World.

If the actual whole, comprising nature and history, which we in a special sense call the world, means nothing other than the self-unfolding of the Absolute through finite oppositions, then the course of the world is objectively comprehensible and governance is easy to explain. Here there can be said to be in the great process of development both an end and yet not an end. The Absolute constantly goes out from itself and, through the intermediate stages of the development, constantly returns to itself. If emphasis is here laid on the difference between the Absolute's beginning and resulting development, then the Absolute in the result of its development is end, the intermediate links are means, and the conception is teleological. If, on the other

hand, emphasis is laid on the Absolute's absolute identity with itself under all forms [182] of development, at all stages of transition, in all final results, then the development is an infinite process, then there is here, in relation to the Absolute, no progress, no purpose and no final end, but the Absolute first and the Absolute last in the eternal circuit of the movements.

As it goes with the comprehensive whole, so also with the particular parts. If we consider the formations of nature and bring out the opposition between organic forms at lower and higher stages, in particular the opposition between animal and man, then the ascending movement takes on a teleological appearance. By manifoldly winding detours, through the most diverse preparations and approaches, the Idea has known how to work its way up from obscurity to clarity, from dispersions in the elemental through totalizations in the organic, through rising concentrations, to that summit of individualization where the universal knows itself as the subject and the Absolute becomes conscious of itself. What wisdom, what plans and purposes: say now that there is not a governance here! And yet it is a small matter to put all this teleology, these means and aims, aside again as soon as, by their decisive claims of selfhood and the omnipotence of will reflected in them, they begin to be a nuisance. What, after all, is animal individuality? A reciprocal determination, thoroughgoing at its stage, of the individual with the particular in the universal. The individual and the particular must necessarily be as it is, because the universal expressed in it necessarily is as it is; there is in the aim of these organic formations no aim, in these apparent means no means: the finite difference of means and aims dissolves in the totalized unity of the Absolute into an indifference that obliterates all aims.

This ambiguity plays a great role where the talk is of the aim of human life, of the purpose for the individual, for society and for states, of the epochs and periods [183] of world history. One extols the right of reason and the might of reason and the cunning of reason; the individual is an end in himself, the state is an end in itself; reason is in league with freedom, and freedom is the goal. From this teleological point of view one is then also easily reconciled with unfreedom, injustice, evil. For evil, after all, has its ground only in the finitude of the world, and finitude is inseparable from actuality. A world without limits and negativity would, as both philosophers and

philosophical Church teachers have recognized, be the emptiest, most monotonous and most imperfect world one could think of, “a painting without shadows, a piece of music without deeper tones among the higher, a speech without pauses, a verse without short syllables among the long, a poem without antitheses, a drama without a villain, a sheer one and the same without multiplicity”.

But since no self is absolute under this refraction of oppositions, inasmuch as the Absolute is selfless, and the self in each individual human being is gnawed by the worm of corruptibility, this whole drama of freedom and self-development is an empty play: the serious matter is that each individual being is a point of passage for the universal, and the significance of the ephemeral individualities is necessarily determined by their position and place in the whole. In the Absolute’s “divine thinking and willing each individual is posited with precisely only that measure of perfection which it actually has. When we see a blind man, we compare him with others who see, or with his own former condition when he could still see, — likewise when we find someone carried away by sensuous desire: and therefore we judge that both are contrary to his nature, the former as physical, the latter as moral evil. But on the contrary, once the divine will or the concatenation of causes has brought about [184] blindness for one individual and awakened sensuous desire in another, then in the first case sight, in the second, at this moment, the rational constitution belongs as little to the essence of such an individual as the former to that of a stone, the latter to that of an animal: the supposed privation is thus only negation, which cannot be subject to any blame”²².

The philosophy of the Absolute has, as regards the development of form, undeniably worked its way far beyond the Spinozistic abstractions and knows, in a quite different and penetrating manner, how to bring out the particular, acknowledge the conflicts of freedom, and assert the significance of national individualities, of ages, of heroic passions and of great characters in world history; but as regards the point of selfhood, the religious-ethical cardinal point, pantheistic speculation has not come a hair’s breadth further than Spinoza. “The government of the world itself” — says Strauss — “is not to be regarded as a determination of the course of the world by

²²Spinoza. Cf. Strauss. *Den christl. Troesl.* II. S. 307–8.

an understanding standing outside the world, but as the reason immanent in the cosmic forces and their relations themselves: and the fact that the destiny of mankind, of the nations and of individuals stands under the guidance of providence can only have the meaning that, on account of the universal dominion of spirit over nature, the development of the human race on the whole proceeds according to its concept, and that the contingency of the individual's action and of the natural occurrence constantly evens itself out again into universal necessity".

Still the old theme, the same empty selfless essence! The play has been rewritten, the exposition is richer, the catastrophes more exciting, the costumes more brilliant and the scenery more splendid; but the plot is the same, the untying of the knot the same: the inadequacy of the individual wills for the universal of spirit, the swallowing [185] up of individuals and races by necessity, the corruptibility of the self and its half-hour eternity in the Absolute — that is the result of the struggle, the outcome of the course of the world, the share of governance in the whole.

β) The Revealed Word Concerning the Governance of Providence.

With creation and preservation the foundation is given for the governance of the world. Since the creating and preserving will bears and permeates the activity of nature in an infinite manner, the ground of necessity and the natural independence of the world can subsist together with the hidden miracle of preservation, and no proof drawn from science can establish the impossibility of the governing cooperation of an omnipotent, omnipresent will. The final separation between what happens by natural causes and what is immediately effected by God has the inner infinite unity-in-difference as its presupposition and is determined solely by revelation and faith. Through everything in the world, the least together with the greatest, God can place himself in a personal relation of will to man, and man to God. It is not the event according to its immediate objectivity, not the outwardly actual fact, that determines the relation; it is conversely the relation that determines the conception of the fact and gives it its significance: not what happens, but how what happens is interpreted and understood, is the main thing. From this it follows that the revealed word concerning governance must, from an objective point of view, take on an arbitrary appearance,

and the representation be colored by the imagination. On account of the absolute heterogeneity of the principles this cannot be otherwise.

[186] A sensuous natural world, an actual order of things, is given; this foundation is included in the immediate presupposition of all religious judgments. What is peculiar to faith is that it refers the natural facts now to the creating, now to the preserving and, on the whole, to the governing will. When, then, it is expressly said in the revealed word that God determines each individual human being's birth and span of life, that he draws man forth from the mother's womb and shelters him from childhood on (Ps. 22:10 ff.), that man's days are numbered and written in his book (Ps. 139:16), etc., then there is hereby not given the very slightest contribution to a scientific determination of the relation between the physiological working of nature and the scholastic fixing of God's cooperation (*concursus*), but a correct statement of what religion and faith are.

If natural science could actually prove that man's natural coming into being was conditioned by such forces and causes as cannot possibly be subject to the omnipotent will, then this one thing would be enough to make faith impossible. By an intermediary independent in nature, such a dividing wall would be raised between the divine and the human self that an essential relation to God could not be conceived. By such an intermediary God would have to cease to be omniscient, omnipotent, i.e. cease to be God; nor could man then be set free by the unfree Deity, but would have to put up, from the beginning of his life onward, with being bound to obscure selfless powers of nature.

To presuppose God's free omnipotence — and that, after all, is what the believer does — to be in infinite need of God's liberating self-power — and that, after all, is what the believer does — and then nevertheless to assume that the human self, according to its natural origin, is separated from God, sprung from a root torn loose from God's knowledge and will, is an intolerable self-contradiction. It is this self-contradiction that faith sublates, and that with a power of inwardness all the greater, the purer and [187] stronger it is. It is with this strength of inwardness that the revealed word speaks of the human self's original springing forth from the divine; it is to the dependence of the formation of man on the creating will that the Psalmist bears witness when he

says: "I will give thanks to thee, for I have come into being in a wonderful manner. My bones were not hidden from thee when I was formed in secret, when I was curiously wrought; thine eyes saw me when I was yet unformed" (Ps. 139:33).

But although the word of revelation thus refers the disposition of each human individuality to the creating self-power that governs all things, it is by no means overlooked that the disposition is an actual natural disposition, and as a natural disposition must presuppose natural connection and be subject to natural conditions. The reality of the natural conditions is, as regards this point, not merely included in the immediate presupposition, but comes, through the cognition of sin, to play a leading role in particular.

It has already been shown that the cognition of sin rises with the cognition of God, so that the intensity of the one of these cognitions can be regarded as the gauge of the strength of the other; it has further been pointed out that the cognition of sin lays bare the self-contradiction that man both can and yet cannot take the whole guilt upon himself. Now, as the cognition of sin steps in separatingly between the holy and the sinful self, how then is the penitent before God to explain to himself what we may here call the inner infinity of sin, of the sinful essence? To make the creating will the author of sin is blasphemy; to excuse oneself with the imperfections of one's contingent individuality is frivolous and irreligious; to take the whole guilt upon oneself in the sense that the arbitrarily free will, which commits sin because it wills to, can also make itself free of sin whatever moment it wills, is brazen superficiality: what, then, remains? That the penitent must take the whole guilt upon himself, place the cause of sin in the will, but in such a way that what is sinful in the will is referred [188] to its natural ground. "I was born in iniquity, and my mother conceived me in sin" (Ps. 41) — in these words the thought of original sin is expressed. Original sin is not willed by God; but it falls under the divine governance.

That the concepts of faith are in principle absolutely heterogeneous with the concepts of knowledge shines forth from the propositions set up here: man's individual disposition is determined by creative activity, and man's natural disposition is sinful. Should these two propositions be conceived scientifically, they must yield a conceptual contradiction that cannot be resolved. The insolubility of the contradiction does not

lie in the fact that a self-cause works together with finite natural causes; for then the contradiction can be resolved by reducing the self-cause to an immanent Idea-cause: the solution must then be sought in the identity of the material organism and the organizing principle. Nor can the insolubility be placed in the fact that the will of God stands outside or over against the finite causes and, by holding these in absolute passivity, transforms them into non-causes; for the whole difficulty with an absolute *agens* standing outside is an easily seen-through chicanery of the negative critique, which, by the deterring notion of “a God standing outside,” exempts itself from any closer treatment of any theistic problem whatsoever that goes deeper. No, the insolubility lies in the fact that the creating will, which cooperates in the formation of each individual human being’s natural disposition, is a holy will that wants sin away, and yet expressly — according to the thought of original sin — refrains from cleansing the natural disposition from the ground up: this contradiction cannot be resolved in objective knowledge. If one says: the divine will cannot cleanse the natural disposition, then the natural disposition forms a limit, and we fall back into the [189] contradiction touched on above. If one says: the connection of nature does not tolerate a thoroughgoing cleansing of each individual disposition by itself, then one places the reality of nature in sinfulness, and we then have the contradiction in another form. If one says: God will not cleanse the natural disposition, then one appeals to God’s arbitrariness; but grounds of arbitrariness are not scientific. From the standpoint of faith the contradiction is resolved, namely in the form of self-contradiction: the solution is in the expression of the cognition of sin.

With this, faith in the governing will has been characterized; the wisdom that governs the world cannot be justified by objective reasons; that is against its essence and nature: it is personal, absolutely personal; the last reasons, the deepest motives, are hidden in the fatherly Self — in the Mystery.

All reasons of governance are, on God’s side, reasons of will, and thus, as regards understanding, on man’s side reasons of faith. To dismiss the scientific debates concerning the relation between God’s foreknowledge and men’s free will, between the divine plan of the world and the evil in the world, between God’s unchangeableness and the effects of men’s prayers, etc., will in the present context be superfluous: according

to the standpoint chosen they fall away of themselves. On the other hand, there is another side of the doctrine of providence which the philosophy of religion must illuminate in particular; it presents itself where the talk is of definite dispensations, particular aims and corresponding means. The statements belonging here are of very different kinds, have on the whole a different stamp in the Old than in the New Testament, and must, as regards their universal religious validity, be judged according to the principle of faith.

In the election of the people of Israel, its wonderful deliverance from Egyptian bondage, its legislation, its wandering through the desert, its conquest of the promised [190] land, features of a governing providence are seen so great, so clear, so significant, that the people of Israel has rightly been called “the typical people.” But if we go through the believing statements about this in detail, it is unmistakable that the strong images, the colorful descriptions, the interpretations offered of natural phenomena and historical events bear witness to the changing moods, the religious conceptions and subjective judgments that are peculiar to that people with its prophets and priests. To conceive of the plagues of the land — pestilence, locusts, drought, failure of crops, the calamities of war, slavery and exile — as chastisements of the punishing providence, and of deliverance, victory and prosperity as signs of the grace of providence, is at once so popular and so religious that we cannot on the whole conceive of faith in providence otherwise. That elements of a lower kind mingle in the religious conception, eudaemonistic expectations, egoistic secondary notions and the like, is explicable from the sensuousness of the people and the one-sidedness of the preparatory standpoint.

In order not to misinterpret the details we must constantly remember that the immediate judgments of faith are judgments of mood, a circumstance that can very well be united with what is fundamentally religious in their content. Thus, e.g., when Jehovah says in the prophet Amos (3:6): “Shall evil befall a city, and the Lord hath not done it?” then the thought is by no means that Jehovah’s will is the cause of evil as evil; but the thought of governance is that fortune and misfortune, evil and good, all dispensations are so wholly subject to God’s will and might that every intermediate cause, every finite author, vanishes as a nothing when the talk is of standing in the way of Jehovah’s thoughts and plans.

The doctrine of providence is in its concept just as anti-rational as the doctrine of creation; which is why it is also characteristic that the doctrine of providence in the [191] New Testament can be so spiritually pure without being rational. That God clothes the lilies of the field and feeds the birds of the air is, from a rational point of view, only a lyrical-poetic expression; but that from the standpoint of the Gospel it has another meaning is seen from the application: "If God so clothe the grass of the field, which today is, and tomorrow is cast into the fire, how much more shall he not clothe you, O ye of little faith!"

γ) Faith in the Governing Providence.

The opposition characterized here between the scientific and the religious conception of the governance of the world confirms anew the fundamental proposition set up concerning faith and knowledge as absolutely heterogeneous principles; we now come to an answer to the following two main questions: 1) Can the one who knows believe in a governing providence? and 2) what significance does faith in providence have both for the one who knows and for the one who does not know? The answer to both questions is already contained in the presupposition of principle that the relation to God is an eternal relation of selfhood, and the goal personal liberation, personal self-development.

1) *The one who knows can, without coming into contradiction with science, believe in the governing providence.* By identifying the one who knows with science, it is an easy matter to tighten the opposition between faith and knowledge into caricature. "Science cognizes no personal God, no creation, no preservation by a free omnipotent will, and hence no free omnipotent governance of the world either, and yet the one who knows is to believe in all this: he is thus to know that a personal God is unthinkable, and yet believe in God's personality; to know that the notions of a creating, preserving, governing will lead into insoluble conceptual contradictions, and yet, in spite of these [192] actual contradictions, in spite of the open breach of the principle of contradiction, do violence to his whole spiritual being, persuade himself and others that he can actually believe in what he himself has cognized to be manifest contradictions!" From what we have said before it can now be seen that these distortions rest on sheer

surreptitious assumptions and false presuppositions. It is, as we have seen, a subtle surreptition that science should actually be able to prove either the impossibility of God's personality or the impossibility of any work of God whatsoever corresponding to it. One confuses two entirely heterogeneous results of knowledge with each other: being able to comprehend the possibility, and being able to prove the impossibility — a crude, unscientific confusion! It is a false presupposition, a subtle surreptition, that the one who knows should have no need of cognitions of any other kind than such as can be grounded in science. Science is not a personal being, but the one who knows, however much he may, in objective self-forgetfulness, forget the ideal demands of personal life, is and remains a personal being. If the one who knows awakens to personal self-cognition, then the very first thing he will see is this, that science, according to its principle, cannot possibly give him decisive personal answers to decisive personal questions. It is, when we consult science, neither comprehensible nor probable that the Absolute itself should be a personal being, but it is possible — yes, it is possible! It is, from the point of view of knowledge, neither comprehensible nor probable that there should be an Omniscient One who could see everything with full clarity, an omnipotent Self who was able to master, determine and guide everything down to the least, the very least details, so that even all the hairs of the head are numbered, so that not even a sparrow falls to the ground without the will of the Father who is in heaven; it is incomprehensible, it is improbable, but — it is possible. By settling personality's account with science and presupposing the principle of faith, [193] the one who knows gets the possibility out on all sides. More than the possibility he does not get; more than the possibility he does not need.

2) *Faith in providence has essentially the same significance for the one who knows as for the one who does not know.* In the course of personal life the present always draws its most essential significance from what is to come; the actuality on which everything here chiefly depends is a future actuality; but a future actuality is always a possibility. The acting individuality lives, in actuality, on nothing but possibilities. The way in which he conceives the conditioned possibilities of actuality depends on how decisively he acts, and on how he understands himself in the moment decisive for the action, whether his self-understanding falls outside or inside the relation to God.

If the self-understanding falls outside the relation to God, God as God being denied, then the highest concentration the subject can attain is a self-concentration in the Absolute. Were it possible to drive the concentration to the point where the self became absolute, then the corresponding action in time would not merely hold for eternity but would even be an act of eternity, whereby the one acting had made himself God. But to make oneself God, or, what is the same thing, to make one's own self absolute, is impossible. The Absolute does not itself act; the acting self is not absolute: as soon as the action is accentuated, the Absolute and the self part from each other. Where, then, is governance here, what is it that governs? To govern is, acting with an eye to the goal, to cross through conditions and possibilities: the Absolute cannot act, and so it cannot govern either. The Absolute has possibilities enough—indeed it has [194] all possibilities—it releases them into the manifoldness of contingencies, it gathers them under the unity of necessity, but that does not help the one who acts. Under the pressure of necessity, surrounded by accidents and contingencies, the acting subject must on its own account take on the possibilities, must itself set its goal and determine its way: the acting subject must govern itself. And by what shall it steer? To steer by the Absolute instead of by a relative goal is like a skipper wanting to steer by the whole of space instead of by a star. To say that the Absolute is in the one acting, is in the possibilities, in the purposes, is meaningless; for the secret is that the Absolute is so immanent in all relations of finitude, in all acting subjects and actions, that precisely because of this pure immanence it is outside the whole of it. So the self governs itself finitely and goes under in infinity.

It is otherwise when the self-understanding falls inside the relation to God. The religious individuality has its decisive concentration in faith itself: faith is the action of actions, the inward, first, absolute action. The believing self does not through the act of faith itself become absolute, but from the absolute Self it receives the principle of action and of governance as its first mover. That the absolute Self can be a principle of action lies in its being able, in the most original sense of the word, itself to act; for the same reason it can be a principle of governance; as principle in the relative it is what it is in itself as absolute. The absolute Self can act. For what is it to act? It is to make the will immediately the causality of actual changes in an actual world: the

absolute Self is one with the absolute will. The absolute Self can govern. For what is it to govern? It is to make the will *mediately* the causality in a system of conditions and means corresponding to a certain end. The objection that an acting and governing God is a contradiction, since God, by acting and governing, would have to be drawn [195] down into finitude and thereby himself be made finite, is superficial. The acting and governing God does indeed himself enter into finitude, enters, so to speak, into the terms of finitude; but since this happens through action and governance, it happens in such a way that finitude is at one and the same time both upheld in its reality and permeated by infinity. The unity of the self with itself through all actual oppositions is unity of will, the actual unity of will is unity of action. Through the unity of action, then, the divine Self can unite the relative with the absolute, can work in all that is finite and yet, as the one infinite Self, be exalted above the finite.

The immediate expression of the divine action, God's work, is the miracle, the manifest miracle. The principle of the miracle is, as already shown, the unconditioned principle of will. That the will as will can become the causality of actual changes in nature, this and this alone is what is miraculous in all miracles. Through the miracle, according to what has been made clear in the foregoing, nature is by no means either sublated or botched; for the causality of will does not annihilate the causes of things, it only transforms them: the miracle, seen from the side of nature, is an effect of the interaction of transformed natural causes. Conceived as divine action, the miracle expresses that the natural, what in its elementary naturalness is external and finite, is permeated and transfigured by the spirit in an inward, infinite way. The miracle makes it manifest that God has a will.

The essential expression of governance is the will's use of intermediate causes in their immediate finitude and relativity. In the miracle the intermediate causes seem quite to vanish before the immediately intervening will; in governance, conversely, a mediately intervening will seems quite to vanish before the intermediate causes. [196] Both forms of the will's activity must arouse offense in the unbeliever. That the miracle arouses offense as contrary to reason—the contrariety to reason lies, namely, in the fancy that the intermediate causes have been annihilated—is understandable; but governance, which with its intermediate causes looks so reasonable, how can

governance arouse offense? For the opposite reason, namely that the governing will disappears altogether for the observer fixed on the intermediate causes, so that it becomes a will that is no will. It is infinity from the other side that here tips the balance. When a finite power of will governs, it is always noticeable in one way or another how it intervenes here and there in the course of events. The finite will, however great the shrewdness and wisdom of the one governing may be, can never so omnipresently permeate means and intermediate causes that it would not at some point need to intervene externally; but this the divine will can do: it governs in an inward, infinite way, and therefore it is as though it did not exist at all, as though there were no governance.

The miracle and governance contrast with each other and yet hold together in infinite interaction: the miracle is governing, governance is miraculous; the miracle is the manifest, governance the hidden miracle. The expression of the unity of miracle and governance is given in the revealed word: "*With God all things are possible.*" With this word the believer appropriates the principle of the governance of all things as the principle of personal self-development. That all things are possible with God means that the ideal tasks of freedom can, with the aid of governance, be solved in infinitely many ways within the existing order of the world. Necessity is the firm foundation of freedom, and is to that extent necessary for freedom; but in actual existence necessity [197] is also a limit to freedom. The more relative the demand of freedom is, the more natural is the self's agreement with the finite limits and conditions: a reasonable man expects only the probable, not the improbable, sets himself to attain the reasonable, not the extraordinary. The higher the flight, on the other hand, that personal development takes, the more ideal the demand of freedom becomes, the sharper becomes the conflict between the probable and the improbable; the fulfillment of the ideal demand will in actuality always prove improbable: then the task is to will the possible with enthusiasm, however improbable this possible may be. The inward, unconditioned liberation of the self—unconditioned insofar as the personality is to subject all finite conditions to itself—must therefore drive the one acting forward in a direction that has the current of probabilities against it: the one who acts thus wills the possible in spite of the improbable; it almost looks as though he willed the impossible, for in faith

he wills unconditionally his freedom and blessedness. So placed, the individuality disposed toward freedom, be he otherwise one who knows or one who does not know, will surely learn in self-understanding to understand the significance of the words: with God all things are possible.

It must be emphatically impressed that, as regards faith in the governing providence, the talk is not of the actual but of the possible; thus not of what is finite in actuality but of the infinite, for what is infinite in actuality is the possible. With God all things are possible: such a faith in the governance of the world seems at first glance to verge on the fabulous; but the limits of actuality, the entanglements of life, the pressure of necessity and the impersonal powers are included in the presupposition, and the presupposition therefore contains guarantees that faith does not become fantastic. Here there is no question of what governance *will* do in this or that case; [198] here the talk is only of what it *can* do. This distinction between what governance can do and what governance will do is of infinite significance for the life of faith.

The believing self that ventures out on the sea of improbabilities must, seeing itself surrounded by dangers, be just as prepared to perish temporally as the unbelieving self; it must, as has already been said, practice infinite resignation. But the difference between the resignation determined by the Absolute and that which corresponds to faith in governance shows itself in this, that the former is only a reconciliation with necessity, the latter by contrast a personal deepening in freedom. Let them both, then, the one who knows, living on the Absolute, and the believer, who has placed himself under the fatherly providence, let them both suffer the same thing outwardly, both go under outwardly in the same way: here there is nonetheless an infinite difference inwardly. The one who knows, who goes under in the Absolute, goes under because the selfless dissolves the self, because personality is finite and only the power of necessity infinite, because the individual, a merely temporary appearance of the universal, must vanish in death. The believer, on the other hand, who lives under providence, goes under in no danger, however threatening and apparently unavoidable it may be, because it follows unavoidably from necessity, but because governance wills it. And why does governance will it? Because it is thus the best, is what serves this personality best. If it is not personally the best, then the believer

is fully assured that he will not perish temporally either. Therefore the believing resignation is so inseparably bound up with hope. Hope holds unconditionally to the eternal, but also takes up the temporal conditionally. As hope is, so is fear: "Fear not them which can only kill the body, but cannot kill the soul"; "yea, even all the hairs [199] of your head are numbered": these words were given by the revealed providence as provision for the way to those who were going out precisely to meet such as both could and would kill the body.

The reciprocal determination of fear and hope receives, in the inwardness of faith, its deepest explanation in prayer. "With God all things are possible": this is the fundamental thought of prayer when it is seen in connection with governance. That man, under all finite dispensations, in fortune and misfortune, in sorrow and joy, has essentially to do not with the external dispensations but with the all-governing power, God's eternal, unchangeable will; that the infinite task of freedom, of personality, is: under all possible dispensations to understand the governing will and in this believing understanding to understand oneself—that is the truth, the personal truth, at whose attainment prayer aims. The one who prays presupposes that the governing will, for which all things are possible, both can and will help, not *in abstracto* but *in concreto*, not merely in general with the eternal, but for the sake of the eternal also in the temporal, the finite, the present actual. The one who prays does not want, in a selfish sense, to try to bring about a change in God's will—if that is so, he violates the principle of faith and is not a believer; if that is so, he violates the revealed word, for he then posits some finite help or other as the only possible one, although the word expressly says that with God all things are possible—the one who prays does not in his hoping forget infinite resignation: he prays to the Unchangeable; but the Unchangeable is not the Absolute of necessity. The Unchangeable is the heavenly Father—"the ideal of majesty!"; yes, but also the ideal of love and personal freedom, in love and freedom [200] the Unchangeable.

C.

The Kingdom of the Father.

§ 14.

At the expression “the Kingdom of the Father” thought is involuntarily led to a comprehensive worldview, a coherent cognition of the fundamental relations of existence. It must above all not be forgotten that the worldview the philosophy of religion here means to develop is not the scientific but the religious one, and that the development is aimed especially at setting the opposition between the cognition that falls inside and the cognition that falls outside the relation to God in the clearest light.

It is the human world, with the great turning points of the life of the spirit, that steps into the foreground. The object of consideration is on the whole common to religion and science. The state of things on earth when man appeared, the beginning of human life, the transition from the natural to the cultural state, the separation of the peoples, the difference between the people of the myths (of the Ideas) and the people of revelation (of the spirit), the education of the people of the spirit until the absolute turning point, “the fullness of time,” is reached: these facts, which speak for the governance of the world, may well be said to lie as close to the science of reason as to the philosophy of faith; but precisely because the object, although outwardly taken it is the same, nevertheless shows itself so very different in the light falling on it from the opposed standpoints, precisely because the world of spiritual events becomes quite another when it is viewed in the light of science than when it is presented in the light of religion, we must lay weight on the alternation of principles and the heterogeneity of standpoints.

[201]

a) Ideal and Actuality.

§ 15.

In the actual relation to God, the one corresponding to man’s given condition, the life of the spirit moves around the two cardinal points, sin and redemption. Now since redemption can have no significance except in relation to sin, the question of the origin and essence of sin is one of the very first and deepest fundamental questions of religious consciousness. From what has already been made clear about the relation between the cognition of God and the cognition of sin, it follows that the answer to the question must be sought in revelation. To clarify what sin is, how sin came

into the world, and its consequences, sacred history begins with a presentation of what we may call the ideal natural side of the relation to God, passes from there to a presentation of man's breach with the ideal in the relation, and then gives the hard actuality, contrary to the ideal and just for that reason so oppressive and burdensome, an interpretation that corresponds to the original, undimmed consciousness of sin. It is thus the *ideal of innocence*, the *temptation* and the *Fall*, with the ensuing *curse*, that we are to consider.

α) **The Ideal of Innocence.**

And God said: "Let us make man (Adam) in our image, after our likeness ... So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him." Seen under his ideal determination, man is thus an image of God. Wherein the image of God properly consists is not said outright, but is nevertheless not difficult to find out when we note Jehovah's words to man. Man is to rule over the earth: "replenish the earth, [202] and subdue it"; and man is to obey God's commandment: "of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat: but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it"; by the first of these determinations man is conceived as a rational being, by the latter as a religious being. It thus belongs to man to develop not merely in his relations to the world but originally according to his relation to God, for—"in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die"—the relation to God is what is decisive. Created in the image of God, after the ideal of love in the image of the eternal Son, man is "the free, personal unity of spirit and nature, a *spiritual soul*, which is not, like the natural souls, captive in corporeality, but is destined freely to reveal itself through its body as a temple of the spirit"²³.

To the ideal description of man in his originality now corresponds the whole surrounding, the Garden of Eden, the animals, which Jehovah brings to man to see what he will call them, etc. On children and childlike souls such a description must involuntarily make the impression of something actual, something that once existed but has now, alas, vanished. And this is indeed actually so, if we take the ideal actuality for what it in truth is, actuality of the spirit, actuality for the spirit.

²³Martensen. "Den christelige Dogmatik." S. 140.

But the naive fusion of the ideal with what is actual in the external sense has produced misunderstandings and confusions which, if they were to persist, must end by undermining religion. On the presupposition that the facts of sacred history must absolutely have the same external actuality as those of profane history, the biblical presentation of Paradise has been taken, in a spiritless sense, for an externally actual history. In this way faith and knowledge have been fused together, and out of the fusion their mutually irreconcilable strife has arisen. [203]

In the name of faith the explanation runs thus: If the story of Paradise is not actual, then there has never been any actual Paradise; if there has never been any actual Paradise, then no actual Fall has ever taken place either; if no actual Fall has taken place, then the whole of revelation is false and faith a fancy. Now we know that revelation cannot possibly be false; therefore we know that an actual Fall must have taken place; therefore we know that at the beginning of history there must have been an actual Paradise in an actual place on earth.

In the name of knowledge the explanation runs thus: There has never been any actual Paradise; there has never existed in nature either a tree of life or a tree of the knowledge of good and evil; no such Fall as the one the Bible speaks of has ever happened; revelation is therefore false, and faith a fancy.

Both parties are agreed in identifying the principles of faith and of knowledge; both are agreed that what is true in religion must also be true in science, and conversely; both are therefore agreed in drawing scientific consequences from religious presuppositions and religious consequences from scientific ones. But what, then, is the result of all this agreement? Disagreement! It stands fast in science that the biblical Paradise has never been actual, so fast that natural science would instantly have to undermine its own foundation if it admitted the possibility of the opposite; and it stands fast in religion that the ideal state of innocence has reality, so fast that faith cannot possibly give up this reality without giving up itself. To settle the strife there is only one way out: to cognize the absolute heterogeneity of the principles. The actuality at which revelation aims in the description of its Paradise is not the actuality that natural science sets out to investigate: the two kinds of actuality, the ideal and the material, belong to two quite different regions. [204]

Already from an aesthetic standpoint it must be recognized that it is not nature in its outward material immediacy that appeals to man, but that everything depends on the mood it awakens, and so on man's inner being. Not what is actually seen and heard and felt, but the eye with which one sees, the ear with which one hears, the heart with which one feels, is what lends nature its spiritual luster. We find it in order that the poet, in order to open to us an insight into the essence of nature, so to speak creates nature anew, so that we may rightly see how it is created; for we understand that he produces illusion only because the illusion is even more truthful than actuality. Is Paradise, then, an illusion? By no means! As high as religion stands above poetry, so high stands the religious explanation of nature above the merely aesthetic one.

The believing mind resists with reluctance conceiving the narrative of Paradise as a philosophical myth, a poetic clothing of a profound thought; and from the standpoint of revelation it cannot be conceived so either: the content of the narrative has taken on the stamp of actuality and means to count as full actuality. But then it also becomes a matter of becoming conscious of what kind of actuality it is, so that one does not confuse the higher with the lower.

The lower actuality is sensuous; it stands and falls with the testimony of the senses. He who says: I cannot believe the story of Paradise unless I may assume that the trees in that garden had the same external actuality as the trees in any other garden, [205] builds his faith on sensuous ground; his faith is superstition. Yet here is an objection of a more serious kind. "If the serpent that seduced Eve was not externally actual," one might say, "then Eve, who was seduced, was not externally actual either, and so neither was Adam, nor Cain and Abel: our 'first parents,' with the descendants whose names are read on the oldest genealogy of the human race, are thus sublimated into ideal beings of fantasy without contact with the so-called lower actuality; but that such a conception conflicts both with the nature of the case and with the express testimony of Scripture is incontestable." This objection, however striking it must seem at first glance, rests on a misapprehension, as thoroughly ruinous as it is pervasive, of the original position in which, according to the principle, the historical and the religious stand to each other in the revealed word.

Religion is of the people; the history of revelation goes from the beginning together

with the history of the people, namely as this history was conceived by the people chosen for revelation. But it is so far from being the case that historical faith grounds religious faith that the opposite holds: it is precisely religious faith that governs, explains, and grounds historical faith. Originally the two heterogeneous elements are fused together; but after the conflict between faith and knowledge has been driven to its extreme, the moment has arrived when a critical separation must be carried through: the critique of knowledge has already done its part; it remains for the critique of faith also to do its part.

The ideal of innocence, whose actuality is made visible in Paradise, is precisely the ideal of actuality that forms the bright background of the cognition of sin, the presupposition without which sin cannot be actual. The difference between the aesthetic and the religious ideal is here conspicuous. The aesthetic ideal belongs to the imagination alone; it satisfies contemplation, but makes no demand upon the will; [206] it requires no realization; in illusion it has its own unactual actuality, its completion and conclusion. The religious ideal, on the contrary, is in the very strictest sense of the word an ideal of actuality; for it is first and last an ideal of the will, and the ideal of the will demands its realization. Sin is guilt; the sinful will is guilty. But the will can have become guilty only through an actual break with its ideal, i.e. through an actual sublation of its own innocence. Original innocence is therefore an actual, inescapable presupposition of actual guilt, and for that very reason contains the actual, inescapable demand that sin must be atoned for, that guilt must one day be blotted out.

The ideal of innocence thus stands at one and the same time both before and behind actual human life: before, as the final goal toward which the guilty one yearns; behind, as the point of departure without which his yearning and anxiety would be in vain. Inwardness in the cognition of actual guilt and inwardness in the cognition of original innocence are in principle the same inwardness, the same actuality: it is actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit.

Insofar as actual human life is marked by guilt, the sinful condition comes immediately to present the given as actuality, namely the untrue actuality, while the ideal of innocence, the actuality true in itself, is pushed back, has assumed the form of something unactual, and presents possibility. Man in his state of innocence is man at

the beginning of his life, conceived according to his inner true essence, i.e. according to his ideal as actual man. Both sides—that the beginning actuality is ideal, and that the ideal of the beginning is actual—the revealed word emphasizes with equal force. Revelation speaks a double language, but without ambiguity. It speaks of the actual
 [207] beginning of human life, thus of actual human beings, of the first human beings, “our first parents”; but it speaks also of the original, the ideal-actual in this actual beginning; then it speaks in images, in symbols; then the veil of corruptibility is drawn aside; then the holy vision is seen: nature transfigured in the light of the Spirit, the springs of peace with the tree of life, Adam and Eve in the garden of Eden.

β) Temptation and Fall.

“Now the serpent was more subtle than any beast of the field which the Lord God had made, and it said to the woman: Is it so, that God hath said, Ye shall not eat of every tree of the garden? And the woman said to the serpent: We may eat of the fruit of the trees of the garden; but of the fruit of the tree which is in the midst of the garden, God hath said, Ye shall not eat of it, neither shall ye touch it, lest ye die. And the serpent said to the woman: Ye shall not surely die; for God doth know that in the day ye eat thereof, then your eyes shall be opened, and ye shall be as God, knowing good and evil. And the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was pleasant to the eyes, and a tree to be desired to make one wise, and she took of its fruit, and she did eat, and she gave also to her husband with her, and he did eat.” (Gen. 3:1–6). This is in brief the “supra-historical” history of the Fall, a history that yields no gain for knowledge, but all the richer a gain for faith.

It is the woman, according to the ideal the most innocent of all women on earth, who is here appointed to make manifest how sin came, and still continues to come, into the world. Innocence is a two-sided concept; one can say of paradisaal innocence both that it is and that it is not destined to disappear. Insofar as innocence designates
 [208] the first childlike immediacy of the life of spirit, and this is indeed precisely the case with Eve’s innocence, it is certainly destined to be sublated. Before the temptation sets in she is without any guilt, and therefore innocent. Innocence shows itself in this, that the personal is still a possibility; the duality in the natural-spiritual self has not

been awakened to conscious separation: the religious and the selfish elements still slumber in tranquil unity. She is innocent; her soul is pure, a mirror for the dawning of the Spirit in the incipient relation to God; but in her innocence she is nonetheless a natural self, and in her natural self she has a hidden egoism. Thus the child, in all its innocence, is a little egoist. This hidden, still unconscious egoism is not in itself sinful; it is only the natural disposition of the natural will, and the natural disposition of the will is necessary as the foundation for the will of the spirit. The ideal determination of the natural will is to be awakened by the Spirit to self-denying obedience. If the will obeys, then the ambiguity of innocence is sublated in the sense that guilt is excluded and the tested faith, with self-conscious freedom, has been set in its place. If, on the contrary, the will refuses the Spirit obedience, then egoism comes forth from its hiding place and sublates the ambiguity by making the innocent one guilty.

For a closer determination of the relation between ideal and actuality we must begin with the relation to God. The relation to God corresponding to the principle of revelation is actual; it is indeed a relation between the working God and an actual human soul; Eve is to that extent to be regarded as an actually existing individuality. But this actual individuality is more than a single individual; the ancestral mother is, essentially seen, the individuality in all individuals yet to come, individuality according to its first ideal fundamental determination; she is *instar omnium*. All attempts to explain psychologically the spiritual condition of “the first human beings,” i.e. of the first human individuals, must fail even for the most acute, for they rest [209] on a misunderstanding. The ideal presentation that is to reveal to us what from the very beginning dwells essentially and originally in the soul must go far beyond the immediate condition of empirically limited individuals. Here one cannot ask how Eve in her first naturalness could have understood Jehovah’s word and grasped the Spirit’s command so clearly and purely; such considerations of finitude stem from an objectively reasoning understanding that wants to know something. Here there is nothing for knowledge, but everything for faith. Eve’s soul is the soul in its first ideal relation to God; but in its first ideal relation to God the soul can understand the Spirit, understand the thought of the holy will deeply and purely and clearly; for without the possibility of such an inner understanding faith would lack its principle, and the

relation to God would remain in eternal ambiguity.

For a closer determination of the relation between ideal and actuality we must also take note of the holy symbolism: it is the tree of knowledge and the serpent that capture our attention. That the tree of knowledge is as little an external, tangible actuality as an empty allegory is easy to see. The slumbering life of the spirit is to be awakened to self-activity; it is awakened by the Spirit through the word, it is awakened through the law: the commandment of the law is a prohibition. But a prohibition cannot, after all, be given unless there must in actuality be something that is prohibited. In the reciprocal determination of the prohibition and the prohibited, the relation between the actual and the ideal shows itself here. The prohibition against eating the fruit of a definite, named tree is so unambiguous, so immediately comprehensible, that not even the most innocent can mistake it. The actual definiteness, then, is stressed as strongly as possible. And yet the ideal significance goes far beyond any [210] limited particular whatever. For what kind of fruit is it, then, whose enjoyment is here forbidden? The forbidden fruit! The object of the prohibition coincides to such a degree with the prohibition itself that the universal is: Thou shalt not do what is forbidden! The tree of the knowledge of good and evil is the object of the trial; but since the knowledge of good and evil depends precisely on the outcome of the trial, the object of the trial is essentially a moment in the trial itself: in such visible forms does the symbolism of revelation express the first proclamations of the Spirit.

Between the tree of knowledge and the woman the serpent suddenly appears. It is not enough here to ask: what does the serpent *mean*; we must expressly ask: what *is* the serpent? If it holds of the tree of knowledge that it *is* what it means, then the same must surely hold of the serpent. It lies in wait by the tree and—it lies in wait for the woman. At once, at the first glance, the serpent shows itself to be a contradiction; and indeed it is a contradiction: it is the author of contradictions, contradiction itself from the beginning. In the first place it is a contradiction that the serpent is an animal and yet a spirit. That it is an animal is plainly said; that it is a spirit we hear from its speech. What, now, does this animal spirit, this spiritual animal, mean; whence does it come, what is it? We answer: it comes from the hidden depths of natural life; it rises up from the ground of the soul; it is the egoism hidden in paradisaal innocence, which

in this symbol projects its shadow-outline. This is seen from the manner in which it comes. It comes, as it seems, of itself: no one has sent for it; and yet it does not come of itself, for the spirit has conjured it forth, the spirit of contradiction that the prohibition awakens. That is why it is so characteristic that, as if to make sure, it begins by asking whether it is really so that God has forbidden man to eat of all the trees in the garden. Here, then, we have the prohibition reflected in egoism. Through the reflection that [211] rebels against the prohibition, egoism becomes spirit. In elemental naturalness egoism is animal; with animal unruliness it works in the strong, raw, savage natural man. Were it to be presented in this character, it would surely have to be symbolized by the wolf, the tiger, the panther rather than by the serpent. But in the form of rawness it could not possibly make its appearance in Paradise. It comes forth, then, under the symbol of cunning, falsehood, and craftiness, and takes the innocent one by surprise. Just as the word from God is clear to Eve, so now is the corresponding word too, an echo of self-will from the selfish interior, a clear and definite contradiction of the word of God. It happens before Eve's eyes; it takes place in the soul, and the soul knows of it, and yet does not know of it. The ambiguity is at its height; that means that it must disappear: so, then, the temptation begins.

“Let no man say when he is tempted, I am tempted of God; for God cannot be tempted with evil, neither tempteth he any man. But every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed.” (Jas. 1:13–14). These last words some have wished to use to explain the serpent away, as if the serpent meant that the temptation came from without²⁴, but without any ground. With the serpent the temptation by no means comes from without, but on the contrary from within: precisely for that reason the external symbolized in the serpent is necessary. All temptation presupposes reflection; but the reflection in the first temptation has this peculiarity, that it is involuntary, that it takes place as if of itself. Certainly Eve is tempted by her own lust; but she does not yet know the subjective essence of lust: if she knew it, she would not be innocent. Innocence shows itself precisely in this, [212] that the hidden egoism, the natural selfishness of human nature, emerges as a being different from herself; the egoism is in herself, and yet is not her personal self, for the

²⁴S. Kierkegaard. *Begrebet Angest*. S. 43.

personal self is in the will that is now to concentrate itself in the choice, whether she chooses obedience or disobedience. It is the immediacy in the tempting reflection that gives the temptation so objective, and precisely thereby so innocent, a tinge. What is tempting in the phenomenon forces itself upon Eve as a fact; she sees that the tree is good for food, and pleasant to the eyes, and then—yes, then it is a moment of perdition, a single now, and then she becomes guilty.

But how, now, does it really stand with this guilt, this very first sin? That Eve has fallen is certain; but in what does her guilt consist? She is, after all, taken by surprise, beguiled; before she has had time to collect herself and offer resistance, she has already fallen. Her fall is like that of one who suddenly stands at an abyss and then grows dizzy and plunges down. And yet she has become guilty, as essentially guilty before God as any soul in the world can become. The moment in which she falls is precisely the moment in which she could have been saved, namely the moment when faith was to come into being for her. In the untested immediacy of innocence faith is still only, so to speak, conceived, but not born; it can be born only in temptation, for temptation awakens doubt, and faith is the inner act that strikes down doubt and holds fast to God. This act is the fundamental act of the will of the spirit: it is a moment that encloses a whole eternity. If the moment passes without the act of faith taking place, then the selfish has conquered; the temptation works like a sorcery; the eye darkens, and even if the one grown dizzy recovers her sight in the next instant, it is another sight, the sight of desire upon the false ideal: the self is transformed. What transformation takes [213] place in Eve in the moment of temptation is seen from this, that without hesitation she believes that it is God who is the liar, and the serpent who speaks the truth.

In excuse of Eve people have pleaded her inexperience, her lack of firmness, her guilelessness, thus her innocence. But however much such grounds of finitude may signify where the talk is of the psychological weaknesses of a limited individual, they signify nothing here, where the talk is of the ideal collision of the will of the spirit and the fundamental egoism in the depths of individuality. Instead of diminishing the guilt, the preceding innocence will on the contrary heighten it. How, in the spiritual sense, should the inexperienced gain experience except by setting faith against doubt and resisting temptation? By succumbing to a first preliminary temptation and becoming

provisionally guilty, she could surely not possibly gather strength to preserve her innocence in the decisive trial. The only thing that could still be said in excuse of the fallen one would then have to be that the first temptation was too great, was beyond her strength. But it is not so. Eve has in her innocence all the presuppositions, all the help that a human being can have, for meeting the first temptation; the temptation itself is of such a nature that if she were able to resist any, it would have to be this one. She lacks nothing, indeed she has everything in abundance: she may “eat of all the trees of the garden” except the one. What tempts her is not something natural in itself, but, when we look more closely, something so heaven-storming, so spiritually rebellious, that it could, one would think, be tempting only to a Titan, not to an innocent woman. For what is it that tempts her? A forbidden fruit, people say, an apple perhaps, nothing else! Yes, it looks childish and insignificant enough; thought can almost be revolted by the notion that such a fuss is made over so slight a thing, [214] that the whole human race should be punished so severely for a piece of apple. That this is a spiritless misunderstanding anyone can see. If one says: she is tempted by the forbidden; the forbidden, whatever it may be, always tempts; that lies in human nature; *in vetitum ruimus, petimusque negata*—then one has reduced the highest to a triviality. No, what tempts her is nothing less than the ideal-egoism of wanting, by transgressing God’s commandment, to become like God: *Eritis sicut Deus*. That this main point is not sufficiently heeded has its ground chiefly, no doubt, in this: that with all manner of mystical secondary notions about what the serpent is—perhaps the masked devil—one lets the serpent keep the thought and Eve thoughtlessly reach for the fruit. But such a conception conflicts not only with the spirit of the narrative, but also with its letter. For the woman, who sees that it is “a tree to be desired to make one wise,” enters precisely into the thought, the serpent’s thought; she reaches for the fruit expressly in order to gain understanding, the understanding of good and evil that is to make her equal with God. To a higher spiritual majesty Adam himself could not rise; he therefore follows Eve in silent admiration; thinks as she does, and does as she does: thus sin came into the world.

Is this, now, to be comprehended? In faith! yes—but not in knowledge.

From the standpoint of knowledge the task would be to explain the Fall by ground-

ing the act of will from which guilt proceeds; but that is impossible. Whether one (Schelling, Steffens), in order to explain sinfulness, assumes an “intelligible act” taking place outside time, whereby the individual has predetermined himself to evil; or one (Hegel) derives sinfulness from the contradiction that obtains between man’s concept
 [215] and his immediate naturalness; or one (Fichte) conceives evil as the *vis inertiae*, the original sloth, according to which the ego wants to remain in the given state of nature instead of grappling with its limits and working its way forward to freedom: the knot is equally insoluble. The question that remains unanswered in all these attempts is: what reality does the will have? This question science cannot answer, since will must in the last instance be explained by will, by a fact of self-determination which, in spite of all reasons and counter-reasons, rests not on universal necessity of thought, but on the willing self. Were scientific grounding to be possible, one would have to have the strength of the will as a magnitude known by itself, the resistance of nature likewise as a definite magnitude by itself, and then, by a kind of psychological differential calculus, state the point of equilibrium and find out the conditions under which the preponderance would have to fall either on the side of the resistance of nature or on the side of the will. But the strength of the will can in no case be stated by any finite known magnitude whatever. For the utmost exertion of the will there is no finite, fixed limit. Even if there were such a limit, sin and guilt still could not be explained from it. For guilt cannot be derived from the resistance having been stronger than the will; one would then have to subtract the quantum of inhibition that indicated the excess; for the will does not become guilty because it has not *been able* to do the impossible, but because it has not *willed* the possible. The relation of the will to motives cannot be scientifically determined. If one lets the motives determine the will, then the will’s self-determination ceases; it then becomes merely the tongue on the balance of the motives; it evaporates into a semblance. If, conversely, one lets the will determine itself without motives (indifferentism), or at any rate determine the motives itself, then it must either determine itself blindly, and thus quite involuntarily, or have in
 [216] itself the motive according to which it decides for or against the other motives; but by having the decisive motive in itself, it becomes incommensurable for scientific grounding. When predeterminism wants to explain sin from an act of will preceding

all sinfulness, it is right insofar as it wants to derive sin from a sinful will instead of deriving the sinful will from sin; but it falls into contradiction with itself when it comes to explaining how it is thinkable that a will preceding sin and sinfulness should be able to be so sinful as to determine itself to sin. Sin is a concept of faith and never becomes a concept of knowledge: the origin of sin cannot be explained in science.

From the standpoint of faith the task is soluble, namely in the sense that all the moments corresponding to the principle can be cognized from the revealed word. The ideal of innocence shows that the fundamental will, with its two-sided disposition, has in the relation to God the possibility of subordinating to itself the natural self-will and determining itself as will of the spirit, but also the possibility of neglecting the decisive moment and letting self-will rule. Outside the relation to God, sloth, *vis inertiae*, is no doubt the only acceptable, though insufficient, ground of explanation when the question is of the preponderance of the sensuous over the spiritual: the first sin is then only an impersonal act, merely *peccatum omissionis*. But within the relation to God the choosing self is so strongly accentuated that *peccatum omissionis* is precisely to be regarded as the forming personality's own fundamental act, its first *peccatum commissionis*. The innocent one is tempted so that personality may come into being: the tempted self is *eo ipso* choosing. In the relation to God corresponding to the ideal of innocence the choosing self has not only the obligation but also the condition to concentrate itself into will of the spirit and put faith into force. When the self nonetheless does not do so, the reason is that in its selfishness it will not do so. The choosing self does not will sin immediately, for it wills only its self-will; and [217] yet this is a delusion, for to will its self-will is, according to the given prohibition, expressly to will sin: the self sins, therefore, because it wills to sin; its first act of personality is a sin; it does not sin from sinfulness, but it produces sinfulness by its sin, and sin by its personal will.

γ) The Curse.

The first sin is a free act of consciousness, insofar as it is a personal act of will; and yet through the act itself a transformation takes place in consciousness. Before the act, sin is still only a possibility; after the act it is an actuality; the act itself is the free

translation from possibility to actuality; by this translation sin acquires so altered an aspect that it has not merely become something else in the deed, but has even, by this its alteration, altered the whole actual surroundings. "And the eyes of them both were opened, and they knew that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together, and made themselves girdles" (Gen. 3:7). In these few words the psychological effect of the Fall is compressed. In its first innocence the spirit is dreaming; the dreamer is a child who does not see actuality as it actually is: the dreamer must be awakened. But spirit is awakened by spirit, in that it awakens itself. When, then, it awakens itself under the self-power of self-will, it wakes in sin to consciousness of guilt; it wakes to see what the child could not see — its nakedness, and it is ashamed. It wakes to self-reflection, to work; but this work is not the free deed of freedom, the first bold step on the way of culture; it is on the contrary an involuntary expression of the bad conscience, a wretched endeavor to hide the nakedness that sin has laid bare. "And they heard the [218] voice of Jehovah walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and Adam and his wife hid themselves from the presence of God Jehovah amidst the garden."

What, according to what we have said above, holds of the state of innocence and the Fall, holds also of the punishment and the curse: the revealed word acquires its meaning only when the content of the account is conceived as an object of faith and judged from the standpoint of faith. Two diametrically opposed modes of view, the historical-literal and the philosophical-mythical, have each in its own way contributed in equal measure to confusing the conception.

How impossible it is to carry through the historical-literal interpretation may well be assumed, at the general level of cultivation of the present day, to be self-evident. We cite merely one example. "In the day that thou eatest thereof," says Jehovah (Gen. 2:17), "thou shalt surely die." Taken literally, Adam should accordingly have died on the same day he transgressed God's command. Was this threat then fulfilled; did death then come on the same day? — "Assuredly death came on the same day!" — remarks Irenaeus — "For the Fall took place, together with the creation, on a Friday, and Adam died on this day 930 years later. Or, more exactly still, on the very same day, namely by divine reckoning, according to which 1000 years are = 1 day (Ps. 90:4); for Adam did not, after all, live to be 1000 years old."

That the mythical interpretation can come to terms with the words of the text in a far easier and more natural manner is understandable; and this circumstance has indeed in recent times done its part to efface the boundary of principle between myth and revelation. "In the divine pleasure garden, whose cultivation and keeping had been entrusted to the first human beings, these had permission, it is true, to eat of all the other trees; but one Jehovah had reserved for himself and the other divine [219] beings, namely the tree from whose fruits the Elohim obtained their higher insight. ... By threatening death as an inevitable consequence, Jehovah had therefore tried to deter the humans from partaking of this fruit; but the serpent, which on account of its cunning saw through the real motive of this prohibition, revealed it to the woman, who now, through the enticing hope of an insight equal to God's, and through the beautiful appearance of the fruit, let herself be led into partaking of it, and straightway thereafter also seduced her husband to do so. At once the food of the gods had its effect in the humans; they awoke from the animal unconsciousness of the difference between good and evil, the seemly and the unseemly. ... With displeasure Jehovah, who jealously watches over his prerogatives, remarks that the humans have gained a knowledge like that of the gods; he cannot let such an overstepping of the bounds set for them go unpunished. ... The most important thing is that man, so that he may not also seize the Elohim's other prerogative, immortality through (a continued) partaking of the fruits of the tree of life, is driven out of that place, the garden of Eden."²⁵

It lies in the nature of the case that the narrative itself is not in a position to decide which of the two modes of explanation is the only right one. What turns the scale here is the principle alone. What "God Jehovah" said: "Behold, the man is become as one of us, to know good and evil" (Gen. 3:22), can certainly from a mythical standpoint be conceived as a divine envy (*θειον Φθονερον*), but it can and must none the less, from the standpoint of revelation, be conceived as an expression of the righteous wrath of the Spirit. How necessary it is that the conscience which wakes in sin, veiled and stupefied by sin, be awakened by a word that reveals the holy and the righteous, can [220] be seen in Adam and Eve. They have a bad conscience; they want to hide from the presence of the Holy One. At the moment they committed the trespass they had quite

²⁵Strauss. *Den christl. Troeslære* II. S. 15–16.

forgotten the Omniscient and took no notice at all of the Omnipresent; but hardly is the deed done before there is a stirring in the conscience, and Jehovah is present: they hear his voice “walking in the garden in the cool of the day.” And yet selfishness is so strong, and the stupefaction so great, that when the voice calls and demands an account, the answer is not given in repentance with acknowledgment of sin; no, the answer is given with evasion and excuse: each of the guilty excuses himself by shifting the guilt onto another, the man onto the woman, the woman onto the serpent. This system of excuse is a soul-corrupting, spirit-darkening system of stupefaction. With sin the system of stupefaction came into the world; but for that very reason the stern word of holiness, the punishing word of righteousness, has also been heard in the world. If there is any point in sacred history where it becomes truly manifest that the judgment of conscience must in principle be a judgment of God, it is surely here.

The serpentine lies in the stupefaction. “And God Jehovah said unto the serpent, Because thou hast done this, thou art cursed above all cattle, and above every beast of the field; upon thy belly shalt thou go, and dust shalt thou eat all the days of thy life.” So the judgment begins, then, with a curse. The lightning stroke of the curse, however, does not strike man immediately — had it struck immediately, man would have been crushed — no, the lightning strikes at man’s foot; it strikes, but it does not kill: it strikes something human, but in the symbol. It is natural egoism, the selfishly sly in man’s essence, the false principle of will, which has brought and still brings sin into the world; it is the principle of selfhood, actual and yet, in spiritual essentiality, [221] ideal, that is immediately struck by the curse. With vital vividness the actual animal — in natural-historical actuality certainly not accountable, but through cunning and venom naturally alarming — is stamped as the cunningly stinging hereditary enemy of the race, as a symbol crawling in the dust.

As regards the penal sentence upon man, it becomes evident to an unprejudiced eye that the lot of the woman and of the man corresponds straightforwardly to the burdens that actual existence, according to the factually given world order, lays upon both. Either, so it seems, there can properly be no question here of punishment, or, if the burdens imposed are really to count as punishment, it must be assumed that another world order in actuality preceded this present one. Now since the latter assumption is

flatly rejected by science, and that not on account of an unbelief which argues from the improbable, but on account of a cognition of the world so penetrating that everyone who knows sees the impossibility: the conflict between faith and knowledge is once more on the point of breaking out. The curse on the serpent alone is enough to show where the literal explanation leads. Not to speak of the animal's lack of accountability, even if the devil himself had spoken through it, the supposition that the serpent originally had feet leads to absurdity and justifies the objection from natural science that the curse itself is incorrect and merely rests on the Jewish prejudice that the serpent actually eats dust. If it were in truth impossible to carry through a critical separation between a merely external actuality and actuality for the spirit, then the principle of revelation would really be dissolved; then faith would have to give up. But in this connection too it is seen that the conflict is imagined, not actual.

It is not primarily an external change in nature but an internal change in man [222] that is in question. The transition from innocence to guilt coincides here with the transition from ideal to actuality; as man is in earnest about to make the acquaintance of stern actuality, he comes, according to the penal sentence, to begin with what is still far sterner, the cognition of his trespass. The cognition of the trespass and the cognition of the stern conditions of actuality cannot, from the standpoint of revelation, stand as two cognitions indifferent to each other. If that were so, the consciousness of sin would soon be stifled under the pressure of actuality. Instead of being dissatisfied with himself, man would readily excuse himself with the imperfection of existence and cast the blame on actuality, on its burdens and sufferings, its pains and bitter toil. So that this shall not happen, the punishing word sounds to man: this you have deserved; such a hard and burdensome actuality you have brought upon yourself by your guilt; you have deserved more than that, you have deserved death. The task for faith, then, is not to speculate on how actual nature would have looked if Adam had not sinned; rather, the task of faith is here, as everywhere, a task of inwardness; the task is to cognize original sin and guilt so deeply that it can in earnest be understood that the burdens of actuality are deserved.

But — it is asked — is not something explained away hereby that nevertheless belongs essentially to faith, namely “death and the corruptibility of the whole cre-

ation"? We answer: No! here not one jot, not one letter is explained away of that which in truth is, or ever has been, an object of faith. As regards, in the first place, the corruptibility of nature, science will not deny that there is corruptibility in nature. The [223] question, then, is only in which light corruptibility is to be regarded, that of necessity or that of freedom: here, then, we again have the absolutely heterogeneous principles.

Under the point of view of faith, and so under that of freedom, the Pauline view (Rom. 8:19–23) is unconditionally correct, but precisely for that reason not scientific. When the ideal of freedom furnishes the presupposition for the judgment on the corruptibility of nature, then the consideration takes its starting point in the believing consciousness; then corruptibility comes to mean a condition in which the one consecrated to freedom, awaiting "the adoption, the redemption of our body," is bound; then nature echoes the sigh that presses forth from the breast of man; then we cognize "that the whole creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now."

As regards, next, the relation between sin and death, it ought not to be passed over in silence what science has established by striking, incontrovertible facts: that in the physical sense there was pain and death on earth long before the appearance of man. But it must be emphasized on the side of faith that it is not death as a physical fact but the consciousness of physical death on which it essentially depends. For the animal death does not exist; for when the animal is, death is not, and when death is, the animal is not: only for a mortal, self-conscious being does death exist as death, or, only in the consciousness of death is death. It can, then, be understood in the language of science too that only with man, the self-conscious being that cognizes death as death, does death come into the world; on the other hand it cannot be said on any scientific ground that death is a punishment for sin, that "death is the wages of sin." This, by contrast, can be said with full right in religion. The decisive thing is that man is guilty, that his original consciousness of spirit has become a consciousness of [224] guilt, so that he who does not know within himself what guilt is does not know, in the religious sense either, what spirit is.

Just as man is not merely by nature, and so far with necessity, disposed to work and bear the burdens of actuality, but in consequence of sin is expressly sentenced to work in the sweat of his face and to regard the thorns and thistles that the earth

bears as a punishment — indeed as a gracious punishment, in that the curse, instead of annihilating him in his inner being, has fallen upon the outward: so man is not merely born naturally with the germ of death in his body, but in consequence of the transgression is spiritually sentenced to dread death as the dark enemy, obliged to bear as a punishment for sin the overwhelming impression of a sensuous nature that confirms Jehovah's word: "dust thou art, and unto dust shalt thou return."

This is the essential beginning of human life: the ideal vanishes in sin; actuality begins with guilt. The lost ideal is to be reached again; that is a promise. But the way goes forward, not back: the cherub with the flaming sword guards the entrance to the tree of life.

b) World-Ideals.

§ 16.

The religious worldview is not, and will not be, what in the language of cultivation is called many-sidedly objective. It is not the inner reciprocal struggles of the working forces, not the refraction of individual wills against the universal of reason, not the gradual, conditioned shaping of ideas in national peculiarities, states and civilized societies, about which the revealed word will instruct man: every enlightenment tending in that direction it leaves to reason. It is a direct consequence of the absolute heterogeneity of the principles that the cognition of the world which reason can [225] develop and ground is not imparted by revelation, while conversely the view of the world that reason essentially lacks is opened up in religion. A glance at sacred history, as it begins in the Old and ends in the New Testament, readily shows us what this means. In the Old Testament, where the history of revelation constantly goes together with the history of the people, the outlook is no doubt on the whole turned outward. The conception of the affairs of the Jewish people combines naturally with a corresponding conception of the foreign nations, which from so many sides intervened in this people's history. In this respect there is no lack of descriptions either in Moses or in the prophets. But of a calm, comprehensive survey of world-historical

relations, of a penetrating rational understanding of the position and significance of the individual kingdoms for one another and for the development of the human spirit as a whole, there is here no thought.

We must, as regards the narrowness of the horizon, make a critical separation between the limitation that lay in the passionate particularism of the Jewish people and its lack of humane cultivation, and the limitation that lies in the religious principle itself. It is a task for the critique of knowledge to find out what is historically factual in the Jewish legends and descriptions; but it is the task of the critique of faith, by consistently holding fast the religious principle, to bring to light what is characteristic of revelation in the Old Testament worldview. As regards the New Testament, the particularistic worldliness that obscures the view of what is foreign does, to be sure, fall away, as the eternal light of the Spirit rises over the world; but then at the same time the gaze becomes so turned inward, the principle of revelation so overreaching, and the view of the world as a whole so otherworldly, that the opposition between the rational and the antirational appears in full.

[226] The religious worldview is and will be antirational. This is seen from the principle, the principle of freedom. The humane view of the world, too, posits freedom as the goal of development. But when the opposite of freedom, unfreedom, is brought forward, the character shows itself. For the humane consciousness unfreedom is only a naturally necessary boundness, a provisional limitation of reason, and liberation a constantly advancing civilization. For the religious consciousness unfreedom is sin; "sin is the ruin of the peoples," it is bondage itself and the cause of bondage: liberation, then, is not a self-emancipation of the human spirit but a work of God, a redemption. Under this point of view, decisive for faith, the actual world order must be regarded. What religion teaches us about the world-ideals we cognize from what it teaches us about: *the fallen race*, about *the gods of the world*, and *the prince of this world*.

α) The Fallen Race.

That the history of the human race must have begun with violent outbreaks of the selfish forces of individuals can, in good agreement with what still goes on in the midst of the world of culture, be understood without revelation. Heathen popular

legends, too, tell of bloody strife, of violence and murder from the very first beginning. What is peculiar to the Hebrews' cycle of legends, on the other hand, is this: that the revealed word does not stop at the natural side of the crimes, but lays bare sin as sin and shows how the original relation to God has been disturbed. Seen from the side of the ideal, death comes into the world as a punishment for sin; seen in actuality, death comes into the world as an effect of sin: the first death is a murder, the first murder a fratricide.

It begins with a religious act; Cain brings Jehovah his offering, just as Abel does. But how selfish Cain is, to what degree the serpent principle has poisoned his mind, [227] comes to light when the act of offering is at an end (Gen. 4:4). In envy of Abel and resentment against Jehovah the smoldering egoism works its way forth in Cain on two sides: the dark look, the downcast countenance betray the glow that burns within him. First the relation to God reacts through conscience: "Why art thou wroth, and why is thy countenance fallen?" Beware, beware! that is the admonition, and in the admonition sin is brought to consciousness as sin. But so strong is the selfish essence in self-will that the resistance which the admonishing word has set against the sinful thoughts in order to drive them back serves precisely to heighten the tension with which they suddenly break forth, and the crime is done. Then comes the after-effect within; God's voice is heard: "What hast thou done? The voice of thy brother's blood crieth unto me from the ground."

It is, in the character of actuality, a powerful manifestation of the Fall. The curse is repeated, but in such a way that it now falls, not on the symbolized principle, but on the head of the guilty one; and besides, at the same time, in such a way that in actuality it strikes him in the inner, not in the outer, hits him in his relation to God, not in his relation to the world. The cognition of the trespass brings Cain — not to repentance, but to despair: "My iniquity is greater than I can bear." And yet, seen outwardly, it is as though the despair could pass and the deed be pushed back into oblivion. Cain must flee, that is unavoidable; but in fleeing from home he flees after all in a way from the crime as well. So it passes over. The thundercloud of judgment drifts past, the storm of the spirit subsides; Jehovah sets a mark upon Cain.

If we regard Cain from the point of view of world-consciousness, he is more than

a fugitive criminal, a common murderer. There is in this figure something mighty, for [228] he is marked by the spirit; something that arouses a shudder, for he is branded. But the very mark he bears on his forehead is like a coat of arms with which he makes his way. Everyone who meets him at once gets out of the way: so he presses through and breaks himself a path. If we take the childlike account immediately according to the letter, one could almost be tempted to think that Jehovah had come to terms with Cain, had settled with him on easy conditions, so that Cain should be free of further punishment if only he “went out from the presence of Jehovah” and from his land. But if we attend to the thought of revelation, another light falls on the whole.

In the land “on the east of Eden,” where Cain settles, everything goes as he wishes. The family grows; Cain builds a city and becomes the father of a numerous race, as vigorous and active as it is clever and inventive. Tillage, fixed property, crafts and arts proceed from this race; the life of culture begins: there is work in the workshops, there is “hammering in brass and iron”; one hears “harps and flutes.” Amid this busy life, rich in exertions and enjoyments, the thought of Jehovah is wholly pushed back; so far is the obscuring of the relation to God from being a hindrance to the development of the forces and the successful progress of the works that precisely the opposite is the case. The hidden despair, the secret gnawing of conscience, contains precisely a spur to outward-going activity; for outward-going, grandiose activity is a powerful means of stupefaction, a means that the ever more reflective selfishness is even able to employ until the self is completely secularized and its original relation to God extinguished.

In this respect Lamech is a truly remarkable figure beside Cain. For Cain’s worldliness despair furnishes a hidden foundation; for that the mark of Cain should let itself [229] be effaced by work is not to be thought of. With Lamech it is another matter. He does not seem to carry any dark secret. His essence is worldliness, but a worldliness in which, without any thought of a relation to God, he feels quite at home. Outward power and personal repute are his gods. He has chosen Cain for himself as his exemplar, but enjoys at the same time the satisfaction of far surpassing the exemplar. That Cain is a mighty man, a man who can defend himself and take retaliation if anyone dares to injure him, Lamech concedes; but Lamech — with such sons and such wives: “Adah and Zillah, hear my voice!” — Lamech himself is after all quite a different man.

If Lamech murders man or boy, he can defend it; but let anyone come near him himself and try to insult him, then he shall learn what vengeance is: "For sevenfold shall Cain be avenged, but Lamech seven times seventy times." In measuring himself against Cain, Lamech has naturally forgotten the religious measure; it does not occur to him at all that anything can be said against his view of life: that a man avenges himself when he has the power to do so is, after all, quite in order.

The fallen race is a race of Titans. When the consciousness of God is darkened while great divine powers nonetheless continue to stir in individuals, the mythical representation of a natural mingling of the divine and the human comes to the fore. What this means is clear from the heathen, and especially the Greek, myths of the heroes. Such myths naturally find no place in sacred history; and yet there is here a trait of the mythical-heroic which must be brought out in particular, to shed light on the religious worldview. "And it came to pass, when men began to multiply on the face of the earth, and daughters were born unto them; and the sons of God saw the daughters of men, that they were fair, and they took them wives of all which they [230] chose ... There were giants in the earth in those days, and also after that, when the sons of God came in unto the daughters of men, and they bare children to them; the same became mighty men which were of old, men of renown" (Gen. 6:1-4).

In reading of this race of giants we receive an impression somewhat like the one we have when we hear Nestor in Homer begin his speech to Achilles and Agamemnon by reminding them that he had lived with stronger men, with a Caeneus, Dryas, Pirithous, Theseus, men "with whom none of the mortals now living would venture to enter into contest." That the sons of Elohim in the ancient Hebrew legend have, however we may interpret the narrative, a mythical tinge, cannot be denied. But this hint of the mythical, far from obscuring the principle, serves precisely to set the opposition between myth and revelation in the clearest light.

With the Greek, whose consciousness is essentially mythical, the legends of the heroes give the imagination rich material for detailed elaborations and ingenious poetic inventions. In the Hebrew legend there is no trace of anything of the kind; what is said here is said briefly; for what is really to be emphasized is that "the wickedness of man was great in the earth," and that it was this wickedness that aroused the wrath

of Jehovah: it is the offense against the Holy One himself on which the stress falls. The Greek legends, too, tell of the wrath of Zeus and of the flood in which he let the human race perish, save for a single pair. But the difference between the wrath of Jehovah and that of Zeus is like the difference between Jehovah and Zeus. The ground of Zeus's wrath is not the violation of a holy will, but an equivocal resentment, because the Titan Prometheus, and not he himself, had kindled in man a spark from heaven. Geologically considered, the Noachian flood has, to be sure, no greater extent than the flood of Deucalion; but its significance is other from the religious standpoint [231] than from the mythical. Mythically, the catastrophe ends with a new race of men springing up, according to the oracle's answer to Deucalion and Pyrrha, from the hard stones of the earth, a hard, unbending, defiant race, *et genus durum experiensque laborum*; whereas according to the revealed word it ends with a renewal of the relation to God, with a holy promise: the rainbow is seen in the cloud, and Jehovah makes his covenant with Noah.

The pictures of life that the religious history of the people unfolds here are to be regarded not merely as counter-images but also as after-images of the archetype corresponding to the ideal. From this standpoint too the thought of faith shows itself to be a thought of life running through the whole. When man, by crimes that cry to heaven, breaks with the Holy, turns away from God and gives himself up to the movement of the world, the religious principle reacts; the Spirit is angered, and the wrath is revealed in the punishment. But what is punitive in the punishment is not felt, because of the stupefaction; selfishness, the egoism inspired by the principle of the serpent, renews its outbreaks with growing force over an ever wider compass. At last the Spirit withdraws; it is as if God at length had to give up, as if the governing hand were too weak. Already as a prelude to the Flood, Jehovah says: "My Spirit shall not rule among men for ever" (v. 3), and (v. 6) it is said expressly: "It repented Jehovah that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him at his heart." However figurative this language may be, it is nevertheless not mythical; what is stressed here is not a divine rashness but the holy wrath of the Spirit; and the wrath of the Spirit is, in the sense of revelation, sufficiently grounded.

When actual dispensations, however hard, are no longer conceived religiously,

and so also cannot be understood as judgments of punishment upon sinners, then — [232] this is the condition of freedom — the self-willed race must be left to the consequences of the presuppositions that it itself posits in its spiritual darkness. That is the one side of the matter; the other is that there are always found in the fallen race individuals who are receptive to the workings of the Spirit, and in whom the relation to God can be renewed. What happens with Noah and his family at the Flood is a foreshadowing of what will later happen with Abraham.

The race of Noah too, which grows and multiplies after the Flood, is subject to the workings of the principle of the serpent; it too tries its hand at storming heaven; it too arouses the wrath of the Spirit. But as the Mosaic legend leaves the general primeval history of the human race and is about to pass over to telling of the patriarchs, an event is presented which is characteristic where revelation is concerned.

“Is the whole human race descended from one pair, or does each of the different races have its own origin?” The treatment of this question again recalls the difference between faith and knowledge. What importance the question has in science may be seen from the dispute between the polygenists, who derive the origin of the race from several different pairs, and the monogenists, who explain the differences found among the human races partly by “heredity” and partly, and chiefly, by the “medium,” counting under the medium not only the physical conditions — climate, humidity, heat, means of nourishment, etc. — but also the intellectual and moral surroundings. This matter will, now that science has once emancipated itself from the authority of the Bible, be pursued and decided without the intervention of religion. But just as science, by virtue of its empirical-rational character, is entitled to carry through its investigations without letting anything be prescribed to it by faith, so the philosophy of religion, by virtue of the antirational nature of faith, is entitled to conceive the matter from its own standpoint without consulting the science of reason. [233] “And the whole earth was of one tongue and of one speech”; it is the building of the tower of Babel that is alluded to here.

One of the most magnificent phenomena of worldliness is the cooperation of peoples in multitudes; to bring forth by common labor an astounding great work, a uniting center, a monument that could defy the vicissitudes of the earth and raise the

names of its master builders to heaven — that was the ideal the peoples in the vale of Shinar set themselves to realize; with this lofty goal in view they began to build the tower of Babel. Jehovah's displeasure at this is depicted in a way that undeniably makes it easy for negative critique to explain the whole as a myth.

For one sees plainly, critique will say, how Jehovah, impressed by the high tower, actually begins to grow afraid of the growing might and power of men. "Behold, the people is one, and they have all one tongue; and this they begin to do: and now" — if it goes on like this — "nothing will be restrained from them, which they have imagined to do" (Gen. 11:6). To set a dam against the swelling storm-flood, the embittered Jehovah, jealous of his sole rule, knows no better counsel than to "go down and confound their language, that they may not understand one another's speech." This measure, moreover, is quite profoundly devised. The "Almighty," anxious for his over-power, could easily, to be sure, have destroyed both the tower and the city by lightning and earthquake; but what good would that do? So long as the human race held together, and the high-striving multitude formed a closed mass, they could easily begin upon another, still more magnificent and dangerous undertaking; by [234] confounding the languages, bringing misunderstanding into the crowd and scattering its forces, the governing wisdom succeeds, on the other hand, once and for all in setting a limit to the presumptions, and moreover in doing it so cleverly that it looks for all the world as though the tower and the plan collapsed of themselves: *divide et impera*, that is the policy of governance, a golden rule for all who govern. What is negatively edifying gains still more weight when, on the presupposition that we have here an actual event — which is scarcely the case — one goes more closely into the connection of the matter and sees how the supernatural governance turns the natural causes upside down. Seen from the standpoint of actuality, every human undertaking, be it ever so magnificent, has its essential limitation in itself. By overstepping the limit, ambition only betrays its impotence and sets a limit to itself: this holds of all high-flying building plans, the Babylonian one included. The top of the tower was to "reach unto heaven"; that was an exaggeration, and the exaggeration fell before the limit. The whole ambitious race imagined itself to be agreed on one single giant work of honor and renown; that was an illusion. The higher ambition that unites men

for great exploits is inseparable from the lower, which smolders in individuals and calls forth discord and confusion. The actual causal connection, grounded in reason, is therefore this: in its youth the human race had a swelling energy for deeds, united with a gigantic, heaven-storming imagination that drove it on into the unlimited. But exaggerations and presumptions have served precisely to make the indwelling limit of reason manifest. The point is not that the multitude of people on the earth would have been agreed among themselves to build the infinite tower if the divine will had not caused the disagreement by a miracle; the point is rather that the germ of disagreement lay hidden beneath the apparent agreement, and that its breaking through satisfied [235] the divine reason. The miracle is not the cause of the confusion of tongues, any more than the many different tongues are the cause of the dispersion of the peoples; but the reverse: the dispersion of the peoples, the original and natural diversity of the tribes, is the cause of the diversity of tongues, and the diversity of tongues is the most essential cause of that separation and dividedness which, by preventing the masses from running together into one single great uniform crowd, rationally conditions an all-round development of powers and dispositions.

The rational interpretation of negative critique is, from the standpoint of knowledge, irrevocable. Were the religious conception to go in a rational direction, then in working against critique it would only be working against itself. But the difficulty vanishes when the word of revelation is allowed to be what it in truth is: antirational. The antirational is recognized at once by the inverted causality. Suppose, to go to the extreme, that the polygenists are right, that natural actuality is therefore as opposed as possible to the word of revelation: what follows from this? That religion is nonetheless proved right in the spiritual sense! We already have the suggestion of it in the humane view. For let the marks of race be ever so prominent, and the roots of the great families of languages ever so dissimilar, one thing still stands firm: that man in all races is man, a rational being disposed for self-conscious development. Rationally seen, the human race is but one.

This essential unity, however, receives a quite different and higher significance through the religious presupposition that man, as man, is created in the image of God; before this original stamp of unity of the spirit, every natural difference must be

[236] regarded as vanishing. While Judaism otherwise, by its sharp opposition to heathenism, expresses itself particularistically, as regards the original equality of men before God it not only lets the whole race descend from one pair of parents — for an analogue to this is found also in several mythologies, for example in the Norse — but also holds to its presupposition so steadfastly in thought that the most essential consequences of all are later drawn from it.

Now when religion sees in the human race one single great family from the beginning, and yet wants to explain the fact that this family has in the course of time become estranged from itself, has divided into tribes and nations that do not understand one another's tongues, then the explanation must be conditioned by the inversion of causality. The preceding dispersion is then regarded not as the cause of the confusion of tongues; rather the confusion of tongues, a consequence of discord in mind and thought, is regarded as the cause of the dispersion of the peoples, and so as a punishment. Inner discord, confusion and division belong precisely to burdensome actuality, and every burden of actuality must be borne as a punishment for sin.

The particular guilt corresponding to the particular punishment is made visible in the presumptuous attempt at building the tower. On this point too causality is inverted. Rationally, the cause of the enterprise's coming to a halt lies in its own unreasonableness, and the divine displeasure is to be regarded as an effect of this unreasonableness; antirationally, on the contrary, the cause of the halt lies in the divine disapproval, and the effect of this is the unreasonableness, the infinite confusion, in which the enterprise dissolves. From this inversion of causality it is seen at the same time that the antirational does not stand in logical conflict with the rational, but only signifies the absolute heterogeneity of the religious principle with the scientific. The natural intermediate causes are by no means displaced by the supernatural cause of will; but the latter appears as immediately effective in that the former are, at the decisive turning point, reduced to vanishing moments. "The tongues are confounded, and thereby God's will is done; for the fallen race in its presumption wills something sinful, and the confusion of tongues is a punishment for sin." In this way the antirational can indeed, in all ambiguity, be combined with the rational. But revelation has no liking for the ambiguous; in its language it means expressly to remove the ambiguity;

that is why, passing over the intermediate causes, not rhetorically but categorically, it emphasizes exclusively the divine cause of will wherever the thought of governance demands it.

From this it can be understood that the effect which in one connection is referred to a natural intermediate cause may, in another connection, from another standpoint, have to be referred to God's will. The difference between God's effecting will (*voluntas efficiens*) and his permitting will (*voluntas permittens*) is, in the form of knowledge, meaningless, or rather: contradictory; but for faith it is essential and significant: the difference is antirational, not rational. We see it from the confusion of tongues.

In what sense the confusion of tongues or the multiplicity of languages, regarded from its shadow side — the essential significance of the abiding differences is not under discussion here — is a punishment for sin becomes evident when we look to the final end. For the final end is that division, enmity and confusion shall vanish; the final end is that the God of Israel shall be the God of all peoples; the final end is that the middle wall of partition shall be broken down, and that men, despite their many dissimilar thoughts and purposes, shall understand one another in the understanding of the one purpose that is exalted in the eternal sense. Just as the race is one by its fall, so shall it also be one by its restoration; it is the governing causality that scatters, [238] and it is the governing causality that gathers; but in both respects the causality is antirational: it wills not only the reunion on account of the dispersion, it wills also the dispersion with a view to the reunion; it wills not only the restoration for the sake of the fall, it wills also that the fall become manifest for the sake of the restoration. "For God hath concluded them all in unbelief, that he might have mercy upon all" (Rom. 11:32): the fallen, falling race falls not outside but inside the Kingdom of the Father.

β) The Gods of the World.

It lies in the nature of the world to be ambiguous: it is dependent, for it is created by God, and yet independent, for it has its ground in itself; it is dependent, for it is preserved by God, and yet independent, for it is borne and moved by its own powers; it is dependent, for the aim and final end of its movements are determined by the governing will, and yet independent, for aims and means develop out of its original

disposition. The ambiguity doubles and grows when the gaze fixes on the essential center, the human self, which with its spiritual tasks is placed precisely midway between God and the world. The ambiguity of the world is now not merely outside man but in man, for the human self begins in natural ambiguity. If the relation to God could simply be strengthened by the weakening of the consciousness of the world, then the choice between God and the world might well become recognizable enough; but the difficulty is that the relation to God becomes empty when the content of the world falls away; the difficulty is that the self which is to renounce the world must precisely take a vigorous hand in the world, work in the world against the world, and so know the world both in itself and outside itself. The difficulty increases when we

[239] consider that the self, developing under great impressions of the world, must take the first step on the way of the spirit with the acknowledgment of guilt, and the next with decisive self-denial. To acknowledge one's guilt when one has already, beforehand, in the finite sense, with full freedom done something and made oneself guilty of something, is difficult enough already because of the stupefaction; but to have to begin with the acknowledgment of guilt — not in this or that, but of essential guilt — in order to be able to begin with God, is yet far more difficult. To deny oneself a good in the world, be it this or that allurements, is already hard enough; to force oneself to infinite resignation and to acknowledge all relative goods as indifferent (*Adiaphora*) is harder still; but to resign everything in the world in such a way that infinite resignation means a new beginning with the world, an unconditional readiness to use the world and do God's will in the world — this task is, as it seems, so superhuman that reason's eyes swim when it rightly considers it. Religious self-denial is, spiritually understood, certainly the very deepest self-affirmation; but the living cognition of this can in actuality only arrive when the self-denial has taken place. That the cognition which should come first, in order to bring about the self-denying act, comes only afterwards, is an expression of the originality of the relation to God and of the inner infinity of faith; but a direct transition from the relation to the world to the relation to God there cannot be.

From what has been set out here it can be understood that there must be a conflict between reason and religion about the essence and significance of the world, a conflict

that can be settled only in consequence of the absolute heterogeneity of the principles.

For a rational consideration, the actual world is rational. The rational is seen in the laws of things, i.e. in the unity of the individual with the universal, for the things represent the individual, the laws the universal. The rational is that the universal is [240] higher than the individual. Now if the world as a whole is rational, then man, the human self, ought surely to be rational too; but it becomes rational only by cognizing itself, as an individual being, to be the universal, and by making itself an organ of the universal. This instinct of reason — to let the universal raise itself step by step and master the individual — underlies the formation of great national communities, the formation of states, history and civilization. Science has its strength precisely in investigating, developing and presenting these many formations in their characteristic diversity and mutual connection, constantly, in the midst of particulars, with its gaze fixed on the universal. The rational self, which is to work in all directions for the universal and therein to cognize and recognize its own essence, finds in manifold suffering and acting rich occasion both for self-denial and for self-affirmation; but the question is how far it can go, how high it can reach. It is the gods of the world that must lead the way in this connection. The fundamental significance of these gods changes remarkably according as they are regarded in the light of revelation or in the light of reason. From the standpoint of revelation they are all without distinction idols, a Zeus and Athena just as much as a Moloch, Baal and Astarte, visible signs of outrageous crime. The crime is that the false gods are set in the place of the true God. Conceived from the standpoint of humanity, on the other hand, the mythical deities are bearers of great world-ideas. The figure of the god itself has the higher determination of being the protecting symbol while the Idea works its way through to actual existence and deposits a form for the universal.

The highest universal, in the form of spiritual actuality, is the state. The state as state is the supreme power, the ruling deity on earth; the state is the great projected human essence; it is the reflected splendor of the glory of reason, the express image [241] of its essence. The highest position in the highest universal of actuality is the position of the ruler in the state; only here does the rational self find its proper determination, its true sphere of activity: a magnificent prospect, a wide horizon! The universal,

however, cannot coincide so immediately with the individual that a single one should have all the power and all the others be slaves. This form of state is only a first crude sketch. The task is that power be distributed, and society organized in such a way that all, each with his limitation and according to his titles, can be given a share in power and so far also become holders of power. If only this task were solved, the state would be the temple of the deity, or rather the kingdom of the deity, and the deity present in its kingdom would then, as the universal and by virtue of the universal, permeate both arts and sciences and the customs of the people and the activity of the citizens and the ethical consciousness of the individual: this is an ideal of the world whose realization must be striven for through millennia, and which can yet be reached only by approximation.

With the world-ideal set out here, religion cannot possibly be in agreement with reason. It does not lie in the principle of faith that religion should either deny the state or in any respect fail to recognize its actual significance; but the deification of the state and of power that springs from the principle of reason is what repels the consciousness of God and makes it comprehensible that sacred history, far from engaging in any pragmatic presentation of the history of states, rather holds fast to its antirational standpoint, protests against the gods of the world, and holds judgment over those in power. In order to consider what significance this has from the standpoint of faith, we choose a couple of examples from the prophets.

Isaiah sees in a vision the fall of Babylon (ch. 14) and describes the pride of the [242] fallen Chaldean king. "And thou saidst in thine heart: I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God, I will sit upon the mount of the congregation, in the sides of the north." This description of a tyrant "who smote the peoples in wrath with a continual stroke, who ruled the nations in anger" is religiously full of pathos, aglow with holy passion, but in its fundamental character it is not in the least exaggerated. In the Babylonian ruler self-deification goes so essentially together with the deification of power that the egoism of the ideal shines through. It is not the conceit, not the boastful words of a high-flying imagination, on which the emphasis falls; such outbursts of an overflowing Oriental imagination, which point rather to a state of spiritual drunkenness than to a methodical lust for rule and deliberate

wickedness, cannot heighten the imputability; no, what is outrageous is the egoism of the ideal itself. This outrageous thing the critique of reason cannot strike, since it is itself stricken by the egoism that idealizes itself through the universal. The reflecting world-consciousness is, to be sure, not selfishly naive like an Eastern despot, but it nevertheless bows deeply before outward greatness and practices the deification of power with every Nebuchadnezzar.

Religion does not begrudge the ruler his power, but it punishes the encroachments of ambition and judges the deification of power. Religion is the only authority that can do so, since it is the only one that sees through the self, the only one that has a measure of height for power. If the holy will is thought away, then the egoism of the ideal is entirely justified; if the almighty Self goes out, then the selfish deification of power is in order. What reason cannot do, the revealed word can: step forth against presumptuous greatness and make history a mirror of the impotence of the mighty. It is not selfish hatred, it is the authority of the Spirit, it is Jehovah's judgment, that breathes in the mighty words with which the prophet describes the annihilation of [243] the fallen prince. He descends into the realm of shades, the pale heroes rise, the dead kings stand up from their thrones, and trembling they speak: "Art thou also become weak as we? art thou become like unto us? Thy majesty is brought down to the underworld, the noise of thy harps. Now shall the worms spread under thee, and the maggots cover thee." — True enough, a gifted poet could give an equally shattering portrayal; but there is this great difference between the poet and the prophet, that the former only affects the imagination, while the latter, by virtue of the principle of faith, asserts the claim of the Spirit and affects the will.

"World history is the world's judgment"; when these words are understood scientifically, they are understood objectively: there are in history crises and catastrophes of which we can say that each of them has been like a day of judgment over a given age; but the judgment is only relative and ambiguous, for the Judge of the world does not appear. There is a picture in Daniel (ch. 5) that makes really vivid what it means that a day of judgment draws near. It is not ambition strong in deeds that swings the scourge over sighing nations; it is another form of glory that here comes to revelation: luxury, spiritual slackness, stupefying enjoyment and contempt for the holy have with

noisy festivity gathered a circle around the gods of the world. It is King Belshazzar, who makes a feast for his lords, “a thousand in number,” and he drinks wine before the thousand. — “And when he had tasted the wine, he commanded to bring forth the vessels of gold and silver which his father Nebuchadnezzar had taken out of the temple in Jerusalem, that the king and his lords, his wives and his concubines, might drink therein ... And they drank wine, and praised the gods of gold and of silver, of brass, of iron, of wood and of stone.”

[244] The critique of reason will surely not, as regards the total impression, find a single feature in this picture so rich in character that goes against probability. On the contrary! Here there is, if not exactly clear signs, then at least likelihood that a kingdom under such governance, with such a governor, might be near its downfall. In actuality it will depend on the circumstances. Should the mighty kingdom suddenly be shaken and collapse, the whole upheaval would naturally be comprehensible from causes, conditions and intermediate causes which clearly show that the governing power is the world-reason itself. For that a God who felt offended because the guests drank from the holy vessels of his altar should intervene as an arbitrarily acting cause is mythical. — But what here, for the rational world-consciousness, is mythical and in that respect inessential, the word of revelation expressly posits as what is in the highest sense essential, decisive; religion closes its eye to the intermediate causes in order to see the holy cause all the more clearly: religion is antirational; that is seen in the moment of tension.

“In the same hour came forth fingers of a man’s hand, and wrote over against the candlestick upon the plaster of the wall of the king’s palace: and the king saw the hand that wrote. Then the king’s countenance was changed, and his thoughts troubled him ...” And none among the wise men of Babylon on whom the king called, neither the enchanters nor the Chaldeans nor the soothsayers, could read him the enigmatic writing. The enigmatic writing is a word of judgment which, often repeated, still repeats itself each time that the deification of power and of self is to come to an end. “*Mene, Mene, Tekel, Upharsin*”: so it is often written with fingers of an invisible hand; but it is seldom that the writing is read aright; for only a prophet can read it. —

[245] “Is this, then, actuality?” Yes, actuality of the spirit, actuality for the spirit.

γ) The Prince of This World.

If the world is an ambiguous being, it goes without saying that the world-spirit must be an ambiguous spirit. Expressions such as *zeitgeist*, the spirit of the time, party spirit, national spirit and the like are reminder enough of the ambiguity. In the science of reason, however, the category world-spirit is used as the designation for the human spirit developed to full consciousness, a spirit that has its purposes and its final end in itself, and it is presented as the deity of the Absolute revealing itself in history. That the world-spirit, so conceived, is more than a fantastic personification of an essentiality indeterminable in itself, that it actually corresponds to a determinate concept, can easily be shown. The Idea in the form of consciousness is spirit. Now, society as society, the people as people, humanity as humanity can by no means be said to have unity of consciousness in itself, or in a literal sense to be conscious of itself: the unity of consciousness is distributed among the individuals singly. But as the individuals are awakened to the cognition of the essence of society, they are at the same time awakened to the cognition of the universal power that governs society. Out of the many individual consciousnesses a common consciousness forms itself, and this common consciousness, penetrating all individuals, then transforms itself for reflection into a consciousness of the universal, an essential universal consciousness with retroactive objectivity. What content the universal consciousness is to receive depends, moreover, on the circle of tasks, interests and Ideas which the age sets in motion each time. The spirit impregnated with Ideas acts on the individual wills as a universal will moving the whole; in great turning points the universal spirit can even at times rise up with so decisive a stamp of objective unity of will that it gives the impression of a willing self, an invisible ruler. And yet this spirit ruling in the times is not a willing self; it is only a general selfhood, a selfless willing; this selfhood and this willing are, with all their objectivity, only the mirroring and reflection of what moves subjectively in the individuals. The world-spirit in its concept is at once both objective and subjective, but the unity of the objective and the subjective is an ambiguous unity; the ambiguity is mythical: the world-spirit is a mythical being. [246]

Now, as religion sets its holy principle of will sharply against the principle of the world, it is a matter of course that the struggle must become hard. A mutual

hatred develops: love of the world is hatred of God, and conversely; this conflict is so thoroughgoing precisely because it goes through the innermost core of the self. The self moved by the world-spirit must, in order to remain true to its purpose, be willing to sacrifice itself for an Idea, and above all for the most comprehensive subjective Idea of the egoism of the ideal, the Idea of honor; for just as the Idea of power is the most objective, so the Idea of honor is, among all the world's Ideas, the most subjective: if the self cannot attain power, then it must at least preserve its honor. Now if the goal of honor were unconditionally inward, the claim of honor would be so inward, so absolutely decisive a claim of selfhood that the self would therein comprehend its own eternity and posit itself and its own glorification as the final end of existence. That such a self-deification must be regarded by religion as rebellion against God is a matter of course. But that the world-spirit, too, does not tolerate a deification of this nature is then also evident. For it is not the individual as individual, but the universal revealing itself in the totality, on whose development and progress everything depends. If the self that works for the Idea is to come to a true understanding with the world-spirit, then it must unconditionally live for the universal, comprehend the universal, not [247] in metaphysical abstraction, but in actual existence as power; it must deify power. Over against actual power the self as self is a nothing. Even if at a given time it comes to power and, through the union of power with honor, can unite the deification of power with self-deification, the fundamental contradiction is nevertheless only veiled, but not resolved: in the moment of crisis the contradiction breaks forth, and the self sinks together into nothing. When religion now comes forward against this with its urgent admonition: "Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world! If any man love the world, the love of the Father is not in him" (1 John 2:15), then we can understand that it is not a dark ascetic failure to recognize the validity of the world's Ideas and the humane tasks of actual life, but care for souls, concern for the self, that breathes in this admonition.

So long, then, as we remain standing at the world-spirit in its mythical ambiguity, it will not be difficult to follow the religious train of thought. But now revelation goes a step further. In order to unveil the symbolized serpent-principle and illuminate the darkness in which evil keeps its origin hidden, it leads the egoism of the will back to

the evil will, to the egoist himself in supernatural magnitude.

The evil will in its highest unity of consciousness is the evil self: the evil will is spirit, the mightily ruling spirit of the world-spirits — “the prince of this world”! Here the antirational is once more conspicuous; and here again is a summons to examine the relation between what can be ascribed to the immediacy of representation and what essentially follows from the principle.

Religion often speaks in images of the universal powers; the psalmist sees in the storm winds the angels of Jehovah (Ps. 104:4), and the water in the pool of Bethesda receives, according to the evangelical explanation (John 5:4), its healing power from an angel’s going down at certain seasons into the pool. If it is now unmistakable that [248] personifications of both good and evil powers occur in Holy Scripture, what certainty have we then that everything said about the spirit of darkness is not likewise to be understood figuratively, so that expressions such as “Satan,” “the devil,” “the god of this world” and the like are to be taken as personifications of the essence of wickedness, of evil in the world, but by no means to be taken literally of a personal evil spirit? What is said in the New Testament about the devil, that he falls from heaven like lightning and yet desires to sift the disciples as wheat, that he is already bound and yet goes about as a roaring lion, and so on, is actually so vague and figurative that Schleiermacher must seem to be right when he²⁶ rejects the doctrine of the devil as not belonging to the Christian doctrine of faith. And yet even the most acute explaining-away of the devil’s personality will not satisfy the Christian consciousness. “It is clear,” says Martensen, “that the statements of Scripture about the devil, about the *enemy*, also speak of *more* than a principle, of more than a universal evil *willing*, namely of an actual personal *will*, although indeed now the one, now the other side, now the generally spiritual, now the personal, may be the one that comes forward more strongly. Christ’s struggle with the devil is indeed a struggle against a universal principle, but it first receives its full significance when it is at the same time a personal *will* that he repels and overcomes.”²⁷ So it is. Scientific critique does not tolerate the devil; if he flees from knowledge, he is arrested by faith; if he makes a sally from faith, he is attacked again by knowledge: so the devil himself must keep guard on the border between faith and

²⁶“Der christliche Glaube”. I. Band. Berlin 1835. S. 209–22.

²⁷Den christelige Dogmatik. S. 202–5.

knowledge.

[249] The spirit of darkness is essentially a tempting power; temptation is the fundamental function on which its superiority rests; it attacks no one except through temptation, it conquers no one except by temptation: the devil is the tempter. But what is it to be tempted by the devil? Every man is tempted “when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed”; that is the general psychological explanation of temptation; it fits every human being as an individual in the race, every human being burdened with sin and guilt; but from participation in sin and guilt there are two ideal exceptions: pure innocence, which is not yet spirit, and the sinless will, which is personally spirit. To neither of these can the general psychology of temptation be applied. The innocent one is indeed tempted by its desire, but not in the form of desire, that is to say: not with consciousness that what tempts is precisely the self’s own impure desire; for in the same instant as consciousness of this enters, the self, as we have seen, is impure and innocence is lost. — The sinless will cannot possibly be tempted by its own desire, for it is tempted with full consciousness as spirit; were it now conscious under temptation that it was being tempted by its own desire, then it would indeed be conscious of its sinfulness and could not be sinless. And yet the sinless will can and must be tempted, as surely as it is subject to human conditions. Sinlessness is determined in actuality by the sinless one’s freeing himself from sin by excluding sin, keeping sin away: sin will thus press in from without, i.e. from another will, and must be kept out by an express act of will. Eve is tempted by the serpent, but Christ is tempted by the devil; on these two extremes attention must fix itself if we are to understand the word of revelation about “the tempter.”

[250] In order to be tempted by spirit, man must himself be spirit; only in the same measure as the individuality that is tempted is conscious of its will of the spirit will it be able to refer the tempting promptings of lusts, images, representations and thoughts to the evil will; the less firmly the self is established in the will of the spirit, the more it is either affected by the immediately sensuous or, in the form of general selfhood, streamed through by universal Ideas, the less will it be able to apprehend the tempting principle as will. As regards sensuous allurements, the individual must with a little self-reflection easily notice that what tempts lies in desire; as regards

beguiling promptings of Ideas and false ideals, the gifted man with his strongly working reflection will discover that what tempts really comes from dark possibilities, from an obscure egoism of Ideas; he will cognize that he is tempted by spirit; but it is still only the world-spirit in all its veiledness: the evil will, the tempting self, does not appear. It is otherwise with Christ's temptation; in this connection we shall reflect only on the tempter.

It is, from the standpoint of faith, highly characteristic that Christ's temptation in the wilderness does not precede but falls at a point of time that follows immediately upon his baptism in the river Jordan. His messianic coming forward is thus a fully matured resolve; he has the consecration; he is in the Spirit, absolutely concentrated in will of the spirit. What in the world should now be able to shake this holy, pure, resolved will? Nothing! What illusion, formed of billowing air, of the juggling vapors of the wilderness, should be able to confuse the thoughts of this resolved one and becloud this gaze that sees through every deception? Nothing! And yet in the wilderness, out of this nothing, in this waste, out of this emptiness, a tempter comes forth with a temptation. It must then be a temptation of a peculiar kind, a temptation to which rational psychology knows nothing corresponding. To be tempted is, at this summit, not to be ensnared, beguiled and made to waver; but it is: in redoubled selfhood, as [251] spirit, to be attacked by spirit, so that thought stands against thought, will against will, self against self. This redoubling in selfhood is the deepest crisis of freedom. The tempting self is not Christ's self; far from it! it is as opposed to the Holy One as possible. And yet Christ takes up both the tempter and the temptation into his consciousness; for if he did not do so, he could not be tempted. The tempter can only "come to him" because he, in his infinite superiority, lets him come; and he lets him come for the sake of freedom, of revelation and of salvation: only upon the tempter's fall can the Messiah found his kingdom.

That Christ lets himself be tempted means that he compels the tempter to reveal himself: it is the decisive defeat of the evil will that its self-contradiction comes to light, that it becomes completely revealed. From the standpoint of knowledge not only the tempter but also the tempting word are to be brought under the category: myth; but in consequence of the principle of faith the story of the temptation is

precisely antimythical. The antimythical is known by the clear opposition of the tempter to the tempted, of self to self; through this opposition the revealing word receives its significance in the course of the temptation. The tempter makes his attack in such a way that each utterance strikes precisely at the contradiction, the conceptual contradiction which, from the viewpoint of a negative critique, lies in this: to be God-man. "If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread." To hunger as a man and yet be as God, who by a word can turn stones into bread, what a mythical contradiction! But just as the contradiction is to have its tempting effect and bring the tempted one into self-contradiction, the antimythical is heard: "Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God." But a contradiction it is nonetheless, a mythical self-contradiction, to know oneself as [252] the one who could command legions of angels, and notwithstanding to know oneself as the one who, over against the world's misrecognition, contempt and mockery, is to be the powerless one who cannot make himself a phenomenon, because he cannot for his own glorification avail himself of supernatural means. "If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down" — from the pinnacle of the temple — "for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee, and they shall bear thee up in their hands." ... If thou art really the one whom the Father will glorify, then let the glorification begin at once, that the world may see it and marvel. — Against a mythical glorification that bursts all the laws of actuality the Messiah now sets the antimythical resignation: thou shalt not selfishly challenge the supernatural power, "thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God."

But it is nonetheless a contradiction, an intolerable self-contradiction, that he should be the servant of all who knows within himself that he is equipped to be the lord of all and to lay the whole world under his foot. He who is as God in himself must surely also have the right to rule as a God and to deify himself. The self-contradiction should thus, if this is the tempting thought, find its resolution in immediate self-deification. This turn of the matter seems, however, at first glance to conflict with the text. According to the story of the temptation (Matt. 4:8, cf. Luke 4:6) it is not, after all, immediate self-deification to which the tempter urges the Messiah; what he literally urges him to is, on the contrary, an infinite and, as it seems, utterly outrageous

self-abasement. “All these things” — all the kingdoms of the world and their glory — “will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me.” A more foolish demand, then, in the opinion of critique, the devil could not make; *ergo* — this is the scientific verdict of critique — not only the clothing of the temptation, but the temptation itself too, is a myth.

The absolute heterogeneity of the principles, of faith and knowledge, must surely [253] here, if anywhere, be conspicuous. The story of the temptation, which in the eyes of knowledge has driven the mythical to its uttermost point, is, according to the principle of faith, precisely to be capable of being said to have cast light into the innermost recesses of selfhood, into those corners of the spirit from which the mythical proceeds. It is the relation between the personal will and the false, tempting world-ideal that is to be cleared up once and for all. The temptation is at its height when the opposition of the tempting ideal and the will is at its height. The temptation ends when all circumlocutions fall away. Had Christ had the tempting principle within himself, had he, like another Hercules, stood at the crossroads with ambiguous impulses within him, then the power tempting through the world-ideal could have wrapped itself in a mythical nimbus, and the mythical would have been recognizable by the tempter’s making circumlocutions. The mythical temptation could then not possibly begin with the tempter—however many thousand times he might have imagined that he really had what he, plainly understood, does not have, all the kingdoms of the world and their glories to give away—openly and without ceremony demanding that the Messiah, “the Son of God,” should fall down and worship him. No, he would have had to begin the other way round; he would rather have had to begin with the promise that if the Son of God, the Messiah, would only understand his task practically, then not only all the kingdoms of the world, but he himself too, the prince of this world, would fall down and worship the almighty Messiah. Could the tempted one let himself be beguiled by this, then the tempter would have conquered; then it would follow of itself that it would not be the prince of this world who fell down and worshiped the Messiah, but conversely the Messiah who would have to fall down and worship the prince of the world, victorious through the temptation.

Before the pure, self-transparent will such evasions are impossible. What the

[254] tempter has to say, he must say openly and plainly, for the ambiguous, the veiled, is instantly seen through. Precisely the circumstance that every rejoinder on the tempter's side is so plain and unreserved that guile itself is forced into candor brings it about that each single attempt, especially the last, comes to look so presumptuous and yet so poor, so simple and almost insane. But precisely thereby the secret in all temptation is laid bare: temptation comes in the last instance from the evil self; its innermost meaning is essentially meaningless; the decisive victory is conditioned by its obscure, self-contradictory essence being completely seen through; the decision is that the pure will, the true self, with resolute energy banishes the tempter: "Get thee hence, Satan! for it is written: thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve".

Once the mythical veil which the ambiguous world-spirit spreads over the tempting principle, and thereby over all temptations, has been torn apart, it will also become apparent that the selfish being which tempted Eve was a veiled appearance of the tempting power, the selfish self that wished to try its strength with Christ. The tempting spirit can now be seen in reflected light as "the old serpent", as "the liar", "the murderer from the beginning".

Immediately and directly, no sinful human being on earth has ever stood *vis à vis* the tempter himself, the prince of this world. To wish to know oneself immediately and personally tempted by the tempter himself is a blasphemous presumption, the presumption of wishing to set oneself equal with Christ and on one's own account to pass through the deepest crisis of freedom; for only in the deepest crisis of freedom can the evil self stand objectively clear before the holy Self, the evil will be objectively determined against the good. It is not the case that the power of the devil, together
 [255] with the devil himself, is already sufficiently revealed before Christ comes, so that Christ has only the task of overcoming the well-known devil; no, the truth is that Christ alone makes the essence of the devil revealed and, precisely by making it revealed, breaks the devil's power. According to the principle of revelation, faith in the devil can acquire essential significance only through faith in Christ; all propositions about the devil, in the New as in the Old Testament, are propositions of faith, which look pitiful when they are transformed into propositions of knowledge and treated

cosmologically.

And how, then, do matters stand with faith in the devil and his tempting power? “Every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed.” This is temptation as a psychological fact. But this fact, about which reason and revelation are agreed, would hide its ground in the night of doubts, the eternal darkness of ambiguity, if it did not receive light from the revealed word. The more relative and veiled the tempting thing is, the more bewitching is the temptation; the bewitchment vanishes only when the temptation, briefly and definitely, without any evasions, can in faith be traced back to the tempting principle, the selfish self, the evil will. Just as faith in Christ is unconditionally positive, so faith in the devil is unconditionally negative, a faith that aims exclusively at renunciation. “Dost thou renounce the devil and all his works and all his ways”? That is the question; this pithy, short, authoritative sacramental word is without evasion, without ambiguity.

The ideals of the world, like the Ideas of the world, are in and for themselves neither good nor evil, in the personal sense neither true nor false; they become so only through the relation in which they are set to the holy will. The kingdom of the world acquires its ideal significance only by furnishing, with the conditions of actuality, a natural and yet spiritual foundation for the Kingdom of God.

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c) The Ideal of the Kingdom of God.

§ 17.

How the original relation to God was obscured and cancelled has already been shown; we shall now see how it is renewed. The fallen race is to be raised up again; so a Kingdom of God is founded on divine and yet human terms. It is a covenant which God establishes with man, a relation of Self to self, of will to will, from which the fundamental character of revelation shines forth. The Kingdom of God thus founded is actual and yet supra-actual, present and yet constantly to come. The ideal enclosed in actuality rises forth step by step and demands its actualization; but at each following step the present becomes ever more unsatisfying, and the strife between ideal and actuality more keenly felt. The thought of life is great and blessed, but it is followed by

a curse and satisfies with blessing only insofar as it nourishes itself on a promise. The inversion, that progress is regress and regress in turn progress, gives the education of the chosen people so peculiar a stamp that the whole development of spirit noticeably distinguishes itself from rational development of culture. We survey the movement from the three points of view: *election*, *legislation* and *promise*.

α) Election: The Chosen People.

Religion is of antirational origin; the thought of governance cannot be grounded in knowledge: the grounding is inverted, as is seen from the election of Israel. In order to answer the question why God chose the Jewish people as his own people above all others, appeal has been made to the piety of its patriarchs and to its natural peculiarity, [257] its individuality stamped to a wondrous degree. In order to bring out still more the peculiar significance of natural determination, some have even wished to demonstrate a division in the human race from the beginning, according to which the pious natures, “the children of God”, were noticeably distinguished from the ungodly, as Abel from Cain. This view is without objective validity. There is indeed a difference between pious and impious individuals; but the difference is so individual that it cannot ground any separation of peoples. It is said that Seth was set in Abel’s place (Gen. 4:25); one would therefore expect to see the stock divide into the good race of Seth and the evil race of Cain; but against this stands, in the genealogies, the fact that the opposition is erased again. According to ch. 5 all Adam’s descendants without distinction are Sethites, unless, that is, one will suppose that Chanoch (Enoch), who “walked with God”, was a son of Cain, and Noah, who “found grace in the eyes of Jehovah”, a son of Lamech. Indeed, Lamech — if ch. 5:25 and ch. 4:18, through a mingling of the genealogies, refer to the same Lamech — Lamech himself, with all his worldliness, seems at last to have felt a need for divine comfort, a sign that his arrogance was more youthfully naive than reflected in defiance. Through Noah, then, Abraham himself is of Cain’s line: the Israelites are Cainites. Judging by such facts, if they really are facts, “religious natures” must therefore be found in roughly equal measure in all peoples.

But even if it is so, as we willingly concede, that the Jewish national character is in a peculiar sense disposed toward religious development, this fact can in any case not

be something accidental for governance. Whence, if we hold fast to the standpoint of religion, do the peoples have their various natural dispositions, if not from the Creator? Now if the reason why the Jewish people is created with a peculiar physiognomy is to be sought in its being created to be God's people, and the reason why it becomes God's people through election is to be sought in its being created with the dispositions needed for this, then the grounding goes in a circle; this circular grounding leads from knowledge to faith. We hear (Gen. 12:1) Jehovah say to Abraham: "Get thee out of thy country, and from thy kindred, and from thy father's house, unto the land that I will shew thee"; but nothing precedes that could inform us what it is that makes Abraham, precisely, worthy of such a calling rather than Nahor and Haran. We may ascribe to Abraham as many hidden advantages as we please, but nothing stands about them in the text. Abraham's election must then be ascribed just as unconditionally to God's free choice as it must be ascribed to God's free choice that Jacob was later preferred to Esau (Rom. 9:11–13). With election as the expression of God's unconditioned will, the character of what follows is already indicated. [258]

Here, at the founding of the Kingdom of God, there is from the very beginning the sharpest opposition of an almighty will and natural conditions, and yet both factors in turn interlock in so infinite a manner that the unity loses itself in the Mystery. Just as election itself has taken place in faith and on the terms of faith, so its historical actuality, too, can confirm itself only for a believing consciousness. The history of the Kingdom of God is in a double sense a history of faith, namely a history about believers and a history for believers. The series of natural intermediate causes is broken through by the miracle, and while probability at every moment runs against the ideal, the improbable happens, and faith triumphs.

Jehovah's promise to Abraham runs: "I will make of thee a great nation, ... and I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed". Thus expectation is at its highest; but time passes, the fulfillment keeps them waiting, and comes only when it can happen only against all probability. The son on whom the promise rests, Abraham's only one, on whose life it depends whether the patriarch shall really become a great nation, or only leave behind him illegitimate children and so after all die a childless old man — him Jehovah

[259] demands as a sacrifice; it is as though everything were to go backward again. Here there must be faith with hope against hope, in possibility against probability. And faith triumphs; the family grows into a great nation, but — is this the chosen people, the people over whom the blessing rests? Why, they are slaves, nothing but slaves! Far from the land of the fathers, the land Jehovah himself gave Abraham, Isaac and Jacob for inheritance and possession, the people of the promises toil in slavery under a foreign yoke: the apparent progress is a sorrowful regress.

Here, humanly seen, there is no prospect of salvation; but precisely this signifies that salvation is near, that it comes from the God of the fathers. From the burning bush in the desert of Midian Jehovah speaks to Moses, and Moses stands forth before Pharaoh, and Pharaoh is terrified by sign upon sign, and the deliverance is wondrous. “In the third month, when the children of Israel were gone forth out of the land of Egypt, the same day came they into the wilderness of Sinai ... And Moses went up unto God, and Jehovah called unto him out of the mountain, saying: Thus shalt thou say to the house of Jacob, and tell the children of Israel: Ye have seen what I did unto the Egyptians, and how I bare you on eagles’ wings, and brought you unto myself. Now therefore, if ye will obey my voice indeed, and keep my covenant, then ye shall be a peculiar treasure unto me above all people: for all the earth is mine. And ye shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and an holy nation” (Exod. 19:1–6). So the covenant is concluded, so the promise stands firm after all; so the slavery was only for the sake of deliverance, so the sorrowful regress was after all essentially progress.

But what progress? The trial is long and the way narrow: there is hunger in the desert, complaints and cries of woe are heard; in bitterness and defiance the people rebel against Moses and against Jehovah; indeed, so harsh is the opposition of ideal and actuality that the earth must open and swallow the rebels, and a whole generation [260] die away, and its bones be scattered in the desert, without any eye having yet seen the promised land.

In the history of peoples, contrasts of fortune and adversity, exaltation and abasement, fluctuations of progress and regress will everywhere be demonstrable, while the movements on the whole nevertheless lead toward the goal, the goal that is set for the particular people and designates its calling. In this respect it depends not merely on

what a people actually experiences or has experienced in outward things; it depends also, and chiefly, on how it has experienced these outward things and understood what it experienced. Only through understanding is what is outwardly actual transformed into inward actuality, into actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit. In this respect a people's legendary history is not merely just as essential as, but even more essential than, everything the critique of knowledge extracts as bare facts; for in legendary history the outward has become inward, and the inward in turn outward. Legendary history is the history of the spirit of the people, a history that wishes not merely to be remembered but to be essentially recollected. But from this it follows that the history of the spirit in every peculiar people must in principle correspond to the spirit of the people; and from this it follows in turn that the history of the chosen people, according to its whole actual character, in the outer as in the inner, must be just as different from any heathen national history whatever as the word of revelation in its principle is different from myth.

β) Legislation: The Theocracy.

The Mosaic legislation is the spiritual, universal foundation of the Kingdom of God. What is peculiar to this legislation is that it is immediately and without evasion traced back to God himself; already from this it is seen that it is intended for believers, not for knowers. The Kingdom of God is not an ordinary kingdom of Ideas but in the strictest sense a kingdom of will: the almighty Self, the holy will, will be absolute sole ruler in this kingdom. Not only the words of the Law but also the tables of the Law are originally from Jehovah himself; "the tables were the work of God, and the writing was the writing of God, graven upon the tables" (Exod. 32:16). The opposition between Judaism and heathendom is thereby designated as sharply as possible. In spiritual heathendom it is the Ideas, the intermediate forms rich in content and dazzling by their divine content, that place themselves between God and man and obscure the consciousness of God; in Judaism these intermediate forms are pushed back, even to the degree that it looks as though they had quite vanished. This removal, not to say exclusion, of the Ideas, which is so characteristic of revelation, is a condition for the divine Self being able, in reflected immediacy, to penetrate and move the human, a

condition for God being able inwardly to breathe upon man, to speak to man, and in the Spirit through the word to make himself understood by man.

But precisely through this peculiar self-communication of the divine will in the commandments of the Law a unity-in-difference of the divine and the human is posited which impresses the imagination and repels the understanding.

What, for the immediately believing view, could be more exalted or more awe-inspiring than a beginning such as this: "And God spake all these words, saying: I am Jehovah thy God, which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. Thou shalt have no other gods before my face. Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image, or any likeness of any thing that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth. Thou shalt not bow down [262] thyself to them, nor serve them: for I, Jehovah thy God, am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation; and shewing mercy unto thousands of generations of them that love me and keep my commandments" (Exod. 20:1–6). Thus the holy Self has a voice; where this voice resounds in consciences, it awakens earnest thoughts; where this voice of the spirit is heard, it shakes the ground of the mind, so that the gods of the world, the new with the old, must collapse.

But the same thing which in the divine speaking conditions the exalted brings with it at the same time such a finitization, parceling out and multiplication of commandments and prescriptions that reflective understanding, which is not attentive to the principle itself, must take offense. That prescriptions for the arrangement of the tabernacle, insofar as it is a matter quite generally of the fundamental thought, are traced back to Jehovah we can indeed understand from the standpoint of religion; but the more the prescriptions go into particulars and are yet immediately put forward as Jehovah's commandments, the more pettily exact everything is prescribed, the more the human shows through, the more we miss the intermediate determinations of the Idea, and the more offensive the whole becomes. Or what man of reflection can read the following command (Exod. 25:1 ff.): "And Jehovah spake unto Moses, saying: Speak unto the children of Israel, that they bring me an offering: of every man that giveth it willingly with his heart ye shall take my offering. And this is the

offering which ye shall take of them: gold, and silver, and brass, and blue, and purple, and scarlet, and fine linen, and goats' hair, and rams' skins dyed red, and sealskins, and acacia wood, oil for the light, spices for anointing oil" etc. — who, we ask, can read such things without being involuntarily seized by a secret dread that negative critique may after all be right, that the spirit of revelation is spiritless, and the whole holy work of legislation a work of religious politics?

Immediate historical faith in sacred history is superstition; this holds just as well [263] of the facts through which the highest and deepest shines forth as of the prescriptions that concern the least, the most petty of all. If faith in the revealed word is to be put into force, then superstition must go; if superstition is to go, then the principle must be looked to. That religion is antirational does not mean that religion is spiritless; but spiritless it becomes, more spiritless than the most spiritless of all mythologies, when there is immediate, literal faith in a God who in an outward, finite manner dictates outward, finite prescriptions. It is this dictating that forms the hard point, the knot, in the Old Testament revelation. But the knot is untied when we reflect on the principled relation between the outward and the inward, between the immediacy of religious representation and the thought of faith. For immediate beholding the matter stands thus: that Jehovah outwardly and sensuously shows himself to Moses and speaks to Moses as one man can speak to another. If this way of seeing is to be defended, then it must be defended by defying all thinking; if faith in this sense is to bid defiance to thought, then the defense is easy to conduct: "Religion is thoughtless; he who believes dare not think". It is a poor pretext that there is some thinking here and there and back and forth about religion, when the foundation itself is thoughtless and thoughtlessness is fixed fast in the principle.

To begin with thought is to begin with the spirit, that is: not to begin with abstract reflections that despise the outward, but with the thought of revelation itself, the thought of will, the holy fundamental thought; it is: through the outward to seek the inward and in the light of the inward to clear up the outward. The almighty Self is not for Moses something outward, but originally and essentially something inward; Jehovah is invisible and becomes visible only to the prophet's vision: Jehovah is the [264] God of the spirit, Jehovah is spirit. But spirit is will, and the all-determining will reveals

itself in thought and speech. The inner speaking cannot be explained by rational psychology; for here it holds that religion is antirational. But that the inner speaking in the prophet's spirit is determined by an infinite conversion of divine thoughts into human ones, of divine words into human language, can be cognized in faith; for this ideal doubling expresses precisely the essence of faith. Since, now, the holy thoughts are thoughts of will, and the revealed word is proclaimed in commandments and prescriptions, it follows from the principle of faith itself that Jehovah's prophet cannot engage in any finite distinguishing between Jehovah's thoughts and his own thoughts, between Jehovah's commandments and the commandments devised by himself; the moment he permitted himself such a distinction, the Spirit would leave him: he could not possibly, in the prophetic sense, come forward as Jehovah's servant. Mightily moved by the Spirit, the legislating prophet must proclaim every commandment in Jehovah's name, with authority from Jehovah.

When laws and institutions are immediately determined by God's will, the state must be conceived as God's state, and God himself be believed to be the people's king. The Idea of the state then does not come to any particular development; the civil laws become religious, and the religious civil. With this fusion of the holy and the secular, the ideal and the actual, which is the distinguishing mark of theocracy, it accords that the prescriptions for cultus and customs are put forward so definitely and so specially that they can be immediately complied with. In that the divine will gives itself expression in the many finite commandments and prohibitions, it acquires a concrete content and enters into many-sided reciprocal action with the human will. In order to be able to obey God's will, the Israelite must know what it is God wills in each given case; this he comes to know in the Law. What significance the individual [265] prescription has in itself, whether it is necessary or unnecessary, rational or irrational, significant or insignificant — about that the believing Israelite dare not reason: the decisive thing is that the prescription is Jehovah's commandment, that it is found in his Law. That there must now also be a special order which watches over the promulgation and observance of the Law, that the Levitical priesthood, in other words, corresponds to the theocracy, is understood of itself.

But although the Law consists in a sum of finite precepts, it is nonetheless in its

essence spirit, and must be understood spiritually. This determines the position of the prophets in relation to the priests. While the priests have to preserve what is already given in revelation, uphold what has been handed down, and see to it that the Law is fulfilled according to the letter, the prophets are organs of the continuing revelation; they therefore look not primarily at the outward but at the inward, and take the Law not according to the letter but according to the spirit.

The life of the spirit now has a double resistance to overcome: it meets resistance in the lower, sensuous nature, and it meets resistance in the egoism of the understanding. In the first respect the temptation to idolatry, in the latter respect righteousness by works, is what predominates. The sterner the spirit is, the more it provokes to recalcitrance: the colder the high Invisible One is, the warmer are a Moloch and the other foreign gods. The continuing strife between the people and Jehovah is a natural consequence of the dualism in man's essence, and an eloquent testimony that it is not the people that has chosen Jehovah for its God, but Jehovah that has chosen the people for his people. In righteousness by works we have a typical expression of what spiritless spirit means. It is a demand of the spirit, the first, elementary condition of spirit, that the law of the commandments shall be observed; only in the observance of the commandments does reverence have its actual expression. But the commandments nonetheless concern primarily what is outward; the outward fulfillment of outward precepts is in practice possible without essential change in what is inward. The State of God is then conceived as a civil state, God's laws as merely civil laws, the Ruler, Jehovah, as a civil king. This is the inherent one-sidedness of theocracy. That through the outward the inward is aimed at, that conditional obedience in what is outward is only a sign of the inward, unconditional obedience—the obedience that breaks egoism and bends man's will in each and every thing to God's will—this is overlooked. Now if it were merely crudeness and thoughtlessness that brought the people to forget the inward over the outward, then spiritlessness would be immediate, and could essentially be removed by instruction and cultivation. But with a revelation as its presupposition, spiritlessness cannot be immediate; it is the serpent-principle at work, that egoism places the fear of God in the outward in order to keep the inward for itself. As the fear of God becomes egoistic, egoism becomes God-fearing; from this

fusion there issues not only hypocrisy, but here is bred a fanaticism, a zeal glowing in selfish self-ignition for the commandments of the Law, for holiness, righteousness and blamelessness in what is outward. It is spiritlessness; but this spiritlessness is not naive: it is a crime against the spirit. Against the egoism reflected in a crime against the spirit, an egoism of godliness which can well unite even bloody misdeeds with its holiness of works, the merely instructive, quietly admonishing word is too weak; then the prophetic voice is raised. "To what purpose is the multitude of your sacrifices unto me?" saith Jehovah. "I am full of the burnt offerings of rams and of the fat of fed beasts, and in the blood of bullocks and of lambs and of he goats I delight not ... Your new moons and your appointed feasts my soul hateth; they are a burden unto me, I am weary to bear them. When ye spread forth your hands, I will hide mine eyes [267] from you. Yea, when ye make many prayers, I will not hear you; your hands are full of blood" (Isa. 1:11–15).

The prophetic judgments are penal judgments. The chastening of the people, its spiritual education, is conditioned precisely by the religious reciprocity between these judgments and their execution. If we disregard the judgments, then the humiliations and chastisements which, after the division of David's kingdom, befall first Israel and then Judah would not be qualitatively different from such misfortunes and miseries as also befall heathen peoples. If, conversely, we abstract from the actual chastisements and conceive the penal judgments merely as pious threats against the ungodly, outbursts of mood from a subjective holy wrath, then the prophets sink down into ordinary preachers of repentance, without higher divine authority; the word of revelation dissolves into a poetic imagery of religious enthusiasm. Only when the execution of the penal judgments is cognized in the corresponding chastisements, so that these receive their spiritual significance precisely by being in truth the execution, can the punishing word be cognized as a prophetic word. Thus it was cognized in faith by the people of Israel. By humbling itself under the mighty hand of Jehovah, the believing Israel felt itself not only bowed down under the fatherly rebuke, but also raised up by the promise attached to its conversion.

γ) The Promise: The Messianic Ideal.

On the basis of opposition, the supramundane joins itself in theocracy so immediately and directly with the mundane that the strife between ideal and actuality must strike the eye plainly. For the keeping of the Law the very richest blessings are promised, but against transgression of the Law the most terrible curses are directed as well. "If ye walk in my statutes, and keep my commandments, and do them," saith [268] Jehovah (Lev. 26:3 ff.), "then I will give you rain in due season, and the land shall yield her increase ... and ye shall eat your bread to the full, and dwell in your land safely ... And ye shall chase your enemies, and they shall fall before you by the sword ... And five of you shall chase an hundred, and an hundred of you shall put ten thousand to flight, and your enemies shall fall before you by the sword" ... So worldly is the in itself supramundane Kingdom of God that the rewards held out by Jehovah must appeal in the very highest degree to the egoism of the people. Equally sensuously deterrent, again, are the threats added. "But if ye will not hearken unto me, and will not do all these commandments; and if ye shall despise my statutes, and if your soul abhor my judgments ... and break my covenant, I also will do this unto you: I will visit you with terror, with consumption and with burning fever, that shall consume the eyes and cause sorrow of heart, and ye shall sow your seed in vain, and your enemies shall eat it" ...; in this spirit curse follows upon curse, each more terrible than the last. What holds of the blessing holds of the curse: it appeals to what is selfish in man. Herein there is certainly a contradiction, indeed a fundamental contradiction; but the contradiction does not strike revelation, it strikes only human nature, whose egoism becomes manifest precisely through the relation to the Holy.

The Kingdom of God will and shall be a kingdom of actuality; so corresponding conditions are set: the blessings aim immediately at what is actual, just as the threats do. The actual, in sensuous presence, is something earthly and tangible. It is from the earthly-tangible that one must begin, when one is to begin with a crude, recalcitrant, but vigorous people and yet begin in the spirit. The spirit cannot from the beginning make comprehensible to the sensuous man what in the eternal sense must be under- [269] stood by actuality, actual blessing and actual curse; so it begins with the temporal, for the temporal too is actual. This double-sided essence of actuality provokes and deceives egoism, and sets the powers of the spirit in motion. "If ye walk in my statutes,

and keep my commandments”—that is the ideal demand, which what is egoistic in man involuntarily resists; yet what follows? “Then I will give you,” etc.; here in the added promises there is something for egoism, and yet the promises cannot possibly be understood egoistically without being misunderstood. When, then, reflection is set in motion, and man asks himself: does it then always go well with the pious? How does Jehovah fulfill his promises?—then conscience is awakened and raises the religious question: how are Jehovah’s commandments fulfilled? “There is none that doeth good, no, not one.” It is the problem of retribution that presses forward and, in its continued, anguished working-through, brings it about that the cognition of sin grows deeper and deeper, and that the actuality of reward and punishment acquires for believers an ever more spiritual significance.

How the spiritual, ideal conception of the Kingdom of God works its way forth out of the first actual presuppositions is clearly seen from the transformation that the fundamental theocratic thought underwent in the course of time, a transformation which, far from being a product of human arbitrariness, was in the strictest sense of the word a work of the Spirit.

Originally Jehovah is the King of the people, and the community, with its civil institutions, is immediately Jehovah’s State. But as regards the organization and governance of the State, the chasm between the human and the superhuman, the earthly and the heavenly, was bound gradually to show itself so great and deep that [270] the need for an actual mediating link could be cognized. The development of this need, called forth by the strife of the ideal with actuality, went hand in hand with the development of the fundamental religious consciousness and corresponded to the prophetic view. So the people chose for itself an earthly king; but the earthly king was anointed by the prophet with Jehovah’s spirit, and now comes forth in his ideal light as the actual mediating link between the Lord in heaven and his kingdom on earth, as Jehovah’s son, the Anointed, the Messiah.

On the king, the head of the people, the promise now rests; the greatness, might and glory of the kingdom are conditioned by the king’s corresponding to his ideal. But just here the strife between ideal and actuality is made visible. Only one among the kings was so anointed with spirit that all the signs of the promise could be recognized

in him: that was David. For the glory of Solomon, a worldly reflection of David's spiritual greatness, was a brilliant phenomenon that came and vanished.

The Son of David who was to establish the Messianic kingdom, at once holy and yet worldly, had then also to be the son of the Lord of Hosts, a mighty war-prince, to whom Jehovah would give the heathen for an inheritance, that he might "break them with a rod of iron and dash them in pieces like a potter's vessel" (Ps. 2), and yet a Prince of Peace, who "hath delight in the fear of Jehovah," who "judgeth the poor with righteousness" and "reproveth with equity for the afflicted of the land" (Isa. 11:4 ff.). As the heavenly is in this way drawn down into the earthly, this earthly is by the same token raised continually more and more up toward the heavenly; actuality thus gradually takes on an ever stronger stamp of the supra-actual, of symbolized actuality of the spirit. When the Messiah "smiteth the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips slayeth the wicked," then "the wolf shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the kid," and the child "shall play at the lizard's den."—"They shall not do evil nor work ungodliness in my holy mountain, for the earth is full of the knowledge of Jehovah, as the waters cover the sea." [271]

Essential progress is conditioned by regress. The more things went backward with actuality, the outwardly actual kingdom, the more they went forward with the ideal conception of the Messiah and his kingdom. What is not to be seen on earth, the prophet then sees in the clouds of heaven. "I saw in the night visions, and, behold, with the clouds of heaven came one like a Son of man, and he came to the Ancient of days, and was brought near before him. And there was given him dominion, and glory, and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should worship him. His dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away; his kingdom shall not be destroyed" (Dan. 7:13-14). The Messiah is thus the Son of David and yet the Son of God, an actual man and yet a supernatural being. By the Messianic ideal a view of the union of the divine and the human nature is prepared. Jehovah's countenance is softened, for the Father loves his Son. But it is only a preparation. Ideal and actuality, the heavenly and the earthly, do not approach one another directly: the extremes are strained to the utmost. Only when the representation of a Son of God who is also to be a Son of man has taken up so many ideal presuppositions that the

seal of the mysteries can be broken does the turning point arrive, the turning point of eternity, which is the fullness of time.

[272]

Faith in the Son.

A.

The Essence of the Son.

§ 18.

That Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Mary, is the Savior of the world and the Son of God means, in other words, that Jesus of Nazareth is the sign of contradiction. "This child," says Simeon of the Child in the Temple (Luke 2:34), "is set for the fall and rising again of many, and for a sign which shall be spoken against." The sign of contradiction has, as shall be treated more closely later, the peculiarity that each must understand it in proportion as he understands himself; it is the problem of self-understanding that this sign would awaken. If Jesus of Nazareth is the Savior of the world, then his figure must be seen in faith, transfigured by the Spirit; if, on the other hand, the figure of Christ is regarded from the standpoint of knowledge, then the negative critique has already sufficiently shown what historically comes out of the evangelists' accounts. There can be no greater proof of the absolute heterogeneity of the principles than the change that takes place in the Savior's image according as the light falls in through the temple door either of science or of religion. The improbable must be believed, but the impossible cannot be believed. It ought therefore first to be investigated how far the science of reason is able to prove the impossibility that Jesus of Nazareth, [273] this individual man, can have been conscious of himself as the Savior of the world, and how the divine-human self-consciousness, if its possibility is maintained, is to be conceived in faith; we bring this investigation under the consideration of: *The Self in the Son*. It ought next to be investigated how the ideal marks of essence by which alone the Savior of the world can be recognized, conceived as marks of faith, withdraw themselves from the dissolving critique of "the modern consciousness"; we treat of this under: *Fundamental Determinations in the Son's Self*. It ought finally to be investigated how far and in what way it is possible to cognize the relation between God and Christ, between the One who reveals himself and the Revealer, as an original

relation of essence, an eternal fundamental relation between the Father and the Son; we gather together what belongs here under the point of view of: *The Personality of the Son*.

The problem of personality is at once the fundamental problem of humanity and of religiousness; it must then at length become evident where this problem is to find its final, proper solution, in knowledge or in faith, in reason or in revelation.

a) The Self in the Son.

§ 19.

What lies originally in the concept of a Savior of the world, that he must be “both true man and true God, and both in union,” the old teachers of the Church, Athanasius for example, have already brought out with clear consciousness and full emphasis. “For unless his nature had been of like kind with ours, he could not have redeemed it; without true Godhead he could not have made us divine; and without a living bond [274] between both sides he could not have established any connection between God and men.” Here the following three questions now press themselves upon us: α) in what sense has the evangelical Christ been conscious of himself as a human self? β) in what sense has he been conscious of himself as a divine Self? and γ) within what limitation can the unity of the divine and human self be cognized as divine-human unity of self?

α) The Human Self.

That Jesus Christ, who in the Gospels by preference calls himself “the Son of Man,” was an actual man, is something that scarcely anyone in the present day calls into doubt. For that Christ should have been an Aeon emanated from the heavenly Pleroma, who had not become man in flesh and blood but had only taken on an apparent body, with which he had also been crucified without suffering—such gnostic fairy tales no longer find credence. Clement of Alexandria does indeed find it a ridiculous opinion “that the body of Christ, which was sustained by the holy power of the Logos, should

have needed food for its nourishment, since on the contrary it was only in order to forestall docetic opinions about his person that Jesus had taken food, although he himself was equally insensible to impressions of pain and pleasure, toward which one is passive”; but not to speak of the fact that such a forestalling of docetic opinions is self-contradictory, since it confirms precisely what it was meant to forestall, this whole way of looking at things is equally at odds both with the evangelical presentation and with the concept of a Savior of the world. If now the emphasis is to fall on being an actual man—on being born, growing, being affected by sensuously pleasant and unpleasant impressions, etc.—then weight must first and foremost be laid on answering the question how the development of the human individual properly stands in relation [275] to the human self.

The human self begins in unconsciousness. That an actual child should be able to be born into the world with fully developed self-consciousness is a contradiction from which faith recoils just as much as knowledge. The Gospel of the Infancy of Jesus, in which it is related that Jesus spoke in the cradle and said to Mary his mother, “I am Jesus, the Son of God,” is certainly apocryphal, not only by the judgment of knowledge but also by that of faith. With all the supernatural signs with which the Christ-child is found surrounded, the canonical Gospel narratives nonetheless hold fast to the fundamental thought that the child in actuality began as a child, that it grew, in soul as well as in body, a quiet growth—that, in other words, an actual natural self-development took place. If, therefore, in the present connection there were talk only of the actual man, then, as regards Christ’s human self, there could not possibly be any dispute. But here, surely, the talk is not of the merely actual man, but expressly of the *true* man. The *actual* man is to be the *true* man, and this *true* man an *actual* man: here we have the strife again between faith and knowledge.

In his “Presentation of the Christian Doctrine of Faith”²⁸ Strauss, from the standpoint of knowledge, with clear survey and penetrating acuteness, has defended his Christology against the attempts to uphold the ecclesiastical representations. We set down this defense, for the sake of what follows, as a rounded whole. “It was surely not at all unthinkable—it was said—that the Creator had originally given human nature

²⁸II Bd. S. 191–194.

such a disposition that the universal human determination, i.e. the religious-moral one, could at a particular point be attained in perfection. As such a mere thinkability says nothing, there is also nothing to say against it; but the conclusion which is now drawn, namely that if one denies that thinkability one must assert that it belongs to man's essence to be imperfect, and that human nature would be sublated by religious perfection—this conclusion need only be better expressed: namely thus, that it is essential for the individual man, or for the phenomenon of man *an sich*, to be imperfect, in order to say exactly the same as we assert. But the manifestation of a man perfect in religious respect, it is now said, was necessary if the religious life of the community was to reach its completion. The whole religious process of development of mankind strives toward an all-commanding founder of the true universal Church, whose religious life cannot be further heightened and made complete. One easily sees that what was first to be proved is here presupposed. That all other forms of religion are destined to pass over into the Christian Church can, so long as this transition has not actually taken place, be inferred only from the dignity of the founder of Christianity; but one cannot conversely infer the latter from something that as yet stands only as an empty pretension. But there dwells in man, it is further remarked, a deep longing for the completion of life: now if he is unable to actualize the Idea of mankind in himself, it nonetheless affords him essential satisfaction when he finds it actualized outside himself, in another individual of his race—or imagines it actualized; and we do not see how the argument, lame by nature, could defend itself against receiving this twist. Yet one comes with still another objection, and in it the polemic of the Schleiermacherian tendency against the speculative Christology meets with that of the Hegelian school: if there has never actually existed a man perfect in religious respect, then the concept of mankind never becomes perfectly actual; so long as the Idea has not been fully realized in one individual, it is a mere ought and an empty ideal. At the root of this lies the most unclear confusion of two quite different representations of the actualization of a generic concept. By it one can understand either that the genus and each individual, or that the genus and the totality of individuals, exhaust and cover one another. The former one does not find in mankind (as indeed not in any genus at all, since this concept contains the opposite): very well, then one must

content oneself with the latter. That one has no wish to do, and so one will take a middle way: in the one individual, Christ, the genus is to have actualized itself in the first manner, but in the rest of mankind not. The human race thus becomes impotent as regards the overwhelming majority of its individuals, and in addition there comes a rent in the circuit of its actualization such as one finds in no other genus: namely the difference between one individual in whom the genus satisfies itself, and such in whom it does not find its satisfaction. If these latter are not to appear rejected and cast off, then the excellence of that one individual must in one way or another redound to their benefit: which is not only the doctrine of the Church but also Schleiermacher's, since according to him God sees mankind only in Christ. But when God thus, in order to find the Idea of mankind perfectly actualized in mankind, must as it were reckon together Christ's merit and the defects of the rest of men, then after all it becomes the second manner in which a generic concept can be actualized, namely such that it becomes completely actual only in the totality of its individuals, which mutually supplement one another; only in the thought- less combination with the first kind [278] of actualization, which is to take place in one individual, while the other takes place through all the rest in their relation to that one. This combination is contrary to reason for the reason that the genus, if it could actualize itself completely in one individual, would not torment itself with dispersing itself into a multiplicity of such individuals and into their development in time; but it would exist only in that individual and as that individual, as genus-individual; just as God, if he could immediately be an individual personality, would have been able to spare the whole enormous apparatus for the production of personalities (the creation of the world and world history)."

Though from a scientific standpoint there may be a good deal to object to in the *nervus probandi* of the arguments with which Strauss here combats his opponents, it is nevertheless evident that on the ground of knowledge there is no foothold for one who would forcefully repel the well-aimed attack of the negative critique. Consider the intelligent resoluteness with which the spokesman of "modern science" concedes "that it is essential to the individual human being, or to the phenomenon of man *an sich*, to be imperfect"; note the objective unconcern with which "the argument lame by nature" that is drawn from "man's deep longing for the completion of life" is pushed

aside: and one will understand that religion must absolutely be given up when its antirational principle is to be rationalized.

[279] Strauss appeals to the fact that the race and the single individual do not “cover each other”, since it lies necessarily in the concept of the race that it can be exhausted only in the totality of its individuals. From this point of view the human race as race is identified without further ado with any animal genus whatever, and even so the consideration is lame. If the human race as race is to be placed in line with the animal genera, then it comes to stand not on an equal footing with them, but lower than them all. For of genera and species in the animal kingdom it really holds that the genus is covered by the species, and the species, each in turn, by the corresponding specimens. It is the normal health of the specimens, and by no means their number, on which this covering essentially depends. A single specimen of a sound and tolerably faultless horse is without further ado congruent with the species, whereas a plurality of faulty specimens, of which one, e.g., has spavin, another glanders, a third the staggers, and so on, by no means contribute by their number either to exhausting or to covering the species. In the animal world there is no essential discord between species and specimen, and therefore there is no incommensurability either between the genus and its individuals: the genus is exhausted in the totality of the individuals precisely in the corresponding way as, through the species, it is exhausted in each single specimen. The one-sidedness that naturally clings to the specimens in their singularity is, when we look at the matter in principle, not at all remedied by multiplication. If the one-sidedness is placed in the difference of sex, two specimens would be enough to represent the whole species. This comes simply from the fact that in the animal individual there is no conflict between ideal and actuality.

But conflict between ideal and actuality is precisely characteristic of every single human being, and just thereby, in the highest sense, characteristic of the relation between the human race and its individuals. That no human being is perfect, that according to the natural order of things there is not a single true and perfectly sound human being on earth — on this reason and religion will easily agree; but when it is to be determined more precisely wherein the imperfection consists and whence the untruth stems, they at once disagree. How deep the disagreement goes is seen already

from this, that while religion holds to the actuality of *the one true man*, reason holds [280] to its impossibility. The whole dispute turns essentially on the self. Religion, which asserts the self-validity of every single human being by unconditionally asserting the validity of the self, places the imperfection in the self and the untruth of the self in sin. Conceived as sin, the untruth is not merely a general contradiction in the essence of the self, but a contradiction of the will, in every human individual the innermost, deepest self-contradiction. Now if it lies in the nature of every contradiction that it must demand a resolution, then this must hold in the very strictest sense of self-contradiction. That in the race One has appeared who has presented himself as the true man, as the one who is himself from the ground up free of self-contradiction, and thereby able to loose the individuals from the chains of contradiction, and able, on the terms of faith, to save everyone from the gnawing untruth and to make it possible for him to *become* a true man: this presupposition is so far from containing any contradiction that everyone who contradicts it precisely makes himself doubly guilty of self-contradiction. If the individuals and the race are to “cover” each other, this can happen only through the sinless man.

It is, however, highly interesting from the standpoint of knowledge to observe the cunning with which the negative critique maneuvers when it is a matter of getting every testimony to Christ’s sinlessness explained away. “Christ’s sinlessness, and that not merely as the realized possibility of not sinning (*potuit non peccare*), but as the impossibility of being able to sin (*non potuit peccare*), had,” remarks Strauss, “in the old ecclesiastical system its firm dogmatic ground in this, that in Christ the human nature, which was apt for sin, had no personality of its own at all, but was only taken up into the personality of God’s holy Son. For Schleiermacher this grounding falls away together with the ecclesiastical Christology. Just as little will he rely on the [281] exegetical proof, and in this he does right. For what probative force would it have, if Paul, of whom it is not known that he knew Jesus personally, after his conversion ascribed sinlessness to him in ever so definite terms? But instead, he moreover says only in a rhetorical antithesis (2 Cor. 5:21) that God has made him who knew no sin to be sin, or a sin offering, for us, that we might become righteous in him; wherein, as a definite thought, there lies only this, that Jesus’ violent death may not be regarded

as punishment for a transgression of his own. No more lies in 1 Pet. 1:19, where he is called a lamb pure and without spot, and Heb. 7:26, where he is called a holy, innocent high priest; only that here the notions of Levitical purity have also mixed themselves in ... Yet even if these statements had a less typical and dogmatic form, even if they had the most definite historical form, and were moreover taken from genuine writings of Jesus' immediate disciples, they still could not, even if they would, say more than that well-known testimony of Xenophon concerning Socrates (*Οὐδεις πωποτε Σωκρατους ουδεν ασεβες ουδε ανοσιον ουτε πραττοντος ειδεν ουτε λεγοντος ηκουσεν*), from which, however, no one has yet wished to conclude that that heathen was sinless. For as sinful men Jesus' disciples could never be certain whether something in him which, precisely on account of their sinfulness, did not appear to them as sin, was not nevertheless sin in actuality. Only the sinless one can give a valid testimony to sinlessness, and consequently Jesus, since he is supposed to have been the only one of this kind among men, could alone know that he was so. This consciousness he is now also supposed to have expressed in the well-known question (John 8:46); but even leaving aside that *αμαρτια* here, according to the context, must rather mean error, and that, even if it were said in the sense of sin, it could only have been said of such sins as could be [282] observed, Jesus' own assertion cannot prove his sinlessness, since we should indeed already have to be certain of this beforehand in order to be sure that by that assertion he did not deceive himself or others"²⁹.

Critique has here brought out a decisive point, a truth that cannot be impressed enough, namely: that of Christ's sinlessness there is no objective knowledge. Sinlessness is a concept of faith. The objection that nothing is known about that which, by the nature of the case, cannot be an object of knowledge thus falls away. The sinless one can know with himself that he is without sin; but his own testimony to this must be received in faith: faith is in this connection not a surrogate for a lacking knowledge; the certainty of faith is, in relation to its object, self-certainty, and self-certainty is more infallible than any straightforward historical fact whatever. That Jesus Christ knew himself to be the true man, free of all sin, is not to be proved from single passages of Scripture; it is to be seen and cognized from his whole appearance, from the authority

²⁹Strauss. Anf. Skr. II. S. 155–56.

with which he speaks, from the decisive weight he lays upon himself and his relation to the Father, from the infinite superiority with which he, “meek and lowly in heart”, invites all “that labor and are heavy laden” to come to him, that souls may find rest. In truth, if he who calls himself the Savior of the world did not know with himself that no one either in heaven or on earth could convict him of any sin, then he has been caught in a terrible self-deception. For the nearer a man comes to the ideal without realizing it, the more clearly he sees the distance; this holds of every ideal, but especially of the holy one.

It is a religious-psychological fact that the consciousness of sin grows with the [283] consciousness of God, until sin is removed; therefore the great religious characters, not only the Reformers but also the apostles, not only a Luther but also a Paul, have so vivid a cognition of sin that people at a lower stage of consciousness cannot rightly understand them. This cognition of sin is not among the things about which truly religious characters are glad to keep silent, over which they prefer to spread a veil; on the contrary! it belongs precisely to what they speak of with emphasis, so that they speak loudly without becoming loud-voiced: for as repulsive as it is to hear a preacher of repentance, exalted by holy imaginings, speak conceitedly of himself as the greatest sinner and, as further proof, shamelessly peddle his secret frailties and private wretchednesses in order to titillate the pious curiosity of his hearers, just as essential and categorically necessary is it that the cognition of sin sound along in religious discourse, and that so penetratingly that everyone must feel that this speaker speaks from within.

Now when this stands firm, what then are we to judge of him who calls himself the Savior of the world? One of two things: either this man is in truth without any sin, or else he is the greatest sinner! That this is said without any exaggeration, everyone will see. Even if Christ had in actuality been the most religious of all religious men, if he had nevertheless not been sinless, then his word and work are a monstrous crime of spirit against God and men; for he has indeed spoken only of the sin of others, but not of his own. Even if it could be proved exegetically, which it cannot, that none of the utterances attributed to him speak of sinlessness in the strictest sense of the word, that is still not enough. Had he really not been sinless, we should have to expect

[284] that in his whole appearance, in all his discourses, on every occasion, there would be found a confession that he himself was originally a sinner, precisely the one who in his human self had the deepest cognition of sin, since he had the truest cognition of God and by it came nearest to the ideal. Now when this confession is nowhere to be found, when neither followers nor enemies have been able to discover the least hint of such a self-confession, but on the contrary have heard from his own mouth, both to edification and to offense, that he was the truth itself, the King of truth, the way and the life and the truth: then he has, with or without consciousness, concealed a truth and violated the truth. Here there can be no talk of innocent self-deception. If Christ on this one point deceived himself and others, then he is not a King of truth but of lies, the incarnate serpent-principle, the greatest deceiver who has lived on earth. Though knowledge might not find such a deception improbable, faith nevertheless finds it impossible.

When Christ's sinlessness is referred to its possibility (*potuit non peccare*), it is chiefly the human side of freedom that is brought out. Herein lies an invitation to compare Christ with Adam, the original human essence in the individuals of the race. Of Adam too it holds that, by virtue of the ideal of innocence, he could have avoided sinning (*potuit non peccare*). Every attempt to ground the necessity of Adam's sin, of the continually repeated fall in the individuals destined for freedom, is, according to what we have seen, only an attempt to explain sin away. Since sinlessness in the human self begins as possibility, temptation must enter in order that the possibility may differentiate itself and pass over into actuality. Adam was tempted and fell because he *willed* to fall. He willed to fall because he did not originally will to resist the temptation; for he could indeed have resisted it: *potuit non peccare*. That the old Adam now afterwards explains it otherwise, namely that he could not resist the temptation, that he really would not have fallen if he could have resisted, is an equivocal evasion, an unclear mixture of excuse and self-accusation, which is invalid, and invalid above all for the reason that it comes afterwards. Christ was tempted and stood firm in the temptation; he conquered because he willed to conquer: he did not sin because he did not will to: to that extent the same conditions hold for Christ as for Adam.

If, however, Christ's sinlessness were merely to express the realization of that

whose possibility human nature, regarded from the standpoint of the ideal, bears within itself, then Christ, the true man, could well be said to be the moral exemplar of the race, the awakener of the powers of will slumbering in the individuals, but by no means the Savior of the world. For Christ to be the world's Savior, the Redeemer of the race, his sinlessness must have another ground than Adam's innocence: freedom in him must essentially be conceived from the divine side (*non potuit peccare*). The qualitative difference between Adam's and Christ's state of innocence, between Adam's and Christ's temptation, in a word: between Adam's and Christ's self, consists originally in this, that whereas the germ of selfhood in Adam is naturally selfish, the germ of selfhood in the Christ-child is, on the contrary, supernatural, a Logos-germ, which through the Spirit has entered into interaction with the natural matter and has organized the body. How a principle of life can in general form and fashion a bodily organism shall not be investigated here; here it shall only be pointed out, on behalf of faith, that the organizing activity of the Logos-principle is, from the standpoint of natural science, just as comprehensible and just as incomprehensible as the activity of any other principle of life in nature. That the Logos-principle works as an organizing principle of life means that the Self in the Son is from the germ onward not merely natural but also holy, not merely human but also divine. [286]

β) The Divine Self.

The essential difference between Christ, the true man, and every other human being is decisively marked by this, that the true man has himself presented himself as a true God, as God's own Son, the Son who has come down from heaven, as divine Self. This difference of essence shines forth, among other things, from the fact that he remembers a pre-existence: "before Abraham was, I am" (John 8:58). Such a recollection of pre-existence must, as far as human individuals are concerned, necessarily either lose itself in abstract speculations or dissolve into mythical fantasies. With mythical fantasies nothing is accomplished. What is appealing in Plato's beautiful philosophical myth of the pre-existence of souls lies by no means in the depiction of the souls' existence with the gods preceding birth, but in the ingenious, conscious and yet naive visualization of the a priori in every psychical-rational self. How great a

blunder is committed when someone seeks to explain Christ's pre-existence to himself by holding to the representation and taking the Platonic myth as basis, we learn from Origen. In Origen's doctrine of pre-existence attention is particularly fixed on the self-being of the pre-existent souls in objective immediate singularity. The Logos, in contrast to God himself, is held fast in so self-enclosed an individual existence that he is even represented as a god by himself, a subordinate god (*δεύτερος θεός*). For in Origen the Son is "not the highest God, but less than the Father, the second God, and stands in a certain way midway between the nature of the Original and of [287] the Non-Original. He does not cognize the Father so perfectly as the latter cognizes himself; the world is not created by him, but through him by a higher principle than he, by the Father, and just as little may one pray to the Son, who indeed himself prays, but through him to the Father". — "Origen first," says Strauss, "was led by the necessity, partly of finding a subject for Christ's bodily and mental sufferings, in general for the finite form of his inner life as well, outside the unchangeable and unbounded Logos, partly of finding a connecting middle term between this and the material body, to distinguish definitely a human soul in Christ from his higher nature; a distinction which, in connection with his theory of pre-existence, also served him to answer the question how and why just this soul had come into such a union with the divine Logos. From the beginning, i.e. already in pre-existence, it was supposed to have clung to the Logos in a quite different way (from free impulse, as goes without saying in Origen's system), and through this devotion it was supposed to have been absorbed into him ever more and more, and to have become one spirit with him — to be sure only in the way that, according to 1 Cor. 6:17, everyone who cleaves to the Lord is one spirit with him; and thus Christ and the Logos were determined as two persons who are one only as far as the moral is concerned"³⁰.

It is the way of objective knowledge in the doctrine of faith that we have here trodden with Origen. That this way is impassable when a solution of the problem of pre-existence is the goal, surely no one will deny; the result to which investigations in this direction, despite all orthodox speculations and explanations, must consistently lead is by no means even approximately an understanding of the relation between God

³⁰Saml. I Bd. S. 380 flgd. med II Bd. S. 84–85.

the Logos and the man Jesus, but on the contrary so bottomless a misunderstanding [288] that the critique of knowledge need only follow the debates of the history of dogma in order step by step to point out the contradictions and triumph over the dissolution. To shelter oneself against the flood tide of the consequences behind a dike of Scripture passages is impossible. For Scripture passages there is always an interpretation, and as the principle of cognition is, so will the interpretation be. Those who would rightly impress upon themselves that the so-called Scripture principle is, strictly speaking, no principle at all, need in this connection only note the exegetical tactics with which, e.g., the Socinians went to work in order to explain away Christ's pre-existence, a tactic which Strauss has known how to appraise excellently; one need only cast a glance at the sample he gives of an interpretation which Faustus Socinus has given of John 8:58; 17:5 and of the Johannine prologue³¹. [289]

³¹"When Jesus in John 8:58 says to the Jews: *ἀμην, ἀμην λεγω ὑμιν, πρὶν Ἀβραάμ γενεσθαι ἐγὼ εἰμι*, then, first, according to F. Socinus, *πρὶν Ἀβραάμ γενεσθαι* can just as well mean: before Abraham came into being, as: before he came into being; secondly, these words must not be connected with *ἐγὼ εἰμι*, but with *λεγω ὑμιν*; and thirdly, *ἐγὼ εἰμι* must not be understood of mere existence, but of the dignity of the Christ: Verily, before Abraham comes into being, I say unto you that I am the Messiah. But Abraham had indeed not merely come into being but also passed away many hundreds of years before; how, then, can it be set down as something future that he is to come into being? The man with the name Abraham, answers Socinus, had to be sure come into being long ago, but that had come into being, or come to pass, for the sake of which God had given him this name, namely that he should become the father of many nations (Gen. 17:5), i.e. according to the Apostle's interpretation (Rom. 4:11) *πατὴρ πάντων τῶν πιστευόντων δι' ἀκροβυστίας*, since the gospel had not yet been offered to these, but was first to be so on account of the unreceptiveness of the Jews. To these, therefore, Jesus here gives the earnest admonition that they should acknowledge him as the Christ before the Kingdom of God is taken from them and given to the Gentiles".

"At John 17:5 F. Socinus struck out on another path, which Sam. Crell and, later, the rationalists also used for the passage just mentioned. How can one be so blind, he asks, as not to see that Christ here means to say nothing other than that it had already been resolved with God before the creation of the world to bestow on him in due time the glory for which he now prays"?

"Yet a tightly tied knot of exegetical difficulties awaited the sword of Socinian hermeneutics in the Johannine prologue. We shall see whether it has managed to cut through it, or whether it has not rather got hacked to pieces in it. — V. 1. *In the beginning*. This must be understood according to the context. Just as Moses (Gen. 1:1) meant by this expression only the beginning of the things whose origin he there intends to speak of, and those were the things of the visible, not those of the invisible world, so John too can here mean only the beginning of that of which he intends to treat, namely the gospel. Not before anything at all was created, but before the new world of Christianity took its beginning, was already — *the Word*. Just as the Baptist is metonymically called a voice, so Christ is called the Word as the proclaimer of the divine word or the gospel, and it is said of him that in the beginning, i.e. at the time when the Baptist called the people of Israel to repentance, he was already present and chosen by God to proclaim his will. But the Word — was in the beginning *with* God; i.e. before Jesus became

Only when the recollection of pre-existence is regarded from the standpoint of
 [290] the self's relation to the truth will its significance show itself; but then the difference between a knowing and a believing conception will also be conspicuous. For the knower it holds that the self and the truth correspond to each other, not *in concreto* but *in abstracto*, not in actuality but in essentiality, in all generality. Through the truth the knowing self, purified of accidental individuality, goes back into pure selfhood and thereby into pure eternity. Recollection of pre-existence is in this sense a metaphysical dissolution of all existence: the knowing selfhood does not exist, it *is*; it recollects its eternal being by viewing itself *sub specie æternitatis*. The Socratic thesis that all knowing is a recollecting is, says S. Kierkegaard, "an intimation of the beginning of speculation; but for that very reason Socrates did not pursue it either; essentially it became Platonic ... For Socrates, therefore, the thesis that all knowing is a recollecting signifies ... two things: 1) that the knower is essentially *integer*, and that for him there is no other difficulty with regard to the cognition of the eternal truth than this, that he exists, which difficulty is so essential and decisive for him that it signifies that existing, inward deepening in and through existing, is the truth; 2) that existence in temporality has no decisive significance, because there is constantly the possibility of taking oneself back into eternity by recollection, even though this possibility is
 [291] constantly cancelled by the fact that inward deepening in existing fills up time. — Thus subjectivity, inwardness, is the truth; is there now a more inward expression for it? Yes, if the saying: subjectivity, inwardness, is the truth, begins thus: subjectivity is untruth. ... Speculation also says that subjectivity is untruth, but says it in exactly the opposite direction, namely toward the claim that objectivity is the truth. Speculation

known to the Jews through the Baptist, his higher determination was known to God alone; but this determination was of such a kind that it could with justice be said, in the wider sense established above: *the Word was God*. — V. 3. *All things were made by it*, etc.: all the spiritual and divine effects which Christianity produced in the world have their ground in Jesus as the proclaimer of the divine word. — V. 4. *In it was life*, inasmuch as everyone who follows Jesus will attain eternal blessedness and be raised by him to immortality; he *was the light of men*, in that by his teaching and his example he gave them light. — V. 10. *It was in the world, and the world was made by it*: i.e. Christ appeared among men, who through his activity were transformed in a moral respect. — V. 14. *And the Word became flesh* — on the contrary, Christ, the proclaimer of the divine word, *was* already flesh or man at the time spoken of, and so therefore must *ἐγένετο* be translated, as it also can be with justice; and it has been added so that one should not take the being from which such great effects proceeded for a superhuman one; but precisely this word, which was meant to forestall the dreams of a higher nature in Christ, the devil caused men to misunderstand". Anfr. Skr. I Bd. S. 410–413.

determines subjectivity negatively toward objectivity. The other determination, on the contrary, obstructs itself in wanting to begin, which is precisely what makes inwardness far more inward. Socratically, subjectivity is untruth if it will not grasp that subjectivity is the truth but, e.g., wants to be objective. Here, on the other hand, subjectivity, in wanting to begin to become the truth by becoming subjective, is in the difficulty that it is untruth”³².

The relation between the self and the truth is quite different in rational ethics from what it is in revealed religion. The demand of existence is indeed as decisive for ethical subjectivity as for religious; but insofar as the universal-ethical truth is rational, the self in its striving constantly proceeds from the presupposition that it is originally in the truth, and that its self-development is therefore a development of truth, whereas the religious self in its relation to God must cognize that it is essentially in untruth, insofar as it is in sin. The rational-ethical subjectivity, whose troubles and exertions for the truth’s sake are owed only to the temporal, not to the eternal, can therefore, if it will, withdraw from temporality, rest in the thought of eternity, and find relief by identifying itself, through a metaphysics of the recollection of pre-existence, with “the Absolute”. For the religious self such relief is impossible. Self-cognition is in faith inseparable from the cognition of sin; the cognition of sin, the self-contradiction [292] concentrated in an inescapable demand of existence, signifies that the strife between the self and the truth, with all the conflicts belonging to it, concerns not merely the temporal but, in the very strictest sense, the eternal; for the eternal threatens. For the believing consciousness the eternity lying behind is closed, and every recollection of pre-existence unconditionally cut off. But Christ, whose consciousness is the light of revelation, Christ could not possibly be the true, the sinless Self, had he not been able to recollect his pre-existence.

“I am the truth”; “before Abraham was, I am”: these two sentences correspond so completely to each other that if the first fits Christ, then the second does too. It is not the universal Idea of truth, but the holy, personal truth, the truth that is eternally one with the true Self, that is spoken of here. In that Christ personally knows himself to be the truth revealed as man, he knows himself *eo ipso* to be God revealed to men,

³²Afsluttende uvidenskabelig Efterskrift. S. 151–153.

the divine Self, the Son of God from eternity. That in his discourses he nevertheless presents himself as the one who speaks the truth, bears witness to the truth, and so again makes a distinction between himself and the truth, is comprehensible when we think of the existential opposition between phenomenon and essence, between the self as existing individual and the inner infinity indwelling the self, which contains all “the fullness of the Godhead”. Moved by the Spirit, a prophet too can speak the word of truth and bear witness to the truth; but as existing self the prophet is still only a human organ for the divine truth and therefore cannot, even with the highest inspiration, make himself one with the truth; if the inspired one for a single moment [293] confused the human with the divine and gave himself out as the truth, he would be condemned. Therefore none of the prophets in the Old Testament has anywhere hinted at any recollection of pre-existence or dared to say: “before Abraham was, I am”. A prophet too can indeed speak with divine authority; but when he uses his highest authority, he speaks not in his own name but in the name of Jehovah. But Christ, the divine Self, speaks with the highest authority in his own name, speaks from God in speaking from himself: “Verily, verily I say unto you”.

The most telling expression of Christ’s acting as divine Self we have in his word to the paralytic: “Thy sins be forgiven thee”. The scribes, who in him saw and heard only the man, said within themselves: “This man blasphemes God” (Matt. 9:2–3). This was, when we enter into their way of thinking, at bottom quite correct. That one man cannot in his own name pronounce the forgiveness of sins to another, insofar as both are sinners, goes without saying; if it happened, it would seem as parodic as if two prisoners on the way to the examining magistrate were to take turns comforting each other with assurances of acquittal. Even if the one knew himself innocent of the crime charged against him, he could still not possibly acquit the other. Just as little could Christ, even if he knew himself sinless, as man impart forgiveness of sins to any other man. To present oneself as the one who in his own name has authority and power to forgive sins is to present oneself as the divine Self, as the one who is before Abraham was, i.e. as the eternal Judge.

The critique of knowledge has made a great to-do about the great discrepancy that is supposed to exist between the Synoptics and the author of the fourth Gospel in the

presentation of Christ's person. Now, that not only in words and mode of expression, [294] but also in what we may call the fundamental representations and characteristic categories of the philosophy of religion, a difference shows itself, must be granted: John has a deeper eye for the Logos, for the Son's eternity, for his going forth from the Father, than the Synoptics. But this discrepancy does not touch the principle of faith³³. The Johannine Gospel marks no transition whatever from the immediately religious representation to speculation. The speculative element that people have wanted to foist on John is a semblance: the Johannine principle is from first to last a principle of will; the relation between the Father and the Son is unconditionally a relation of will, and Christ's recollection of pre-existence as antirational as possible.

When Christ has healed the sick man at the pool of Bethesda (John 5:1 ff.), and the Jews, who take offense at this, "sought the more to kill him, because he not only had broken the sabbath, but also called God his own Father, making himself equal with God"; there follows a declaration in which the Savior expressly presents himself as the one sent by the Father, as the Judge of the world; for "the Father judgeth no man, but hath given all judgment unto the Son: that all men should honour the Son, even as they honour the Father". The unity of essence of the Father and the Son of which the discourse treats is, as anyone can see, by no means rationally grounded in the metaphysical necessity of the divine self-objectification, but has its antirational [295] ground in the religious-ethical unity of freedom, in the unity of self, the original unity of will; for, testifies the holy voice whose testimony is true, "I seek not mine own will, but the will of the Father which hath sent me".

γ) The Divine-Human Self: The Mystery.

That unity of self rests essentially on a self-doubling conditioned by an other is a principle whose validity modern philosophy has made so evident that it can no

³³"The first three Gospels conceive Christ's divine glory essentially under the prophetic standpoint of eschatology, or, if we may so express ourselves, under the standpoint of his post-existence. ... But in this conception the thought is latently present which John clearly expresses: that he who is the *Last*, who in his coming is to be over all in creation, over all in heaven and on earth, must also be the 'First', must be before all creatures; that he to whom we must in this sense ascribe post-existence must also have pre-existence." H. Martensen. "Den christelige Dogmatik". S. 247-48.

longer be called into doubt. But just as the unity of self, when it is to be more closely determined, is of different kinds, so too the self-doubling is of different kinds. There is, to keep to self-consciousness, an essential difference between the merely formal and the real doubling. The formal one is easy to see through. To become conscious of oneself is to posit the self at once both as subject and as object; the doctrine of formal self-objectification already belongs among the worn-out topics and will not be further developed in this context. It is otherwise with the existential reality of self-doubling. On this important point great obscurity still prevails in philosophy, and for the simple reason that the metaphysics of abstraction, which one-sidedly looks at the universal, all too easily makes short work of turning subjectivity into a theory and reducing the fundamental act of self-objectification to a general act of thought. If this one-sidedness is already harmful to the philosophy of reason, which thereby imperceptibly sinks down into an empty philosophy of words, it is still more harmful, indeed utterly ruinous, to the philosophy of religion.

In the philosophy of religion the unity of self must unconditionally be conceived as personal unity of will, and the corresponding doubling posited not as a mere act of thought but originally as an act of will. How matters stand in this respect with the [296] existential doubling of the self, and how the doubling depends on the difference in the self's centralization, has, as far as the consciousness of sin is concerned, already been touched on in the Introduction. Such concepts as repentance and regret would indeed lack all deeper reality if the pain of repentance were not grounded precisely in the fact that the same existing self cognizes itself as a double self; for the self that has posited the transgression and the self that would blot it out are the same and yet not the same. Only a superficial regret can demand a changed action without demanding a changed self.

The deeper the self, the richer the inwardness, the more peculiar the phenomena of self-doubling that may arise. The mystic's self, e.g., may be now as in heaven, now as in hell; may, without his therefore in a finite sense going out of himself and madly imagining that he has several selves, live through wondrous crises, in that the ideality of the self, through successive and diverse concentrations, makes a series of transformations of consciousness possible. Where rich spiritual gifts and religious

enthusiasm are united, a sober observer will always find it extremely difficult to get to the bottom of another's inner life. We can imagine a man, e.g. a poet, so richly gifted that his productivity is, literally speaking, a riddle even to himself; we can imagine a spark of holy fire falling into such a soul and kindling it into flame; but to measure the depths of subjectivity, to unveil the secret of productivity and discover the hidden wellspring of enthusiasm, this we cannot do. We are taken by surprise, we are almost gripped by fear of madness, when a hitherto unknown inwardness wells forth, incalculably swelling, when a religious enthusiasm that knows no bound suddenly breaks out of its concealment and would give itself vent in transfiguration. The more peculiar the relation to God is, the more it withdraws from every control of a scientific kind. Truth and self-deception, wisdom and derangement can enter into the most [297] diverse combinations in a religiously moved interior and deposit the most wondrous phenomena: the more gifted the individuality is, the harder it is to see through its ground of life and bring the development of its character under universally valid determinations. The one moved in the Spirit can be measured only by his own measure, and the stronger, deeper and more original the movement, the more exceptional the standard. Even when self-reflection, with a psychologically observing, scouting gaze, has been driven to an extreme, and a religious-ethical formation of character carried through with strict vigilance and impressive consistency, the inwardness in the relation to God cannot possibly be expressed in direct communication. "I would" — says one wondrously gifted, just where he is to speak of his relation to God, of what has taught him to marvel at God, his love, and at what a man's impotence is able to do with his assistance — "I would, more resolved than that king who cried: my kingdom for a horse, and blessedly resolved as he was not, give everything, my life included, to find what it is more blessed for thought to find than for the lover to find the beloved: the expression" — the expression of thanksgiving — "so as then to die with this expression on my lips. And lo, it offers itself: the thoughts as enchanting as those fruits in the garden of the fairy tale, so rich, warm, inward, the expressions so soothing to the need of thought in me, so cooling over the hot longing — it seems to me that if I had a winged pen, yes, if I had ten, I would still not be able to keep pace quickly enough with the riches that offer themselves. But as soon as I take my pen in hand, I cannot

for the moment stir it, as one speaks of not being able to stir a foot"³⁴.

[298] So long, however, as the relation to God keeps to a derived stage, so that the religious individuality essentially has its life in an appropriation of the revealed word, without itself daring to present itself as a special, independent organ of revelation, analogies from the universally human will still be able to furnish orienting points of support, and a rational psychology, although the hidden miracle of faith will always withdraw from scientific inquiry, will be able to make negative contributions in determining such limits as may not be overstepped, if actual phenomena of faith are to be distinguished at all from phenomena of eccentric fanaticisms and uncanny aberrations of spirit. If, on the other hand, an exclusive, independent organ of revelation appears, e.g. a prophet, then the mystery in such a self-consciousness will correspond categorically to the revelation. But where mystery and revelation correspond categorically to each other, so that the mystery halts knowledge while what is revealed enriches faith, there every standard taken from humanity and rational psychology is inapplicable. Of penetrating cognition of a self-consciousness of a different kind it holds first and last: only like is understood by like. If already a prophet's religious self-consciousness, by virtue of what has been entrusted to him, is qualitatively different from every other believing consciousness, then Christ's self-consciousness must surely be in an absolute sense different even from the prophet's. The Son, the Only-begotten, knows himself — realiter — to be God, and knows himself at the same time — realiter — to be man: this self-doubling is in its divine-human reality an impenetrable Mystery.

Nevertheless the spokesmen of faith and of unbelief alike, each from his own side, have with great importunity attempted to work their way through the Mystery. The confusion of thought has moreover been increased by the fact that, instead of holding the task fast in the spiritual form of self-consciousness, hence of self-certainty and ideality, people have had it transformed into a piece of philosophy of nature, a physiological-hyperphysiological task, by introducing the doctrine of Christ's two natures.

The starting point of the christological conceptual aberrations must originally be sought in the speculations on the Logos. However different the representations

³⁴S. Kierkegaard. Synspunktet for min Forfattervirksomhed en ligefrem Meddelelse. Rapport til Historien. Kbhvn., 1859. S. 51.

were from the beginning, there was nevertheless general agreement in regarding the Logos as an independent being. The representation of a distinct Logos-self stood firm as an indisputable presupposition when the doctrine of the Logos as the uncreated Son, begotten of the Father from eternity by necessity, was declared orthodox. So the task was to explain to oneself how the eternal, almighty, omniscient and omnipresent Logos-self could at a given point in time take on human nature and let itself be born as a man. This task is insoluble. Here, for the objective view, a double Logos-self takes shape, one in God and another in man; the former is from eternity, the latter has a beginning in time; the former is being, the latter becoming; the former is almighty, the latter suffering; the former remains in heaven while the latter walks on earth: instead of one Son of God, speculation, however reluctantly, gets two Sons of God, one who has not become man and one who has become man. If we next consider the Logos-self that has become man, the difficulty repeats itself with respect to the self of the man. If God the Logos has actually himself become man, a true, complete man, then in the God-man there must surely be either a double self, a Logos-self, for this man is the Son of God, and a human self, for this Son of God is a true man; or else the Logos-self must exclude the human self. But whether one now assumes that in the God-man there is a double self, or that the Logos-self has displaced the human self and put itself in its place, the result is equally absurd.

When the limits of the cognition of faith are overstepped and the inseparable unity [300] of the two separated natures is to be exactly fixed, the critique of knowledge at once comes forward with objections such as these. "If the Son of God, an almighty being, the ruler of the world, eternal, equal to himself in actuality, was to be united with a finite man who had come into being, then only two ways were open: either the God had to contract himself into human finitude and submit to human becoming, so that he had actually slumbered unconscious in the mother's womb along with the man, after birth developed successively, and for his lifetime renounced participation in the government of the world; but thereby his divinity was sublated, and the Church, which needed it, consequently could not go this way. So there was then the other way: while the man developed successively from embryo to adult, the God remained equal to himself in his absolute actuality; while the man slept unconscious in the ship,

the God was omniscient; while the man hung on the cross and lay in the grave, the God governed all things. This is the general basis of the ecclesiastical representation; but thereby, to be sure, the unity of Christ's person would be completely torn apart. Therefore his human nature was also made to share in the prerogatives of the divine; thereby the still more glaring contradiction was posited, that one was now to think of this one human nature on the one hand as raised above successive becoming, as omniscient and almighty, and yet on the other hand as successively becoming and limited in power and knowledge. This latter it never actually was either, but constantly only the former, though in a hidden way, said the one party: — and thus it dissolved the whole human life of Christ into a deceptive jugglery. It did possess those prerogatives of the divine nature, said the other party, but as a rule abstained from using them: —

[301] so Christ was after all sometimes, as man, with the human structure of the brain etc., omniscient and almighty; indeed, his human nature could just as well already in the mother's womb, consequently as an embryo, have known everything, governed the world — it was only the fault of his free will when he did not do it.”³⁵

Once the doctrine of faith has crossed over onto the preserves of objective knowledge, it is too late to take refuge in the incomprehensible and appeal to the Mystery when one is struck by the arrows of critique; for the boundary has been overstepped. The Mystery is the boundary, the categorically decisive boundary for the thinking of faith as well as for that of knowledge. The boundary is determined by the concepts' own consistent self-dissolution. That the unity of the self in Christ with the eternal Logos-self is a unity of principle, faith must hold fast; but how Christ's consciousness was able to convert this unity of principle into a concrete personal unity of self is and remains an impenetrable Mystery. What help is it, then, to take refuge in phrases such as these: “Here there are not two Sons of God, but one Son of God; with Christ no other Son is added to the Trinity; the whole movement takes place within the circle of the Trinity,” and so on, when it is nevertheless impossible in the objective sense to think, or even to form a representation of, how the Logos-self in God and the Logos-self in man could, despite the separation, be united within the circle of the Trinity? Or is there really any thinker who will seriously undertake to make clear to

³⁵Strauss Troesl. II. Bd. S. 117

us a doubling such as this, that one and the same self can at one and the same time be both omniscient and yet not omniscient, both almighty and yet suffering? If there cannot be two Sons of God here, then still less can the one Son of God be thought to have divided himself into two half Sons. It is surely a monstrous notion that the one half Son, the one half Self of the Son, “the pure Logos of the Godhead,” should pervade [302] “the kingdom of nature in all-filling presence,” while the other half Son, the other half Self of the Son, could only at a particular time be present in a particular place, be it in Nazareth or in Jerusalem. What help is it to want to correct the old dogmaticians, who, in order to maintain the unity of self, represented to themselves that the divine properties were communicated by *communicatio idiomatum* — to the human nature in all infinity, when there is not the slightest scientific prospect of getting a hair’s breadth further with “the rightly understood concept of the divine self-limitation” (*κενωσις*)? Just one example: Christ foretells the end of the world and adds (Mark 13:32): “But of that day and hour knoweth no man, neither the angels which are in heaven, neither the Son, but the Father only,” and Quenstedt explains the passage: “I, Christ, as man, now in the state of humiliation make no use of the divine omniscience, which I nevertheless possess, so that I now in actuality do not know the time of the last day.” How will one correct Quenstedt in an objective scientific doctrine of faith? If one says that Christ in his state of humiliation actually did not know the day and the hour, while “the pure Logos of the Godhead” in heaven knew both day and hour, then we surely get a double Logos-self, “a Christ with two heads,” the one with limited, the other with unlimited knowledge.

Now if it were possible to cut away the spongy excrescences of speculation with a single stroke, or at least to weed out the weeds of the science of faith as one weeds thistles with a sharp iron, then it would undeniably be the most practical method to declare “the God-man” “a paradox” and the paradox “an absurdum.” That is the Kierkegaardian way out, which, as regards the inward deepening of the problems of existence, certainly has its right. But the thought of faith, as thought, has its right too. The religious conception of the God-man must, as surely as it is to be at one with [303] an essential self-understanding, necessarily presuppose a believing conception of the divine-human Self; but a believing conception is conditioned by the thought of faith;

now if the thought of faith is broken off just as abruptly as the thought of knowledge, then one surely pulls up the wheat together with the tares, and things look doubtful for the weeding.

S. Kierkegaard reduces the religious conception of the God-man to the conception of a divine-human incognito. The God-man is God, but chooses to become the individual man. "This is the deepest incognito or the most impenetrable unrecognizability that is possible; for the contradiction between being God and being an individual man is the greatest possible, the infinitely qualitative one. But it is his will, his free resolve, and therefore an almightily maintained incognito. Indeed, by letting himself be born, he has in a certain sense bound himself once and for all; his unrecognizability is so almightily maintained that he himself is in a way in the power of his incognito, wherein lies the literal *actuality* of his purely human suffering, that this is not a mere appearance, but in a certain sense is the over-power of the assumed unrecognizability over himself."³⁶

Whoever rightly reflects on what is said here will see that there is a difference between a mystery and an absurdum. The Mystery dissolves the contradiction by dissolving the contradictory concepts. In an absurdum, on the other hand, we have a hard knot of fixed, undissolved and yet incompatible conceptual determinations, of eternal contradictions, indissoluble in themselves. "That an Almighty One" "lets himself be born," "that an Almighty One voluntarily posits an incognito so almightily that the Almighty himself is in the power of his incognito"—such screaming contradictions [304] belong not to the Mystery but to the pure absurdum. The reserving expressions "in a way," "in a certain sense," give no understanding in the context cited. The author must surely be right when he adds: "It is a strange kind of dialectic, that he (the God-man) almightily — binds himself; and he does it so almightily that he actually feels himself bound, suffers under the consequence of his having lovingly and freely resolved to become an individual man." Indeed, it is a strange kind of dialectic that the divine-human Self, the Self in which all cognition of God, all true self-cognition is to be grounded, is not merely a sign that is spoken against by others, but essentially a sign that contradicts itself.

³⁶Indøvelse i Christendom af Anticlimacus. 2det Oplag. 1855. S. 141.

The divine-human Self of the Son is no paradox; but it is a Mystery.

b) Fundamental Determinations in the Self of the Son.

§ 20.

Jesus Christ, God's only-begotten Son, is not an object of knowledge but the object of faith. As the object is, so must the objectivation be; just as the objects of knowledge presuppose an objectivation in knowledge, so the objects of faith must presuppose an objectivation in faith. Now as surely as the principles, that of faith and that of knowledge, are absolutely heterogeneous, so must the objectivation of faith also be absolutely heterogeneous with that of knowledge. The absolutely heterogeneous lies, as we have seen, not immediately in the difference of the object, but essentially in the transformation which the differently constituted objectivation brings about. Now all objectivation in faith has this peculiarity about it, that self-understanding and understanding of the object condition each other in inner infinity. The sinful one must know himself by the sinless One, and conversely; the one darkened in temporality must know himself by the One transfigured in the light of eternity, and conversely; this is objectivation in faith. The like and the unlike, the common and the different, can [305] only through such an objectivation come forth and obtain their full significance. This, then, is the likeness, the common element: that the Christ-self, the holy Logos-self, which "sinks itself into the womb of humanity as possibility, as holy seed" and lets itself be born of a woman, begins from the germ of its becoming its development in time in a manner corresponding to every natural human self; while the unlikeness and difference is that the selfish self, lost in finitude, forgets eternity, whereas the holy Self, striving in finitude, unceasingly remembers its eternity and makes manifest the eternal life of the self. This is the likeness, the common element: that the Christ-self, the holy Logos-self, does not have its life immediately of itself, but of God in its relation to God, in a manner corresponding to every believing human self; but the unlikeness and difference shows itself in this, that the true original relation to God, the Son's life of the Father in the Father, is his eternal life in himself, while the believer can have a

derived life in himself only by appropriating the life in the Son and through the Son of the Father. This is the likeness, the common element: that the man Christ, the object of faith, is as an existing man with human limitation a single self-luminous point in the outer infinite universe, in a manner corresponding to every man developed to consciousness; but the unlikeness, the thoroughgoing difference, is that Christ, the original light of truth, of life, is the sun of spirits for time and eternity, while the light of eternity that is kindled by faith in man's soul is a derived light, a ray from the sun of spirits.

α) The Self of the Son Is Logos.

Originally the gaze of faith is to be fixed on Jesus of Nazareth, appearing as an
 [306] actual man and yet as Messiah. By hearing his words and seeing his works the disciples at once received a double impression. With John it begins as if the understanding came of itself; it begins with ideal expectations: "Hereafter ye shall see heaven open, and the angels of God ascending and descending upon the Son of man" (John 1:52). But that the contrast between the outward lowliness and the inward glory worked strongly on the first disciples, and that it fermented and labored in them before they could come to a clear and secure understanding, of this the Gospels contain many and eloquent testimonies. It came to a breakthrough in Peter when he (Matt. 16:16), to the Master's question, gave the celebrated answer: "Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God"; but how unsteadily the flaring light burned, and how easily the understanding could go backward during the walk with Christ, Peter himself shows by his example to the very last. Only after the Risen One had entered into his glory, and the Spirit had been poured out upon his witnesses, did the image of the Transfigured One stand living before them with all its divine-human features. If we then gather the utterances of the Evangelists and Apostles about the divinity of Christ into one total impression, they all agree in acknowledging the Son of man as the Son of God, as the Firstborn of all creation, as Logos, as the brightness of God's glory and the express image of his essence (Heb. 1:3); this is the first fundamental determination in the Self of the Son: *the Son is Logos*.

If we now take note of the way by which the fundamental determination has been reached, we learn what it means that the object of faith will be objectified in faith. For the starting point of cognition is not set in God's eternal essence, in the Trinity *ad intra*; but the starting point is in God revealed as man, in the living personal impression of the person of Christ. One does not begin with God's immanent self-objectivation, the great problem of necessity in speculation; but one begins with the existing Self, with [307] the pure, the holy will, which alone is able to awaken the life of truth, of freedom and of love in believing souls: one begins not rationally, but antirationally.

Therefore in the apostolic objectivation a series of determinations is also left out which scientific reflection constantly seeks but never finds, and these are the metaphysical intermediate determinations, precisely those determinations of essence which were to raise faith up to knowledge and give the doctrine of faith the stamp of objective science. It is said briefly and simply that the Logos was in the beginning with God and was God; but of the original relation of the Logos-self to the God-self there is not even the faintest hint. It is said briefly and simply that the Logos became flesh, but about the relation between the self in the eternal Logos and the self in the Logos become man not a word is said; and why not? Because the metaphysical problem of the Incarnation did not exist at all for the Evangelist. The more personally the matter is taken, the plainer it becomes that the metaphysics of the problem falls outside faith. Just imagine how it would look if one of the disciples, for example Peter, had turned metaphysical along the way and had put the following question to Christ: "Master, tell me honestly, how can you, who are now the Son of God on earth, bodily present among us, at the same time be the Son of God in heaven, the Almighty, Omnipresent One, who together with the Father governs all the world—are you able to do this *κατα κρυφιν* or perhaps *κατα κενωσιν*?"—and one will get an impression of blasphemy, an impression that Christ would sternly have rebuffed the questioning Peter, as on a given occasion he rebuffed the admonishing Peter: "Get thee behind me, Satan! thou art an offense unto me." Should a clever man of metaphysics find the rebuff natural on the ground that "Christ, who was not a metaphysician and consequently not yet fully [308] transparent to himself in the universal, naturally had to avail himself of his authority and snap at the disciple because he was unable to answer his scientific question": then

an enlightenment of knowledge of that nature will certainly not darken the believer.

Scholastic orthodoxy, however, is not content with a religious development of the content of religion; it demands metaphysically exact intermediate determinations, it objectifies in knowledge, it determines the indeterminable, it violates the Mystery.

How characteristic in this respect is the controversy between Arius and Athanasius! They both proceed from the presuppositions of faith, they are both agreed that the content of faith must allow itself to be thought, and so they both also come to commit the same blunder, of confusing thoughts of faith with thoughts of knowledge: we hear it at once in the fundamental question. Is the Son *created* or *begotten* of the Father, is the Logos from God with freedom or with necessity? To answer this question exactly, one would of necessity have to have the two concepts, creation and begetting, perfectly clear, and also be able to make the concept of God so objectively transparent that the difference between a *created* and a *begotten* God became entirely evident. But how impossible it is, from the standpoint of faith, to comprehend God's inner, eternal self-revelation is noticeable already at the beginning of the controversy. When Arius asserts that the Son is created, but with the advantage over the other creatures that these all, the Holy Spirit not excepted, are in turn created through the Son, it is evident that he does not comprehend what he himself is saying. There are certain notions, in his opinion offensive, of an emanation of the Logos from God, a division of God, a fusion of the essence of the Father and of the Son, and the like, that he wants to ward off; but that he has not made the concept of creation clear to himself, and still less seen [309] through what lies in such concepts as a *created God*, a *created Creator*, is unmistakable. But the same must be said of Athanasius. Instead of seeing that the blunder of Arius consists precisely in his demanding metaphysical intermediate determinations where they cannot be given, and therefore arbitrarily setting up propositions that confuse the religious representations, Athanasius himself treads the same path as his opponent, only that he wants his own metaphysics, not his opponent's, sanctioned. That Athanasius comprehends what he himself sets up as little as Arius does can easily be proved. According to Athanasius the Son is to have been begotten of the Father from eternity; but not to mention that the category of begetting, as the Arians indeed amply emphasized, points especially to a sensuous-bodily natural production,

a division of the Father's essence, the concept of a begetting from eternity is surely heavily burdened with contradiction. To be begotten from eternity was accordingly, for the Arians too, the same as not to be begotten. "If the Son is not to be begotten, since he already was, which is a contradiction, then he cannot possibly have existed before his begetting." The eternal begetting is a beginning without beginning, a production of something already produced, a coming-to-be of that which does not come to be, but is. So Athanasius and his friends had at last to admit that the begetting of the Son took place in an incomprehensible manner (*ἀρρόπτως και ἀνεκδιηγητως*), that in other words the concept of begetting, applied to God, is an incomprehensible concept³⁷. [310]

So then: first one violates the Mystery by forcing metaphysical intermediate determinations into the Confession of Faith; when it then turns out that these intermediate determinations end in sheer contradictions, one appeals to the Mystery — the Mystery one has oneself violated.

β) In the Self of the Son Is Life.

"The Father hath given to the Son to have life in himself"; herein lies that Christ gives the world a new life, in that he introduces a new Self into the world. From the standpoint of ecclesiastical metaphysics this Self has admittedly been mistreated to such a degree that negative critique has done religion an essential service by making the mistreatment manifest. According to the scholastic-objective doctrine of the Church, no personality of its own is to be ascribed to Christ's human nature; but — this is a Straussian objection — Jesus' humanity would then surely be mutilated, and he could not have had any human spirit at all if, on account of the union with the Logos, no personality could develop from his human nature. In that case no human soul could develop either, nor any human body. "For since it is evidently an effect of

³⁷That some of the Church Fathers at least had an inkling that the defenders of orthodoxy were forced by the inventions of the heretics onto an unnatural path can be seen, among other things, from the following utterance. *Sufficiebat quidem credentibus Dei sermo ... Sed compellimur hæreticorum et blasphemantium vitiis illicita agere, ardua scandere, ineffabilia eloqui, inconcessa præsumere. Hilarius de trinitate. II, 1. Jvfr. Gieseler I, 2, S. 43.* — So far is it from being possible to say that the *Symbolum Nicænum* clarified and strengthened the life of the congregation, that the Greek Church, as Grundtvig has with full right emphasized, by making this Symbol its foundation and, in accordance with its Alexandrian principle of Scripture, exchanging faith in the living word of Christ for faith in dogmatic metaphysics, brought about precisely the spiritual self-enfeeblement under which it suffers to this day.

the human spirit enclosed as a germ in the human embryo that it develops into an ensouled body of definite shape and constitution, an organism of quite another kind [311] would have had to form for the Son of God when he as the germ of personality joined himself to a human embryo (just as the gall wasp, when with its sting it bores into the branch of a rosebush, produces no rose, but the moss-covered concretion that the common people in Germany call Schafapfel)³⁸.”

These and similar objections lose their significance when, in accordance with the principle of faith, we place the qualitative difference between the Christ-self and every other human self in sinlessness alone. The sinless Self is, as Logos-germ, of divine nature, holy and pure as God's own Self. That the interaction between the supernatural Logos-principle and the bodily matter in a human embryo is an impenetrable Mystery is granted; but then we ask: what does science have with which it can prove, not the improbability, for that is understood, but the impossibility of such an interaction? Facts, as in the fine example of the gall wasp and the rosebush, it surely does not have at all. “But concepts!” Yes, empty formulas for the benefit of verbal critique, meaningless contradictions such as: that a supernatural principle is not a natural one, that Christ is not a man like other men, and so on, conceptual contradictions which all creep forward under the mystification that we know what we nevertheless do not know, have knowledge of what we nevertheless do not have knowledge of.

As the true man and Son of God, Christ lives in himself only by living in God, and lives in God in living in himself: he does not have a religion, for he is religion. In religion itself the relation to God is the pure, ideal relation of will; religion itself is life, eternal life. That man in his relation to God is absolutely dependent on God, the believer can learn from Christ. For although the Son testifies of himself that he and the [312] Father are one (John 10:30), yet he also testifies most emphatically to his dependence, his absolute dependence on the Father. He has nothing of himself, cannot speak of himself and can do nothing at all of himself (John 5:19); but all that he is, he is of the Father, and all that he speaks, and that he does, and that he is able to do, all of it is given him by the Father. But in this absolute dependence he has *eo ipso* his absolute freedom, his inner infinite independence. His life of the Father is his own life, his

³⁸Strauss. Troesl. II. S. 94.

original living in himself. “For as the Father hath life in himself, so hath he given to the Son to have life in himself, and hath given him authority to execute judgment also, because he is the Son of man” (John 5:26–27). The relation to God is, to speak in the language of the schools, an infinitely rich relation of immanence; but while we lay weight, decisive weight, on the immanence, we must not forget that this holy relation of immanence is a relation of freedom, a relation of will in principle, therefore — antirational!

The divine-human life, the eternal life of religion, is life in the Logos; to this Logos-life, doubled in itself, there now corresponds the doubled Self, the Self in God and the Self in man, but in such a way that the Self in God, by the living contrast to man as man, is one with the Father revealing himself in the Son, while the Self in man, by the living contrast to God as God, is the true man, the Son of God, who says of himself: “He that hath seen me hath seen the Father” (John 14:9; 12:45). Objectified in faith, the life of Christ is thus an original double life; to this double life there corresponds, as we shall now see, the categorical doubling of the Logos-Self.

In order to do the Father’s will on earth, the Son must have knowledge of the Father’s will, which is in heaven. Whence, then, does he as man have this knowledge? He has it from himself; for the human Self in him, the Logos-principle developed in [313] time, is the revelation of the Logos-Self in God, the eternal Self in which the Father has all knowledge and will. And yet the Son does not have his knowledge immediately or once and for all of himself; for in this sense he has nothing, nothing at all, of himself: he has it only in that it is given him and in every moment is being given him; that is to say: he has it in his relation to God: he has it in religion, and he is religion itself. Both moments in the fundamental determination, both that he has his knowledge of himself and that he has it from the Father, are accordingly also presented in the evangelical objectivation in such a way that the union and the separation come to view equally. He is the knower of hearts, who sees through both Pharisees and Sadducees and “sees their thoughts”; but that he is so because it is given him is recognizable from this, that although as man he is not omniscient, he nevertheless knows, when it is needed for the completion of the revelation, what he could not possibly know on human terms (John 11:4), while such knowledge in turn, where it is not needed (Mark 13:52), is also

not given him. To draw a scientific inference from his human to his divine knowledge, or conversely, is impossible, since his divine-human knowledge moves in and with the revelation itself as a living personal knowledge.

In order to do the Father's will on earth, the Son must have a power like the Father's in heaven. The revelation of the will in the sign of power is the miracle: the Son could not reveal the Father's will in deed if he could not perform the miracle. Whence, then, has he the power? Not from himself immediately, as an actual human being; for an actual human being cannot, in consequence of the limitation of human nature, be omnipotent. He has it from the Father, through the eternal Logos; he has it [314] in his relation to God, inasmuch as it is given to him (John 11:41). And yet he has it in himself as his own power, a Logos-power appropriated in the human self, where it is needed: he helps because he wills to help, he heals because he wills to heal. From the momentary revelations of power, therefore, no scientific conclusion can be drawn to the denial of his human suffering, any more than from his human suffering any scientific conclusion can be drawn to the denial of his divine power. He who cannot understand in faith that the Son's power is not an omnipotence inherent in his human nature, but a living power of will, a power which he neither can nor will have except as the Father gives it to him, a power of religion and of prayer, a power in the relation to God, must go to Gethsemane and hear the one who prays: "Father, if it be possible"!

Just as little as the miracles that Christ performs can shed any light on his actual human nature, just so little can the miracles that happen to him himself give any light that falls outside faith. He walks upon the sea, he is transfigured on the mountain; but he who would conclude from the walking upon the sea that his human body was, by its nature, raised above the laws of gravity, would go astray just as surely as he who would infer from his transfiguration on the mountain the constitution of the body with which he was crucified. The momentary transformations, foreshadowings of the last great, concluding transformation in which he enters into glory, are as incomprehensible for faith as for knowledge: the concepts belonging here dissolve into the Mystery, the Mystery in which the unity of nature and creation is hidden.

Instead of holding to the evangelical exemplar and conceiving the relation between the Christ-Self and the Logos-Self indwelling in the Father as the revelation of the ideal

relation to God, the living religion, “the life, the eternal, which was with the Father and was revealed to us,” orthodoxy early struck into another, an objectively scientific track, and, without heeding the categorical boundary-line of the Mystery, has set out [315] by exact determinations of character to make plain the union of Christ’s two natures as a union of two existing substances. What disputes and confusions, what a swarm of contradictions, what monstrosities of the understanding this doctrine of union has brought into the world in heterodox pains with orthodox birth-pangs, is well known. The orthodox theory of *unitio personalis* and *status unionis*, with the consequences flowing from it, cannot be improved by paraphrases or mediating alterations; by its sharply stamped form, as the ripe fruit of scholasticism, it has precisely fallen due to critical dissolution.

Concerning Jesus’ words on the cross: “My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me”? Strauss remarks that these words befit only a human being who is not personally united with God, so that he whose personality is constituted precisely by this union could not speak thus until his personality had become another; and the critique follows: “Now in the doctrine of the Church the person of Christ is formed by the Son of God, while the human nature in him, as impersonal, is only taken up into that divine person. That outcry, then, could come only from the Son of God or the Logos, since there is no person in Christ besides him, and he must have called upon the Father, by whom he had therefore felt himself forsaken. But how will one be able to represent this to oneself without tearing the Trinity asunder and abolishing the Son’s divinity? Therefore it is not the Son of God or Christ’s divine nature that is supposed to have felt itself forsaken by the Father, but Christ’s human nature by the divine, and at the same time (since *derelictio* — as *opus ad extra* — is supposed to be common to the three Persons) by the whole Trinity. But the human nature, which was in itself impersonal, could not have any self-feeling of its own either, and consequently could not cry out those words either; rather the Son of God in Christ must have done so, and he must [316] therefore, in the name of his human nature, have complained to himself of what he himself had done, or, since his human nature was not a subject distinct from him, have forsaken himself; and so he would more properly have cried out: why have I, rather

than: why hast thou forsaken me"?³⁹

Such positive and negative unnaturalnesses fall away of themselves when the relation between the Father and the Son, with the corresponding doubling of life in the Logos-Self, is conceived as a fundamental religious relation; we can then, from the standpoint of religion — not from that of science and speculation — conceive “the divine-human states” as exemplary designations for the alternation of states which is lived through by believers in outward as well as inward experiences. “For not only in the outward states of the saints, but also in their inward states and moods of soul, there must be an alternation of *κρύψις* and *Φανέρωσις*, of obscurity and transfiguration, emptiness and fullness. ... As surely as Christ had to be tempted in all things as we are, yet without sin, so surely must there also be in his inward life this alternation of states of obscurity and transfiguration, of emptiness and fullness. Although he was never alone, but the Father was always with him, although the fullness of the Godhead dwelt bodily in him, he nevertheless knew not only such states in which the fullness broke through the earthly limitation and the Only-begotten rested blessedly at the Father’s bosom, but also such states in which the fullness of the Godhead had withdrawn into the hidden depths of his being, was only in the *ground* of his existence, while in his actuality of soul he had to fight the fight of patience”⁴⁰.

[317]

γ) The Self of the Son Is the Light of the World.

“As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world” (John 9:5). Christ is the light of the world because he is the life of the world: as the life is, so also is the light. Now as surely as the Christ-life, the holy Logos-life, is a life in God, the eternal life of religion in the ideal relation to God, so surely is the light that goes forth from Christ to illuminate the world also the holy light of religion, which must not be confused with that of science. Where, however, a great and comprehensive religious contemplation of the world is concerned, the confusion lies near at hand. At first glance it looks as though the evangelists and apostles, in their various utterances about the Son as Logos, as the Firstborn of all creation, as the Mediator between the Father and the world, had

³⁹Troesl. II Bd. S. 119–20.

⁴⁰H. Martensen. “Den christl. Dogm”. S. 298–99.

really given us the foundation for an objective scientific cosmology resting on the doctrine of Christ. What can be adduced from this point of view has already been set forth in “the Christian Dogmatics.” The Son of God, it says, as the Logos of the Father, who is at the same time the eternal world-Logos, has in his pre-existence already prepared for himself the conditions for his revelation of love, his becoming man in the fullness of time, the revelation in which he first completely actualizes his concept as the *mediating* God. His revelation, which has not merely historical, not merely religious and ethical, but metaphysical significance, cannot be determined by sin alone, for sin has not entered according to a metaphysical necessity; it is cosmologically determined: he could become the Savior only because it is his eternal concept to be the Mediator (*Etsiamsi homo non peccasset, Deus tamen incarnatus esset*). Only as the world-redeeming and world-completing Mediator can the Son in truth be cognized as the self-revelation of the divine Logos. For the world-completing principle cannot [318] be different from the world-creating one, through which all things have come to be. Thus, then, Christ, the Logos become man, is not merely the center of the human world but the center of all creation. For him who stands as personal eternity in the midst of the times, indeed in the midst of all creation, the sensuous difference between past and future has only vanishing significance; for all the ages of the world, all aeons, move about him as about their all-determining center.

The profound utterances in which the author of the Christian Dogmatics⁴¹ has presented the Only-begotten as the life of the world and the light of the world we shall willingly grant our recognition, now that the dark sides of the matter have already been sufficiently brought out in another connection⁴²; but we ask: is it not after all necessary to secure the holy truths by securing their grounding? And, when grounding is in question, is it not then necessary to reflect on the difference between rational and antirational grounding, on the difference between the light of science and that of religion, on the difference between objectifying in knowledge and objectifying in faith? To a separation of this nature the word of Scripture cannot directly guide us. The biblical worldview corresponds, also with regard to outward actuality, immediately to the believing conception of Christ as the center of all creation; nor, as far as the

⁴¹Cf. “Læren om Sønnen”. S. 243–44; 265–68; 273–74.

⁴²Den gode Villie som Magt i Videnskaben. S. 76–110.

light is concerned, can there be any question here of a divorce between religion and science, for to the apostolic consciousness science did not exist at all. But in the [319] present time, when science from so many sides and in so many ways makes it felt that it exists; in the present time, when actuality in outward nature has changed because the consciousness of it has changed, and the whole universe has received another shape; in this present time it is unavoidably necessary to distinguish between world and world, between life and life, between light and light.

In order to see the necessity of a thoroughgoing separation between religion and science, we need not make science partial to unbelief; we may well let it proceed from the presupposition that everything revelation teaches about "the mediating God" as "the center of all creation" has its validity, its full truth, in the universe of the spirit and hence, to that extent, also in the universe of actuality: and yet, when the question here is of light and illumination, of ground and grounding, science has its misgivings and will and must make its objections. Christ says: "All power is given unto me in heaven and on earth." Now when these words are explained to mean that "all heavenly and earthly powers, all forces in nature and history, find in him their liberating center and are subservient to the kingdom whose head he is," then the question is: how is this to be understood scientifically? If Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Mary, is the only Christ in the whole universe, then the human race on this earth must presumably also be the universe's only human race. Or, if there are on other globes also races that stand in need of redemption, then there are indeed several possibilities. Either the redemption of all races on all globes must be included in the redemption which has taken place once for all on earth; or Jesus of Nazareth must wander from globe to globe and on each globe let himself be born anew of that globe's Mary, become a child again and grow up in the form of a servant and begin the work of redemption over again; or else each globe must have its own Christ, so that there will be as many Christs as there are [320] fallen races. But if there are several Christs, indeed perhaps an incalculable number, how then can we understand that our Christ must be precisely the highest among them all, the only true over-Christ, "the center of all creation, the second Adam, in whom the heavenly and the earthly, the invisible and the visible, the forces of all creation, angels, dominions and powers, find their all-comprehending conclusion"? If

we say: there can be only one Christ in the universe, since in all rational races there is essentially only one race, in all falls essentially one sin, in the work of redemption valid for the whole world essentially one redeeming activity, then we hold exclusively to the principle, and can to that extent appeal with reason to the world-creating and world-redeeming Logos-principle. But the principle is one thing, the self another.

Between the Logos-Self in God and the Logos-self in the true, sinless human being the difference must surely become infinitely great when we take it cosmologically; for an orthodox Protestant who would say that it is Jesus of Nazareth who created the world would surely express himself just as unscientifically as a simple Catholic who would hold that it is the Virgin Mary who created the world.

Once one has placed oneself at the standpoint of science and drawn the outlines of a christological cosmology, one ought not to shrink back from difficulties lying near at hand or excuse oneself from further explanation of obscure points. If Christ is the light of the world, and the light scientific, then the religious cosmology must be capable of being placed in objectively clear illumination. That this has not happened, and by the conditions of cognition cannot happen, is an eloquent proof that the religious cosmology neither is nor will be scientific.

From the standpoint of faith the objections of science fall away as of themselves. According to the principle of faith, no objective proof is to be conducted that Christ, [321] by virtue of the concept “the mediating God,” must absolutely be the only possible Savior of the world and in consequence of this the true Savior for us; were such a proof to be conducted, then the grounding would certainly have to be rational, and lack of rational grounding would mean lack of light. But the grounding is inverted. Here one begins with the inner self-assurance, the assurance that Jesus of Nazareth, the true, sinless human being, is the only true Savior for us human beings, that, as Paul expresses it, “there is no salvation in any other,” and then one sees from this that he, objectified in faith, must also be the Savior true in himself, the Son of God, the Only-begotten of the Father, whose redeeming, saving power is cognized not only on earth but also in heaven.

c) The Personality of the Son.

§ 21.

The corresponding fundamental features are already indicated in the exposition of the Father's personality. But just as the Self in the Father first receives its full illumination through its relation to the Self in the Son, so too the Son's human existence, with the revelation of personality corresponding to it, will first be able to furnish the real, life-filled foundation for the development of the concept of personality which, because it corresponds to the Son only by corresponding to the Father, and conversely, expresses the personal unity-in-opposition of the Father and the Son. We bring this development of the concept under the three points of view: *the metaphysics of personality, the revelation of personality, and the eternal life of personality.*

[322]

α) The Metaphysics of Personality.

The improbable is to be believed; but the impossible cannot be believed: to secure ourselves against the absurdity of impossibilities we take our point of departure in knowledge. "Two," says Hegel, "cannot be One," and in this he is certainly right. His explanation is, in brief, this. The category *One*, the abstract One, is, as logic shows, a bad category. Now as far as personality is concerned, every person is indeed something rigid, brittle, independent, being-for-itself; but it nevertheless lies in the character of the person, still more in that of the subject, to sublate its isolation, its *separateness*. Ethical life, love, is: to give up one's particularity, one's particular personality, and to extend it to universality; so that the identity of the one with its other shows itself. In acting rightly toward another, I treat him as identical with me. In friendship, in love, I give up my abstract personality and thereby win it as concrete. The truth in personality is precisely this: to win it through this sinking in, this immersion in the other. When personality is as *undissolved*, then one has *evil*; for the personality that will not merge in the divine Idea is evil. In the divine unity personality is posited as dissolved; only in appearance is the negativity of personality different from that by which it is sublated. The Trinity is brought under the relation of *Father, Son* and *Spirit*; this is a childlike relation, a childlike, natural form. The understanding has no such category, no such relation, as could fittingly be compared with this; it must then be

brought to consciousness that it is only figurative: the Spirit does not clearly enter into the relation. Love would have been more fitting; but the true is the Spirit. The abstract God, the Father, is the universal, the eternal, all-embracing, total particularity. We are at the stage of the spirit; *the universal here includes everything in itself*; the [323] other, the Son, is the infinite particularity, the appearance (the phenomenon); the third, the Spirit, is individuality as such; all three are the Spirit. In the third, we say, is the Spirit of God, but this is also presupposing; the third is also the first⁴³.

That such a foundation is far too thin for a doctrinal edifice to be erected upon it to the honor of the personal God of the Trinity, anyone will easily see. The divine Self, the real kernel, is entirely dissolved, and the whole reduced to a trilogical unity of a formal process in the ideality of the spirit. The slipperiness of the Hegelian doctrine of the Trinity Strauss has demonstrated with sharp acuity of understanding. Concerning Hegel's rejection of the application of number: "Three cannot be One; of three as a number there is no question here at all," he remarks: "Against what, then, is one not to dare to bring number to bear? against the Hegelian or against the ecclesiastical Trinity? To do so against the former has not yet occurred to anyone, because moments which dialectically pass over into one another are not stable enough to permit any counting; but in the doctrine of the Church these moments, by Hegel's own declaration, stand fast as subjects existing for themselves, and consequently they not only can, but must, be counted. Against the doctrine of the Church, then, what Hegel calls bringing in the categories of finitude has its full right, as he himself has acknowledged in other places (e.g. *Phänomenol.* S. 577 f.). Why, then, censure it here and thereby prepare for the orthodox a delusive joy, for the rationalists an undeserved vexation?"

The whole metaphysical-critical-dialectical dispute for and against God's personality, whether personality is otherwise conceived trinitarianly or antitrinitarianly, is a mock fencing, for the good reason that the concept of personality in the divine sense, [324] i.e. applied to God, is not a concept of knowledge at all, but a concept of faith. On the other hand — and this always has its significance when the question is of possibility — a metaphysical concept of subjectivity or selfhood can be developed which shows that

⁴³Cf. *Philosophie der Religion*. Berlin 1840. S. 239–40.

concrete selfhood essentially consists in the totalized syllogistic unity of a threefold self⁴⁴.

β) The Revelation of Personality.

There have, as is well known, been vehement disputes over whether the Trinity was to be found in the Old Testament or not. An evident misunderstanding on both sides, both on the part of those who deny it and of those who assert it, lies at the root of these disputes. That Jehovah has revealed himself as an almighty, omniscient, holy Self, as the unity of will of knowledge and power, cannot be doubted from the standpoint of faith. On the other hand it can in equal degree be disputed whether Jehovah in the Old Testament revelation is in the proper sense of the word a *personal* God, and whether he is a *triune* God. For in the concept of God personality and trinity belong together so inwardly that the one of these categories cannot possibly be developed without the other.

It has already been shown in the doctrine of the Father's personality that the fatherly Self originally presupposes a self-doubling. In formal respect this self-doubling is so essential, belongs so ineluctably not only to the concept but even to the bare notion of a self, be it otherwise human or divine, that not a word can be said about the self, indeed that the self itself cannot say a word, without the self-doubling being [325] noticeable. "And God said: Let there be light!" Here, in this sentence, there is not merely a difference between the speaker and the word, but there is at the same time a difference in the self, a logical self-separation. In distinguishing himself from the word he speaks, the speaker becomes conscious of his speaking. But to be conscious of one's speaking is impossible without being conscious of oneself as speaking. Whom, then, is it that the speaking God addresses when he says: Let there be light! He speaks of the light, but he does not address the light; he speaks in himself to himself; but to speak to oneself is, in speaking, to double oneself, to be at once both subject and object for oneself. "And God said: Let us make man in our image, after our likeness"; in this form of speech the self-separation is clearly expressed. The orthodox Church teachers certainly missed the point of view when, relying on the plural form, they

⁴⁴Cf. "Grundrid. Logik". II. S. 344–84.

thought to see in it a revelation of the Trinity; it is of course not the plural form (*Pluralis majestatis*) but the self-separation in the speaker's inner being on which the emphasis falls. Now since the self-separation both proceeds from and returns to the unity of the self, and consequently rests on the indissoluble unity of doubling, there is undeniably shown herein a logical adumbration of the essence of the Trinity, and the spokesmen of heterodoxy are wrong in wanting to make the mode of expression an empty grammatical form, since it is incontestable that the grammatical form has its proper ground in the logical. But that there can be no question here of trinity in a concrete and personal sense is evident to such a degree that the demonstrated logical adumbration of the unity of doubling, when more closely considered, is not even sufficient to justify the doctrine of Jehovah's personality.

Personality presupposes not merely a self, but also a totality of original fundamental determinations, a richness of content, an articulated inwardness in the self. To inwardness and to a self-absorption rich in content belongs a system of inward- [326] going redoublings, a world of powers and thoughts, a world of Ideas, whose reality corresponds exactly to the reality of the self-unity's own fundamental redoubling; but of such an inwardness, such a self-absorption rich in content and unfathomable, there is no trace in the revelation of Jehovah. Inwardness, concrete inwardness rich in Ideas, is on the whole not the strong side of Judaism. If Judaism is set against paganism, then it has inwardness, elements and presuppositions of true personality; but if it is set against Christianity, then it lacks inwardness and true personality. This is easy to understand when one considers that the stage of Judaism is the stage of the Spirit, but in the form of the Law. Such stirrings of sin and repentance as give, e.g., a Davidic self inwardness and a personal unity of redoubling can throw light on the essence of Jehovah only insofar as he is the holy, law-giving Self who is angry with the sinner, punishes the sinner, but has mercy on the penitent; these stirrings, if we may so call them, on Jehovah's side are not inward-going but outward-going, since they concern not the Almighty himself but man: from this it is seen that at the stage of the revelation of the Law, the Old Testament, there can be no conditions for religious insight into the "depths" of the Godhead, or clear features of revelation *ad intra*. Jehovah is spirit, invisible, holy, almighty will; but the spirit, with all its grace,

mercy and loving-kindness, is cold, for here inwardness is lacking; the high, almighty Self reveals its will in the Law, but the will is hard and severe, it contracts into the self's arbitrary commandments and keeps the grounds of personality hidden.

In confirmation of a revelation of the Trinity, and especially of an unambiguous designation of the personality of the Son, appeal has furthermore been made to theophanies in which Jehovah and the angel of Jehovah (e.g. Exod. 13:21 and 14:19) [327] show themselves to be both the same and yet not the same: the angel is then the Son, Jehovah the Father. The truth in this is that every revelation of God presupposes an inner distinction between the one revealing himself, God in essence, and the form of revelation, God in his phenomenon; but how fleeting and formal the distinction is shines forth precisely from the way in which the two designations are interchanged.

In the New Testament God has inwardness, and consequently also personality; the Idea of this inwardness, this personality, is owed neither to Plato nor to Philo, but solely to the Word revealed in Christ. That the author of the fourth Gospel makes use of the pregnant category Logos in order to express the fundamental relation between God in himself and God in his revelation by no means entitles us to the conclusion that John has taken up either Platonic or Philonic subsidiary notions into his Gospel. On the contrary! it goes with the category *λογος* as with the categories *ζωη* and *Φως*; they are chosen because they occur in the language; but their meaning does not conform to an already given usage: the Spirit of truth breathes a new life into them, so that they undergo a rebirth. Thus we come once again to the problem of the double Logos-self, and thereby to the question of the Son's personality.

To make the solution of the problem possible we must remind ourselves beforehand of what all know and yet so easily forget: that the spirit gives life, but the letter kills. It is the principle of revelation, not the literal holding fast to the Evangelist's words, to which we have to hold. Were we to hold literally, punctiliously and grammatically to the evangelical text, we should have to deny the spirit and deify **Absurdum**. For what does the text say literally? It says that *the Word was with God*, and that *the Word* [328] *was God*; it says, therefore, that God in the beginning was with God: it says, therefore, when we put the letter in the place of the spirit, that in the beginning there were two Gods. The literal twoness comes clearly forward in the sentence: *the Word became*

flesh; for it is not the God with whom the Word was, but the Word which was with God, and so the second of the two Gods, that became flesh. If finally we make precise what is immediately literal in the sentence: the Word (the second God) became flesh, what then does it say? It does not say that the Word, God, assumed the form of flesh — such a paraphrase departs far too much from the literal and spiritless — no, it says that the Word, which was God, became flesh, so that flesh stepped into the place of God: here the literal goes together with the absurd, and the absurd together with the blasphemous. For the sake of what follows it is necessary to have brought this out sufficiently.

If we interpret the Evangelist's words in the spirit of the Gospel, then we certainly need do no violence to the text in order to reach the fundamental thought: for the fundamental thought is explained by revelation itself. In the beginning was the Word, the Word of the Creator, the Word by which all things were made: in and through this his creating Word God is eternally revealed to himself. The Creator is God, God in himself; the creating Word is God, God in his inner revelation: this is God with God, God's unity with himself in original self-redoubling. The self-unity is personal, for the opposition is spiritually real.

The spiritually real opposition in the Creator's Self is, however, different, qualitatively different, from the externally real opposition between *Creator and creature*, between *God* and *world*. Over against the outer opposition the inner one vanishes; it withdraws from contemplation, since with all its reality it is spiritual. Opposed to the manifoldly conditioned unity of connection of the actual world, God in himself is infinitely concentrated self-unity. At this stage of revelation it comes easily and naturally to the religious view to hold fast to faith in *the only true God* as Creator of the world; while all talk of God's trinitarian essence only looks like offensive speculation. [329]

But the revelation of personality has not yet been completely set forth; the Evangelist adds: "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us," and by this he points to the new revelation, namely that by which the personal God, and so God's personality, first of all becomes revealed to men. That which reveals is again the Word, the Word which was in the beginning. The Word itself has not altered its essence, but its revelation has become another. For here we must distinguish between the

revealing Word and the means by which it becomes revealing. From the standpoint of creation it is the world that is the means; from the standpoint of the incarnation it is the God-man. Religiously understood it is then clear enough that the world, the natural, actual world, stands in a quite different relation to the Word than the God-man does. The world is, according to what we have learned from creation, a nothing for the Word of omnipotence and yet an actual, existing something: this unity-in-difference is impenetrable to thought, opaque to view: the means is, in other words, externally finite, inadequate. The God-man on the other hand, the true, sinless man, is in his temporal difference from the Word essentially one with the eternal Word; the unity-in-difference of the means of revelation and revelation itself is so transparent, so intuitable, that the Word's means is the Word's form (John 1:1–2). The revealing Word in the God-man, the actual Logos-man, itself becomes revealed. In creative unity with the means the Word is life; in the transparency of the means for the Word, the Word is light. The Word therefore does not give, with the world, the great whole, as means, a more perfect revelation of God, and in the God-man with his individual limitation a less perfect one, but conversely: the revelation which the

[330] Word began in creation it completes in the incarnation. If we now remember that the talk is of the Word from the beginning, that it is the same Word which in becoming man completes what it began in creation, and that the God-man, seen in the light of revelation, is the Word, then we understand also the Evangelist's testimony: "He was in the world, and the world was made by him, and the world knew him not. He came unto his own, and his own received him not."

In making Christ, in expressions full of life, one with the Creator-Word from the beginning, the Evangelist evidently places the unity in that which reveals, *the Word*, not immediately in the existing self. It is the confusion of the unity of revelation with immediate self-unity that has occasioned the unhappy speculation that it is the second person in the Godhead, despite all the protests of orthodoxy orthodoxly understood, the second God, who, in accordance with express agreement, consultation, with the first God, has descended from heaven, has humbled himself and assumed the form of flesh. Against this absurdum the religious view sets an express opposition between *God and Christ*. Personality in Christ has for this view a quite different stamp from that of the

Creator of the world, the almighty, omnipresent God's personality. God's personality rests in its infinite self-concentration on a universal basis, Christ's personality on the other hand on an individual basis: the opposition between personality in the universal form and personality in the individual form is of decisive significance for the faith of revelation.

So then it becomes a task of the philosophy of religion to state how the personal relation between God and Christ is to be thought more precisely. It is first and last a relation of revelation: the way of cognition in this determinacy goes not from God to Christ, but from Christ to God. Only in faith in Christ's personality is it possible to [331] cognize God's personality. The revelation of the personal opposition is grounded in the personal unity; the unity of revelation is the Logos; the Logos-self therefore belongs at once both to God's and to Christ's personal self-revelation. In the Logos and by means of the Logos God is from eternity personally revealed to himself as God; in the Logos and by means of the Logos Christ is personally revealed to himself as God-man; in the Logos and by means of the Logos the personal opposition between God and Christ is expressly revealed as a personal unity; only by the Word become flesh being set in personal unity with the world-creating Word has God in his Word become reconciled with the world: "God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself" (2 Cor. 5:19). The Logos-self in God and the Logos-self in Christ is a self redoubled in itself: in this redoubling revelation is grounded; but the redoubling presupposes the principal unity: on the personal self-unity of the redoubling revelation is grounded. Thus the relation between God and Christ enters, for the view, into a new stage and presents itself as a personal relation between *the Father and the Son*. By means of the Logos-self in God, God is the Father of Jesus Christ; by means of the Logos-self in Christ, Jesus Christ is the only-begotten Son of God.

γ) The Eternal Life of Personality.

"This is life eternal, that they might know thee, the only true God, and him whom thou hast sent, Jesus Christ" (John 17:3). For the sharp separation of the eternal and the temporal, propositions are sometimes set up such as these: the eternal *is*, but does not *become*; the temporal *becomes*, but *is* not. But however much significance such

a separation may have for abstracted thinking, it is nevertheless easily seen that it
 [332] cannot hold for life; for in this way abstraction takes life away from both the eternal and the temporal. Life is just as little a being without becoming as, conversely, a becoming without being. Life is, in its peculiar being-for-itself, essentially the unity of being and becoming. If now being designates the eternal, and becoming the temporal, then it can rightly be said that life as life is the unity of the eternal and the temporal.

Even natural life has a stamp of eternity, insofar as it has a stamp of selfhood. Its development is self-development, and in the becoming of self-development it preserves, under all formations and transformations, a typically peculiar being: the temporal is that it ceaselessly changes; the eternal is that in the stream of changes it preserves the fundamental stamp of its essence unchanged. The smallest blade of grass at the foot of the mountain has, as a living organism, more eternity in it than all "the everlasting mountains" together; but it also has more eternity in it than all the streaming rivers together. That life is the unity of being and becoming means that in all its immediacy it is reflected, that its organic self-activity is an ideal-real circular motion, a motion of form bent back into persistence. To this corresponds the opposition between the inner and the outer. The plant is the outer, the life in the plant the inner; however much the inner goes together with its outer, the living opposition of inner and outer is nevertheless clearly expressed in the fact that the outer, in nourishment, growth and formation, is constantly determined by the inner. Life moves from itself through its other back into itself, from its inner through its outer back into its inner: it is an image of eternity. The determining inner lies in the germ as a peculiar disposition; life consists in the actual unfolding of the disposition, but the unfolding is as a self-revelation: it is the essence of life that the eternal wills to reveal itself in the temporal.

Now just as temporal life already has something eternal in it, so eternal life too
 [333] originally has something temporal in it. It belongs to the life of the spirit as much as to the life of nature to move through oppositions. The richer and deeper the life of the spirit is, the freer is its inwardness; but the freer the inwardness is, the greater the significance it is able to give to its corresponding outer. If the free inner were indifferent to its outer, if eternal life had nothing whatever to do with temporality,

then the relation between God and the world would make no sense. It is indeed not God who is dependent on the world, but the world that is absolutely dependent on God; nonetheless God, by creating the world, has brought forth temporality, just as he also, by preserving the world, bears temporality and, by governing the world, works in temporality. But that the Eternal himself brings forth the temporal, bears temporality and works in the temporal, is surely an eloquent testimony that eternal life must have something to do with the temporal.

It is, says religion, not out of necessity but out of goodness and love, and so with full freedom, that God has created the world. What does this mean other than that freedom, goodness and love, which belong to God's eternal life, entail precisely that eternal life wills to move through the temporal? Now since God's freedom, goodness and love are one with his personality, we can understand from this that it must belong to God's personal life to impart life to the world. It is a fact that temporal life arises in time on natural conditions; but it is none the less untrue that any life whatsoever could be derived from any temporal composition whatsoever; the least germ of life is of eternal origin: all life in the world is from God. Nor can any temporal life be annihilated by anything temporal whatsoever; it can be developed in temporality, on temporal terms, but — it follows incontrovertibly from the law of selfhood⁴⁵ — [334] when its self-development is ended, it returns, enriched with the inner result of its development, to its source, to eternity, to God, whence it came.

And yet there is a difference, a qualitative difference, between a temporal and an eternal life, as surely as there is a difference, an infinite qualitative difference, between God's life and the world's life, a qualitative difference between life in God and life in the world. The eternity of life rests on its essential selfhood. The lower selfhood stands, the more corruptible is life; the higher selfhood stands, the more it approaches the incorruptible. In personal life selfhood is a self conscious of itself, determining itself: the more personal life is, the more clearly eternity shines through.

To become conscious of one's personal life and to become conscious of one's eternal life are at bottom one and the same. But to become in truth conscious of one's personal life is possible only in faith; for it is possible only by becoming conscious

⁴⁵Cf. *Forelæsninger over phil. Propædeut.* 1860–61.

of the personality of the revealed God. To know eternal life is to know the only true God; but life can only be known by life; to know God's life is to live in God, from God; but to live in God is to live from God's revelation. Revelation is life; God himself lives only in his revelation. Therefore it belongs not merely to a higher development of life, a clearer conception of the eternity of life, but it is life itself, eternal life, to know the revealed God, to know him personally in him whom he sent, Jesus Christ.

[335] So long, however, as it is still only a matter of personality, life and revelation in general, the consideration can easily move through crossings of thoughts of faith and of knowledge with so hovering a gait that it almost looks as if the opposition of faith and knowledge were here soared over. This holds, however, only so long as one speaks generally about the general. As soon as the problem, the problem to whose solution the introductory remarks point, is drawn forth and held fast sharply, the crisis too sets in. For the problem is this: *how is the eternal life of personality in the Son's relation to the Father essentially to be thought?* When this question is set in motion, faith and knowledge arm themselves anew for battle. Even if in knowledge one begins ever so piously with the presuppositions of faith, the method corresponding to the grounding must nevertheless necessarily bring with it consequences that deny faith. We see it already in Jacob Böhme. The struggle of the powers of life in the divine essence, that wondrous tension and stir of the elements of spirit through which the eternal life of the all-personality must work its way up from darkness to light, so that "God's hidden will, which in itself is only one, may become revealed," was indeed precisely the object of the profound theosophist's wildly fermenting speculations. From him stems the Idea of a becoming God; only a becoming God is a living God. Eternal being is in this life of God so absorbed into temporal becoming that the eternal itself becomes principle and possibility, but never full actuality: the becoming God is never finished. On the Böhmean foundation Schelling worked further and attempted to develop God's personal unity out of an originally presupposed twoness. His words against Jacobi are well known: "So long as no actual twoness is cognized in God, and so long as no limiting, negating power is opposed to the affirming one, so long will the denial of a personal God be scientific honesty." But even from the dawning light of Schelling's "primal ground" the Godhead's way to perfect self-revelation is infinitely long: the

becoming God is never finished.

Now if God as God, because of the infinite becoming of his life, can never be [336] finished with the formation of the person of the Father, then the one who knows in faith has still one way out left, namely: to give up the fatherly personality, personality on the universal basis, to let God as God sink down into the indeterminable unity of the substantially absolute, in order then to hold fast to personality on the individual basis, the true personality in the person of Christ. As representative of this peculiar way of seeing we name Schleiermacher. Schleiermacher's "Son of God" is a son without a father, a fatherless son, so to speak, in the divine sense; in the human sense he has on the other hand, as a kind of compensation for the want of the heavenly one, received an earthly father. What is contradictory in Schleiermacher is that he wishes, within science, to free religion from science. Schleiermacher has very rightly seen that "the ecclesiastical formulas concerning the person of Christ⁴⁶ might need a critical treatment." He acutely draws attention to the impropriety of designating "the Redeemer's divine nature from eternity, before its union with the human, in such a way that this union does not appear at all as a moment co-constitutive of the person Jesus Christ, but much rather merely as an act of this person himself." How little the Schleiermacherian Christology, despite the critical fineness and dialectical sharpness with which it is carried through, has however been able to withstand "the daily swelling stream and storms of critique" can be seen in Strauss; how little it, with its otherwise unmistakable religious merits, satisfies the ecclesiastical view can be seen from utterances such as this: "Since Schleiermacher proceeds from the opposition between sin and redemption, he conceives the Redeemer as the second Adam, the perfected creation of human nature, and cognizes his God-consciousness as [337] the expression of the actual presence of the Godhead in him, sees him as exemplary for all times and generations, as the head of a new communal life that continually receives of his fullness. But the defects of this Christology may be referred to two main points, to the divine side and to the worldly side of Christ's existence. As regards the divine side, the concept of the Son's *pre-existence* is lacking here, and with it also the concept of a descending revelation of love of the eternal Logos. It is only the impersonal

⁴⁶Der christl. Glaub. II. Bd. S. 49.

Godhead that in Christ attains personality. As regards the worldly side of Christ's existence, this Christ has only religious and ethical, but not cosmic significance; he stands indeed as the perfected creation of human nature, but not as the conclusion of *all creation*, and the biblical passages which declare that all principalities and powers and forces are subject to him must be content with a merely moral interpretation."⁴⁷

This, in outline, is the result of the objectively scientific movement of thought. We shall now try, from the standpoint of faith, how far it is possible, by means of the inverted grounding of the philosophy of religion, to approach the fundamental view of the Church.

It must then once more be insisted that science knows nothing and can know nothing of God's personality, since this concept lacks every scientific foundation. Since here, as regards the cognition of personality, one begins in faith, one begins here unconditionally with Christ as the object of faith; thus not immediately with the universal personality, but with the personal individuality of the God-man. Were the objective consideration of science really to be carried through here, then, according to [338] what we have shown in the foregoing, the knower would have to think he discovered two Sons of God, one in heaven and one on earth. So we should then have not three but four Persons in the Godhead: 1) the Father, 2) the eternal Son, by whom the world is created, 3) the Son of Man, born of the Virgin, and 4) the Holy Spirit: a confusing sight! Whence comes the confusion? From an optical illusion! The knower of faith sees double, much as one speaks of a drunken man seeing double. The knower of faith looks at one and the same time into two absolutely heterogeneous mirrors, that of reason and that of faith, that of metaphysics and that of revelation; thereby the image of the one Son becomes two images: the image of the eternal Son, the universal personality, appears in the mirror of metaphysics, while the image of the Son of Man, the individual personality in flesh and blood, is beheld in that of revelation. To remove the optical illusion we must get rid of the metaphysical mirror, or at least see to having it placed in such a way that no more than one image can possibly appear.

The image that is seen in the mirror of revelation is Christ's individuality with the pure, holy features of the God-man. How this personal individuality, which came

⁴⁷H. Martensen. Den christl. Dgmt. S. 277–78.

to be in time, is related to the eternal universal personality, exalted above temporal becoming, is then the question. Is the Son who appeared in time perhaps the eternal Son's representative or deputy among men, *vicarius filii æterni*, much as the Pope is *vicarius Christi* for the Catholics? By no means! For an individual or a society of individuals an individual can be a deputy; but the eternal Son is no more an individual than the eternal Father: the eternal Son is one with the Father in universal personality. But a universal personality has no deputy and can have none. Instead of being conceived as deputy for the Eternal, the Son of Man in time must be conceived as the Eternal's Revealer. This gives an entirely different view. The deputy always [339] stands in an external, finite relation to the one or ones he represents; but the Revealer is one in being and will, in life and personality, with the one he reveals. When Christ remembers his pre-existence, he knows himself to reveal the eternal Son; but in his revealing of the Son he does not represent the Son, but is the Son, the Son who reveals the Father.

The eternal Son, the Logos-Self in God, is God's invisible Self-revealer *ad intra*; but the Son of Man, the Logos-Self become man in time, is God's visible Self-revealer *ad extra*. Whence, now, do we know the revelation *ad intra*? Solely and only from the revelation *ad extra*! How do we know that the revelation *ad intra* is a revelation of personality? We do not know it; but we cognize it in faith, thus solely by virtue of the revelation *ad extra*. Faith, with its antirational aim, sees the inner revelation only through the outer, sees the eternal Logos only through the Logos become man, the universal personality only through the individual. Therefore the eye of faith cannot possibly get two images, one of the eternal Son, another of the Son revealed in time. Between God and the Word, between the One who is revealed and the One who reveals, i.e. between the Father and the Son, there forms a religious, personal opposition, an opposition of revelation for time and eternity; but between the eternal Son, the Father's Revealer *ad intra*, and the Son of Man, the Revealer *ad extra*, no religious, personal opposition can possibly form. The inward-going and the outward-going revelation cannot be set up side by side in such a way that an actual separation of two revelations appears here; for the same reason, neither can any personal separation appear between the Revealer *ad extra* — the Word that became flesh — and the Revealer *ad intra* — the

[340] Word from the beginning — the Word *ad intra* and the Word *ad extra* are, in the sense of revelation, the same Word: the two Revealers are in personal working one and the same.

But what, then, does the doubling signify? It signifies that the individual personality, which passes through temporal development, has its origin from the universal personality living in eternal being and working. The self-doubling signifies that the eternal Revealer has in the fullness of time doubled himself. The Son of Man comes in addition, that is true; but he does not come in addition as a finite helper; he grows forth from the Logos-seed, his life in temporality is a personal continuation of the Logos-life from eternity; he does not go forth from the Logos, for his personal Self is indeed precisely the Logos-Self become man; but he goes forth from the Father. Then he completes his life in temporality and returns to his source; but he does not return to the Logos; the visible Son does not return to the invisible; in the light of revelation they are, after all, both one essence, one life, one will; but he returns to the Father, for it is the Father, the Invisible, whom he has revealed to the world. — “I came forth (John 16:28) from the Father and came into the world; again I leave the world and go to the Father.”

B.

The Works of the Son.

§ 22.

That the Visible reveals the Invisible, that the Son reveals the Father, is recognizable in the essence of the Son; but now the Son's essence doubles itself in such a way that [341] the Visible too is in itself invisible, that the Son can reveal the Father only by revealing himself in words and works. This doubling follows directly from the double-sided nature of individual personality itself. In personal life there is not merely an opposition of inner and outer; but on account of free inwardness the separation is at the same time so thoroughgoing that the outer, individuality in its phenomenal immediacy, can just as well be said to conceal as to speak for and explain the inner. The richer, clearer and freer the inwardness, the more significant the opposition. In the God-man, whose

human exterior at one and the same time both conceals and reveals the divine interior, the opposition is at its extreme: it is this opposition of essence and phenomenon, of the glory of the Godhead and the form of a servant, strained to the utmost and thereby straining, that categorically makes the Son of Man a sign of contradiction.

The point of view for the sign of contradiction is, however, a double one, since it is to correspond most immediately either to the life of faith or to the thought of faith, either to religious existence or to the conceptual development of the philosophy of religion: these two points of view must not be confused.

From the side of existence and in “the situation of contemporaneity” S. Kierkegaard has, with edifying emphasis, set the sign of contradiction in relation to “the possibility of offense,” and has treated in particular: 1) “the possibility of offense that does not relate itself to Christ as Christ (the God-Man), but to him as a simple, individual human being who collides with an established order”; 2) “the essential possibility of offense in the direction of loftiness, that an individual human being speaks or acts as if he were God, declares himself to be God, thus in the direction of the determination God in the composite God-Man,” and 3) “the essential possibility of offense in the direction of lowliness, that the one who gives himself out to be God shows himself to be the lowly, poor, suffering, and finally powerless human being.”⁴⁸ By thus making clear what is categorically posited in the sign of contradiction, the author shows that a scientific conception of what the God-man is, a direct historical knowledge of Christ, is a contradiction, a sheer impossibility, — that, in other words, all immediate historical faith in the sacred history is superstition — and in this we must unconditionally grant that he is right. “The God-Man is the sign of contradiction, and why? Because, Scripture answers, he was to reveal the thoughts of hearts. Does, then, all the modern talk about the speculative unity of God and man, all that which merely regards Christianity as a doctrine: does it bear the remotest resemblance to the Christian? No ... The God-Man is an individual human being — not a fantastic unity which has never existed except *sub specie æterni*; and he is anything but a lecturer who teaches directly for rote-learners or dictates paragraphs for stenographers; he does just the opposite, he reveals the thoughts of hearts. ... And only the sign of contradiction can [342]

⁴⁸Indøvelse i Christendom af Anti-Climacus. Kbhvn. 1855. S. 93 flgd.

do that: it draws attention to itself, and then it presents a contradiction. There is a something which makes it impossible not to look — and lo, in looking one sees as in a mirror, one comes to see oneself, or he who is the sign of contradiction sees straight into one's heart as one stares into the contradiction."

But the sign of contradiction is not for that reason in itself a contradiction; the improbable must be believed, but the impossible cannot be believed: the philosophy of religion has the task of developing the principle of faith and freeing the concepts from every semblance of contradiction. Here, then, an express distinction must be [343] made between the contradictions that naturally accompany the phenomenon, and the contradictions which, both from the side of the dialectic of paradox and from that of the critique of knowledge, are alleged to lie in the essence. Perhaps on this occasion it might occur to verbal critique to come forward with an objection such as this: "It is granted that there are contradictions in the phenomenon; but since the phenomenon is nothing other than the essence's own appearing, the contradictions of the phenomenon are precisely appearances of the contradictions hidden in the essence itself; the essence is thus in itself just as contradictory as the phenomenon, and the *absurdum* which one means to avoid by shifting the contradictions onto the phenomenon is by no means removed." To see how matters stand with this sort of fine critique, we need only take note of a concept such as, for example, misrecognition. Misrecognition is a contradiction in the phenomenon; a contradiction in the phenomenon is at the same time a contradiction in the essence. The contradictory is an absurdum, something impossible in itself; *ergo*: misrecognition is impossible. — There is a metaphysical fineness in thinking which comes about through the thinker's avoiding touching the problems, and it recalls that fineness of tone which was conjured up by the virtuoso's bow not touching the strings at all.

The works of the Son, the divine-human acts in which Christ has revealed his personal essence to the world, may, from the standpoint of the philosophy of religion, be comprehended under the three categories: *the Fulfillment of the Law*, *the Atonement*, and *the Redemption*.

a) The Fulfillment of the Law.

§ 23.

Christ's relation to the Law is double-sided. As the Son of Man, born of a woman, he is born under the Law and "made subject to the Law"; as the Son of God he is exalted above the Law, is Lord not merely of the Sabbath but of the Law, himself [344] Lawgiver. The double-sidedness shows itself also in this, that he both confirms and abolishes, both fulfills and sublates the Law. The one does not stand in conflict with the other: the contradiction is only apparent. Christ is not under the Law in spite of being above the Law, but he is above it just because he is under it; he does not abolish the Law in spite of confirming it, but he abolishes it by confirming it, he sublates it by fulfilling it. To see more closely how matters stand in this regard, we then seek an elucidation of *the Spirit of the Law*, of *the Law of the Gospel*, of *the End of the Law*.

α) **The Spirit of the Law.**

How Judaism in Christ's time had become an external, spiritless affair, an established order which, following the direction of the Pharisees and the scribes, held to a hair-splitting interpretation of the letter of the Law, to traditions and arbitrary ordinances, and in this spiritlessness deified itself, is well known. That Christ's appearance is marked from the beginning by a break with this established order is likewise well known, and has, in our time especially, been brought home with convincing force and clarity by S. Kierkegaard. That it now matters not only that there is a break with a spiritless established order, and that the break is decisive, but that it also matters how the break is made, in what spirit the break takes place, every thoughtful person must grant. Among the works in which Christ has revealed the divine-human essence of his personality belongs, then, this one too: that he has taught us how, in spirit and in truth, one is to break with an established order that defiantly claims to have the laws on its side. "Think not that I am come to dissolve the Law or the Prophets: I am not come to dissolve, but to fulfill. For verily I say unto you: till heaven and earth pass away, not even the least letter or one tittle shall pass from the Law, till [345] all be fulfilled" (Matt. 5:17–18). It is a quite peculiar beginning. Christ knows within himself that what is at stake is a struggle of life and death with an externality that has

on its side not merely actuality, with the venerability of what is inherited, but also the semblance of upholding the religious-moral order instituted by God himself, by holding to the forms and enforcing the laws; he knows that this external, seemingly godly affair is an ungodly deceit, that against this deceit, as ungodly as it is official, there must take place a revolution that leaves not one stone upon another of the old building: for that, precisely for that reason, he begins by insisting on the validity of the Law. In breaking outwardly with the established order, he breaks at the same time inwardly with everything that in any way resembles willfulness, arbitrariness, lawlessness; and he makes this break so abruptly, so thoroughly, that no one who wishes to emancipate himself from the commandments of the Law shall find support in him. "Whosoever therefore shall break one of these least commandments, and shall teach men so, he shall be called the least in the kingdom of heaven: but whosoever shall do and teach them, shall be called great in the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 5:19). It is thus not in order to sublate, but in order to enforce the Law, that he breaks with what the established order understands by the Law.

But what, then, does Christ understand by the Law and the commandments of the Law? We hear it from his words. It is precisely the remarkable thing about the way in which he interprets the Law in the Sermon on the Mount, that he places its essence neither in the disposition of mind alone nor in the commandment alone, but in that union of commandment and disposition which shows precisely that obedience must always be the essential foundation of religious inwardness. "Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time: Thou shalt not kill, and whosoever shall kill shall be in danger [346] of the judgment" (Matt. 5:21). Had Christ now placed the essence of the Law in the disposition alone, he would surely have said: we do not need this commandment; for it is the essence of the self, the innermost longing of the soul, to love righteousness and in the spirit of righteousness to love one's neighbor as oneself. But instead of abolishing the old commandment, he adds new commandments, commandments so severe that not even a Draco himself, who wrote in blood, could write them so severe: "Whosoever shall say to his brother, Raca, shall be in danger of the council: but whosoever shall say, Thou fool, shall be in danger of hell fire" (Matt. 5:22). To take this in all indefiniteness as ideal demands is just as spiritless as to cling pettily to the words Raca and fool.

What is characteristic is that the ideal demand attaches to definite commandments, commandments which, in expressly aiming at the disposition, attack the selfish point by point, keep account of the individual feelings, thoughts and actions, and precisely thereby, as true commandments of inwardness, bring about a thoroughgoing working over of the actual interior. To hold to the disposition alone is, in all indefiniteness, to hold to the universal, and precisely thereby to grant to contingencies, to the contingent mood, the contingent notion, the contingent word, an all too arbitrary latitude. But to lose oneself in a swarm of commandments of inwardness, an ascetic anatomizing of the inward particulars in the psychic fibers of every entanglement, would lead not merely to spiritless mechanism but to endless self-torment, to scrupulosity and despair. Therefore Christ too, through his commandments of inwardness, lays emphasis first and last on the disposition; on mercy: Blessed are the merciful; on peaceableness: Blessed are the peacemakers; on purity of heart: Blessed are the pure in heart. The commandments of inwardness, which serve to cleanse the mind, are sunk into the ground of the mind in order to surface again when self-examination begins. The Law is the universal essentiality of inwardness, of the inwardness that is thoroughly purified through religious obedience to the ideal demands of the commandments; as a [347] reflected, active unity of commandment and essentiality that moves the will, the Law is spirit.

From the spirit of the Law the judgment upon the established order must be derived. What matters then first and foremost is in what character the established order is held; for there is a difference, a qualitative difference, between a spiritual and a worldly, between a religious and a civil established order. And as there is a difference between established order and established order, so there is also a difference between law and law. The political-civil established order is not merely something external, but has by its nature also a relatively original right to be something external, to maintain itself as something external, and to defend itself against attack by external means. The laws on which such an external established order grounds its right are then not pure laws of inwardness either, but on the contrary laws of fact, laws of compulsion, laws of right, not in the proper sense laws of righteousness. With an established order of this nature, a political-civil established order, Christ, properly speaking, will have nothing

to do; he will neither tear it down nor build it up nor improve it; he is personally independent, absolutely independent of it, of every finite regard, even the faintest side-regard to it. As his independence of it is absolute, so too his dependence on it, his submission and obedience, is in a certain way unconditional, insofar as he does not set himself up in outward resistance, offers no physical resistance at all, stands in league with no outward-going selfish striving whatsoever. No rebel against the civil established order can use his name; but let us then, for truth's sake, not forget either that no defender of a political-civil established order can use his name.

[348] The established order against which Christ turns with his whole personal authority and the strongest expressions of holy wrath is a religious, ecclesiastical established order, which, after the ideal demands of the divine Law have long been forgotten, has transformed the law of righteousness into an external positive law of right, the original, incorruptible right of religion, of the disposition, of the inwardness of faith, into a juridical church law. It is for the Law's sake, in the spirit of the Law, that he breaks with this established order; it is in the name of righteousness that he attacks the pharisaic right. "For" — this For refers expressly to the admonition not to "break one of the least commandments of the Law" and "teach men so" — "I say unto you: except your righteousness exceed that of the scribes and Pharisees, ye shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven," (Matt. 5:20). Were positive church law to be made to prevail, then Christ would simply be in the wrong, and the Pharisees, with all juridical formalities, would easily get him condemned as a transgressor of the law; but the fact is that Christ does not know and will not know any positive juridical church law whatsoever, because he does not recognize and will not recognize any form whatsoever of externality as entitled, by laws of compulsion, to set a limit to the law of inwardness. Does Christ, then, condemn positive juridical right? By no means! Take away the religious motives and put civil ones in their place: and surely no objection will be derivable from Christ's gospel against a civil ordering of external ecclesiastical affairs. Christ does not break the external bonds without giving full compensation by strengthening the internal ones. To loosen all external bonds without the least guarantee that the internal ones become the firmer — whether this happens under one pretext or another, whether it happens by open rebellion or by crooked juridical

detours — is to violate the spirit of the Law and give society over as a prey to unbridled willfulness. When Christ, in the name of the Law, holds judgment over the arbitrary external, he aims at the same time sharply at the self-seeking internal. “Ye have heard that it hath been said: An eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth. But I say unto you, [349] that ye resist not evil: but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also. And if any man will sue thee at the law, and take away thy coat, let him have thy cloak also” (Matt. 5:39–40). This, then, is a piece of Christ’s church law; for the establishment of good order it is quite as strict as the strictly juridical one.

β) The Law of the Gospel.

The Lutheran orthodox, and on the whole the old Protestant, doctrine of the Church has made a sharp separation between law and gospel. Agricola’s antinomian zeal against the preaching of the Law to “the regenerate” provoked a polemic that was in several respects unclear, and that at last found its clarification in the Formula of Concord. For the sake of an overview we cite Hase’s concise presentation⁴⁹. “*Verbum divinum absolvitur Lege et Evangelio. 1) Lex est summa eorum, quæ Deus facere jussit hominem, additis minis in legis transgressores.* This moral law comprises both the law revealed in the Old and the New Testament and the natural law as well. The old ecclesiastical dogmaticians therefore treat *natural law* as a general, if imperfect, moral law, and *the moral law* as the eternally valid part of the Mosaic Law, whose *summa* is contained in the *Decalogus*. This conditional recognition of natural law is more correct than the restriction of the moral law to the Mosaic Law, for only through the New Testament has the moral law, with its highest spiritual demands, and in original sin the whole depth of our misery of sin, become manifest. *Legis usus est triplex: a) politicus s. civilis, quatenus externo hominum timore externam quandam disciplinam retinet; b) elencticus s. pædagogicus, quatenus interno Dei terrore ad miseriam agnoscendam [350] fidemque impetrandam peccatorem ducit; c) didacticus, normativus s. tertius, quatenus docendo renatorum vitam regit; 2) Evangelium est doctrina de venia peccatorum per Christum obtinenda.* Accordingly, the Protevangelium, all the messianic prophecies, and the types also belong to the Gospel.”

⁴⁹ Hutterus Redivivus. Leipzig 1836. S. 302–305.

It is, however, a large question how far this separation essentially furthers the cognition either of the Law or of the Gospel. It always looks as though law and gospel fell outside each other, as though there were something in the Law that did not concern the Gospel, and conversely. Without regard to the Gospel, both “natural law” and “the moral law” can no doubt assert their significance in political and civil respects; but no law that does not by its nature fall within the Gospel’s own field of vision, and so make up an integral element of the evangelical conditions of life, will be able either “pedagogically” to prepare faith in the Gospel or “didactically” to regulate the life of believers. One praises the division’s “purely practical significance,” while yet in the same breath demanding that “law and gospel must always go together in life⁵⁰, since the Law alone would preach despair, the Gospel alone levity”; but if law and gospel cannot at any point in actual life do without each other, then this is surely a sign that both must necessarily be referred to the same principle. If the forgiveness of sins cannot be separated from the cognition of sins, then neither can the cognition of sins [351] be separated from the cognition of the Law. Instead of speaking of the Law and the Gospel, we would then rather speak of the Law in the Gospel, of *the Law of the Gospel*.

When one of the Pharisees, a lawyer, asked Jesus, saying, Master, which is the great commandment in the Law? the answer ran as follows: “Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it: Thou shalt love thy neighbor as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the Law and the Prophets” (Matt. 22:35–40; Luke 10:27; Mark 12:29). If we now compare with this what is already said in the Sermon on the Mount: “Think not that I am come to destroy the Law or the Prophets; I am not come to destroy, but to fulfill!” how then could we be in doubt that Christ wants the Law included in his Gospel, that there is in truth a law of the Gospel? It now depends merely on understanding this unity of law and gospel, for the misunderstandings are manifold and go in different directions.

The principle of the Gospel is a principle of will just as much as that of the Law. The fundamental error is that, instead of developing the religious concepts from their

⁵⁰ *Lex et Evangelium in praxi quovis puncto mathematico sunt conjunctiora. Confluunt enim ad poenitentiam peccatoris, ad renovationem hominis justificati, ad conservationem hominis renovati in perseverantia pietatis. Hollatius.*

own principle, one has had the doctrine of will transformed into an objective doctrine. From an objective standpoint every decisive, determinate act of will, be it divine or human, must necessarily take on the stamp of arbitrariness. The law revealed by God bears, as we have seen, in its individual commandments the marks of arbitrariness. God simply demands so much of a human being, neither more nor less; he could have demanded more, he could have restricted the demands to less: such things rest on an omnipotent good pleasure about which there can be no reasoning. This is a view as external as it is objective; and when one then tries by the objective route to penetrate into the divine grounds of will, the matter does not become better but [352] worse: the contradiction is that one reasons about that about which there can be no reasoning. It is the very same with what, according to the orthodox doctrine, is to be the exclusive distinguishing mark of the Gospel, namely the forgiveness of sins through Christ. The forgiveness of sins is, objectively seen, an arbitrary act of grace; God promises a human being the forgiveness of sins on condition of faith. Why the merciful God has prescribed just faith alone, faith in the merit of Jesus Christ, excluding every regard to other possible conditions—about that there can really be no reasoning from an objective standpoint. And yet the objective doctrine consists precisely in all manner of reasonings going back and forth, thus in a reasoning about that about which there can be no reasoning. Once both law and gospel have in this way, each by itself, been made the object of external consideration, what wonder, then, that they are set up externally against each other? Indeed, the doctrine of objectivity has had so bungling an effect that even the dialectic of paradox, which after all aims so expressly at abolishing all objective externality, has retained a questionable residue of indigestible objectivity, and thus of externality. For what is the paradoxical, the absurd? It is surely precisely that which consciousness comes up against as against something foreign, something incomprehensible, something indissoluble, thus something objective, external to thought, about which there can be no reasoning. The forgiveness of sins, it is said, is a paradox; what does that mean? It means that the forgiveness of sins is an act of grace, incomprehensible in itself and arbitrary, which can take place or fail to take place, just as God wills.

From the standpoint of faith, that is, of the principle of will itself, the matter looks

otherwise. The objectivity here is not that of knowledge, but the objectivity proper to faith and thereby to revelation, thus an objectivity in which the cognition of God, as much with regard to the Law as to the Gospel, corresponds point for point to self-cognition, and conversely. There can, then, be conceived no divine law for the human self that does not originally correspond to the inner, true nature of the human self. "Sin is that which is against the Law," that is, sin is the deepest self-contradiction, strife against God's holy will and thereby strife against one's own fundamental will. The law that bids man love God with all his heart, with all his soul, and with all his mind is no arbitrary commandment. Just as little as any ground of necessity is conceivable which, if we may express ourselves freely, should have driven God to reveal this law of his free love to the human being darkened by sin, just so little can any ground of freedom be conceived that could move God to abolish this law and without it make man blessed.

In the law of love necessity is freedom, freedom necessity, but—be it noted—in the form of freedom, not in the form of necessity. To love God above all things is in truth to love oneself. Only self-love purified in love to God can furnish the ideal measure for love to one's neighbor, and the first great commandment grounds the second. For the second is like the first. It is therefore also inconceivable that God should be able by an arbitrary act of will to abolish the second. He who sins against the one of the two commandments sins against both. That man nevertheless sins against both commandments thus makes known that man as man is a sinner before God, that the human self, in other words, is in self-contradiction. So man stands unconditionally in need of the forgiveness of sins. If God could now forgive transgression of the law of love in a manner corresponding to that in which a king who has an unlimited right of pardon can forgive any transgression whatsoever of any civil law whatsoever, then the forgiveness of sins, as an arbitrary act of will, could rightly be said to be paradoxical. But that is impossible. Contradiction of the Law is essentially self-contradiction; the forgiveness of sins, the act of grace by which sin is lifted, must therefore be an act of grace by which self-contradiction is lifted; but self-contradiction can only be lifted by the Law's being fulfilled; the forgiveness of sins thus cannot possibly consist in man's being in one way or another exempted from the Law, but must consist in his being

enabled, by an express act of grace, to fulfill the Law.

γ) The End of the Law.

“Christ is the end of the Law” (Rom. 10:4); in this lies both that he fulfills the Law and that he makes an end of the Law, both by himself being the Law’s end and goal. For the holy, divine-human Self the Law does not exist in abstract universality; the law of love, as a determination of essence, is taken up into living love: so the Law gains form in Christ’s personality. In doing the Law full justice, Christ does justice to himself; he fulfills the Law, that is, he fills its empty forms with personal content; he breathes movement and life into the dead features, he gives the cold silhouettes light and color. That Christ is nevertheless said to be under the Law, to obey the Law, is understood from the fact that his life on earth is in voluntary humiliation, in suffering and self-sacrifice. Thus he has the Law not only within him but also above him, just as he has the Father’s will not only within him but also above him. In this sense too he is religion itself, the relation to God existing personally, in that he has his absolute freedom in absolute obedience; his self-revelation is a thoroughgoing revelation of obedience: “he learned obedience by the things which he suffered.” When the evangelical doctrine of faith has made a sharp separation between Christ’s active and passive obedience (*obedientia activa* and *ob. passiva*), this is again an indication of scholastic externality; for obedience, as voluntary submission, is the categorical unity [355] of suffering and acting. A patience in pure suffering without inner self-activity is not a revelation of freedom, but an unfree condition without significance for spirit. On this very thing rests the inner infinity of the will, the divine as well as the human, the omnipotent as well as the impotent will: that in inward-going self-activity it can lift its outward-going activity and transform its acting into suffering; that is why religion speaks not only of Christ’s patience but also of God’s long-suffering. “No activity of Christ can be conceived in which, owing to the sin of the world, there is not also a suffering; his Passion history does not begin only in Gethsemane, for his whole life of obedience is a history of suffering; but on the other hand no suffering in Christ can be conceived that is not activity, that is not according to its innermost significance

a holy work of freedom; for his whole life of obedience is a striving and victorious history of freedom”⁵¹.

The fulfillment of the Law is at the same time its sublation. It goes with the Law in this respect as with possibility. Real possibility requires conditions in order to pass over into actuality; it lies in its essence that it demands its actualization. But when the possibility is actualized, it has thereby vanished; actuality has taken its place: the satisfaction of possibility is its sublation. In like manner with the Law. The Law, the pure law, is with all its ideal necessity not full actuality; for if it were full actuality, it would be sufficient unto itself, and could to that extent contain no demand. That it demands something means that it lacks something for the completion of its essence; [356] that it lacks something in itself means that, precisely with regard to what it lacks, it is a possibility, not an actuality. In being fulfilled, the Law takes up the rich sum of moments of personality in which it has its fullness, and ceases to have existence for itself as law. The Law does not in actuality exist outside or alongside its fulfillment; its true, full existence is its sublation. It is not the Law that by its fulfillment consumes life; it is conversely life that takes up and digests the Law, reduces it to a moment, and causes it to vanish as law. Just because Christ is the only one who has been able to fulfill the Law, he is also the only one who has been able to sublate the Law.

Because the fulfillment of the Law is its sublation, Christ can be Lord of the Law by being its servant. The old dogmatic assertion that Christ, as Lord of the Law (*dominus legis*), was just as little obliged to fulfill the Law (*legi subjectus*) as to suffer and die, is perverse and rests on an external, finite separation of what he has done for his own sake and for our sake. What holds of his life holds also of his fulfillment of the Law: he has lived on earth for our sake; but from this it by no means follows that he has not lived for his own sake. With regard to the relation of his will to the commandments of the Law, it is on the other hand true that in Christ’s fulfillment of the Law there can be no talk of duty and obligation. Concepts such as duty and obligation gain particular significance only where a commanding law has a natural self-seeking love as its opposite. The obligated subjectivity then, on this presupposition, feels itself at strife with itself and can only fulfill its duty by subduing its lower nature. Such a self-overcoming, resulting

⁵¹H. Martensen. *Den christl. Dogmt.* S. 314–15.

from inner, finite strife, the God-man does not know. The holy, strong will of the Logos is, in its self-denying, suffering activity, raised above finite strife with flesh [357] and blood. It does indeed have in sensuous immediacy, in pain and suffering, a limit that it must ceaselessly overcome, a resistance that it must combat in every moment; but this inner, ceaselessly continuing strife is infinitely far from being a strife of subjectivity with itself; it is on the contrary an expression of the fact that the striving will is, in infinite energy, absolutely at one with itself. Through the unconditional self-overcoming that holds for the continuity of all individual utterances of will, the personal fundamental will has in absolute obedience won itself so unconditionally that the continued self-overcoming is transformed into a self-satisfaction continuing in itself; which is to say, in other words, that unconditional obedience is a revelation of an unconditional freedom. Christ has not, out of pure pity for us poor sinful human beings, once for all, so to speak, done violence to himself and made life hard for himself and fulfilled the Law in our stead, so that we might at last, once for all, be rid of the hard, confounded Law and come to live in pure heartiness, from the overflowing good nature of an immediate love: this misunderstanding is obvious. It is as much out of love for the Law as out of love for human beings that Christ has fulfilled the law of love; for the law of love is eternally one with the Father's will. Love is the fulfilling of the Law; therefore Christ is the end of the Law.

Instead of beginning with the Law, the believer must therefore begin with Christ, with the appropriation of Christ's fulfillment of the Law; in this sense it can truly be said that Christ has fulfilled the Law for our sake, in our stead. But that the believer, by appropriating the fulfillment of the Law, should be able to become exempt from fulfilling the Law is a monstrous contradiction. We see it in the relation between *love* and *fear*, between *faith* and *works*.

To begin with the Law is to begin with fear. Now it is no doubt true, what preachers [358] of repentance and shakers of hearts have often enjoined with strong pathos, that a person's conversion must begin with horror at sin, with terror before the judgment of God's wrath; but it still depends on what kind of terror it is, and by what means the cognition of sin is awakened. To begin with the thunder of the Law is just as sensuous as to begin with the fire of hell and the lake of brimstone. In the thunder of

the Law only the command of omnipotence is heard; such thunder does not awaken the fear of God; it awakens only fright before the Almighty; that may work on the rude mob, but the questionable thing is that a person whose fear of God begins with fright in the blood begins with a hidden admixture of superstition that he will get over late or never. In vain is love presented to him in the image of the Crucified; he does not see love, cannot discover its essence; for he has it in the blood, and sees in the blood—nothing but sacrificial blood, the blood of expiation that the angry God has demanded. It holds of love that it casts out fear; but it does not hold of fear, the fear that oppresses the senses of the soul, that it drives love in. To begin with love is to begin with Christ, is to begin not outside the Law but inside the Law, with the fulfillment of the Law, with the law of the Spirit, with the self's eternal, ideal demand.

Yet the law of the Spirit too can be conceived in so glaringly abstract a form that the presentation of love's demand, even if it is formally entirely correct, consumes the content of love; as when it is said to a person: "God is your mortal enemy; he, Love, he wants out of love for you to be loved by you: this means that you must die, die away, otherwise you cannot love him. So there he sits, omnipresent and omniscient as he [359] is, and watches you, knows even the least thing that goes on in you—that he knows, your mortal enemy! Beware of wishing for anything, beware of fearing anything; for what you wish for is not fulfilled, but rather the opposite, and what you fear, the more you fear it the sooner it comes upon you. For he loves you, and he wants to be loved by you, both out of love; but as soon as there is something you wish for, you are not thinking of him, just as when there is something you fear; or if you bring him into connection with your wishing and fearing, then you are surely not thinking of him in and for himself, that is, you do not love him—and he wants to be loved, wants it out of love"⁵².

In Christ's life the law of love has its rich, intuitable content; he gives a person eternal life for the sacrifice of the temporal. He does not say to the one who fears something: God is your mortal enemy; but he says to the one who hopes for something: I am the resurrection and the life. It is not renunciation of the temporal that teaches a person to love the eternal; but it is conversely love for the eternal that gives strength to

⁵²S. Kierkegaard. *Øieblikket*. Nr. 5.

sacrifice the temporal. It is not fear of God, not a thoroughly reflected, clear knowledge of what and how much God can demand and how infinitely strict the Law is, that awakens a living love to God, but it is conversely love to God that reconciles a person with the strictness of the Law and awakens true fear of God in the heart. The fear of God that is not awakened by God's love is without understanding of God and therefore without essential self-understanding; it is, even if the sinner trembles before the judgment of God's wrath as the malefactor before the executioner's axe, just as false and spiritless as the love of one of the awakened that has remade God after the wishes of the natural heart and, in thoughtless, jubilant boldness, forgotten fear. As love is related to fear, so the Gospel is related to the Law. One does not begin with a fear without love, but one begins with a love that has fear within it; one does not begin with a law without gospel, but one begins with a gospel that has the Law, the Law fulfilled by Christ, within it. [360]

If we consider the relation between faith and works, we come to the same result. To begin with the commandments of the Law is to begin with good works and, insofar as the revealed Law presupposes faith, with the good works of faith: the emphasis falls on the works. But good works are only utterances of the good disposition; it is not the work that makes the disposition good, but conversely. With works, therefore, as with the Law, namely the Law of the Gospel, it depends essentially on the disposition, on the heart, on the purity, truth, and strength of the will, thus on free inwardness, thus on faith. The believer does not believe in his own faith; he believes in Christ. To believe in Christ is to believe in the truth in Christ's life, that is, in the truth of the fulfillment of the Law. Only in the same measure as the believer appropriates the truth in the fulfillment of the Law can he appropriate Christ's life. To appropriate the truth in the fulfillment of the Law is possible only by oneself fulfilling the Law; but to fulfill the Law is possible only by a work. So we do after all come to begin with a work! Yes, but with a work of the Gospel, the work of God without which Christ's life and all his works would be in vain for us, namely with faith. "What shall we do, that we might work the works of God?" We know the Savior's answer to those who asked: "This is the work of God, that ye believe on him whom he hath sent" (John 6:29). Faith itself is thus a work, the inner, original work of all good works, the work by which

[361] the fulfillment of the Law is appropriated, the only work by which man on his part can fulfill the Law. But to fulfill the Law by believing in Christ is to come to an end of the Law; for Christ is the end of the Law.

b) The Atonement.

§ 24.

To come to an end of the law, not by breaking it but by fulfilling it, is an indispensable condition for man's coming to an understanding with God in spirit and in truth, for his being reconciled with God. The task is great, human and yet superhuman, a world-task which the God-man alone is able to accomplish. The law in its widest scope is at once both a law of nature and a law of the spirit; the latter cannot be fulfilled without the former. But although the law of nature and the law of the spirit are in the Mystery one and the same law, they nevertheless constitute in the actual world two absolutely heterogeneous systems, that of necessity and that of freedom. To remold the laws of the spirit after the laws of nature is paganism; self-conscious paganism is the denial of spirit: on the terms of the denial of spirit it is an easy matter, in knowledge, to come to terms with actuality and to be reconciled in metaphysical absolutism. But when the laws of the spirit are proclaimed, and they are proclaimed only in the word of revelation, the discord between nature and spirit begins.

At the Old Testament stage the discord has come to light on every side. The people of Israel, with its firm faith in Jehovah's loving-kindness, has never quite been able to come to terms with Jehovah himself; for it has never fully understood the conditions of the fulfillment of the law. To obedience under the laws of the spirit are attached promises whose fulfillment is everywhere conditioned by partial alterations in the
[362] laws of nature: so outward help is given by outward miracles. But the extraordinary help will not quite suffice either for the individual or for the whole people. The pious, who do the works of the law, do not after all receive all the blessing that is promised them in the law; and behold the ungodly! "they bend the bow, they lay their arrow upon the string, to shoot in darkness at the upright in heart", and yet the curse will

not quite strike these ungodly: there is always something in the way. What is it? The sin of men and the wrath of Jehovah! So then sin must be repented of; but the penitent nevertheless sighs after the help of the Almighty as after a temporal aid. So Jehovah must be propitiated by sacrifices; but bloody sacrifices of dumb beasts do not after all avert the wrath. So there must be waiting in patience, and “the servant of Jehovah” must suffer for the sins of the people (Isa. 53 ff.); but the secret of his sufferings no one can fathom.

The secret is that the religious life, because of the strife between nature-bound actuality and the spirit’s claim to the freedom of the self, essentially is and must be a life in suffering and passion. The believer is not exempted from being under the law of nature because he has come under the law of the spirit; on the contrary! now he feels himself precisely at strife with the world and in discord with himself, for “the flesh lusteth against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh”. To fulfill the law of the spirit is a suffering to him. Therefore he never gets it fulfilled either; he remains in self-contradiction, and so in sin, — and yet in suffering all the same. Through the suffering of repentance the sinner hopes to obtain forgiveness from God; repentance is a suffering fulfillment of the law of the spirit, a sacrificial fire of the soul in which what is selfish is burned away. But that the inward self-sacrifice is imperfect is tellingly expressed by the fact that help is sought in outward sacrifices. Instead of sacrificing himself, his natural life, his whole natural mind in suffering, man receives, at the first stage of revelation, permission to sacrifice the animal in his stead, whereby [363] the suffering then ceases in a finite manner and the sacrifice becomes symbolic. But the symbol of sacrifice is only a symbolic fulfillment of the law, and the symbolic fulfillment of the law can then also bring about only a symbolic atonement. So it begins all over again. Jehovah, propitiated by the sacrifice, ought now, once the sin is forgiven, to exempt the pious from all further suffering, bend the laws of nature, and so arrange the outer world that “the righteous” might at last get the better of “the unrighteous” and live in peace and happiness. That does not happen, and cannot happen, for the law is in actuality not fulfilled. God is not yet reconciled with man, nor man with God; for God and man each have their own concept of self-sacrifice and suffering. According to man’s concept the suffering of the pious must cease, and the

cessation of suffering be an unfailing sign of piety; but according to the divine concept the suffering shall not and cannot cease, for the fulfillment of the law is conditioned by self-sacrifice, and self-sacrifice is categorically voluntary suffering. The law can be fulfilled only by self-sacrifice, and with it voluntary suffering, being carried through unconditionally; and the law shall be fulfilled.

Originally, in the deed, in spirit and in truth, no sinful man can understand this secret of the sufferings; only the God-man, the pure, sinless man, knows the secret; only the God-man can, by unconditional self-sacrifice, reveal the secret of the voluntary sufferings, fulfill the law, and accomplish the atonement.

By considering the doctrine of the atonement first from the scholastic-objective and then from the mystical-subjective side, we prepare our way to an insight into the two-sided essence of the atonement.

[364]

α) The Scholastic-Objective Doctrine of the Atonement.

By his voluntary, and yet historically necessary, suffering and death, dependent on given conditions of the world, Christ has in the place of men borne the punishment of sin and satisfied the divine justice. When this thought is to be held fast in the objectivity of a scientific representation and developed in scholastic juridical form, we arrive at the satisfaction theory set out by Anselm.⁵³ "To sin", says Anselm, "is nothing other than not to give God what one owes him. But every rational creature, be it angel or man, owes it to God to be subject to his will; this is the whole honor which God demands of us. Now there is nothing less tolerable than that the creature should rob the Creator of his honor without making good to him again what was taken; since, then, it is the greatest injustice to put up with such a thing, God's justice demands of him that he maintain his dignity. With regard to the order of the world, too, it would be a disorder, a disturbance of the beauty and harmony of the world, which God as ruler of the world ought not to tolerate, to let sin go unpunished. It is therefore necessary either that man, who has sinned, voluntarily give back to God what he has robbed him of and in addition render full compensation for the offense done him, or else that God must take by force what is due to him: the former is voluntary satisfaction, the latter

⁵³ *Cur Deus homo.*

involuntary, or punishment. But man for his part, once he has sunk into sin, cannot even with the best will make such satisfaction to God as might move him to cancel the punishment. To a perfect religious and moral conduct he is obliged in every present moment, and cannot with it pay for sins committed. Moreover, the guilt is infinite, [365] since in God's commandment it is God himself who is offended. But over against God's justice stands God's goodness. This would indeed have to be changeable, which it is not, if it did not move him to complete in man the work of love that was begun at creation; just as it would also conflict with God's wisdom if he were to let the most excellent of his works, the rational creature, go to ruin. The task is therefore to find a being that is able to render complete satisfaction. Such a being must be able to pay to God, for man's sin, more than all that is outside God. But to give so much of its own is possible only for a being that is itself more than all that is outside God. But more than all that is outside God is only God himself. Consequently no other than God himself can render the required compensation. But on the other hand a man must nevertheless render it; for it is to be rendered for men; since, consequently, only God can render it and only man ought to render it, it follows from this that God as man, or the God-man, must render it. The satisfaction which the God-man is to render cannot consist in his giving himself up to God in active obedience; for this obedience every rational creature, consequently the God-man too, always owes to God. But to suffer death he is neither physically compelled, since he is almighty, nor morally obliged, since he is sinless: his voluntary death can therefore count as the required satisfaction. The surrender of so great a good as the God-man's life God cannot leave unrewarded. But the Son of God, who already has everything, cannot receive any reward for himself; God must then give him freedom to make over the merited reward to whom he will; and he makes it over with most propriety to men, who are most in need of it and are related to him according to his human side, and consequently are his [366] natural heirs". Strauss has⁵⁴ aptly remarked of this satisfaction theory that it is like a "parallelogram of forces, in which the divine love by itself claimed outright pardon, the divine justice by itself unsparing punishment of the guilty, but both, acting together, had the diagonal of satisfaction as their result".

⁵⁴Troesl. II. S. 211.

That the doctrine of the atonement in so objective a form of necessity was bound to provoke objections is understandable, since necessity and arbitrariness easily change places in scholastic reasoning. According to the theory the mode of atonement described by Anselm would have to be the only possible one, and the suffering and death of Jesus for the sake of sins therefore necessary; but the notion of God's arbitrariness would not be driven back. Anselm himself concedes that God was in no way compelled to become man, and Thomas Aquinas declares flatly that God, had he so willed, could have freed man from sin without any satisfaction at all.

At the time of the Reformation it was above all the Socinians who subjected the juridical-objective satisfaction theory to a penetrating and sharp critique. "Forgiveness of sins on the ground of satisfaction", says Faustus Socinus,⁵⁵ "is a concept that not only conflicts with the divine perfections but also contradicts itself. It does the former in that it is as little conceivable that God should not have been able to forgive men their sins without satisfaction as that he should not have been willing to: the former is namely not conceivable, since God's right would be more restricted than that of [367] any man if he were not free simply to forgive offenses — and what else are sins? — against his person. It is said, to be sure, that God's justice demands either punishment or satisfaction for sins. But this rests on a false notion of the divine justice. This is not essentially punitive justice, but only the equity and rightness of the divine mode of action in general, and it can show itself just as well in forgiving as in punishing sins. Only in this generality is justice an abiding determination (*perpetua qualitas*) of the divine essence: whether God in accordance with it punishes or forgives is a passing measure of government or determination of his will. But that God should indeed have been able to forgive without satisfaction, but not have willed it, would conflict all too much with his goodness. — But besides, the concept of a forgiveness of sins in consequence of a compensation dissolves of itself, since it is composed of two mutually exclusive elements. For to demand compensation is precisely to exact the debt that is to be remitted in the forgiveness. That it is demanded of another than the one who actually owed it signifies nothing, since the creditor (God) nevertheless gets the debt paid, and consequently remits nothing: it is no remission of the debt, but

⁵⁵ *Christl. rel. breviss. institut.*

only an exchange of debtor and payer that takes place here”.

The false objectivity which, in the name of science, would bind reflection to fixed factual presuppositions is just the thing to provoke the resisting understanding and to develop its finite, and for that very reason endless, reasoning from grounds: grounds and counter-grounds alternate into infinity. Thus the dogmatic-objective doctrine of the atonement has been transformed into a formal suit for debt, with the examination of witnesses and attorneys’ pleas for and against. It is not the arguments in their particulars but the basis of the argumentation, the grounding that is rational in unreason, which on the whole characterizes the error. Before we attempt, however, to [368] bring out the grains of truth hidden in the heaps of reasoning, we shall first consider the corresponding one-sidedness, namely:

β) The Mystical and Subjective Doctrine of the Atonement.

In opposition to the objective, historical-juridical conception of the Atoner’s suffering and death, pious souls in the Middle Ages asserted inwardness; but since inwardness stood in decisive conflict with the whole outward, Catholic-official ecclesiastical system, the mood against the objective was naturally bound to be polemical; it is thus easily explained that sectaries such as the Bogomils, the Beghards, the Brethren and Sisters of the Free Spirit, and others, carried the mystical interiorization of the divine essence to caricatured extremity. According to the teaching of the Bogomils the Son of God is born in every believing soul. The believing soul that awakens faith in another is a Mother of God (*θεοτόκος*), who does not fall short of Mary⁵⁶. With the Siblings of the Free Spirit every pious person was a Christ, in whom God becomes man; their claim to an inner unity of essence with God and Christ seems, in metaphysical absoluteness, even to have approached the insane.⁵⁷

⁵⁶ Λέγουσι τοὺς τῆς πίστεως αὐτῶν, ὅσοις ἐνοικήσει τὸ παρ’ αὐτοῖς ἅγιον πνεῦμα, πάντας θεοτόκους καὶ εἶναι καὶ ὀνομάζεσθαι, βαστασαντας καὶ αὐτοὺς τὸν λόγον τοῦ θεοῦ, καὶ γεννήσαντας αὐτὸν διὰ τοῦ διδάσκειν ἑτέρους, καὶ μηδὲν πλέον αὐτῶν ἔχειν τὴν πρώτην θεοτόκον. — Euthymius Zygadenus. Cf. Gieseler. Kirchengeschichte. II. Bd. 2 Abthl. Bonn 1848. S. 684.

⁵⁷ *Item credunt, se esse Deum per naturam sine omni distinctione. Item quod sint in eis omnes perfectiones divinæ, ita quod dicunt, se esse æternos et in æternitate. Item dicunt, se omnia creasse et plus creasse, quam Deus.* Giesel. Anfr. Skr. S. 645. — This, one may say, is indeed “to relate oneself absolutely to the absolute”.

[369] When the Reformers, in adherence to the Anselmian satisfaction theory, had the merit of Christ transferred to believers by an *actus forensis*, Schwenkfeldt and Andreas Osiander protested against the externality of this conception and laid the decisive emphasis on the inward life of the soul, on the living appropriation of Christ's divine nature, on the Christ growing up in the heart. In Valentin Weigel and Jacob Böhme the doctrine of the atonement acquires a still richer mystical luster of color. "Men have", says Jacob Böhme, "dipped Christ's mantle with its purple color in Christ's blood and taken it as a covering, but thereby only covered up the antichristian child of their own will. For men gladly play the hypocrite for this child and cover it with Christ's suffering, merit and death, and comfort it with the thought that Christ has paid for it and that it need only comfort itself with his merit and accept this in faith as a satisfaction. But the matter hangs together quite otherwise: not by an outward attestation of a special acceptance into grace, by a foreign merit and an imputed righteousness, are we accepted as children of God; but by an indwelling, essential grace pervading all the members, in that Christ, the conqueror of death, with his life, essence and power rises in us from our death and reigns and works in us as a tendril on his vine". After Jacob Böhme, Angelus Silesius in "holy soul's delight" was a minnesinger of pious inwardness: "Ich muss Maria sein und Gott aus mir gebären, Soll er mich ewiglich der Seligkeit gewähren". Not so rich in feeling, but still in the same direction, the striving of the Quakers aims at a spiritual appropriation of the atonement, a birth of Christ in the inward man (*internus partus Christi in homine*), so that they even assume that a man may, by virtue of "the inner light", become a partaker in the "Mystery of the death" of Jesus without knowing his history.

[370] It was now certainly on the whole by no means the intention of those mystics, resting as they did on evangelical presuppositions, either to deny or to belittle the significance of Christ's actual suffering and death as a historical fact; it was only the spiritless objectivity that they wanted to attack. But the mystical lies precisely in this, that they were unable to make clear to themselves the relation between the appropriation itself and that which was to be appropriated. Had the Quakers, for example, really given themselves an account of how the historically actual atonement, as the first preparatory cause (*causa procurans et efficiens*), properly stands related to

the working of the inner light, they would surely not have presupposed the possibility that this revelation of light in the spirit could at any point be separated from the presupposed revelation of life in Christ's history.

So pernicious was the effect of the barren dogmatic objectivity that philosophical thinking, which at last set itself the task of making an end of all mysticism, instead of clarifying the historical presupposition of the religious life let go of the historical in order to grasp exclusively the subjectively ethical, the moral. It is the Kantian doctrine of the atonement that in this respect draws attention to itself. According to Kant it does not essentially matter what Christ as a historical person has done or suffered: the most important thing is that he is the ideal of humanity, a personification of the good principle. "The good principle", says Kant, "is present just as much in the abandonment of the evil disposition as in the adoption of the good, and the pain that rightly accompanies the former arises wholly from the latter. The transition from the corrupt disposition to the good is, as 'the dying of the old man, the crucifying of the flesh', in itself already sacrifice and the beginning of a long series of evils in life which the new man, in the disposition of the Son of God, namely merely for the sake of the good, willingly takes upon himself; but which properly belong to another as punishment, namely to the old man (for this is morally another). Although, therefore, [371] *physically* (considered according to his empirical character as a sensuous being) he is the very same man deserving of punishment and must as such be judged before every moral tribunal, and so also be judged by himself, yet in his new disposition (as an intelligible being), before a divine judge for whom this disposition takes the place of the deed, he is *morally* another; and this disposition in its purity, as that of the Son of God, which man has taken up into himself, or (if we personify this Idea) the Son of God, bears for this man, and for all who (practically) believe in him, as *substitute* the guilt of sin, satisfies the highest justice by his suffering and death as *Redeemer*, and as *advocate* makes it possible for them to hope to appear as justified before their judge; only that (according to this mode of representation) that suffering which the new man, in dying to the *old*, must take over for his whole life, is represented, when referred to the representative of humanity, as a death which he suffered once for all".⁵⁸

⁵⁸Die Religion innerhalb der Grenzen der blossen Vernunft: Schriften zur Philosophie der Religion.

The inner kinship between mysticism and moralism is unmistakable. From both sides it is overlooked that the suffering, dying Savior is and must unconditionally be the mediator between God and suffering, dying man. The mystic, like the moralist, wants to live in an unmediated relation to God. The difference is only that the mystic's relation to God has its inner immediacy in feeling and essentiality, the rationalist's, on the other hand, in reflection and will. The mystic forgets that inner revelation [372] is conditioned by outer; the moralist rejects inner and outer revelation alike, and overlooks that a relation of will to God is impossible without revelation.

γ) The Two-Sided Essence of the Atonement.

Moralism, in all its one-sidedness, has nevertheless held fast to the point which may rightly be called the religious cardinal point, namely the will, and that not merely as will in man but also as will in God; the rationalist-moral relation to God is after all still a decisive relation of will. The advance in the philosophy of religion made by speculation consists, then, only in this, that the relation of will is imperceptibly transformed into a metaphysical relation of essence. The significance of the will is not, to be sure, directly denied; the philosophy of the absolute has, of course, a place in the system for the concept of will just as much as for the concept of knowledge or any other of the fundamental concepts of the Idea. But when the concept of will is to be developed out of the concept of God with the immanent necessity of the Idea, the principle of will ceases to be absolute: the will departs from God and remains behind with man alone. In this sense we may, without in any way failing to recognize the great significance of speculative philosophy for science, say with truth that, as philosophy of religion, it has contributed its share to undermining religion.

The Hegelian doctrine of the atonement, in its advance out of the Schellingian, Strauss has set out briefly and clearly in the following main features: "In itself (*an sich*) — this is the theme of all Hegelian treatments of this point — the knowledge that the opposition between substance and subject, or between selfless universality and infinity and the individual finite self and natural existence in general, is at bottom

sublated and does not exist, is the reconciliation of spirit with itself. But for the non-comprehending consciousness this in-itself (*Ansich*) takes on the form of something existing and something represented. For it the comprehension of this is not a grasping [373] of that concept which knows those two sides as united in and for themselves, but a grasping of the representation that the divine essence is reconciled with itself by the act in which it went out of itself, by its having become man and died. For the finitude and naturalness in which man finds himself seems, in a twofold respect, not to accord with God's universality, the Idea that is free and pure in itself. First, inasmuch as the former, in contrast to the breadth of the divine Idea, its merciful self-outpouring, is, as an individual self, reflected into itself, egoistic and evil; second, because it moreover feels itself unhappy in the want of its nature and its susceptibility to sufferings. This disharmony cannot be sublated one-sidedly by man, who as self stands at the one extreme; rather, its joining together of both sides must have their unity, existing in and for itself, as its presupposition. This unity is present in the fact that both the clear essence and the self reflected into itself are pithless abstractions, that neither does the former have actuality without the latter, nor the latter truth without the former; or more precisely: that the infinite equality with itself is *eo ipso* difference from itself, and consequently finitude."

"The God-man dies; this death is on the one hand, especially in its potentiation as the death of a criminal, the surest proof that he is human; this has shown itself in him to the very uttermost point, and even at this point it has not yet shown itself to be incompatible with the divine life. But on the other hand, through death the humanity, the immediacy, of the existing singularity is sublated and thereby determined as a merely vanishing moment in the divine life⁵⁹ ... What lies in and for itself in the [374]

⁵⁹A passage quite characteristic of the Hegelian view as a whole is, e.g., the following (Religionsphil. XII Bd. 2det Opl. Berl. 1840. S. 301–2): "If in the first sphere" — the Kingdom of the Father — "we conceived God in pure thought, then in this second sphere" — the Kingdom of the Son — "it begins with *immediacy for intuition* and for sensuous representation. The process is now this, that the *immediate singularity is sublated*... and this happens through death; Christ's death is the death of this death, the negation of negation. ... In the death of Christ it is finally still to be emphasized that it is God who kills death, in that he goes forth out of it; thereby *finitude, humanity and humiliation* are transferred as something alien to Christ, as to him who is simply God: it becomes evident that finitude is alien to him and *received from another*; this other is now human beings, who stand over against the divine process. It is their finitude that Christ has taken upon himself, this finitude in all its forms, which at their extreme point is *evil*; this humanity, which is itself a moment in the divine life, is now determined as something

concept of spirit, and on which the reconciliation of the phenomenal human being [375] with his essence rests, namely that what at first only seems to be a limit, a negation for spirit — naturalness, selfhood with its deficiencies, though to be sure only as constantly overcome and reduced to a moment — is on the contrary its actuality: this is here represented as a past existence in which the God-man, once revealed on earth, is supposed to have brought about the reconciliation of human beings with God”.

From scholastic objectivity, then, through the subjective one-sidedness of mysticism and moralism, the movement of thought here arrives at a dialectical mediation between the objective and the subjective, in which the doctrine of the atonement at last obtains its scientific conclusion. That the Hegelian philosophy actually marks a conclusion is evident partly from the inner necessity with which it develops out of the preceding theories, and from the superiority with which it comprehends and takes up the moments of truth contained in them; partly from the fact that it cannot essentially be gone beyond without the boundary of the science of reason being overstepped at the same time. Starting from the principle of faith, the unconditioned principle of will, we now let the movement of thought proceed in the inverse direction, in that, beginning with the subjective significance of the atonement, we step by step make our way toward an understanding of the objective.

It is the work of the Son that he has revealed to us the secret of sufferings: only by striving as he did and suffering as he did can a human being know himself atoned

alien, not belonging to God: this finitude in its being-for-itself against God is evil, something alien to him; but he has taken it upon himself in order to kill it by his death. The shameful death, as the monstrous *union of these absolute extremes*, is thereby at the same time *infinite love*.”

“It is infinite love that God has posited himself as identical with what is alien to him, in order to kill it. This is the meaning of Christ’s death. Christ has borne the sins of the world, has reconciled God, it is said ... This death, though natural, is God’s death and thus satisfactory for us, since it is the *absolute history of the divine Idea*, which presents what has happened in and for itself, and what eternally happens ... That, e.g., the criminal can be punished by the judge, and that this punishment is the carrying-out of the law and its atonement, this is not done by the judge, nor by the criminal through his suffering of punishment as a particular external event, but it is the nature of the matter, the necessity of the concept ... So it is now also with that satisfaction for us; what therefore lies at the ground is this, that that satisfaction has taken place *in and for itself*: not an *alien* sacrifice has been offered, not *another* punished, in order that punishment might be exercised. Each must for himself, out of his own subjectivity and guilt, be and render what he is to be; but what he thus is for himself may not be as something accidental, as *his* condition, but must be something *true* ... The ground of redemption is therefore that history, for it is the matter *in and for itself* ... The confirmation that it is the true is the view which that history gives, and in which the individual grasps Christ’s merit”.

with God. Now both Hegel and Kant seem able to understand this; but if we look more closely, they nevertheless do not understand it: it can only be understood in faith. The human being is — to begin with the subjective — by fulfilling the law himself [376] to suffer for his sins; is, if we inculcate upon ourselves exclusively the moral, as a rational being, without any special help whatsoever on God's part, voluntarily to bear the punishment of sin; is of himself to cognize that voluntary suffering for the sake of sin and for the sake of fulfilling the law belongs to life, so that the whole of temporal life is for that reason, and must be, a continued, a voluntarily continued suffering; is to understand this in such purity and depth that suffering itself is transformed into blessedness — blessed are they who suffer for righteousness' sake — and with this moral self-understanding to know himself in so true and inward an understanding with God that by suffering for his sin he can blot out his sin and atone himself with God. This is, without a shadow of exaggeration, the demand of spirit, of freedom, of righteousness.

If the demand of the spirit is now held fast in its original earnestness, one easily sees what comes of transforming the doctrine of the atonement into a scientific doctrine of reason, whether one otherwise takes the rational from the theoretical or from the practical side. The Hegelian atonement is theoretical, the Kantian practical.

The theoretical atonement is an atonement in knowledge, is the knowing consciousness's reconciliation with itself. Atonement presupposes conflict: as the conflict is, so must the atonement be. The conflict lies in the contradiction, a conflict of thought between opposed concepts; to resolve the contradiction is to bring about reconciliation, is to reconcile conceiving thought with its own conceiving: the resolution of conceptual contradiction is the reconciliation of thought. It is "the opposition between substance and subject, between 'the selfless universality' and 'the individual finite self'," with all that must be ranged thereunder which in natural existence gives itself the semblance of contradiction. The resolution of the contradiction then consists in a knowledge that the opposition itself, with the conflict following from it, is only a semblance; once the semblance has been seen through as semblance, it can no longer deceive. The transparency of the semblance is its nothingness, its impotence. Here, in [377] the eternal sense, for the sake of the spirit, of the eternal, no further exertion is needed

either with the opposition or with the contradiction. The deception is seen through; the deception seen through is in knowledge essentially lifted, just as the contradiction dissolved in the concept is lifted: this is “the reconciliation of spirit with itself.” What this reconciliation means practically is seen from the example of the criminal and the judge. As calmly objective as a judge, in objective reconciliation with the law, can pronounce the death sentence upon the aggravated criminal, just as calmly objective can the criminal, in objective reconciliation with the law, hear his death sentence; he can, as surely as he is a knower, console himself with the nature of the matter, the necessity of the concept; when fantasy shows him the block and the axe, and in the last night in prison lets him feel in advance the killing blow: then he is calmly objective, in objective reconciliation with the law. For the law receives satisfaction, the contradiction is resolved; the killing blow means that the opposition between “the individual finite self” and “the selfless universal” is at bottom sublated: spirit is, after all, reconciled with itself!

With the practical atonement in Kant the matter stands somewhat differently. In Kant subjectivity does not get off so easily with an absolute self-reconciliation as in Hegel. Just as for the fulfillment of the law it is not enough to know one’s duty, but what matters is to do one’s duty, so in the moral sense it is not enough either to know oneself metaphysically reconciled. The task is to actualize the atonement ethically. The new, morally improved human being is then to begin with so absolute an improvement that, though physically the same human being, it is to such a degree beyond the old that it can both bear the punishment which the old has deserved and [378] still punctually fulfill the law; can this be meant in earnest? If it is actually meant in earnest, then one may well ask whether there is, or ever has been, any actual human being who has been capable of this. For if an ideal is set up here which can never be realized, then the demand contains a contradiction. To demand of a human being what manifestly exceeds human powers is to demand the unreasonable; with such a demand it can never be fully in earnest; it conflicts with the well-known rule: *ultra posse nemo obligatur*. It is in this respect quite striking that Kant, who after all wants Christ to be regarded as “a personification of the good principle,” thus as a moral ideal, can take the question of the ideal’s actual existence so lightly. That the actuality of

the ideal is reduced to something indifferent means that its actualization is tacitly assumed to be impossible. So it remains an endless striving and an infinite ought, and the new human being of moralism finds atonement only in the consolation that the rational God is surely fair enough to take the will for the deed.

At the stage of rationalism the divine springs of life in the soul are dried up; it is the law of reason in and by which alone the religious consciousness is to live; in the mystical relation to God, on the other hand, the human being draws spiritual nourishment from the “fullness” in God. The inner revelation, the life in God, the inner light, is a fusion of the divine with the human, in which the soul can taste “the sweetness of atonement.” But with all this the mystics, in spite of feelings, stirrings, images and figurative descriptions, are not able to say definitely what kind of Christ it originally is that is born in the soul, or whence he comes, or what kind of form he actually takes on. One of two things: either the divine child that is to be born in the heart must make the mystic himself an independent son of God, or else be cognized as an image of the historical Christ, whose actual life then becomes the proper exemplar. [379] If the mystic chooses the first explanation, then he can certainly disregard the historical exterior; but his interior is thrown into confusion, he stamps himself as a fanatic. The fanaticism consists in his overlooking the qualitative difference between the God-man and every other human being. Instead of appropriating the life of the God-man, he wants himself to be God-man: so the natural and the spiritual, truth and imagination, the sinful and the holy are mixed in utter unclarity. If the mystic chooses the latter explanation and holds it fast, then mysticism will sublate itself. For by acknowledging the historical Christ as the only true, actual God-man, he will bethink himself that Christ alone, in the voluntary suffering of unconditioned self-sacrifice, has borne the sin of the race and accomplished the atonement. The inward Christ will thus, in appropriation, with the cooperation of the Spirit, be derived from the outward, form itself after the outward, and take on the form which as a psychic image corresponds to its historical exemplar.

The truth in the objective doctrine of the atonement now shows itself in this, that the gaze is fixed on the Atoner himself, his actual suffering and death. But the Atoner is not an object of knowledge but of faith. What is false is that the object

of faith is scholastically changed into an object of knowledge; so it comes about that appropriation is in a spiritless way separated from its object. First the object, the object of knowledge, the external historical object by itself, then appropriation comes afterward! Hence the crass doctrine of an external transfer of all our sin and guilt onto him, mediated by an agreement of love with justice, and the great, soul-harrowing spectacle of the Father “smiting his beloved Son with the rod of wrath” in our place, chastising and punishing him in our place; whereas the truth is that the suffering and death of the God-man is an inner consequence of his self-sacrificing [380] love, a consequence in which he fully reveals his eternal certainty of the Father’s good pleasure, an undeceivable certainty which not even the painful moment of God-forsakenness has been able to shake. Hence the spiritless representation of a juridical transfer of all his merit onto us, a merit which is even conceived so externally that the matter itself is degraded to comparison with a money matter, where the one rich man pays the debt in place of the many debtors; whereas the truth is that the transfer of merit is conditioned by appropriation. Appropriation is in faith. Insofar as faith is unconditioned as faith, the believer too can unconditionally count on Christ’s satisfaction, unconditionally appropriate his merit. But the unconditioned passes through conditions. That faith is unconditioned is to be known by this, that the appropriation of the Atoner’s suffering and death is unconditioned. He suffered for us, that we by the power of his suffering should voluntarily suffer with him and in self-understanding understand the secret of sufferings which he revealed; he died and was buried, that we, atoned with God in life and death, should die and be buried with him.

This, then, is the two-sided essence of the atonement, that the objective is determined point by point by the subjective, and conversely; that God in Christ has made the atonement objective and reconciled the world to himself, in order that the world — the believers in the world — should appropriate the atonement subjectively, be atoned with the Atoner, let themselves be reconciled to God. — The active element in the appropriation of the atonement is now further to be developed in the doctrine of

c) Redemption.

§ 25.

In the orthodox system of doctrine the two functions, atonement and redemption, are both referred to Christ's high-priestly office (*munus sacerdotale*) and distinguished [381] only insofar as atonement (*reconciliatio*, *καταλλαγή*) expressly denotes the removal of God's wrath, while redemption (*redemptio*, *ἀπολύτρωσις*) denotes the ransoming from the bondage of sin; but to any real insight into the fundamental relation itself scholasticism, with its definitions, distinctions, divisions and quaestiones, could not attain. That atonement and redemption are essentially the same means, in other words, that they are at bottom different: atonement is the possibility of redemption, and redemption itself the self-actualizing atonement. Atonement, accomplished once for all, is the foundation of the new life in faith in Christ. On God's side wrath is lifted, the justice threatening in the Law transformed into grace. The old, painful darkness which sin brought into the relation to God has vanished before the new light; one can therefore begin afresh with new powers on new terms: it is not the Terrible One of justice on Sinai, but the Crucified One of love on Golgotha, who makes the new beginning. But in the new relation to God sin cannot possibly be present as it was in the old; for then the atonement would have to consist in God's having let himself be reconciled with sin. If the God who is atoned with sinners is absolutely irreconcilable toward sin, then the power of sin must be broken so that the atonement can prove its power. But that the power of sin is actually broken can only come about in this way, that the Atoner himself frees the human being from the chains of sin and gives it power victoriously to wrestle with sin, to break the power of sin within itself; it is this that happens in redemption.

If the matter is treated scholastically in dead forms of doctrine, it will be impossible to arrive at true insight into the relation between what Christ has done for human beings and what human beings, with his assistance, are themselves to do. To appeal to [382] the Spirit and the cooperation of the Spirit is of no help at all, so long as the conditions of life on which alone the Spirit can and will work have not been sufficiently cleared up. It is something outward, the Atoner, the Redeemer in factual, historical actuality, that here stands sharply against something inward, the atoning and redeeming activity that goes on psychically in believing souls; in other words, it is the essence of faith,

the secret of appropriation, on which the emphasis rests.

As God-man, thus as the object of faith, the historical Christ is the true, sinless human being, and as the true, sinless human being, by his suffering and death, the Atoner. This individual, historically existing human being stands in a two-sided relation to the individuals of the race: he is qualitatively different from them all, and he is essentially akin to them all; he is both for one reason: he is the true, sinless human being. With his qualitative difference from all he stands outside all, above all; he stands alone. No one can be as he has been, no one do what he has done, no one accomplish what he has accomplished. In his essential kinship with all he has stepped into the place of all, has lived for all, has suffered for all, has died for all. He himself, his life, his suffering and death can — on the terms of faith — be appropriated by all. Now the understanding of Him can be laid as the foundation of self-understanding, and self-understanding can have no other foundation; now the appropriation of Him, his life, his essence, can be laid as the foundation of free self-development, and truly free self-development can in all eternity have no other foundation: now the Atoner can work as Redeemer.

From what are the untrue to be redeemed? From untruth! But the forms and powers of untruth are manifold. Sin is a power; but, since sin is a power, death is, [383] after all, also a power; and the powers of sin and death are, with their spiritual stamp, terrible manifestations of the superhuman power of darkness, of the lie, of the evil will, of Satan's power in the realm of spirits. It is the work of redemption that these powers are broken. We can then, in that the philosophy of religion keeps to religion's own strong, full-blooded categories, refer the whole saving, liberating activity to redemption *from sin, from death, from the kingdom of Satan*.

α) **From Sin.**

What does it mean: to have one's life in oneself, to live out of one's own human principle? The whole conflict between knowledge and faith may rightly be said to turn on the answer to this question. Modern science reproaches religion with placing the essence of man outside man. "If the talk is of the atonement, then man is not permitted to seek the conditions of his life in himself; he is directed to seek them

outside himself in another, half-alien being, in a man who is nevertheless something other than man, namely in a God-man; on this account man may naturally not think of expiating his own guilt, freeing himself, redeeming himself: that would of course be an affront to the God-man". Many of the objections belonging here are certainly of scientific significance, insofar as they are directed against a scholastic-objective knowledge of religion; but they are to be regarded as gross misunderstandings when they are directed against religion itself.

To come to Christ is, in the religious sense, to come to oneself; he who comes to Christ in such a way that he thereby in truth comes outside himself does not come to Christ at all; conversely: he who wants to come to himself and remain in himself in such a way that he thereby omits to come to Christ and remain in Christ does not come to himself at all; his remaining in himself as in the absolute is a wretched [384] self-deception.

To come to Christ is in truth to come to oneself; for Christ, the true human being, is the truth itself in every human being. The relation between Christ and the race is, insofar as atonement and redemption are expressly thought of here, by no means a mystical or mysterious relation; it is on the contrary a relation of love declared by the Savior himself in great, clear, unambiguous facts. Why did Christ, the Righteous One, come to suffer for the unrighteous? Answer: because in self-sacrificing love he wanted to reveal to the unrighteous the way of righteousness and, by the revelation of righteousness suffering in love, to overcome the unrighteous. But thus to overcome the unrighteous, what is it other than to bring them voluntarily to see, to regret and bitterly to repent of their unrighteousness, in other words: to bring them to enter into themselves. If Christ is not perfectly right in this, then he is unconditionally wrong.

We must not forget, however, how the matter originally and from the ground up, without any mysterious ambiguity, stands with Christ's suffering and death. Christ was not, after all, misjudged and persecuted merely because he proclaimed certain truths offensive to the powerful of that time; but he was persecuted and seized because he expressly said that he was the truth itself, thus that he was the truth in the sense that he is the only absolutely true human being, and that all other human beings in the whole race over all the earth are, in comparison with him and in opposition to

him, untrue human beings. This his testimony about himself must now, as anyone can understand, be either absolutely true or absolutely untrue. So he was persecuted and seized for the sake of truth — yes, and for the sake of untruth; but on which side, [385] his or the race's, is the truth now? Christ was not hated by human beings although he loved them humanly, as if that generation in which he lived were less loving and more hateful than other generations; but he was hated because he loved human beings divinely, because what he understands by love is so infinitely different from what human beings otherwise understand by love that his love in their eyes looks like unlovingness, indeed like hatred; he was hated because he testified of himself that he is the only one who in spirit and in truth knows what love is, the only loving one, so that all other human beings in the whole race over all the earth are, in comparison with him and in opposition to him, unloving human beings, human beings in whose hearts hatred smolders. This his testimony about himself must, as anyone can understand, have sprung either from incomprehensible love or from inexplicable hatred. So he was hated for the sake of love, yes, and for the sake of unlovingness — of hatred; but on which side, his or the race's, is love now? Christ was not condemned and crucified although he had much right in what he said and did; for if he had only been relatively right against his age, the age too would on its side have been relatively right against him: the crucifixion would then have been a tragic catastrophe according to Hegel's concept of the tragic, corresponding roughly to the condemnation of Socrates. No, Christ was condemned and crucified because he came forward as the one who was unconditionally right. He said that he was the Son of God, and his enemies understood it as blasphemy. It was blasphemy that brought him to the cross; but on which side, his or the race's, is the blasphemy now?

When these decisive questions are to be answered—and such questions, decisive for life and death, are answered only by being answered decisively—then the opposition [386] between knowledge and faith is as conspicuous as it can be. Who is right, then, Christ or Caiaphas? Of course, science is level-headed; it takes good care not to give a straight answer to such “fantastically inflammatory” questions. Objective knowledge, the metaphysics of the Absolute, will always know how to keep a calm countenance, even should it quiver with the fanaticism of knowledge; a calm countenance is, after

all, the hallmark of impartiality, and objective knowledge is, of course, impartial. In its impartiality, science naturally cannot declare Caiaphas right; for it is evident that there is egoism in Caiaphas. But on the other hand it cannot, in the name of the concept, simply declare Christ right either. Certainly the “hero of Gethsemane” is not the greatest egoist who has lived on earth; that is an exaggeration. But there has nonetheless been some egoism in him, a small remnant at least. For there is a remnant of egoism in every human being who has not “become absolutely transparent to himself in the Absolute”. Christ, who stands at the standpoint of representational consciousness, has not been able to raise himself to the concept of the Absolute, consequently has not been able to become transparent to himself, consequently has not been able to consume the egoism remaining in him, consequently cannot be unconditionally right. In other words: Christ, as “the single individual”, must put up with being reduced to a relativity. — But if Christ is a relativity, then he is condemned, for he has laid claim to being the Absolute, and a relativity that lays claim to being the Absolute is to be condemned without grace or mercy. So Caiaphas is right after all, when from his standpoint he calls Christ’s testimony about himself a blasphemy, and metaphysics might just as well say it outright, without any beating about the bush: Caiaphas is right, unconditionally right!

What is sin? Self-contradiction, the deepest, most painful, most spirit-consuming contradiction that can be thought. This self-contradiction has its origin, not in thought, but in the will; it is not thought that began by disturbing the will; no, it is conversely [387] the will that began by confusing thought. The first thing in self-understanding is not: to will to think, but is: thinkingly to will one’s eternal self. Thinkingly to will one’s eternal self is: thinkingly to will, in the name of truth, righteousness and love, to declare Christ right and oneself wrong; it is: thinkingly to will what Christ wills. For what does Christ will? That man shall come to himself by coming to him, shall have the self-contradiction resolved by letting him resolve it, shall in personal understanding exchange roles with him, so that he may be allowed to bear man’s sin and man let himself be clothed in his righteousness. Through unrighteousness man has gone away from himself; through the appropriated righteousness he comes to himself again, and the self-contradiction is resolved.

The relation that is thus brought about personally between Christ and the individual presupposes a universal relation of essence between Christ and the race. Just as the Adam-essence is the essence of the race in its sinfulness, so the Christ-essence is now the essence that is sinless for the race, which each individual is to appropriate in faith. "It is not only the race that is represented in those who stand beneath the Cross; but it is also the race that is represented in him who hangs upon the Cross. It is the old Adam who is beneath the Cross; it is the new Adam who is upon the Cross. The second Adam, indeed, has no part in the sin of the race; but his self-consciousness is inseparable from his unity with the sinful race. The suffering and death that he suffers from the race he himself transforms into a suffering and death for the race; for in the infinite compassion of his love he is able to feel the guilt of his brethren as his own, able to bear the guilt of the race upon his high-priestly heart. So inwardly is he, through his becoming man, bound up with the sinful race that Christ, as Luther [388] expresses it, can say: I am this sinner, i.e. his guilt and punishment belong to me; and that the sinner through faith can say: I am Christ, i.e. his death and righteousness belong to me"⁶⁰.

In determining the relation between Christ and the race it must above all not be overlooked that this relation of essence is, at its innermost ground, a relation of will. Religion presupposes that everyone who in sincerity *will* understand the Atoner also *can* understand him; in which it is implied that he who says that he cannot understand him says so only because he will not understand him, and will not do so because he will not understand himself in spirit and truth. Not to will to understand the Crucified and declare him right—that is: to will the self-contradiction; that is: to will sin as sin, i.e. to will one's own perdition. To will to understand the Crucified and declare him right—that is: to will to recognize the truth in him as truth itself, the righteousness in him as righteousness itself, the love in him as love itself; that is: to will one's own salvation. The personal account between Christ and the race is something other and more than a system of universal Ideas. It is not the Idea of truth in general, not righteousness and love in general, that are in question here; it is precisely the fundamental religious-ethical error of reason that it has had the eternal

⁶⁰H. Martensen. "Den christl. Dogmatik". S. 317–18.

Ideas of the will transformed into universal potencies of selfhood, and the willing self into a “finite subject”; and so it ends in — perdition. Nor does Christ, as an externally existing individual, will to bind the race to his finite phenomenon. The Crucified has in his individuality the eternal universal, has the Ideas of the will and the will itself in living, visible unity. It is the Ideas in flesh and blood, the suffering truth, the scorned righteousness, the thorn- crowned love, through which the holy will on Golgotha set [389] itself against the will of the race, that each individual might go into himself, condemn sin in himself, and let himself be saved.

By condemning sin in himself the believer is raised above sin, receives through Christ a new strength of will, a new will, a new self, and becomes in faith a new man. With Christ’s atonement as his inner presupposition, the anchoring ground of his life, the new man is saved from sin and to that extent without sin; but in natural self-unity with the old man he is nonetheless still encumbered with sin. The self-contradiction that man is both saved from sin and yet bound by sin resolves itself into a struggle which, by virtue of redemption, leads to victory over sin. This victory, by the nature of the struggle, has an absolute and a relative side; the absolute rests on faith as faith, the relative on the strength of faith with which the atonement is appropriated and redemption actualized. We see this in the doctrine of *the following of Christ*.

In the following, the life of the Redeemer is to repeat itself in the redeemed. But the following is no outward imitation. In outward imitation the one who strives places himself outwardly over against Christ, compares his works with Christ’s works, his sufferings with Christ’s sufferings, and thereby comes to be outside himself. It is an error which, for that matter, can take on a very different character—one need only think of the difference between a holy Francis with his childlike, rich mysticism and a sour-tempered, spiritless Pietist—according to the unclarity within from which it proceeds. The fundamental error is that the one thus inflamed wants to copy Christ’s works without understanding Christ’s essence, without deeper human self-understanding. Instead of placing the following in the inward appropriation of Christ’s life, such a follower abstracts for himself a new law from Christ’s example; sighing and groaning [390] under the yoke of the new self-made law he labors with sin, against sin, and cannot possibly overcome sin, since in his darkening of spirit he does not see what sin is.

Understood absolutely, there is only one sin: not to believe unconditionally in one's redemption. Lack of faith is lack of inner life in light and warmth. Every outward break with the outward world, every ascetic exertion of strength, be it ever so heaven-storming, is without religious significance when it does not proceed from the new self in living faith. Against all finite penances, however painful, sin can hold its own; only against the life of faith in personal self-understanding can it not hold its own; before the power of faith it succumbs: penances are piecework, but in faith (*fides salvifica*) is salvation.

β) From Death.

In the measure that the Redeemer overcomes sin in the redeemed, he also overcomes death; for when sin vanishes, death is a nothing. That death came into the world through sin means, as we have seen, that death first became something through sin, became the dark power that signifies the curse. It is fear of death that makes death fearful. From the standpoint of religion, fear is originally to be determined as fear of conscience. For just as sin can be in a man without the man having yet become conscious of it as sin, so too the fear of death can dwell hidden in a man who nonetheless feels no fear, because the fear of conscience is either not awakened at all or only intimated in inexplicable anxiety. Just as little as expressions of natural carelessness and selfish boldness are signs that sin is lifted—since such expressions are precisely signs of the opposite—just so little is a contempt for death springing [391] from sensuous courage a sign that the original fear of death is lifted, since it is on the contrary an unfailing sign of the opposite. Just as there is a difference between sensuous and spiritual courage, so there is also a difference between sensuous and spiritual fear of death. If selfish contempt for death were a testimony to true courage, then one would surely have to admit that the coarser and more defiant a man is, the more courageous he can be: the chieftain of the savage tribe from the primeval forests would then perhaps be more courageous than any civilized general. This measure of courage the Redeemer has broken; he broke it in Gethsemane. Without spiritual fear of death—how should he, who is himself the Life, fear death?—he was nonetheless, in the conflict of his sufferings, as one who in anguish of soul strove with death, moved in

fear and weak as a woman. But this weakness, this trembling in the anguish of death, is in a deeper sense precisely the revelation of his invincible strength of soul. The innermost terror in the Savior's struggle of soul is his feeling of sin, not of his own, for he is sinless, but of the sin of the race, of the misdeed in which it was now to become manifest. The God-man too has had to feel the overwhelming power of a moment of horrors, and the pains that seized him show clearly enough that he was wholly man, that there was nothing hidden in his essence that could exempt him from actual sufferings. It should then also be emphasized that it is not the sensuous sufferings themselves, but the representation of them, with which he struggles; for precisely by taking up the sensuous sufferings beforehand in representation he transforms them into sufferings of the soul and conquers them in the soul. When the struggle of the soul had ended in unconditional surrender to the Father's will, the anguish of soul was also past; the one who had struggled rises strengthened to bear all things, and no hero on earth who ever went to meet the terrible has been so prepared as he was when, fully resolved, he stepped forward and asked the guard: whom seek ye? From the moment when the history of the Passion begins in tangible form, there is in his [392] being no trace of fear left: no wavering, no faintheartedness, no downcast look; only the divine superiority of self-certainty, meekness, and patience is to be seen in the countenance of the conqueror of death.

So he died and was buried; but his actual death was a means of making manifest the impotence of death; for he rose from the dead. "How? Under what conditions? With what body"? Of that nothing *is known*; it is the miracle of revelation, the sign of omnipotence, actuality of spirit, actuality for the spirit, and there it rests. But that he actually rose and was actually seen by his witnesses—of that his redeemed have in themselves, in self-understanding, so powerful and unfailing a testimony that existence would have to become meaningless, and the world a madhouse, if this testimony could deceive. Christ's resurrection stands not in an accidental but in an essential, indeed in the most essential and most inward relation to his whole personal life: he was not merely to overcome death for his own person; he, the revealed truth, was indeed also to reveal himself as the conqueror of death.

The redeemed has in this revelation all the presuppositions and conditions for

overcoming death in himself. Temporal death has lost its sting; for the relation to death changes with the relation to sin; eternal death has lost its sting, for the Redeemer did not die as judge; no, he died with forgiveness on his lips, he died as Atoner. Here, as regards the fear of death, there can no longer be talk of an essential difference between the courageous and the fearful; for the fear of death is, on the terms of faith, essentially fear of conscience: this fear is equal for all and is sublated equally for all. Here no distinction can any longer be made between those strong by nature and [393] those weak by nature; for He who is stronger than the strongest became weak as the weakest, that in the weakness which is strength he might teach both weak and strong to overcome death.

γ) From the Kingdom of Satan.

“For this purpose the Son of God was manifested, that he might destroy the works of the devil” (John 3:8). This and similar sayings in Holy Scripture gave the old Church teachers occasion for a dramatic depiction of a formal wrestling-match between Christ and the devil. “Through the first sin man had come under the dominion of Satan, the prince of sin and death; this was indeed a wrongful act of violence on the devil’s part, which the Son of God would to that extent have had the right to annul by force; but it accorded with his perfection to proceed justly even against the unjust one: therefore he did not tear men from him by violence, but as by a peaceful exchange, redeeming them from him by giving up his soul as a ransom. Therefore he had to be both God and man: man, because he was to redeem men by his death; God, in order to be able to withstand the devil. But since, precisely for this reason, the devil did not keep Christ’s soul, as it could not, according to Ps. 16:10, Acts 2:27, 31, be held fast by the underworld and death: how then was the devil obliged to release mankind for a ransom which he had only apparently received? It was precisely in this that the devil deceived himself. He came to an agreement with God, in the best of form, that in return for the soul of Jesus, which as the soul of the God-man was worth as much as, indeed much more than, the souls of all men together, he would set these free; the soul of Jesus was handed over to him: that he could not hold it fast, since he could not endure the pain this caused him, could not make the contract void, since he ought to

have considered this beforehand. But how could the devil deceive himself so grossly? [394] This became possible through the human veil in which the Son of God had wrapped himself, and that with the intention that the devil, over the easily subdued humanity, should forget the almighty Godhead indwelling it, and so enter into the bargain all the more credulously. When the devil laid hands on Jesus, tormented and killed him, although he had no right to him as sinless, he exceeded his authority and lost those whom he had until then held in his power with a certain right. Like a clever fisherman God hid Christ's higher nature as a hook under the bait of the flesh; but the devil, like a greedy fish, swallowed both the one and the other. Thus was fulfilled the word which God had once spoken to Job (Job 40:19 f.): Canst thou draw out Leviathan with a hook? and does one pierce the nose of Behemoth? A man, namely, does not indeed do this, but Christ has accomplished it. But that unlawful bite agreed so ill with the old Leviathan that, like Saturn once, he had to give up all those whom he had previously swallowed"⁶¹.

To what degree the fundamental religious representations can be distorted when self-understanding does not go hand in hand with the understanding of the word of revelation can be seen from the description cited. In this description the devil has become just as external to the view as Christ; and as soon as fantasy had brought forward the external material, the understanding at once began to work it up with juridical acuteness. Thus the doctrine gradually becomes objective and scientific. But when the devil himself has got into science, what wonder, then, that critique sets itself in motion to drive him out. But in this expulsion there is again something devilish, for now the critique of knowledge regards its victory over the devil as a proof of the [395] complete annihilation of the fundamental religious representation, and thus as a sign of the tottering condition of religion. "Christ and the devil, these two potentates, stand in so decisive a relation of reciprocity that when the one falls, the other falls too."

This misunderstanding is removed when, by virtue of the principle of faith, we hold fast the point of view that the doctrine of the *evil* will too, and, what corresponds to it, the doctrine of the power of the devil, is to be judged solely and exclusively by the influence it exerts on the cognition of the life of the will as a whole, and then in

⁶¹Strauss Troesl. II. S. 203–206

particular on self-cognition.

Will is moved by will; this proposition is decisive for all development of character. The more practical the development is, the more clearly it shows itself that what affects the individual will from without is chiefly another will, the will of others. In the relation between the one who commands and the one who obeys this is evident; but it is so too in persuasion, admonition, temptation, seduction, etc. Every human society is, though in a very different spirit, a society of wills, a system of wills in manifold interaction. That the social will, the general will, can just as well be said to determine the individual wills as in turn to be determined by them has already been pointed out in an earlier context. Among the individual wills themselves the interaction is finite; but between the individuals and the general will it is infinite, and the general will, whether it be otherwise good or evil, has the overreaching power.

If we now examine in what the *evil* general will properly consists, and by what it is known, then its evil does not lie primarily in its making the individuals will-less; for in a society of will-less individuals no general will can exist. If we say: the evil general will must be known by its making the individual wills evil, then this is only a formal [396] paraphrase; for the question is precisely in what the evil consists, and how it comes about. If it is the good of each individual will that, regardless of what it determines itself to in a finite sense, it has the law of self-determination in itself and can act from its own motives, then the evil must surely show itself in this: that the general will robs the individual wills of their original right of self-determination; which can also be expressed thus: that it filches the individuals' right to themselves, steals their conscience, and makes them into blind, but strong-willed, instruments. This cunning of the general will is of so sly, serpentine, spiritual a nature that it takes hold only where spiritual powers are at work; but then also in such a way that the higher the stage of spirit to which the society has raised itself, the more terrible is the evil. At the stage of crudeness the evil in this form does not appear; but in the course of cultural development it has already manifested itself in pagan fashion in the ancient states. In Sparta and Rome, as is well known, the true citizens durst have no conscience for themselves. The common conscience was in the keeping of the state. What in itself was right or wrong, religious or irreligious, which worship was the true and which the

untrue—that the individual, however enlightened he might otherwise be, could not possibly decide on his own; it had to be decided objectively, in the society. From this it is explicable that even the noblest natures could, in the name of the state, commit the most revolting acts without reproaching themselves. And yet the crime of the spirit does not yet attain its proper form; for a crime of the spirit presupposes spirit, and paganism is not essentially spirit. But in the Middle Ages, on the foundation of the Church, the crime of the spirit could take a leap upward. Seen from its shadow side, the papal-hierarchical general will has precisely this peculiarity about it, that like a vampire it sucks the blood of consciences and makes individuals into blind instruments. This is seen in Jesuitism; for Jesuitism is the darkness in the Catholic [397] spirit. The holy becomes egoism, egoism holy; obedience to God is transformed into blind obedience to superiors, who in turn show a blind obedience to the general will prevailing in the society. With an exactitude extending to the very smallest things, the one must confess for the other and answer for the other; but no individual, the highest as little as the lowest, is originally answerable to God, for the selfishly holy general will has put itself in the place of the will of God; by taking the whole responsibility upon itself it has made the individuals unanswerable before God.

Now evil has been brought into a system. In this thoroughly reflected life of the will every crime is a crime of the spirit. And no crime, not even one that could turn the misanthrope's blood to ice and make the hair stand on end on the robber's head, is so revolting that any one of those consecrated to the service of the universal will could not carry it out calmly and in full consciousness; and why? Because the consecrated one has only to obey, because he is without responsibility before God, because the evil will of the universal spirit has stolen his conscience from him by guile.

But how has it actually come about that evil could establish itself at such a depth, and with so inhuman a rigor of consistency, in an unconditionally ruling universal will? No one knows; there is as yet no one who has been able to fathom it right to the bottom — here the path of psychology to the finite runs through the infinite — but everyone who, from the standpoint of civilization and humanity, has gained a deeper insight into the thoroughly worked-out systematics of this universal will, down to its finest ramifications, which twine about all the roots of the mind, must involuntarily,

whether he is otherwise a believer or not, exclaim to himself: it is a *kingdom of Satan*.

[398] But, someone says, if there really exists a kingdom of Satan, then there must also exist an actual Satan; one must then be able to catch sight of him objectively somewhere. This is a misunderstanding. The satanic essence can be observed; but Satan himself, even though science peers through all the telescopes of critique, no, Satan himself is not to be descried. Yet let us try whether there is not perhaps another eye, one organized to see what no knower can see; that would then have to be the eye of faith.

That Christ has redeemed his believers from the kingdom of Satan can, to be sure, have no essential validity if there is no Satan; but then neither can the redemption have validity outside the one who, in believing self-cognition, cognizes himself as redeemed. But in order truly to feel himself redeemed from the kingdom of Satan, the redeemed one must surely once have been in this kingdom himself, and, after having been in the power of the evil will, have experienced what it is to break with this power. So let us fix our attention on such a figure. He was a Grand Inquisitor. He sat in the secret court, a witness to works which we must, in more than one sense, call with horror works of darkness. Then it happened once that one of those unhappy victims, whose patience was greater than all the pains of torture, sent him a glance, a glance so indescribably piercing and yet so gentle that he could never forget it. Quietly, shut up within himself, he now began an inquisition of another kind. It was not heretics he was examining; he felt himself too sickly for that, he said, and his sickliness and exhaustion then had to serve him as an excuse with those around him: he was examining himself. It became clear to him, as he — alone before God, not on behalf of the Order but for his own conscience's sake — immersed himself in the Gospel, that the history of Christ's passion contained the most terrible judgment upon the works of the Inquisition. What, then, had he lived for? A kingdom of Satan! "Did he now see Satan himself in this kingdom"? No! But in the anguish of his soul he nevertheless perceived that Satan is a will.

[399] "For this purpose the Son of God was revealed, that he might destroy the works of the devil".

C.

The Kingdom of the Son.

§ 26.

If we set the revelation in the Old Testament and the revelation in the New Testament sharply against each other, the difference is striking. The doctrine of Jehovah against the doctrine of Christ: it is as shadow against body, as law against gospel, as compulsion against freedom. Were the old theocracy with its priests and Levites to constitute in particular the kingdom of the Father, while the new dynasty of the spirit, established by Christ, were to be regarded as a kingdom by itself, standing exclusively under the Son: then there would undeniably appear here a questionable separation between the kingdom of the Father and that of the Son. But that is not how matters stand. From an external historical point of view, Jehovah and Christ can by no means be said to be related as the Father to the Son. It is a Jewish misunderstanding of the messianic ideal that the Messiah should be able to become the Son of God, although God can nevertheless not possibly be his heavenly Father; for as long as God is Jehovah, he can never become Father. Jehovah, put plainly, has no children. His children are his creatures; but the Creator can only figuratively be said to be related to his creatures as a father to his children. The expected Messiah, whether he is otherwise seen in the clouds of heaven among the thousands of angels or on Mount Zion with the iron scepter that chastises the nations, is only in a spiritual image to be seen as the Son of God: the actual is that he is the Son of David.

This must then also exercise an essential influence on the judgment of the prophecies and their fulfillment. That the prophecies have found their fulfillment in Jesus Christ coincides, in concept, with Jesus Christ's having actualized the true messianic ideal; but to form from the prophecies of the prophets an image of the Messiah that should in each and every respect resemble the actual Christ is impossible. Standing on the foundation of the theocracy, the prophets were constantly bound to apply the measure of the law and of outward dominion to the Expected One. That it was the spirit, "the Spirit of Jehovah", "the spirit of wisdom and understanding", "the spirit of counsel and might", on which everything first and last depended, they saw clearly; but with regard to the spirit there was a secret which they could not possibly see through [400]

at the then stage of revelation, and that was the mysterious unity of the spirit with the Word of life in the holy ground of nature, the unity that makes the spirit the spirit of love and the true Messiah the Son of God. The new life that comes with Christ, the new beginning that takes place through him, is then also decisive to such a degree, and works with such originality upon the believing witnesses, that these can evidently not be said to direct their conception of Christ immediately by the prophecies, but conversely to conceive and interpret the prophecies according to their faith in Christ. Proofs of this we have, e.g., in the use the Evangelist Matthew makes in 1:23 of Isa. 8:8–10, and in 2:15 of Hos. 11:1.

Only when the old covenant in its entirety is regarded as a preparation for the new, only when Judaism in broad outline is conceived as a prophecy of Christianity, can the individual prophecies be placed in the right light; but then they are also testimonies to the stepwise transformation of the revelation of Jehovah. Jehovah is the Father and yet another than the Father, just as Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah [401] announced by the prophets and yet another. It is not God as God who has changed his essence; the change is in the progressive revelation. From the Old to the New Testament there is no rational transition; for the Jew learned in the Scriptures Christ is just as surely a “sign that is spoken against”, to offense, as for the philosophical heathen. The unconditionally new lies in the revelation of the Logos, the revelation of the Word of life; with the Word of life Jehovah is transfigured into *the Father* and the Old Testament Messiah into *the Son*. Now the relation is not figurative but actual; God himself is the Father, he “of whom all fatherhood in heaven and on earth is named”.

As the Son is one with the Father, so the kingdom of the Son is also one with the kingdom of the Father; it is in the unity of this kingdom of the Father and of the Son that the old kingdom of Jehovah dissolves, and the theocracy with its laws of compulsion perishes. In the doctrine of the Father we have therefore also regarded this kingdom from the point of view of the ideals, and under this consideration adduced characteristic features of the preparations in the kingdom of Jehovah; from the point of view of the Son we shall now consider the actualization of the ideals, how they take on life and shape in visible forms, as we conceive the kingdom of the Son as the kingdom of *freedom, love and blessedness*.

a) The Kingdom of Freedom.**§ 27.**

From the historical point of view of the development of the spirit, the opposition between the law in the Old and the gospel in the New Testament is to be regarded as an opposition between two ages of life, the first of which designates the stage of minority, the latter that of majority. At the stage of minority the point is discipline, [402] at that of majority self-education; discipline presupposes laws of compulsion, self-education laws of freedom. This opposition points to a two-sided relation between nature and spirit. There is in man a nature that strives against the spirit, and there is in his fundamental essence a nature that feeds on spirit and nourishes the spirit. What is characteristic of discipline is now this, that here the beginning is made in discord between nature and spirit. Although the spirit originally aims at freedom and works liberatingly by subduing willfulness and awakening the self to spiritual self-understanding, it must nevertheless impress its laws with divine authority upon the sensuously selfish individuals, terrify them with threats, and employ compulsion. It is otherwise when self-education is to begin; for the fundamental condition is that compulsion falls away. That compulsion falls away does not mean that the law lapses; it means, on the contrary, that it is moved from the outer into the inner. It means that the individual is to have the law for his development within himself, is to compel himself; but to compel oneself is in earnest to determine oneself according to the law of freedom: in self-determination the law is acknowledged, but compulsion is sublated. With this the discord between the spirit and nature is also sublated, namely in principle.

Self-education thus begins, under the influences of the spirit, essentially with this, that the individual begins with himself from within, begins by raising the higher nature to dominion over the lower. Here, to be sure, the beginning is made with a demand of the spirit, but this is originally one with a corresponding impulse of nature: man satisfies the spirit by satisfying himself in a higher sense. In order that the satisfaction may be true and deep, and the better nature of the individuality may receive its due, every notion of finite compulsion must be kept away.

[403] To these conditions of freedom corresponds precisely the beginning that Christ makes in founding his kingdom of heaven. "The Kingdom of God is within you": this word is decisive for the beginning from within, the free beginning toward freedom, for freedom begins only from itself. Of the many parables under which the character and essence of the kingdom are depicted from various sides, we shall in this connection direct attention especially to those which, from the spiritual side of nature, make visible the fundamental conditions, the terms, and the burdens of freedom.

α) The Fundamental Conditions of Freedom: The Sower and the Soil.

When, in the individual life of freedom, we distinguish what takes place in the daylight of consciousness from what stirs darkly in the mind and belongs, so to speak, to the night side of the soul, we must of course not forget that the unity is the psychic self, that the original unity of the self is a unity of will, that the individual arbitrary acts of will get their significance precisely as free shoots that shoot forth from the fundamental will. The life of the will too has its nature side; the will works as involuntarily in the ground of the mind as either imagination or feeling or thought: the spiritual life has its vegetative side in the soul, just as the soul has in the body. If, then, the life of freedom is to be spoken of vividly and in a living way, it lies in the nature of the case that now the one, now the other of its two regions is especially brought out. This has then also been done in the parables of the kingdom of heaven.

It lies in the essence of the parable that, as a figurative presentation of the truth, it can never clarify the whole truth from all sides, but can instead illuminate a single main side all the more powerfully. The different parables, when outwardly put side by side, can easily give the superficial observer the impression that they stand in
[404] conflict with one another. Thus we have parables of Christ in which the self-conscious exertions of the will in watching and praying are enjoined in the very strongest terms, while others of his parables bring out the nature side of the life of freedom to such a degree that at first glance it looks as though the word could sprout in the mind like the seed in the field. These different depictions of the same truth are, however, so far from contradicting one another that the one is, on the contrary, a completion of the other: the different parables supplement one another mutually. If it is one-sided to

hold exclusively to those which depict the life of faith as a growth, it is also one-sided to hold exclusively to those which can support the ascetic conceit that the new life can only be a product of reflected self-exertion.

That the will of the spirit is the fundamental will of the individuality presupposes not only that the will has its foundation in the individual nature, but presupposes also that the inner free working of the spirit begins only from the ground up, in that it begins, in an obscure and mysterious manner, as growth. What is signified in exemplary fashion by the Christ child's growing with a holy growth comes to full visible expression in the doctrine of the kingdom of heaven.

This is seen from the parable of the sower (Matt. 13; Mark 4; Luke 8). There is in this image something so popular and free and fresh as spring that no one who truly immerses himself in it can doubt that everything here takes place under God's open heaven. It is with a divine open-handedness that this sower strews the seed everywhere, without pettily troubling himself about what the actual soil is like; so it happens that not all the seed falls on good ground, but that some also falls by the wayside, and some on stony ground, and some among thorns. Thus the parable fits literally the word of freedom, Christ, the divinely liberal-minded sower, who strews the seed of the word everywhere in the soil of the people, leaving it to each individual [405] in particular how he, according to his psychic nature, will receive the gift rich in promise. And how various, then, is not this soil of the people! Immediately after the parable one might almost be tempted to assume that the psychic differences of individuals rested to such a degree on a natural determinateness independent of the will that freedom was lost and the recipients became wholly unaccountable. "What can the wayside do about the birds eating the seed that it is unable to keep? What can the stony ground do about its being so hard, or the thorny ground about its thorns finally choking the seed? Indeed, what merit has the good ground in its fruitfulness? It is as it is, and surely cannot be otherwise". With such reflective considerations the parable, according to its character, cannot possibly engage. Its thoughts are thoughts of impression, visible thoughts of life. But precisely by halting the soaring reasoning, it fastens attention with irresistible definiteness on a single great, decisive point of view. What, then, do we learn from the parable? That the life of freedom must begin

in the mind as a seed corn begins its growth in the soil; that the spiritual vegetation, in other words, is the original presupposition of freedom, and the ground of individuality necessary for the seed of the word the indispensable foundation of the life of freedom.

Most closely connected with the parable of the sower is the parable of the tares among the wheat (Matt. 13). Here too the fundamental conditions of freedom, of inner, naturally determined self-development, are held fast. The seed is sown in the field, the good seed; but the field is not protected by any outward measure whatever. The people sleep, and the householder has not thought of any safety watch that should keep guard day and night lest other sowers with seed of another kind should come to [406] sow in the same soil. So the opportunity is used, so the enemy comes and sows his tares among the wheat. Had it not been for freedom's sake, such a thing would surely have been prevented. Now when the crop grew up and bore fruit, and the tares too showed themselves, it seemed to the householder's servants that if nothing had been done before, then something *ought to be* done now. In their opinion measures ought at least to be taken to stop the growth of evil; they therefore ask the householder whether he does not think they should go and weed out the tares. But the householder says no; and why? It is certainly not from indifference toward the wheat that he spares the tares; it is for the wheat's sake, in other words: for freedom's sake, so that the root of life shall not be harmed. So both grow together, the tares with the wheat; it looks like a kind of immediate natural right. This natural right, however, is in the sense of the spirit so far from harming freedom that it conditions and furthers self-development instead. There is a well-meaning watchfulness, a self-important solicitude, that would so gladly shield the dear individualities against harsh attacks, cover them against every gust of wind, and, if it were possible, transform the tree of freedom into a potted plant: that harms freedom. Outward solicitude does double harm; it makes the individual soft, and it dulls his consciousness of responsibility. The householder in the parable upholds the fundamental conditions of freedom in both respects; he lets the good work its way forward in struggle with evil; he makes responsibility count by pointing to what is coming and awakening consciousness of the judgment. So he says, and says it so loudly that both the tares and the wheat can hear it: when the harvest comes, gather first the tares together and bind them in bundles to burn them, but gather the

wheat into my barn.

[407]

β) The Terms of Freedom: The Prodigal Son.

Freedom is a dangerous thing; that holds not only outwardly but also, and chiefly, inwardly. It is the fundamental condition of self-development that he who is called to freedom must begin by being his own master: so it begins, then, with immediate headstrongness. That a tolerably ordered civil society must consider well what it is doing before it too hastily lets headstrongness loose is natural. But the kingdom of Christ is also something other than a political civil society. In civil society the point is merely freedom in outward things, outward freedom; and it then goes without saying that outward freedom must have its outward limits. In the kingdom of the Son, on the other hand, the point is inward, solely and exclusively inward freedom; but inward freedom cannot begin originally if it does not begin naturally, and cannot begin naturally if it is not permitted to begin in headstrongness.

Incipient headstrongness is dangerous; in the rush of passion it can be like a daring leap between cliffs and abysses, with the foolhardiness of the inexperienced like a voyage in an open boat on the wild sea; it can therefore, in purely personal relations, in the relation between guardian and ward, between father and son, often be a matter of misgiving, indeed of pain, for the experienced to let go of the inexperienced and allow him in the name of freedom to begin his course as he will — in all headstrongness. It is in this respect — and not only with regard to repentance and forgiveness of sins — that the parable of the prodigal son is so instructive. It is with exalted calm, but certainly not without dark forebodings and deep pain, that the father “divides his living” between the two sons. But the age of majority had surely been reached by the younger too. Here no objection helped, and alas, unfortunately, no admonition either. So it was a silent parting, but by no means an easy one on the father’s side, when “not [408] many days after the younger son gathered all he had together and took his journey into a far country”. What road he took, and how it went with him, we know. It is clear enough that there is a double nature in this son, a lower one that storms ahead selfishly and misuses freedom, and a higher one that can only break through when the lower has raged itself out. It is, people say, the bitter experiences that subdue

headstrongness and produce repentance. Yet it is not quite so. The bitter experiences could in the prodigal son also have produced another effect, namely embitterment against the father. "Why did he fulfill my wish so readily? He divided the living at once and gave me my portion, just as if he were quietly glad to be rid of me. After all, he knew my youthful passion, my hot blood, my inexperience; how could he, the experienced one, so calmly put up with everything and hold out his hand in farewell?" Among all the crises of freedom none is more dangerous than this: when everything has been staked and everything is lost, and only one thing remains, the gnawing worm in the mind, then in self-understanding to have to cognize whose the guilt is. Just as the first step of headstrongness is the natural beginning of freedom, so in a deeper sense repentance is the spiritual beginning of freedom; religious freedom begins with repentance.

In an outward sense, and judging by the measure of a civil-moral order, the elder son has a great advantage over the younger. He too could, after all, have done the same as his brother, taken his share and left the father. It was handsomely done of him that he did not do it, but stayed with the old man and helped him. He is industrious, a friend of order, an enemy of excesses, and one cannot blame any civil society for preferring such a man of honor to his dissolute brother.

[409] One might indeed, from the standpoint of the moral law, subject the father's conduct as a whole to a rather sharp critique, since one would then have to find that he is at bottom a weak man who lets his feelings run away with him. Not to speak of his far too great indulgence in humoring the young man and letting him travel on his own without even thinking to send a tutor along with him, he ought nevertheless, when he saw his son come back as a *mauvais sujet*, at least to have given him a proper chastisement, to have humbled him quite perceptibly in the sight of his elder, exemplary brother, so that he should not soon again feel like going off on adventures with freedom. But what does the old man do instead? He forgets, you see, his paternal dignity, he quite forgets moral seriousness and gives a feast — for the lost one! "Bring forth the best robe, and put it on him; and put a ring on his hand, and shoes on his feet; and bring hither the fatted calf, and kill it; and let us eat, and be merry." Yes, such is fatherly love, when it winks at the wilfulness of youth and makes

common cause with freedom.

How anxious, how deeply grieved this father's heart must have been at the thought of the son who had gone away, perhaps lost forever, can be seen from the joy with which he receives him again, for he receives him with open arms. He lost him for freedom's sake, but now he has won him back, won him in the name of freedom, won him in such a way that he belongs to him forever.

This the morality of reason cannot understand, and the man of duty, the elder brother, cannot understand it either. He had just come from the field, from the fulfilment of duties; "and as he came and drew nigh to the house, he heard music and dancing. And he called one of the servants, and asked what these things meant; and [410] when he then was told what it was, he was angry and would not go in."

It is a peculiar kingdom, this kingdom of freedom, where wilfulness can run rife without any compulsion being applied. Yet this is by no means because the king of this kingdom, in logical unclarity and for want of a rational ethics, has confused freedom with wilfulness, so that he is unable to make the distinction. No, it is because he wants wilfulness, selfish self-will, rooted out from the ground up. That this cannot happen on the ordinary terms either of household discipline or of civil order we learn from the example of the elder brother. This orderly man has surely never gone astray, has never, so far as anyone knows, departed from the path of virtue; but that he is nonetheless a self-willed, conceited, egoistic person is seen from his conduct, in that he despises his brother and wounds his father. It is precisely the secret of wilfulness, of selfish self-will, that it can thrive excellently under the restraint of civil law, of external moral order. By introducing strict household discipline the father in the parable, even had he had a hundred sons as frivolously self-willed as "the lost one," would doubtless have trained them all to punctual obedience; for paternal authority is great when power is applied in time and compulsion passes over into habit. By a cleverly calculated and prudently executed system of compulsion he would doubtless have secured himself against the excesses of self-will; but there is one thing he could not do — for not even God in heaven can do it — he could not by any system of compulsion whatever force freedom upon his children.

γ) **The Burdens of Freedom.**

That freedom in the absolute sense is its own end is surely self-evident; but where
 [411] man is involved, the life of freedom is in the making, and freedom in the making is a continual liberation. From what? We can answer at once: from unfreedom. But since unfreedom, as a finite condition, has many forms, and since here in this context the subject is in particular civic freedom in the Kingdom of the Son, attention is involuntarily drawn to the many kinds of toils, burdens and oppressions that otherwise rest upon the citizens of any other kingdom whatever (even of one that could otherwise boast of the very freest constitution), but which all without exception fall away, or at any rate are destined to fall away, in freedom's own kingdom. By this are meant all the burdens, oppressions and cares that arise from temporality being allowed to press with all its enormous weight upon the mind of man without the counter-pressure of the eternal.

The goal of freedom is to lift the pressure of temporality by the impression of eternity. For the eternal does not press upon man's mind in the way the temporal does. Were that the case, it would be terrible to be a citizen in the Kingdom of the Son. Midway between two such powers as temporality and eternity, man would surely be crushed to death under pressure and counter-pressure of superhuman strength; and what then would become of freedom? No, the fact is that only the pressure of temporality acts depressingly, burdensomely, like a yoke of bondage, whereas the pressure of eternity acts upliftingly, liberatingly, and precisely thereby counteracts everything that depresses.

"Come unto me, all ye that labor and are heavy laden! I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn of me, for I am meek and lowly in heart; and ye shall find rest unto your souls. For my yoke is profitable, and my burden is light." "But," someone says, "then here, after all, is a yoke!" Yes indeed, but the yoke is profitable; for it is the yoke of freedom. "And a burden!" Yes, but it is the burden of freedom,
 [412] and the burden is light. For what really matters is not what burden one has to bear, but how he bears it, what strength he has to bear with. Now here lies the great difference between the yoke of freedom and that of bondage: that the latter taxes one's strength without giving strength, whereas the former gives strength, the strength of eternity, and all the more and the greater the more freely the yoke is borne. If

we take the yoke of meekness, of humility, of patience, then it is certainly a heavy yoke, insofar as the temporal alone is thought of here. Who, in the selfish temporal sense, is meek, except the one who feels within himself that he must put up with much because he is capable of little? Then there is in meekness a gnawing sorrow, a bitter melancholy, a hidden pain: it bears a dark mark of unfreedom. The same burden weighs upon humility; it goes with bowed head, downcast gaze. Who, in the selfish temporal sense, is humble, except the humbled one, the deeply shamed one, who, alas, has had to feel his impotence? What cowedness and powerless resignation to the inevitable does not suffering, defenseless patience display! The free, proud nature announces itself with courage, not with patience. — “That which in mean men we entitle patience is pale cold cowardice in noble breasts.” — Thus every yoke in the temporal bears all the marks of temporality and bondage. But if the impression of eternity is added, the yoke is changed. The burden in itself remains the same; weighed on the scales of temporality it may even become greater; but the strength does not remain the same, on the contrary! it is heightened by infinite increase. But when the burden, however heavy it may be, continues to be finite, while the strength grows infinitely, the yoke must surely become infinitely light. Who, then, is the humble one? He who, in spite of all the world’s scorn, does not bow before any finite authority, because he has in freedom bowed deeply before the ideal of all authority, the almighty Self. So he bears the yoke of scorn, but he bears it infinitely lightly. And who has [413] the greatest superiority, the selfishly courageous one or the one who is patient in humility? When the courageous one challenges a stronger, who takes his armor from him and binds him, then the courageous one is unfree: he cannot possibly be at once both bound and yet free; but the patient one, who, although he is bound, is yet free, free like a Paul in chains, is the superior. Under the yoke of freedom, in virtue of inner liberation, meekness, humility, patience are precisely the highest, purest expression of personal superiority. He who says, “I am meek and lowly in heart,” says it as one who knows within himself that he has the strength of eternity to bear all the burdens of temporality; he says it with divine superiority.

That the eternal exists for a person, so that the person is truly absorbed in the present eternity, is recognized precisely by his being freed from cares about the

temporal, and this in turn is recognized by his living in the moment. Living in the moment is a peculiar matter. The frivolous man lives in the moment; the true citizens of the Kingdom of the Son live in the moment: the moment is infinitely different according as it expresses punctually either the temporal or the eternal. The citizens of a temporal state may, when they belong to the favored, doubtless be exempted from many cares that otherwise weigh heavily upon the lowlier; but there is one kind of care from which they cannot be exempted, and that is cares about the future. The number of cares about the future is Legion; there is a day tomorrow, and its possibilities are incalculable. In the Kingdom of the Son eternity is put in the place of the future, and the day tomorrow vanishes. "Take no thought for the morrow." Eternity is what is absolutely present in the moment. He who is absorbed in the present eternal does not [414] see the anxious possibilities of the future; in order to move toward the goal, he has turned his back to the goal. "It is always delaying and distracting to want impatiently, every moment, to look toward the goal, to see whether one is coming a little nearer to it, and now again a little nearer. No, be resolved for eternity and in earnest, and then you turn yourself wholly toward the work — and your back to the goal. . . . One would think that the believer was farthest removed from the eternal, he who has wholly turned his back on it and lives today, while the one who peers ahead stands and looks toward it. And yet the believer is nearest of all to the eternal, while an apocalypticist is farthest of all from the eternal. Faith turns its back on the eternal precisely in order to have it wholly with itself in this very day. But if a person turns, and especially in earthly passion, toward what is to come, then the next day becomes an enormous, confused figure, like that of the fairy tale. Just as those demons of whom we read in the first book of Moses begot children with earthly women, so what is to come is the enormous demon that, with man's womanish imagination, begets the next day"⁶².

The goal of freedom is a punctual fulfilment of the laws of the spirit; but it makes an infinite difference whether these laws are conceived as laws of compulsion or as laws of freedom. What the difference means can be seen by a glance at the legislation. "Ye have heard that it hath been said: Thou shalt love thy friend and hate thine enemy. But I say unto you: love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them

⁶²S. Kierkegaard. *Christelige Taler*. Kjøbenhavn. 1848. S. 84–85.

that hate you, and pray for them which do you harm and persecute you; that ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven; for he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust" (Matt. 5). Were this now to be conceived as an inner, spiritual law of compulsion, a cold, inescapable law of duty: then in truth the yoke of the law would become so heavy that man would [415] have to sink under the burden. It is otherwise, however, when the law is conceived as a law of freedom; for in the feeling of infinite deliverance there is an infinite joy. It is a psychological fact that a person can, in what he calls the happiest moments of his life, be so glad, can in the inwardness of joy feel himself so freed from all selfish considerations, so lifted above all personal injuries, that he could even fall upon the neck of his bitterest enemy. Let this be a passing mood; such a mood nevertheless testifies that there is a joy, a joy of deliverance so rich and great that the one delivered shall surely be able to repay evil with good and to love even his enemies.

b) The Kingdom of Love.

§ 28.

In the living, immediately conscious unity of love with freedom lies joy. The Kingdom of the Son is a kingdom of joy because it is a kingdom of freedom and of love. But just as freedom, conditioned by the struggle of self-development, must fight its way forward to the goal, so the same holds of love: one may then speak of a struggling love just as well as of a struggling freedom; indeed, it may with reason be said that they not only fight together as brothers in arms against a common enemy, lovelessness, bondage, but that each, during the struggle, also ceaselessly strives to cover and shield the other, love freedom, and freedom in turn love. Therefore there is joy in the struggle itself, but only when the struggle has ended in victory is the joy complete.

For the consideration of struggling love three points of view present themselves [416] here: *its essence, its goal, its external resistance, i.e. its limit.*

α) The Essence of Love: Hatred and Love.

It lies in the essence of love that it must have not only its object but also its content. In love of self to self the emphasis is laid exclusively on the object; for only a self can in the unconditional sense be not only the subject of love but also its object, its counterpart. In the love of the Idea, on the other hand, the object vanishes, or rather "it transforms itself into sheer content." In love of art, for example, one can of course say that art is the object of love; but, looked at more closely, art is nevertheless no more an external thing than an existing self is. Art is essence; to love art is to immerse oneself in its essence, to conceive its phenomena as expressive forms for the content of the Idea. He who with his love of art gets no further than a fancier's taste for the great masterpieces as precious objects, "objects of art," does not love art.

That it is really the self that gives personal love its object can be seen directly from the opposite of love, namely hatred. One can certainly, in unfettered style, speak of hating the most diverse things, certain Ideas, e.g. freedom, certain animals, e.g. cats. But if we look more closely, it is the passion of hatred that personifies now an object, now a content of essence, and does so with all the greater vehemence the more strongly the intolerable forces itself upon the individual. The involuntary personification indicates that the real object of hatred must be something personal.

Love of the good presupposes hatred of evil. But in the religious sense, as we have [417] seen, the good is inseparable from the good Self, the Good One; in a corresponding way evil, too, is then inseparable from the evil self, the Evil One. In the language of humanitarianism it sounds fine enough, to be sure, that one should hate faults but not persons, hate the evil in men but not men. But religion, which after all inculcates love of man in a quite different and higher sense, cannot thus without further ado separate the evil in men from evil men; religion maintains that evil is both one with and yet distinct from man's self. And what does it then do in order to carry out this two-sided conception in practice? It places — out of love of man — the original evil in a superhuman self, the evil self, which is unconditionally the object of hatred.

The ambiguous connection of the evil self with what is selfish in men and with the multiplicity of natural impulses, conditions of actuality and temporal states, through which the threads of reciprocal action wind enigmatically, this great, intricate, ambiguous whole receives in the Kingdom of the Son the name of the world. How ambiguous

this figure is emerges clearly enough from the fact that it is set up as the object of both love and hatred. God loves the world, and God hates the world: love of God is hatred of the world. By proceeding from the category of the world it is impossible to arrive at clear insight into what it really is that is here to be loved and hated. Therefore we proceed from love; in love itself must lie the principle for the determination of its content and object.

If we set the two propositions, *love of God is hatred of the world*, and *love of the world is hatred of God*, sharply against each other without any intermediate determinations, then both lose their validity in the Kingdom of the Son, precisely because the Kingdom [418] of the Son is the eternally true kingdom of love.

According to the first proposition love does indeed receive its unconditional object, but without content. The object of love is God: "Thou shalt love God above all things," this is the true part. But in what and by what is love of God now to show itself? By hating the world and all the things that are in the world! thus by casting away the content of love, by merely expressing love negatively; here the untrue part comes in. To love God is impossible without loving men. So love of God must then receive its determinate tasks, its positive content, in the so-called works of love: to feed the hungry, clothe the naked, visit the sick, etc. But now the principle has sublated itself; for he who has literally given up everything in the world must reduce food and clothing to the least possible, indeed he must even hate such necessities as something that belongs to this world. But he who himself hates food and clothing because he hates the world, how can he with a good conscience want to seduce others into accepting what he himself, out of love of God, must hate? The simplest consequences of the principle lead to madness. He who practices works of love without perversity therefore proceeds, too, from an entirely different presupposition, for he proceeds from the presupposition that there is temporal need which ought to be relieved temporally, that the world, however evil it may be in many respects, nevertheless has certain goods that are not to be despised; more definitely still: he proceeds from the presupposition that it is precisely in the actual world, in the acquisition and use of its goods, that love of God must seek its tasks and find its content.

According to the second proposition love receives its content on the condition

[419] that it loses its unconditional object. First the love of the Idea is without further ado made one with love of God, as when it is said that the true cultivation of science is worship of God, the inspired practice of art worship of God, etc.; from here there is then a fairly smooth transition, or rather a gradual descent, to the religion of minding one's trade. If now the commandment of love, Thou shalt love God above all things, is expressly made to hold against the higher as well as against the lower worldliness, then "the modern consciousness" rises up with the protest that the divine Self, which in science is without reality, may not exercise any influence on practical life either. The gaze, it is said, becomes confused by staring at a beyond instead of seeking its tasks in the present. As long as the religious representation of the divine Self, jealous of its exclusive right to men's love and worship, is not given up, so long will the view of life be ascetic at its innermost core; believers can, despite their interest in culture and humanity, only with a bad conscience give themselves over to what in their quiet minds they must condemn as ungodly eudaemonism.

In the principle of faith, i.e. of love, correctives for both errors are contained. Love cannot let go of its object; its unconditional object is God; and God wills to be loved above all things. All things in the world, all things without exception, must therefore be given up, indeed become objects of hatred, when it turns out that they weaken or supplant love of God. There may therefore arise a state of the world that makes it necessary for true love of God to express itself negatively in renunciation of the world, indeed in hatred of the world. But it stands no less firm for all that, that love must have its content, a content that is conditioned by man's relation to the world. What makes the relation necessarily negative under certain conditions, the same thing [420] makes it necessarily positive under other conditions. The decisive thing does not depend on the difference between the negative and the positive, but it depends on the expression itself, whether it is otherwise negative or positive, becoming a true expression of love, an essential expression of the content of love. If unconditional love of God can find its expression in a positive content of the world, in civic activity, in working for Ideas, etc., then the relation ought to be positive; if it cannot find its expression in anything positive, whether the reason for this is to be sought in the inner peculiarity of the individual concerned or in given conditions of the world, then

the expression must be negative. The negative is in itself no better than the positive. Fasting, mortification and flagellation can, when such penitential exercises are deified, just as well draw the mind away from true love of God as artistic or scientific activity can when the Ideas are deified. It is an illusion that a person, by turning away from the world, should be able to love God solely as God, so that love itself would become the content of love. By what, then, should a person express pure love of God positively? By unconditional renunciation of the world! Thus by expressing it negatively. Even the most negative expression will need something temporal through which to take up its positive moment, namely the eternal. For the eternal is indeed qualitatively different from the temporal; but it receives its form only by reflecting itself in the temporal, by its pure light being, so to speak, refracted in the prism of temporality.

β) The Goal of Love: The Salvation of the World.

“Love of God is hatred of the world”: when this proposition, as a revivalist shibboleth for sour-minded godliness, without any correctives and intermediate determinations, is to be the sign of citizenship in the Kingdom of the Son, then protest must be [421] made in the name of the Gospel. If hatred of the world is the highest emblem on the banner of Christ, then Christ cannot possibly be cognized as the Savior of the world. If it begins with hatred, then it cannot end with salvation either. As self-contradictory as it is that a savior of the world should begin his work as a hater of the world, just as contradictory is it that a hater of the world should be able to appear as savior of the world. Christ’s work does not begin with hatred, no, it begins with love. “For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life” (John 3:16).

As regards the beginning, it is highly significant that the first sign by which Jesus, according to the Gospel of John, “manifested his glory” to the disciples was precisely the miracle at the wedding in Cana (John 2). That Christ sits at table among the wedding guests and surprises the steward of the feast by turning water into wine stands in such decisive contradiction to everything that resembles an ascetic hatred of the spirit’s immediate joy in life, that this beginning bears witness from the ground up to the opposite. Without in the remotest way offending the holy, or supposing that

Christ would have reduced the miracle to a means of festive entertainment, we may freely say that he chose precisely a setting and a moment which in the most decisive sense are suited to ward off the misunderstanding that the pure, holy joy he had to bring should set itself in hostility against a universally human joy in life. Were it actually Christ's intention to sow discord between joy in God and the natural joy of life, then the critique of faith would simply have to declare the Gospel of the wedding at Cana spurious. For the matter is plainly presented thus, that the joy over "the good wine" heightens the joy which had already begun with "the worse." Here so gentle [422] a transition is made from the natural to the spiritual, that the joy of faith comes as an addition to the joy of life, a divine wedding gift, a blessing that glorifies the feast. Were the miracle to be understood otherwise; were its significance to be placed in this, that it contains a sentence of punishment upon natural joy: then an elucidating word would necessarily have had to be added. The elucidating word would then presumably have had to run somewhat thus: "All sensuous enjoyment, all natural joy, and so also all wedding joy, is in its essence sinful. To show how sinful it is to drink the wine that was poured out here for the wedding guests, I offer you another wine. Whoever drinks the new wine drinks in hatred of the world and of all the world's joys, the joys of family life too; but he who will not hate the world and the world's joys, to him the new wine will not taste good." How far such an interpretation departs from the character of the narrative can then be seen, among other things, in the steward of the feast. For the steward, who tastes the new wine, must find that the wine is good, and yet he does not taste as one awakened, who is on the point of despising all the world's wine and all the world's joy; no, he tastes as a steward of the feast, freely brings his steward's experience to bear, without the least inkling that the good wine was to herald a hatred that would then have to turn first of all against stewards of feasts.

To convince ourselves properly how false and erroneous it is to conceive the fundamental character of the Gospel ascetically, we cite a couple of features from the Synoptics. John the Baptist, the preacher of repentance under the old Law, appeared as an ascetic; he "had his raiment of camel's hair and a leathern girdle about his loins; and his meat was locusts and wild honey." But that Christ, precisely in this respect,

presented in the eyes of his contemporaries a counter-image to John, we learn from his own words: "But whereunto shall I liken this generation? It is like unto little children [423] sitting in the markets, and calling unto their fellows, and saying, We have piped unto you, and ye have not danced; we have mourned unto you, and ye have not wept. For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, He hath a devil. The Son of man came eating and drinking, and they say, Behold a man gluttonous, and a winebibber, a friend of publicans and sinners" (Matt. 11:16–19). A stronger testimony that Christ by no means appeared as an exemplar for those who express their hatred of the world by fasting and drinking water can scarcely be given. Let one consider what it means that the Pure One, the Holy One himself, so far disdained all outward, arbitrarily chosen signs of godliness that slander could even find occasion to brand him a glutton and a winebibber!

But, someone might ask, how can this conception of the joy of life be reconciled with the doctrine of continued suffering? For an answer to this question it is necessary to recall that the absolute heterogeneity of the principles, of faith and of reason, has not merely theoretical but also practical validity. Natural sorrow and natural joy form finite opposites, such that the more joy grows, the more sorrow diminishes, and conversely; this holds not merely directly for the cases in which the occasion is the same, but also, if only mediately, in such cases in which joy over the one thing weighs against sorrow over the other: the more alike the causes are, the more direct the opposition. It is otherwise with religious suffering and the natural alternation of sorrows and joys; here the causes are absolutely heterogeneous. Religious suffering forms an immediate opposite to natural joy just as little as to natural sorrow; natural joy, when the principle of faith is held fast, can just as little diminish the inner religious suffering as natural sorrow can increase it. This is not to be understood as if the absolutely heterogeneous [424] causes did not concern one another, could not enter into interaction with one another. On the contrary! Religious suffering will act upon natural sorrow, now increasing it and now diminishing it, and in both cases give it a stamp of its own; likewise with religious suffering and natural joy.

If the Christ-principle were not absolutely heterogeneous with any whatsoever among the many and various principles of the human world, and if the absolutely

heterogeneous principles could not enter into interaction, Christ could not possibly be the Savior of the world. His kingdom, which is not of this world, would then either have to relate itself with absolute indifference to everything its citizens might undertake in purely worldly affairs, or else demand that all worldly institutions and all worldly order be abolished. But that neither is the case every sober-minded person will surely concede. Christianity will transform the mind and way of thinking of human beings; nothing more — with that everything is said. The inward transformation is absolutely heterogeneous with any relative change whatsoever, be it inward or outward, that can take place in a worldly respect with human beings and human societies. But the inward, religious transformation in turn exerts an infinitely reshaping influence upon everything worldly. Just as the God who preserves and governs all does not himself intervene finitely here and there in the course of events, because he stands not in a finite but in an infinite relation to the world he governs, so too the world-redeeming principle will reshape the world of human beings without intervening finitely in worldly affairs.

Just as little as Christ with his Gospel will ascetically weaken the natural conditions of life, just so little will he undermine either the state or civil society: there is nothing [425] in his ethics that encroaches upon the right of property. Rich and poor, lowly and mighty, authorities and subjects, lawful livelihood and civil property: all such things belong, after all, to the order of this world, and Christ does not hate this world. How indeed should he hate it, when he wills to save it? That he wills to save it cannot possibly mean, then, that he wills to rob it of the properties that essentially belong to it as world. If that were so, he would indeed not save it but destroy it. But he wills to save it, he wills to free it from a dangerous evil, a mortal disease; for he sees it: the world is sick, its life is in danger, it — has been bitten by the serpent. Its strong constitution, rich in rejuvenating powers, does indeed resist; but the wound burns: there is fever heat; the pulse races: there is poison in the blood! So he wills to save this sick world, to heal it of the serpent's bite of egoism, of the poison of self-contradiction, of sin.

γ) The Limit of Love: The World's Hatred.

It is not Christ who hates the world; but there is in the world a something that hates Christ; this something, which sets a limit to all-embracing love itself, must then be the object of hatred for those who in truth love Christ. What, then, is this something? It is, to designate it by the name of love, self-seeking love, selfish self-love. Love of God is hatred of the world; but the world that is here most immediately the object of hatred is not the great outward world with its emperors and kings, but the little inward one, the world of self-will, of self-seeking love, of vanity, which the individual can contain in his own breast: love of God is hatred of oneself. But to hate oneself, how foolish, how unnatural! Only the strong self can love, and only the strong self can hate; but when the selfishly strong self is forced toward a turning point where [426] it has only the choice between unconditionally loving itself and hating the truth, or unconditionally hating itself and loving the truth, how natural then that it chooses the former. "Richard loves Richard — I am myself alone." Now if self-love can so easily transform itself selfishly in the individual human being into hatred of the truth when the truth demands a sacrifice, then this will surely be able to happen with still greater force and on a far larger scale when individuals do not stand alone, each by himself, but feel themselves united in a common body, a comprehensive, manifoldly ramified universal body, a social body, so permeated and interwoven and worked through from top to bottom by egoism in all forms and in all shapes that even the oppressed find it natural that those in power defy the laws: such is the unredeemed world.

It is a peculiar matter with such virtues as compassion, love of humankind, and self-sacrifice for truth. At a distance, in general, such fine virtues are of course praised by all; one would therefore think that if someone appeared who practiced them unconditionally, he would have to be honored, loved, indeed worshiped, most of all by the eyewitnesses. And yet precisely the relation between Christ and the world shows that the reverse happens. It happens on such a scale that we learn from it how the Mystery in Christ's revelation relates to the paradox.

In itself, Christ's self-sacrificing love must indeed be said to be a mystery, insofar as in spiritual purity, depth, and inexhaustibility it surpasses human comprehension: no one is able to put himself in Christ's place, see with his eye and feel with his heart. But we can by no means say, so long as we keep exclusively to the concepts of faith,

that this love is a paradox. The love of the God-man and the God-man himself agree [427] perfectly; here there appears no contradiction insoluble in the form of the concept. It is otherwise, however, when we take our stand on the standpoint of existence and seek, as S. Kierkegaard expresses it, “to become contemporary with Christ.” For what happens then? Then ideal love steps forth as an actual, existing human being; actual love and egoistic actuality come so close to one another that a cutting conflict arises. To see divine love in the form of a servant is like seeing the existing contradiction.

Outwardly, immediately, the God-man looks like any other human being, without power, without means: he has not, after all, “where to lay his head.” That is the immediate impression of actuality, and sensuous immediacy has a striking power; it acts irresistibly upon the beholder. So it is, then, in actuality a lowly human being, insignificant in the eyes of the world, who appears here. And yet this human being speaks with an authority as if he were Lord of heaven and earth. Indeed, he not only speaks, he acts out of the highest ideal presuppositions of love; every word, every action then looks like a monstrous exaggeration, an intolerable extravagance: here we have the paradox.

Even if Christ had not spoken a single word against the hypocrisy of the Pharisees, had not with a single word rebuked the unbelief of the age, his life and works, his love of humankind, would still have contained such a judgment upon the egoistic age that this alone would have been enough to arouse the bitterest hatred. Since he now not only bore witness to the truth but also laid bare the lie, not only himself did the works of love but testified against the world “that the works thereof are evil”: the hatred flared up, a hatred that knew no bound.

[428] Yet it is with many an ingrained prejudice that the world in Christ’s time must have been more evil than it is now, since even the chosen people could commit so crying a crime as that of crucifying the Savior of the world. One must really pull oneself together and keep awake in order actually to understand that the same hatred which then followed the King of truth on the way of love follows him still, wherever he shows himself present in his true witnesses. Had Christ, to use S. Kierkegaard’s expression, “looked the way the merely human notion of compassion would form his figure, and had he had the merely human notion of what compassion is,” then neither

would his love have been thus rewarded with hatred. "For human beings are willing enough to practice compassion and self-denial, willing enough to strive after wisdom, etc.; but they want to determine the measure themselves, that it should be such to a certain degree; they do not want to abolish these glorious virtues; on the contrary, they want — at a cheap price — in all comfort to have the appearance and name of practicing them. True divine compassion is therefore unconditionally the victim as soon as it shows itself in the world. It comes out of compassion for human beings, and it is human beings who trample it down. And while it walks about among them, the sufferer scarcely ventures to flee to it for fear of men"⁶³.

Christ says to the disciples: "Blessed are the eyes which see the things that ye see. For I tell you, that many prophets and kings have desired to see those things which ye see, and have not seen them; and to hear those things which ye hear, and have not heard them" (Luke 10; Matt. 13). These words fit all who in faith can become contemporary with Christ, thus all who can actually endure the sight of the contrast between the inner glory and the outer lowliness. But that those who without living faith regard him in the form of a servant receive no attractive but on the contrary a repellent, [429] offensive impression, the more offensive the more actual the contemporaneity is made, S. Kierkegaard has shown by describing the phenomenon of his appearance. What an appearance, and in what company! "Everyone knows, after all, that one judges a person by the company he seeks — and his company! Yes, his company one could describe as this: to be cast out of human company; his company is the lowest class of the people, further it is sinners and publicans — whom everyone who is the least bit anything shuns for the sake of his good name and reputation, and a good name and reputation is surely the least one can wish to secure in life; his company is furthermore lepers, whom everyone avoids, madmen, who only arouse horror, the sick and the wretched, poverty and misery. And who then is he, he who in this procession is still the object of the persecution of the mighty? He is one who is a seducer, deceiver, blasphemer, despised! It is a kind of compassion if some person of standing does not actually express his contempt for him — that they fear him is of course another matter."

⁶³Indøvelse i Christendom. S. 67–68.

“If the world hate you, ye know that it hated me before it hated you” (John 15:18).

c) The Kingdom of Blessedness.

§ 29.

The purer, clearer, and stronger the opposition between love of God and the selfishly self-loving mind appears, the more palpable will be the strife between the holy and the sinful, and with it also the tension between the eternal and the temporal. When Christ, with divinely strengthened emphasis, repeated the Baptist's exhortation [430] *μετανοεῖτε ἥγγικε γὰρ ἡ βασιλεία τῶν οὐρανῶν*, it was as if eternity and time collided: the collision was so violent that the present and the to-come went apart from each other like two heterogeneous worlds. The highest is offered, and the highest is demanded; by this every intermediate stage of finitude vanishes, and the knot of decision is drawn tight to the utmost. Had it been a kingdom of happiness, an earthly messianic kingdom, in which a supernatural splendor of the eternal fell in rich rays, glorifying, upon the temporal, then the tension between the present and the to-come would easily have been evened out; but then the egoism of the world would also only have been ennobled and, by the ennoblement, strengthened, but by no means sublated. Now the “kingdom of heaven” proclaimed by the Savior is not a kingdom of happiness but a kingdom of blessedness, thus a kingdom that reduces temporal welfare and earthly happiness to something so subordinate and vanishing that it ought unconditionally to be sacrificed as a means for the eternal end, and only when it has been freely given up can come along as an addition to the highest, according to the exhortation: “Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.” On these terms, then, the opposition between the temporal and the eternal, the present and the to-come, had to come forth in all its severity. What significance this opposition has, under what forms it reveals its content, will appear when we consider in particular what the Gospel teaches us about the *end of the world*, the *resurrection of the dead*, and the *Judgment*.

α) The End of the World.

The hatred with which the egoism of the world counteracted Christ's kingdom from the very beginning betrayed clearly enough that, just as there was in the world something that could be saved, so there was also something that could not be saved, something that according to its nature was destined to perish. The selfish being in [431] which human self-will has entangled itself stands in such close connection with the sensuous, corruptible world-order as a whole, that the judgment upon the egoistic principle in the self and the judgment upon the corruptibility of the outward, natural world must, from the standpoint of revelation, determine each other mutually. In this respect too the ambiguity of the world shows itself; for one can with reason speak both of the imperishability of the world and of its perishability. The world is imperishable according to its universal essence; what changes is only the form of the world. But form and essence in turn correspond to each other in such a way that an essential change of form presupposes and brings with it a change in essence.

The opposition between the scientific and the religious view of the world is here again conspicuous. That the world, i.e. this actual, bounded world existing in a determinate state, is not only changeable but also perishable, science must concede; it will not even find it impossible that a time may come when the sun's fire is extinguished, the sources of heat are exhausted, and our whole planetary system is wrapped in death and darkness⁶⁴. But the end is only partial; the form of the perishable world maintains itself in other perishable worlds: thus the infinite continuation of the perishable gives the scientific observer an imposing impression of the imperishability of the world.

It is otherwise from the standpoint of revelation: a world that crucifies its own Savior is condemned to perish. With its gaze fixed on the corruptible in human life and the egoism corresponding to it in the human self, religion proclaims not merely a change but a transformation of the form of this world, a transformation in which [432] the corruptible vanishes away and the incorruptible comes to full revelation. That Christ in the Gospel foretold the end of the world is certain, just as it is also certain that the apostles took it to be imminent, and that its non-occurrence early (2 Pet. 3:4) aroused offense. The question now is how the presupposition is to be more precisely conceived, how, in other words, the end of the world is to be objectified. On the

⁶⁴That the end of which science speaks is another than that of which the Gospel speaks goes without saying.

presupposition that theology is an objective science, the dogmaticians, older and newer, have naturally all been agreed in subjecting the doctrine of the end of the world to a scientific discussion, both with regard to the time and especially with regard to the manner. We shall here, following Strauss, merely cite a sample.

“Just as, on the ground of the statements of the N. T., it was constantly believed in the Church that the last day and the end of the world stood at the door, so it was also thought that this could be seen in the world, which was supposed to be visibly growing old already. And since the N. T. determined the end of the world as a burning up and set this final destruction over against the earth’s earlier devastation by water, some Church Fathers already, as also more recent natural scientists and theologians, assumed that the moist element was to be successively consumed by fire, so that at a certain point a universal world-conflagration would break out. From the ruins of the old world a new, more glorious one was then to come forth; a transformation which the Church Fathers and the Scholastics almost unanimously, in agreement with their notions of the renewal of human bodies, were not accustomed to conceive as an annihilation of the world’s substance, but only as a change of its accidents. In Luther’s well-known remark, too, that the heavens now had their workday clothes on but would [433] then put on their Sunday clothes, lies the same notion; but the Lutheran dogmaticians preferred the doctrine that this world was to be destroyed as regards its substance too. A world, and in it human bodies, both the same as before as regards their essence, but with other properties — that was indeed, each by itself, a contradiction, but both sides at least fitted together; our dogmaticians wanted their resurrection bodies to stand in contradiction both with themselves and with their place of abode. For this was not likewise to be a transfigured corporeal world, but the perpetually existing heaven, which was not first to be produced by the end of the present world: in a place immaterial by nature, then, beings were to dwell who were still matter. The newer supranaturalism has therefore” — with express acceptance of a partial end — “returned to the notion of a mere transformation of the world. ... When the so-called end of the world had thus, through the restriction of its scope, been moved into the series of natural cosmic processes, the renewal and transfiguration of the world that was to follow upon the destruction thereby came to stand on still shakier ground. A

conflagration, Michaelis objects, would have to turn the earth into a barren slag, and so rather destroy than beautify it; and the comfort he offers against this is extremely meager; for he says that one cannot, after all, know whether the conflagration may not leave some fertile land over"⁶⁵.

What comes of scientific investigations of this sort, and how much "fruitful land" is left over in theology once the critical Moses-fire that is ravaging it finally dies down, we will not investigate further here. The main thing is that the standpoint must be changed.

"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away"; thus [434] speaks the personal truth. The one who speaks is not impressed by the outward magnitude of the edifice of the world, for he speaks the language of personality with authority, decisively. The natural world with its sun and moon and stars, however mighty and great the whole edifice may look, is subject to the laws of necessity; but he, whose essence is freedom itself, knows with undeceivable certainty that the laws of necessity are grounded in divine freedom. The final catastrophe, the thoroughgoing transformation of the world with which the Kingdom of Christ is to reveal itself "with power and great glory," cannot be objectified in knowledge; it can only be objectified in faith. It is not the outwardly natural but the inwardly personal that gives conviction its unshakable foundation. — "If you would have full assurance of the unconditioned power of the spirit over corruptible nature, then lay hold of freedom and beware of staring at necessity! If it is truly the way to the Kingdom of truth, of personality, and of blessedness that you seek, then do not stray into the regions of impersonal cognitions; do not seek guidance from astronomers and physicists and philosophers of nature, for the way of knowledge is not the way of faith; but turn to him who is the way and the truth and the life"⁶⁶.

Christ alone has absolute certainty of the actuality of the blessed Kingdom, an incorruptibility that is mightier than this corruptible nature; but the certainty is personal, not scientific. The decisive moment, the moment when he had to say to his enemies: this is your hour and the power of darkness, that very moment he used, even at the last, to utter his full assurance: "Nevertheless I say unto you, hereafter shall ye

⁶⁵Troesl. II. S. 540 flgd.

⁶⁶Cf. Forelæsninger over Hindrgr. og Betglr. for det aandl. Liv i Nutid. S. 194–207.

[435] see the Son of man sitting on the right hand of power, and coming in the clouds of heaven” (Matt. 26:64).

The transformation of the natural world is a Mystery; but it is not an absurdity. The absurd arises from a double blunder. On the side of the doctrine of faith, from depicting to oneself an actuality that conflicts with every concept of actuality; on the side of the critique of knowledge, when, holding fast to the actuality known to us as the only possible one, one makes natural process and corruptibility into correlative concepts and contrives contradictions out of arbitrarily fixed presuppositions⁶⁷, instead of resolving the determinations of the concept in the Mystery of nature and creation⁶⁸.

β) The Resurrection of the Dead.

The bodily organism is the natural, indispensable foundation of the individual personality. What significance corporeality has in this respect is seen, from the standpoint of revelation, in Christ’s resurrection and ascension. But instead of entering upon any description whatever of the individual peculiarity of bodies after the resurrection, the philosophy of religion holds strictly to the simple contrast, characterized by Paul (1 Cor. 15:1–28), between the corruptible and the incorruptible, and regards every fantastic, groping attempt to speculate out the more precise determinations as a thoughtless deviation from the principle of faith, a violation of the Mystery.

[436] Should anyone still be of the opinion that faith, as regards the images of the life to come, does not have enough in the actuality of the spirit, but must feel called upon to apply the measure of palpable actuality to the state of the blessed after the resurrection: let him try for once what comes of analyzing the peculiar constitution of glorified bodies. “According to the concurring doctrine of the orthodox teachers of the Church, the Scholastics, and the Protestant theologians, in the resurrection the same body is restored, with the same constituents that it had in earthly life, with skin and hair, entrails and genitals, bones and teeth (how else could gnashing of teeth take place in hell? asked Jerome). But now one at once got into difficulty with the hair.

⁶⁷That the transition from a corruptible to an incorruptible world order can be thought without contradiction even in science, the author has sought to show in *Grundideernes Logik*. II. S. 456–65.

⁶⁸How matters stand with the impossibility of making clear to oneself the actuality of a world to come is shown in *Forelæsning over „Phil. Propæd.“ for Universitetsaar 1861–62*. S. 123–38.

Christ had said that not one hair of our head should be lost (Luke 21:18). But how hideous would the body not become, asked Augustine, who connected this passage with the resurrection, if the whole length of the hair of the head and beard cut off over time, and perhaps the nails as well, were to grow back on it in the resurrection! It was a stroke of luck that the Lord had said in another place that all our hairs were numbered (Matt. 10:30); for in this one saw a comforting hint that with the restoration only the number, not the length, of the hairs was meant. But what if someone in this life had had just too few hairs? Bodily defects of every kind, Augustine thinks, are corrected in the pious at the resurrection, excess of fatness and of leanness evened out; yet in such a way that the basic features of the former figure, which are necessary to make the personality recognizable, are not effaced ... But the Church's doctrine did not represent the risen body as merely human-like as regards its outward contour but inwardly undifferentiated like a statue; rather, it also ascribed to it the inner organization of the old earthly body. But now ugly consequences arose, e.g. with [437] respect to the intestines, which Origen had already pointed out; but which the holy Thomas cleared away with the information that after the resurrection those vessels would be filled, instead of with their present contents, with fragrant essences. The veins were allowed to keep their blood all the more readily since, according to the doctrine of the Supper, Christ's glorified body also contained blood; on the other hand the genitals were deprived of semen, since among the risen they were no longer to come into activity. But why then are they restored, if they are no longer of any use? Origen had already asked; likewise, what are teeth for that are no longer to chew, a stomach that is no longer to digest? a question to which the orthodox teachers have remained unable to give a satisfactory answer."⁶⁹

When one goes through the history of the natural sciences in the last three centuries and notes the superabundance of idle reasonings and half-scientific objections with which every one of the great, world-famous theories has had to contend, one gets a notion of how easy it is to come forward with a mass of even apparently acute counter-proofs against fundamental views into whose details one has not yet worked one's way, and with whose spirit one has not become familiar. If it goes thus with

⁶⁹Strauss Troesl. II. S. 526–29.

views for which proofs and counter-proofs are to be sought in the world of facts that fall within the horizon of experience, then one will be able to understand that the reasonings that are drummed up, as much in defense as in attack, where the talk is of an order of things lying outside all human experience, have not the least scientific [438] value. The only thing that can be said about it is that, once the dogmaticians have set up the theories, it is quite in order that critique tears them down again.

γ) **The Day of Judgment: Blessedness and Damnation.**

If, according to the conditions of spiritual life, the principle of faith is the principle of blessedness itself, then it lies herein without contradiction that the principle of the denial of faith must be a principle of unblessedness, and the word of revelation that says: "He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned" (Mark 16:16), is thus in perfect agreement with itself. The scholastically objective doctrine of the Church, which, instead of stopping at the contrast of principle grounded in the matter itself, has entered upon far-ranging, over-ranging considerations concerning the possibility of damnation, with estimates of how many and which people can now really be supposed to be damned, has, by violating the Mystery, brought an incredible amount of confusion into religious thinking. There is, after all, an infinite difference between depicting damnation and the torments of the damned in order to warn against the possibility of damnation⁷⁰, and positing the [439] possibility of damnation as a settled actuality and making oneself a calm spectator at a play of unspeakable horrors; the former is religious and loving, the latter is dogmatically insane.

⁷⁰ "When we thus see Lady Macbeth walking in her sleep, washing the bloodstains from her hand, heaving those terrible sighs in which the repressed conscience seeks to give itself air, must we not say that the representation of eternal damnation forces itself upon us as a reality? For it is no true, no fruitful repentance under which she suffers; in her repentance there is only distress and anguish, but no desire for the good; she holds fast to the evil will, and the good is in her only as the bare possibility that is inseparable from the creature made in God's image. But this repressed possibility, held down in unrighteousness, rests like a hundredweight burden on her soul, without any condition being present for relief and deliverance through healthy repentance. And when we see her walk thus, is it not as though she must go on walking thus through aeons, weeping hell's tearless weeping, whereby we are reminded of the word: Fall on us, ye mountains, and cover us, ye hills." H. Martensen. *Den christelige Dogmatik*. S. 490.

That revelation not only assumes damnation to be possible, but even, in strong, horror-inspiring images, quite emphatically sets out to make the representation of eternal perdition present and living, is certain: it has sought in broad strokes to objectify the actual, last and uttermost contrast between perdition and salvation, damnation and blessedness. But there is a difference in objectification: one thing is objectification in faith, another is objectification in knowledge.

When the contrast of blessedness and damnation is objectified in faith, the standpoint is decisively determined: the one objectifying is a believer. The believer cannot possibly doubt the real possibility of damnation; he cannot say to himself: I do indeed believe in order to be saved, but it was perhaps also possible that I could be saved without believing. No, the stronger faith is, and the more living the hope of blessedness, the greater is also the fear of the opposite, of the denial of faith and unblessedness. That this must be so lies in the nature of the matter, and can be seen not only in a Luther but also in a Paul. That anxiety over the possibility of damnation, however involuntarily strong it may be in dark moments, does not become a soul-consuming torment, the Gospel has provided for by grounding faith on Christ's word and sacraments; but that the possibility of damnation must follow the ideal of blessedness as the shadow follows the body is incontrovertible. The certainty that faith gives is always a [440] personal certainty under personal responsibility. At the thought of the last, irrevocable judgment the believer is thus first and last referred to himself: that the judgment shall not come upon him, that it shall not be he who is lost. That the believer who is in truth concerned for his own salvation must also be able to be concerned for that of others goes without saying; but it depends on what kind of concern it is and how it expresses itself. The concern of love will then always be recognizable by the fact that it bears witness to concern for oneself, never enters upon official damnations, but everywhere, even when the signs of salvation are weak and those of perdition strong, keeps hope in Christ's word: "With men it is impossible, but with God all things are possible."

It is otherwise when the believer forgets the principle of faith, begins with a spectator's contemplation and sets out to objectify in knowledge. Here it is presupposed that the contemplator, for his own person, is sure enough of blessedness. He has

not even needed to work for the assurance in fear and trembling; he was, after all, born in the bosom of the sole saving Church and is partaker in all its goods. For the Church is to him an objective institution of blessedness, and since he is now once and for all in the institution — objective in the objective institution — he is, with this guarantee, quite sure of his own blessedness. He then has plenty of time to concern himself about the prospects for the blessedness of others. Dogmatic questions such as these, whether the heathen, not only those now living but those long since dead, can be saved, whether heretics can be saved, whether the devil might not perhaps also be saved in the end, etc., now acquire a great scientific significance. How indeed could the doctrine of faith be a science if it could not immerse itself in such scientific investigations? That the question of the Day of Judgment, of the time when it shall [441] come and the manner in which the whole thing shall proceed, must from this point of view be reckoned among the great dogmatic problems is beyond all doubt. And indeed, by indefatigable research, not so little has been done toward a scientific illumination of the Day of Judgment.

“Following the direction of the N. T. (?), our old Protestant dogmaticians conceived the judgment of the world which the returning Christ was to hold as a visible and audible event in time and space, and they distinguished between the three moments: the hearing, the passing and announcing of the sentence, and its execution. But a proper hearing of all human beings who have ever lived would, as was well understood, have to last longer than one day. — How long the Day of Judgment will last Michaelis does not know, but it is hardly one of 24 hours. Indisputably, says Reinhard, the judgment of the world must last long, which could happen all the better since the clear exposition of this important matter would be the most instructive spectacle for every thinking being and would spread the greatest light over the darkest secrets. But it can certainly not be determined by us at all with what outward circumstances this great event is to be connected. — For about 300 billion human beings the Day of Judgment would, according to a more recent calculation, have to last 100,000 years. Therefore Origen and other Fathers, admittedly in conflict with the New Testament representation, had put in place of the outward hearing an inward beholding of the Judge as present, and a living remembrance of all the actions of the past life, which

God would bring about in one moment in the inner being of all people. Since in this way people, even if they remained where each one happened to be, could nevertheless be judged in their inner being, one was at the same time — in a more ingenious manner than the old-Protestant dogmatics with its doctrine of the freedom of resurrection bodies from space — raised above every difficulty regarding a venue for so considerable an assembly, a difficulty that as late as the nineties prompted an unnamed thinker to [442] the calculation that if human beings, as was only fair, were to stand in judgment, a surface area the size of the Kingdom of Bohemia would be sufficient”⁷¹.

Here is knowledge in faith and faith in knowledge, scientific signs which show that objective dogmatics is longingly awaiting a Day of Judgment. [443]

⁷¹Strauss. Troesl. II. S. 544–45.

Faith in the Spirit.

A.

The Essence of the Spirit.

§ 30.

The objections of the critique of knowledge against positive religion can all be comprised in the one: *religion is spiritless*. So long now has learned objective science, as much in defense as in attack, tumbled about with the religious representations that the educated of the present must be tempted to regard the whole apparatus of traditional forms of revelation as soulless remains, as the corpse of a great, outlived thought of antiquity: science issues a certificate and attests that religion is dead. Before, however, trusting in the certificate, we fix the burial and send invitations to the funeral, we will nevertheless recall what is told in the tales of the Orient about sleepers who look like corpses because they sleep with a talisman, a magic sign, on their breast. A fortunate hand happens at the right moment to take the sign away, and the spell vanishes, and the sleeper opens his eyes, rises and lives.

If it is really true that religion is spiritless, then it must surely be really true that it is dead; and — it is a sad duty to bury the dead. But what does it now actually mean that religion is spiritless? That it is without spirit can surely not possibly mean that it [444] does not have the spirit of knowledge, that it is not science. But if it turns out that it is science which, being unable to cognize any spirit other than its own, has in its blindness tried to force its spirit into religion and yet has not managed it, because it met resistance, powerful resistance from the spirit of religion, then it is surely not religion that is without spirit in its relation to science, but conversely science that is spiritless in its maltreatment of religion. The spiritlessness of science has in this sense taken on two forms in particular, that of supranaturalism and that of rationalism.

Ecclesiastical-dogmatic supranaturalism is spiritless; for it sets a multiplicity of great, decisive opposed terms outwardly over against one another, without discovering the principle that pervades and unites them all. In an outward, finite manner it sets

God's will against the laws of nature and lets the miracle make an actual breach in the natural connection, although it nevertheless assures us that God is omnipresent in the world. In an outward, finite manner it sets a transcendent, supernatural world against this natural one, and nonetheless transfers determinations directly from the natural to the supernatural. In an outward, finite manner it posits three Persons in the one God; each of the Three is God, and yet — there are not three Gods. In an outward, finite manner it puts God and man together in Christ into one Person with two natures and two wills, a true man with a human nature that is nonetheless impersonal. In an outward, finite manner it puts the suprahistorical together with the historical, revelation with the Bible, God's word with Scripture, divine authority with blind authority, etc. That attempts at mediation by means of mitigating semi-supranaturalism, smoothing semi-rationalism, philosophically painted-up semi-pantheism, immanent-dogmatic theories of love, and such palliatives are not able to remedy the old-supranaturalist [445] spiritlessness, the bottomless absurdity, is understandable.

Modern philosophical rationalism is pantheism, and pantheism is spiritless. The doctrine of immanence levels, equalizes, and dissolves all oppositions in the absolute One, without clarifying the relation between the unity of the Absolute and the multiplicity of the relative. Everything is relative: right and left, right and wrong, up and down, freedom and bondage, wisdom and folly; everything in this world is relative, except the Absolute. By watering down the qualitative and setting the relativities in flux, one no doubt gets off lightly from the hard oppositions of existence; but then, with the empty, formal unity of the dissolved oppositions, the whole thing also ends in soul-devouring spiritlessness. The question with whose answer the whole view of life stands and falls, namely the question: *Is there an eternal self, independent in itself?* is answered once and for all with No in the philosophy of the Absolute; it is — *sat sapienti!*

As long as the doctrine of the Absolute was still in its first fresh development, the expectation of the final result held the thinking consciousness in spiritual suspense. It was, so one thought, still possible that the Absolute, once the development of its form had been properly carried through and all obscurities cleared up, might give eternal life a truer, richer presence; with this expectation it is over. One may alter the

conception as often as one likes, smooth off the development of the form as much as one likes, rub and polish the Absolute as zealously as one likes: the spirit does not return; one does not rub life into what is dead. The Absolute is indeed still, as before, a night of thoughts and so also a night of the spirit, insofar as all inner differences have vanished; but the secret has been betrayed. The night of the spirit is not, as in those [446] days of expectation, a holy night, the starlit night of twinkling Ideas; no, now it is the vulgar night of conceptual shadows, of trivial abstractions, of empty generalities, the night in which all cats are gray.

The Spirit of revelation is one with the eternal Self; only in this unity is life. For the elucidation of this rich unity we must then, on the given conditions of cognition, seek to grasp: *the self in the Spirit, fundamental determinations in the Spirit's Self and the personality of the Spirit.*

a) The Self in the Spirit.

§ 31.

Although the philosophy of religion, in the doctrine of the Spirit just as in the doctrine of the Father and the Son, must hold strictly to the presuppositions given in the faith of revelation, there is nevertheless something peculiar here in the development of the essence of the Spirit. Images and representations do not fit the Spirit himself in the way they do when the talk is either of the Son or of the Father. As regards the Spirit, then, the conceptual development of the philosophy of religion ought expressly to aim at showing how the elements of representation contained in the religious view can, according to their inner correspondence, be conceived as elements and subsidiary determinations of the concept of the Spirit. The living Spirit must have a foundation; in order to determine the Self of the Spirit we must consider the foundation in particular, first in the universal, then in the individual.

α) The Spirit on the Foundation of the Universal.

It has already been indicated in the doctrine of creation that the Spirit, who moves over the waters, is viewed as an intermediate being between Creator and creature. For the religious view, then, the Spirit does not appear immediately and from the beginning as a divine Self — for the Self is God — but rather as selfhood, universal [447] essentiality. That this essentiality is not empty but infinitely rich in content follows of itself, since the Spirit is Godhead. By letting either omnipotence or omniscience or wisdom move over the waters instead of the Spirit, we at once get an impression of the empty, the one-sided, the fantastic; for knowledge, power, wisdom are subsidiary determinations of the Spirit, are comprehended by the Spirit, who encloses all Ideas in his universal-concrete selfhood. That this fullness of the Godhead, this universal rich in content, is not an object of essence for knowledge but a vision of life for faith, is seen already from the fact that the Spirit is not in the waters but moves over them. The almighty Self that rules the totality of the world is the center of the Spirit; the totality of the world itself is his universal foundation.

The next characteristic feature is seen in the relation between the Spirit and the Word. Whereas the universal in the Creator's essence and working is referred to the Spirit, the particular and distinctive is referred instead to the Word. The creating God speaks, and to each distinctive word that goes forth from the Creator's mouth there corresponds a distinctive product. The same is repeated in the revelation to the prophets: the universal is in the Spirit that comes upon them, but the particular is in the words that Jehovah himself speaks to them through the Spirit. There is speaking in the Spirit, and there is hearing in the Spirit; but what is spoken and heard is determined by the Word. From this point of view too the Spirit shows himself as an intermediate being; as intermediate being the Spirit can be sent by God, poured out by God, and return again to God. If we stop at the immediate view, it will naturally be an easy matter for critique to come forward with a series of objections. "God is Spirit, and yet the Spirit is distinguished from God"; from this presupposition a reasoning understanding can derive as many contradictions as you please. But the contradictions vanish when we bethink ourselves that it is not yet the concept of the Spirit, but [448] only the first intuitable traits of his original character, that we have before us here. The living view must always imply the one when it posits the other, the unity when

it posits the opposition, and conversely; it speaks out of the concept, intimates the concept, but the concept itself it does not comprehend.

For the view, God and the world form two extremes which the thought of faith cannot possibly efface; their relation is as of Creator to creature, in logically abstract form, as of cause to effect. What is in the cause must come to light in the effect. The totality in the cause and the totality in the effect are essentially the same totality; here we have the unity, and in the unity the middle. The unity rich in content, the middle of the extremes, is the Spirit viewed as intermediate being, the Spirit as universal selfhood. There is wisdom in the world because there is wisdom in God; the wisdom of God and the wisdom revealed in the order of things are in the Spirit the same and yet not the same. The wisdom in God, the original wisdom, the Idea-content reflected in the unity of will of knowledge and power, is the content of the Spirit as Godhead in God, divine selfhood in the divine Self. The wisdom in the world, the reason of the world in objective form, is the derived wisdom, determined by divine self-power, wisdom in actual, natural facts; it is the content of the Spirit as Godhead in the world, as world-Godhead. The Godhead in the world thus forms an express opposition to the Godhead in God, and yet the Spirit, the Spirit of wisdom, is the unity of this opposition. But instead of developing how matters really stand, in the concept of faith, with the unity of wisdom with the infinite transition from the Godhead in God to the Godhead in the world, revelation at the Old Testament stage stops at the Spirit as intermediate [449] being. The Spirit is sent forth, and the creation is renewed; he is called back, and what was created vanishes into nothing.

That the philosophy of reason could not come to development among the Jews is comprehensible; but neither did the concepts of faith ever come to consciousness in the form of concepts. Instead of a closer determination of the relation between God and the Spirit of God, wisdom in particular was made the object of a representing reflection, put in the place of the Spirit and personified as a divine intermediate being. "Jehovah," says Wisdom (Prov. 8 and 9), "formed me as the beginning of his creation, before his works, from of old. From everlasting I was anointed. When the depths were not yet, I was born; before the mountains were sunk, before the hills came to be. When he (Jehovah) prepared the heavens, then I was there, when he measured

out the surface of the sea with a circle. When he made fast the clouds above, when the fountains of the deep grew strong. When he set the sea its bound, that the waters should not pass his command, when he appointed the foundations of the earth, then I was by him as a master workwoman, and was his darling, day by day, and played continually before his face.”

β) The Spirit on the Foundation of the Individual.

From the human side the Spirit begins on a foundation of the individual, in that he begins with the self that develops itself toward self-consciousness. That the Spirit is essentially involved in this development shines forth from the fact that the self-consciousness which is to answer to the demand of reason and thereby truly satisfy itself cannot be sated with a merely finite content, but must be filled and moved by the Idea, by the universal enriched with individual moments. As unity of Idea and consciousness, the Spirit, in the universally valid form of the individual, is a spirit of humanity and thus again an intermediate being, a middle of two extremes: subjective reason in the individual's interior and objective reason in the world of interests and things. With the Idea of the good the spirit in man begins in particular to stir toward its ideal independence as spirit; but independence, as we have already seen from so many sides in the foregoing, is an ambiguity at the standpoint of reason; only at the stage of religion, and so only as intermediate being between the divine and the human self, does the Spirit work as spirit in the name of truth, freedom, and personality. [450]

From this can now be seen the difference between the working of the Spirit in the God-man and in the believers.

Christ is, according to the Confession of Faith, conceived, not of the Logos, but of the Spirit. The significance of this is evident. The Logos-principle is, in its difference from the Spirit, to be determined expressly as the principle of individuality; the Logos-self in the Son is the bodily-psychically individualized self; the holy principle has in the mother's womb natural human nature as its extreme: the Spirit is again intermediate being, the self-being working in the interaction, the actual middle of the two extremes. During the self-development of the God-man the Spirit is therefore also in a double movement: from Christ toward God and from God toward Christ. On the foundation

of the individual the Spirit works originally in the Christ-child; for “the child grew and waxed strong in spirit, filled with wisdom; and the grace of God was upon him” (Luke 2:40 f.). On the foundation of the universal the Spirit goes forth from God and comes upon Christ, namely at the baptism. That both movements are equally original, that the one neither excludes the other nor makes it superfluous, is grounded in the ideal relation to God, in religion itself; and determined by the Word, the Word of life, which was in the beginning. With the manifestation of Christ the Spirit enters into a new relation to the Word. At the Old Testament stage, as we have seen, the Spirit, the divine essence in its universal selfhood, is the first, and the Word, revelation’s [451] particular expression, the second; at the New Testament stage, on the contrary, the Word, the Christ-life in its whole intuitability and individual determinateness, is the first, and the Spirit the second: Christ reveals the Spirit, so that the Spirit in turn may reveal him, transfigure his life for the believers.

In Christ’s divine-human Self the Spirit of the Gospel has its unalterable center and works as the intermediate being that inwardly unites Christ with the believers. In this his mediating activity the Spirit again shows himself as divine selfhood. He goes in selfhood from self to self, uniting self with self. Just as it is not the universal essence of faith (objective doctrine of faith, system of faith) but the believing self in which and upon which he works, so likewise it is not the universal essence of Christ, separated from his individuality (the Idea of Christ in objective generality), but the Self of Christ, from which his activity proceeds. The Spirit does not dissolve the Word, but he brings the Word, develops the Word, lives in the Word and makes the Word living. — “I have yet many things to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now. Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he shall guide you into all truth; for he shall not speak of himself, but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak, and he shall show you things to come. He shall glorify me, for he shall take of mine and show it unto you” (John 16:12–14).

To this presupposition now corresponds the outpouring of the Spirit upon the apostles. That the Spirit comes by a definite miracle at a definite point in time cannot possibly be understood as if the disciples, during their life together with Christ, had not been moved by the Spirit. But the Spirit, who worked in the disciples an understanding

of the Master's words, worked in complete hiddenness; as long as Christ stood there alive before their eyes, he did not come forward in particular to the consciousness of the disciples, who were immediately dependent on the Master. The Spirit as spirit in particular independence is still with the Father, which is why such works as opening the eye to the "Son of God," drawing souls to the Son, etc., are not yet referred in particular to the Spirit, but immediately to the Father. Only after the Son has gone in to the Father, after the individual manifestation of the Spirit's content has furnished actual presuppositions and historical conditions for his independent activity, does the Spirit come forward with particular independence. The outpouring of the Spirit at the feast of Pentecost is thus not merely a breakthrough grounded on historical presuppositions and explicable from the peculiar state of soul of the apostles, but a work of God, fulfillment of a given promise, hence an unconditioned act of will, an antirational act of freedom.

As a proof that the Spirit is conceived personally in the N. T., appeal has been made to the Gospel account of Jesus' baptism: *Abi ad Jordanem et disce trinitatem*. "But," remarks Strauss, "as regards the narrative of Jesus' baptism, it is a question whether the appearance of the Spirit in the shape of a living being (a dove) is a surer proof that it has a personality of its own than the fact that it comes down in the form of tongues of fire?" Christ, it is true, in John, at the farewell with the disciples (chs. 14, 15, 16), speaks of the Paraclete and thus speaks of the Spirit as of an actual personality; nevertheless it is an easy matter for reasoning critique, merely by applying a tiny bit of hermeneutics, to explain the personal away. For in Luke (24:49) the Spirit is, after all, called outright the power from on high (*δυναμις ἐξ ὑψους*), and so conceived as a power of God, and so impersonally.

γ) The Self of the Spirit: The Mystery.

All fundamental errors, all perverse representations and unclear concepts about the self-revealing Spirit of God have their origin in a false conception of the relation between self and selfhood. We see it in the rationalism of the understanding and in speculative knowledge.

The rationalism of the understanding makes a sharp separation between God and the Spirit of God. God as God, the almighty Self, is held fast in a representation by itself: God in himself is outside the world, exalted above the world, separated from the world; but the Spirit, the Godhead, the divine essence in infinite being and working, is omnipresent, pervades all, moves and determines all. The divine Spirit that pervades the world now fuses with the divine reason indwelling in the world, and in this way becomes synonymous with the world's, with nature's own objective reason: from rationalistic theism there is only a small step to pure deism. "Deism is" spiritless, its abstract God of the beyond is a dead representation, a "*caput mortuum*": here speculation begins.

The dry Self of deism, shriveled up in representation, speculative knowledge casts away as a spiritless residue, a remnant of scholastic externality in thinking; with the Self God vanishes, but the Spirit, the immanent Godhead of all existence, remains behind. So at first glance it then looks as if life in the present, having renounced what is to come, were really to become rich in spirit. "It was the fixed idea of the beyond which, while consciousness was estranged from itself, constantly drew the best powers to itself and thereby spiritually sucked the blood of the here-and-now; now, on the contrary, after spirit as spirit has come to itself in man's knowing self-consciousness, the here-and-now can obtain the whole present spirit and live in the Godhead itself". This spirit without God, this selfhood without self, nevertheless, as we have seen above, becomes spiritless again through the universal selfhood's turning into the selfless universal: from speculative pantheism there is only a small step to pure materialism.

[454] What, according to the foregoing, particularly characterizes the Spirit of revelation, then, is this: that as Godhead with God he originally mediates between self and selfhood, between self and self. All fundamental oppositions in all forms, the individual as well as the universal, under all laws (those of otherness and necessity as well as those of self-development and freedom), oppositions of the material and external, of the ideal and internal, of the unity of connection in the world and the unity of self in God, in short: extremes of every kind have in the Spirit himself their origin, their power, and their uniting middle.

As Godhead over against God the Spirit is originally one with God: God is Spirit,

the Spirit is God. Just as the opposition of God and Godhead is determined by the Spirit, so too the unity of the opposition is determined by the Spirit. The divine selfhood in the Spirit has God himself not outside it but within it; the divine Self in the Spirit has its selfhood rich in Ideas not outside it but within it. The spirits of religion and of science resemble each other in that both take the form of universal selfhood; but they are absolutely heterogeneous in this, that the spirit of science excludes what the spirit of religion unconditionally holds fast: *the divine Self*. As Godhead, divine selfhood, the Spirit is *rational*; as God, divine Self, the Spirit is *antirational*. When the consequences hidden in this presupposition are developed, it will easily be seen how matters stand with the Mystery and the absurd.

As selfhood in power the Spirit has the external actual world as his other, and has in this other a sensuous, immediate expression of his ideal reality. The world is borne by spirit; it is an in-spirited whole. If now the emphasis is laid on the world's being a whole coherent in itself, determined by the interaction of its parts, a whole of reason, then the Spirit loses his independent Self; he goes under in universal selfhood, [455] he hides his Godhead behind the reason of the world: his grounds belong to necessity.

As divine Self, as unity of will of power and knowledge in the form of knowledge, the Spirit has the inner world of Ideas in God as his essential content. If now the emphasis is laid on every determination of the Spirit's being a self-determination decisive in itself, an almighty determination of will which can have outward-going as well as inward-going effects, then the antirational comes to the fore. God's will, the Self that is divine in the Spirit, can then intervene in the actual connection of the world where it will, and effect whatever changes it will, without any other ground being assignable for it than the will's own: *sic volo, sic jubeo, stat pro ratione voluntas*.

The two extremes, that of selfhood and that of the self, of necessity and of freedom, are posited by the Spirit and can be united only in the Spirit; they can neither fuse together nor maintain themselves against each other in finite separateness: as the Spirit's own extremes they must be united in a syllogism. In this syllogism the Spirit is again intermediate being; he is the middle of the extremes. In his difference from the extremes the Spirit as intermediate being is one with the extremes; but this unity is in turn doubled. The Spirit is namely in unity with each of the extremes by itself:

in unity with the world as the reason of the world in the form of necessity, and in unity with God in the form of freedom. The opposition is thereby stretched to its utmost. But now the Spirit is at the same time the pervading unity of the opposite extremes in the sense that he effects, into the infinite, their mutual transition into each other. This transition is articulated in the Spirit himself by an inner reciprocal determination of necessity and freedom, of unity of connection and unity of self, a reciprocal determination which at every point is conditioned by freedom's being reduced to a moment for necessity, and necessity conversely for freedom.

[456] In order to develop necessity by itself we must imply freedom; for selfhood is grounded in the self. Freedom is from this side the ground of necessity; it bears necessity, and the actuality of necessity is, in consequence, at every point the possibility of freedom. In order to develop freedom by itself we must imply necessity; for the self is grounded in selfhood. Necessity is from this side the ground of freedom; it bears freedom, and the actuality of freedom is, in consequence, at every point the possibility of necessity.

If now our gaze is fixed on the world of facts, actual nature with its necessary laws, then we can understand that the connection of things can be developed and pursued into the infinite without the least trace of unconditioned divine self-determination being discoverable in the infinitely ramified unity of connection. The self is hidden in selfhood, and the divine selfhood in the objective reason of the world system. But since selfhood is grounded in the self, we can also, in accordance with what we said before, understand that in the infinite system of grounds of necessity there is at every point the possibility of acts of freedom, of unconditionally divine acts of will; that, in other words, the actuality of the connection of nature is the possibility of the miracle.

If, on the other hand, our gaze is fixed on God as God in divine self-power, then we can understand that every act of will, even if it is in itself absolutely grounded, must nevertheless in the last instance have the determining ground of all grounds in the self-determination itself; we can understand that the almighty will can act just as immediately and particularly on any single point in any single part of the whole as in comprehensive generality on the whole itself; but we can also understand that, whether the determination of will acts on the whole as whole or on the part as part,

the antirational action can nonetheless not possibly disturb the order of things. By [457] making a breach in the rational unity of connection of the system of wisdom, God would indeed come into conflict with his own Godhead, the divine Self with its own selfhood, and what concept should we then be able to form of the Spirit? No, the power of the Spirit, of the will, consists precisely in this, that in the one extreme it always possesses the other: the actuality of the miracle is the possibility of the connection of nature.

If we conceive all acts of will proceeding from the self as proclamations of the supernatural, and all grounds lying in selfhood as expressions of the natural, then in the Spirit of wisdom neither strife nor contradiction between the supernatural and the natural can be thought. The forming and working of the Spirit is an infinite conversion of determinations from self into selfhood, from freedom into necessity, from the supernatural into the natural, and conversely. This conversion is not an endless, uniform process; it is the content of wisdom, systems of means and ends, which is articulated into the infinite. When the goal is posited as the goal of freedom, as purpose, the means are presupposed with necessity; but the necessity of the means is the possibility of freedom. That at every point in the system of selfhood there is possibility for the self means: that at every point in the nexus of means, causes, intermediate causes and conditions there is possibility for the will. Every member of the great whole is as near to the will of the Spirit as the whole itself; from which it follows that the self-powerful will can intervene at a single point in a single member just as immediately as it, in the Spirit, can master and move the whole that coheres within itself. Here there is not merely unity of necessity and freedom; here there is, within the unity, difference and thoroughgoing opposition. Necessity sublates freedom — what happens with necessity cannot immediately be ascribed to freedom — but it does not annihilate freedom at any point; it only reduces it to possibility. Freedom in the determinate act of will sublates necessity — the act of the will is not necessary — [458] but it does not annihilate necessity; it only reduces it to possibility. So, then, freedom and necessity stand sharply against each other in the infinite working of the Spirit; but they do not stand in strife with each other. It is the power of the will in the Spirit that requires the opposition; for the self-power of the will is power over another. Necessity

cannot at any point withdraw itself from the will; for it rests in the universal willing. Everywhere in the system of wisdom the universal willing can be concentrated into punctually determining will.

Every self-determination in the Spirit is, as an inner act of will proceeding from the self, antirational: all grounds of necessity are in this concentration transformed into grounds of will; conversely, every determination of selfhood in the Spirit is rational: all grounds of freedom hold themselves as moments of possibility within the conditioned grounds of connection of essentiality, of necessity. Thus in the system of wisdom the rational can everywhere be articulated by the antirational, and nature be borne by the Spirit; in this there is no absurdity. But how the reciprocal determination of selfhood and self takes place in actuality, how, when and why the antirational acts precisely at these points, in these members and not in others, that is and remains an insoluble riddle, an impenetrable Mystery. "No one knows what is in God, except the Spirit of God."

b) Fundamental Determinations in the Self of the Spirit.

§ 32.

As the self-acting unity of self and selfhood, as the articulating intermediate being between God and the world, the Spirit must originally contain determinations from which the relation between the divine and the worldly can be cognized in all forms of [459] revelation, and hence: *divine-worldly fundamental determinations*. As the mediating unity between the absolute and the relative self, as the intermediate being between God and man, the free, liberating Spirit must contain determinations from which all inner phenomena of consciousness corresponding to the relation to God can be derived, and hence *divine-human fundamental determinations*. As the developed self-unity of the absolute self-duplication, as the intermediate being between God and God, the Spirit must contain determinations from which it can be seen, from the standpoint of revelation, that all outward effects of God in the world and all inward activities in God over the world are moments in the self-developing concept of God,

acts of self-opposition in the very essence of the one true God, and hence *trinitarian fundamental determinations*.

α) Divine-Worldly Fundamental Determinations.

There is nothing that in recent times has contributed more to undermining faith in the supernatural self-power of the divine Spirit than dogmatic, objective supranaturalism. If supranaturalism is philosophical and has taken up speculative determinations of immanence, then critique rightly calls attention to the half-heartedness, the ambiguity in its conception of the miracle, to the emptiness of such profound-sounding phrases as “a new law of nature,” “a spiritual breakthrough,” “a progressive development of the divine life in nature,” etc. If supranaturalism is orthodox scholastic, then it lays down a series of logically delimited conceptual forms in which the supernatural is to be grasped and held fast in a finitely determinate way. The concepts fixed by overstepping the boundary of the Mystery then have this peculiarity about them, that they stand in glaring contradiction with the empirical concepts of nature of physics. The negative critique, which bases its development of concepts on the presuppositions of natural science, then has an easy task when it wishes to attack supranaturalism, [460] demonstrate its contradictions and point out the absurd.

The supranaturalists hold fast to the presupposition of a supramundane, omnipotent God, and hence of the divine Self in unconditioned freedom; in this they are right. But when they introduce this presupposition of faith into science, they are, however much they exert themselves to reconcile the personal God with “the immanent deity of the world,” evidently in the wrong. “Most theologians,” says an acute critic,⁷² “use the concept of the divine personality, its freedom and exaltation above the natural nexus, only to establish a peculiar kingdom for the exclusively divine, the supernatural, and so to introduce anew all the miracle stories and notions of miracles with a speculative semblance and verbal bombast. In these circles especially a veritable debauchery has been practiced with *divine freedom*; under this splendid cloak even the most arbitrary and most external mode of action has been concealed.” But if the supranaturalists meet with misfortune when they clothe God’s supramundane, omnipotent Self in

⁷²K. Schwarz. Den nyeste Theologies Historie. Kjøbhvn. 1868. S. 356.

the speculative garb of modern knowledge, in order, by means of a costume fitted to the taste of the times, to procure recognition in science for his supernatural works, then the neo-rationalists, who by applying pure concepts of reason would help the universally divine selfhood to pull itself together as a willing Self and keep itself afloat above the waters of immanence, certainly have just as great difficulties.

The divine selfhood, the indwelling deity of the world, speculative philosophy finds it easy to acknowledge: the spirit of selfhood is, after all, according to what we have shown in the foregoing, precisely the spirit of science. But when speculation immerses itself in selfhood, it immerses itself in pantheism, and rational theology, [461] which for conscience' sake cannot possibly do without God as God, now exerts itself to work its way through pantheism up to a true religious, scientific theism. "Pantheism," it is said,⁷³ "has truth and validity only as the opposite of the external and abstract theism set up by vulgar theology. It has the merit of having constantly worked against all anthropomorphic and anthropopathic notions of the deity and of having purified and enlarged the concept of God on all sides. But with this negative merit its whole significance is also exhausted, and even in a philosophical respect it is so little justified that it must, on the contrary, be regarded as an abstraction of the worst kind, just as incapable of solving the riddle of existence as abstract theism. For in pantheism not only the sensuous world but also God himself comes off badly. The absolute is here not the truly absolute, but the *caput mortuum* of abstraction, that which remains when all other abstractions have been thought away. God then becomes merely the abstract-universal, the One, pure being, and whatever else one may happen to call it, that which sublates all concrete forms of being. Thereby the beauty of the world and the richness of its multiplicity are lost; it becomes foam and semblance, a non-being bound up with being, a rising and falling wave in the ocean. On the other hand, the depth, inwardness and creative energy of the deity are thereby lost; it finds no rest in itself, it is only a streaming and foaming, a purposeless and resultless blowing of the soap bubbles of finitude, which it takes back again."

Neo-rationalism sets out to transform scientific pantheism into religious theism; [462] that is a self-contradictory endeavor. The divine Self, which according to objective

⁷³K. Schwarz. Anfr Skr. S. 354.

grounding is to be the presupposition and result of the development of the Idea, is, as a surplus of reflection from the metaphysically universal selfhood, too powerless to assert freedom in the midst of necessity. Formal willing cannot, by means of the infinite nexus of nature, condense here and there into will; but a self without will cannot be the God of faith. "From the contentless play, for which the all-embracing divine substance is the grave, tragic background, thought strives to raise itself, in order to come to conceive the world as fixed in itself and, in its higher organizations, as striving ever more toward independent centers, but at the same time to conceive the deity as revolving about itself. This is the endeavor of *speculative theism*; in the midst of the necessary belonging-together and reciprocal action of God and the world it maintains the difference between them, whereby both first come into their own. What is true in pantheism is preserved: the deity is not an individual beside other individual things, but the highest, all-penetrating universal; the infinite does not stand over against the finite, whereby it would itself be made finite; rather it is an activity penetrating finitude and implanting itself in it. But on the other hand the thought also comes into its own that that highest universal is at the same time *a living* universal, self-conscious, returning into itself from its activity penetrating the world."⁷⁴

How far a speculative theism can be carried through consistently on all sides remains to be investigated in science; the investigations of the philosophy of reason pertaining to this do not concern religion as religion. The Self in which faith holds fast to God as God in opposition to the world is not merely supramundane but also supernatural; it could not possibly be the first if it were not the last. The possibility [463] that the Spirit can mediate between the natural in the world and the supernatural in God shows itself when we consider the divine-worldly fundamental determinations.

In this connection there is no question here of new attributes for the absolute or of particular predicates for the divine Self; the task is to develop the concept of the Spirit in such a way that the two-sided essentiality of the divine predicates can be cognized from the standpoint of faith. What holds of some predicates holds of them all; we choose as examples *omnipotence* and *omnipresence*.

That the deity is omnipotent or, what amounts to the same thing, that omnipo-

⁷⁴K. Schwarz. Anfr. Skr. S. 355.

tence is divine, philosophy grants. Omnipotence is an attribute of substance, and in pantheism, after all, "the divine substance is the grave, tragic background." But thereby omnipotence is conceived merely from the worldly side, as a predicate of immanence, a predicate of the general selfhood of the deity. How, now, do we get from selfhood to self, from the all-embracing universal power to unconditioned self-power? A rational transition is impossible; for self-power itself is antirational. For rational universal power the atoms of nature with their properties, forces and reciprocal actions have immediate reality as the other of power; universal power has no particular existence; it is an ideal, infinite capacity; its infinite capacity is to sustain everything finite, to be the spiritual bond of the connection of things, the essentiality in which and by which everything has its subsistence. For antirational self-power the finite elements and forces of the world are as a nothing, a possibility that can become anything the will wills. Omnipotence is God's power, God is omnipotent; this is the divine side [464] of the predicate. Seen from this side the predicate cannot enter into science; for it threatens to burst the actual world, to crack nature open and make the great whole of reason into a perforated, patched-together piecework. If the strong opposition of universal power and self-power were not an opposition in the very essence of the Spirit, the discord between religion and science could never be removed. *Self-power is an imagination; only the actual power in the world of things has reality*; that is the language of power of science. *The world of things is powerless; only God is omnipotent*; that is the language of power of religion. If, on the other hand, we acknowledge the absolute heterogeneity of the principles, then the Spirit comes into its own from both sides, and the strife is settled.

Since science holds fast to its principle, it has universal power as its presupposition, and so, when in philosophy it rightly comes to its senses, it must everywhere tacitly understand the divine power of reason. Ceaselessly occupied with investigating, not the concept of power in empty generality, but the actual revelations of power in phenomena and laws, it fixes its gaze one-sidedly on connection and unity of connection. That all actual unity of connection rests on the universally powerful self-unity, and this self-unity in turn on the omnipotent Self, are fundamental truths of which it must ceaselessly be reminded. Logical theism, which develops the fundamental concept of

self-unity, thus prepares science for the concession it must make to religion in the name of the Spirit; for the spirit of science is one-sided.

The spirit of religion is many-sided. In the religious representation the omnipotent Self can, to be sure, be held fast so immediately for itself that it looks as though God were “an individual beside other individual things,” but the misunderstandings flowing from this belong to ways of seeing that fall outside the Spirit. Considered in the light of the Spirit, self-power has universal power as its presupposition; only thus does it [465] have its opposite in itself and can, as power of will, be power over another. It is not the case, then, that self-power should weaken universal power and with it the nature and connection of things; the opposition of power in the Spirit is an expression of the fact that the extremes mutually strengthen each other. Omnipotence is in God as God’s power; the divine side of the fundamental determination is expressed in the proposition: God is omnipotent. Omnipotence is in the world as the universal substantiality of selfhood; the worldly side of the fundamental determination is expressed in the proposition: the substance of the world is omnipotent. But both determinations must be united in the many-sided proposition: *the Spirit is omnipotent*.

As subject of the divine-worldly predicate, omnipotence, the Spirit comes to meet itself from each of the extremes. In the extreme of transcendence, *self-power*, it has in the infinite the possibility of its power of immanence; for self-power, as power of will, is inseparably one with power in another and power over another. In the extreme of immanence, *the substantial power*, the Spirit has at every point the possibility of the power of transcendence, for the all-embracing selfhood is borne by the self and has, in each individual determination of selfhood corresponding to the unity of connection, a tacitly understood self-determination.

As a divine-worldly fundamental determination in the Self of the Spirit, the concept of omnipotence is thus two-sidedly determined; it is not self-power by itself, not substance-power by itself, but the unity of opposition of both. Take self-power away, and substance-power must vanish; for the power of selfhood is power over another only by being power in the self. Take substance-power away, and self-power must vanish; for self-power is power in itself only by being power over another which in itself is power, the universal power of totality in the actual connection of things.

[466] What holds of power in the form of essentiality holds in the form of the phenomenon of *omnipresence*. Seen immediately, God's omnipresence is an absurdity. If the whole God is to be in every place, then the divine Self must surely be able to divide itself into the infinite and, in spite of the division, still remain the one and same infinite Self. From fear of this contradiction speculation now rushes over into the opposite extreme, abolishes the self in all haste and seizes the universal principle; as if it were self-evident that a principle can divide itself and yet be undivided. Held fast by itself, the latter extreme is just as spiritless as the former. The beguiling thing lies in an infinite interplay of immediacy and reflection. Immediately, i.e. in the phenomenal form of outward actuality, God is not omnipresent. Omnipresence is, in other words, not a predicate of an individually existing subject, but a predicate of spirit, a predicate of reflection for the universal, substantial selfhood, a worldly fundamental determination in the Spirit. Corporeality, essentiality, laws are omnipresent; for corporeality, essentiality and laws have a reflected form, immediate in reflection. Where, then, does the religious representation of an omnipresent God have its point of attachment? In the Self exalted above selfhood, reflected in selfhood! The Self is not in a single place by itself alone, as when it is said that God is in heaven, and the understanding then concludes from this: therefore not on earth; rather the Self subsisting in itself is immanent in its selfhood. Thus immediacy returns with a disjunction of here and there, and omnipresence shows itself as a divine fundamental determination in the Spirit.

Therefore: it is not God in himself, any more than it is the deity in the world abstracted from God, that is omnipresent. Omnipresence is a divine-worldly predicate: God in the Spirit as Spirit is omnipresent.

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β) Divine-Human Fundamental Determinations.

What recent philosophy impresses upon us again and again, namely that spirit as spirit cannot possibly tolerate anything foreign outside itself, anything objective and object-like that it is unable to sublate, is at bottom a great truth; but the misfortune is that the philosophy of reason works most vigorously against the very truth it itself impresses upon us. It demands that everything objective shall be spirit just as much as

everything subjective; it demands that self-consciousness shall comprehend its own essence in the essence that is external and foreign to representation, and comprehend itself in the infinitely rich essence; and in this we must grant that it is right. But when the question is how one goes about solving the great task, the aberration of spirit is glaring. Speculation speaks of an opposition of objective and subjective spirit, whose unity is to be sought in self-consciousness. But what sort of an opposition is that? Its “objective spirit” is not spirit; in its immediate existence it is nature, external, actual, sensuous nature, and in this its naturalness “the principle of subjective spirit.” Its “subjective spirit,” with the natural world as object, is in its finite subjectivity so one-sided, limited and imperfect that, by the philosophy of reason’s own admission, it is only a spiritless spirit, a spirit that has not yet taken possession of its objective content. The opposition of objective and subjective spirit is then, as one sees, an utterly crippled opposition, an opposition whose one member is a spirit that is not spirit, whose other member is a spiritless spirit. By the union of two such spiritual cripples the sound, complete spirit, the new spirit of truth and freedom, the self-conscious world-spirit, is now to come forth; but it will be a spirit to match.

From the standpoint of revelation the opposition between the Spirit of God and the spirit of man is infinitely deep and rich in content; and as the opposition is, so too is the unity. But when the divine Spirit is set freely against the human as Self against self, there must naturally proceed from the free opposition a series of particular reciprocal determinations; it will then easily appear to a superficial observer as if the relation of spirit, by being drawn down into finitude, must absolutely become spiritless. [468]

“How the one human being can himself set himself against another, so that a reciprocal action between finite spirits thereby arises, is evident; but” — it is said — “how the divine Self can set itself against the human in such a way that there truly occurs a reciprocal action between the infinite and the finite spirit is incomprehensible. A human being can know with certainty that he stands face to face with another; but how should anyone be able to become conscious that at a given moment he stands face to face with God, that the divine Self is present in the spirit? Anyone who in all soberness will attempt an actual distinguishing between the thoughts that come from himself and the thoughts that come immediately from God, between what he says to

himself in his conscience and what God expressly says to him, between the powers that are originally in his own spirit and the powers that are imparted to him by the Spirit of God, will surely recognize that the attempt is insane. The religious-psychological self-deception shines forth clearly enough, too, from the church dogmaticians' disputes, as fruitless as they are protracted, over the relation between human freedom and divine grace."

"The Pelagians let man's natural freedom develop under the co-operation of grace; that will not do, and why not? Because the natural, selfish will, which is in itself unfree, has freedom only to resist freedom by resisting grace. So the Augustinians [469] assert that it is grace itself that frees the will. Man's will, then, does not have its freedom in determining and moving itself, but solely in being immediately determined and moved by God's will. But, not to mention that the freedom of the will must, when its self-determination is placed in another will, become unfree, one surely entangles oneself, as regards the transition from natural unfreedom to the freedom effected by grace, in insoluble contradictions."

"The natural will is supposed to be able to resist grace; this implies that it can also refrain from offering resistance; over against grace, therefore, the natural will has complete freedom of choice: it can choose between resisting and not resisting. If it chooses to resist, then it opposes grace and thereby shows precisely what it is, a natural, selfish will. If it chooses not to resist, then in all its naturalness it wills precisely what grace wills, and so cooperates with grace and makes itself a recipient of grace. But that is precisely what the natural will, according to Augustine's doctrine, is not supposed to be able to do; it is not supposed to be able, by any cooperation with grace, to make it possible for grace to work. But if it is now not a natural self-determination but a hidden grace (*gratia praeveniens*) that brings about the surrender, then the natural will does not have the slightest power to resist grace either. Grace breaks through when it will, where it will, and because it will; that the will offers resistance is therefore an untruth. For the will's resistance presupposes that it refuses to do something which it could nevertheless do according to its nature; if it is not in its power to surrender itself, then neither is it in its power to refuse the surrender."

Equally absurd — to the superficial observer — are the results to which a separation

of man's spiritual natural gifts from the Spirit's gifts of grace must consistently lead. [470]

"While the human spirit, under all forms and in all particular manifestations, must constantly presuppose natural dispositions from which it can develop, but which it cannot alter, the Spirit of revelation, on the other hand, is assumed, by virtue of unconditional divine freedom and without regard to the innate peculiarities of individuals, to be able to impart its supernatural gifts, in that it 'divides to every man severally as it will.' In the use of this freedom it goes to extremes which no one, whether he be a believer or an unbeliever, will be able to explain."

"Consider the miracle of Pentecost. The Spirit comes with such speed, with such an effect, that in a moment it teaches the apostles foreign tongues. Whether one now chooses to explain the phenomenon by saying that it instantaneously breathes into the apostles knowledge of what was previously unknown to them, or that it itself speaks the foreign languages through the apostles, the occurrence is equally monstrous. In either case the Spirit of God takes the human spirit by force, by robbing it of self-development, in the same way as grace takes the natural will by force by robbing it of self-determination. This is the one extreme."

"Consider the religious consciousness under ordinary conditions. The one who prays turns to God, but he does not see God himself in the spirit, he sees only his representation of God; soberly speaking, therefore, he prays not to God but to his own representation. Let him now pray for a gift of the Spirit, be it enlightenment or strength or patience or comfort; if, when the prayer is ended, he will be honest with himself, he will admit that all the stirrings took place in himself and came from his own spirit. If he received enlightenment, he received it through the self-collection corresponding to devotion; if he was strengthened in prayer, the strength came, through the gathering of his thoughts in the will's earnestness, from his own interior; if he gained patience, [471] he gained it in himself through resignation. If, on the other hand, he imputes a hidden miracle to his religious moods, if he imagines that the Spirit of God has actually drawn near to him during the invocation, has breathed upon him, imparted to him powers he did not have in himself, and whispered to him thoughts which otherwise could not arise in a human consciousness: then he entangles himself in a pious deception and never comes to the cognition of the truth. This is the other extreme."

“As it goes with the miracle in the outward sphere, the revealed miracle, so it goes also with the miracle in the inward sphere, the hidden miracle; if the former vanishes, the latter vanishes too. In the present age no miracles occur in the outward sphere. What does that prove? It proves that in the present age no miracles occur in the inward sphere either. Were the Spirit of God actually to move the spirit of man, it would have to happen by a hidden miracle; but those who, for want of revealed miracles, console themselves with the hidden ones console themselves not with facts but with pious imaginings.”

What these and similar misgivings amount to can easily be seen from what we have said above. Once again it is the absolute difference of knowledge from faith on which everything depends. In knowledge there is no relation to God; for the one who knows, God can only become a thought, not an object: the knower thinks the thought of God as his own thought, and God vanishes. In faith, by contrast, the relation to God is posited as a holy, inviolable fundamental relation; the opposition between God and man is the opposition of spirit, the antirational opposition, by which the spirit of faith distinguishes itself from that of knowledge.

That the relation to God is a relation of spirit is known by this: that all the determinations of finitude belonging to the relation are permeated by infinity. It is [472] pointed out, and with full justice, that the relation to God is originally a relation of conscience; but in religion conscience is not enough, what matters essentially is the spirit. That there are pronouncements in the conscience which do not conform to man's self-will is certain; but these pronouncements of the holy first acquire their true religious significance by being referred, in faith, to the Holy One himself. The power of inwardness with which this happens rests on the spirit. It is the Spirit of God in man that makes the voice of conscience the voice of God; it is the spirit of man in God that makes the divine pronouncements human. Under this reciprocal determination the relation can be articulated to infinity: understanding with God is self-understanding. No part of the rich content of the fundamental religious pronouncements is by itself either merely divine or merely human; if it is conceived in that way, it is conceived spiritlessly. If your conscience tells you that you ought, that you shall: then, in the religious sense, it is just as spiritless to conceive the demand merely as an involuntary

utterance of your own moral nature as it is spiritless to let the silent pronouncement, by an acoustic deception, sound as a voice that came immediately from God: all the determinations decisive for the relation to God are two-sided determinations of the spirit itself, divine-human fundamental determinations.

What first and last gives the relation to God its actual stamp is, according to what we have already seen from several sides, precisely its peculiarity of being a relation of will. Only by virtue of the will does the opposition become strong and the union inward. Over against the Spirit of God the human will has freedom of choice; it can decide for, and it can decide against, the admonitions of the Spirit; the opposition between man's will and God's will shows itself here at the same time as an opposition within man's own will, namely an opposition between the selfish will and the will of the spirit.

Just as the selfish will can, in the general ethical sense, set itself up against the demands of the good, so it can also, in the religious sense, harden itself against the divine demands of the Spirit; conversely, just as the selfishly natural will can, by virtue of man's fundamental moral will, be sublated through personal self-determination and transformed into a will moved by the Idea of the good, so the natural self-will can, in the religious sense, be sublated by the fundamental will and, through the influence of the Spirit, transformed into will of the spirit. From this standpoint the great problem of freedom and grace can be referred to two fundamental determinations: 1) the determination of the relation between the natural will and the will of the spirit, and 2) the determination of the relation between the will of the spirit and the Spirit. [473]

As regards the first relation, the solution of the problem rests on the insight that the natural will and the will of the spirit can be conceived both as two wills of different kinds and at the same time as two manifestations, two forms of expression, of one and the same human will. What has been brought to light in an earlier connection about the opposition between the natural and the spiritual self holds in particular of the will. If the opposition is stressed in its immediacy, then the change is this: the natural will is thrust out, and the will of the spirit is installed in its place: the old man dies, and the new lives. If the opposition is reflected in its fundamental unity, then the change is this: the same will that selfishly withstood the Spirit transforms itself by

self-determination so essentially that it gives up its egoism and is moved by the Spirit. According to the immediate opposition, then, the natural will falls outside the life of the spirit, and can to that extent decide against the Spirit (*gratia est resistibilis*).

As regards the second relation, the solution of the problem is impossible so long as the opposition is held fast in mechanical immediacy. It looks as though the selfish [474] self-will, and with it all self-determination, would have to be annihilated in order that the Spirit of God with grace might gain the power to create (*gratia creans*) a new will, a new self, a new man by rooting out the old. This is meaningless. It is not by annihilating all self-determination and passively letting grace work as it will that the will of the spirit can form itself; on the contrary, what is required here on man's side is a heightened self-determination, an act of will decisive for time and eternity.

Now when it is said that this determination of will is owed exclusively to grace, that is true insofar as the will can become will of the spirit only by letting itself be moved unconditionally by the Spirit. Thus, as regards the ethical, the will can become moral only by letting itself be moved by the good. Just as the good is something irresistible for the good will, so the Spirit, and with it grace, is irresistible for the will of the spirit (*gratia est irresistibilis*). But that the will moved by the Spirit should not move itself, that working grace should make the will passive, is an error. On the contrary, a far greater self-activity is required of the will of the spirit than can be found in the instinctive will; in other words: the will of the spirit, in being moved by grace, is active in a far stricter sense than the natural will moved immediately by instinct and inclination.

Now since the old man, burdened with sin and selfishness, does not vanish because the new is formed, neither will the will of the spirit be able, at any stage of finite existence, to annihilate the selfish so completely that a remnant of egoism does not always remain. In the subdued instinctive will the will of the spirit has a secret enemy lying in wait for an opportunity; it is never so sure of its victory that it need not always keep itself awake and armed. Were the will of the spirit, at a given stage, to settle [475] down in "the grace that cannot be lost" (*gratia inamissibilis*), then by false security it would precisely expose itself to succumbing to the instinctive will and losing grace.

It is, as can be seen from this, the divine-human fundamental determination of

the spirit on which the solution of all problems of freedom rests. The opposition of the instinctive will (*voluntas naturalis*) and the will of the spirit is an opposition within the spirit and precisely thereby a thoroughgoing opposition; but although the opposed terms, in their immediate difference, confront each other independently, the instinctive will falling *outside*, the will of the spirit *inside* the relation to God, both are mastered by the spirit: it is the destiny of the instinctive will to dissolve itself in the divine-human self-determination by which it is transformed into will of the spirit; it is conversely the condition of the will of the spirit that it does not form itself alongside the instinctive will, but on that foundation of individuality in which the natural will perishes.

To ascribe immediate independence to the instinctive will alongside the will of the spirit is just as spiritless as to make the latter a mere modification of the former. It is not superficial modifications, it is essential reshaping, thoroughgoing transformations, that the Spirit brings about. These transformations corresponding to self-determination proceed no more from the divine will (*gratia*) by itself than from the human will by itself; they proceed from the principial unity of opposition of the divine-human will of the spirit. To speak of the natural will's cooperation with divine grace (*Synergisme*) is meaningless, since the will, insofar as it remains in its naturalness, can only counteract the will of the spirit. To assume a finite reciprocal action between the will and grace is spiritless, since the self-determination of the will of the spirit at no point falls outside or alongside the determining grace⁷⁵; the [476]

⁷⁵“If the Spirit were actually to move the will quite immediately, in the manner of instinct, then it would have to begin the liberation of the will by making it unfree; what a contradiction! The will's first act of freedom, the fruit of its very first inspiration, is precisely the heightened self-determination with which it inwardly longs for, and, in conflict with instinct, surrenders itself to, the influences of the Spirit. Then, as these influences are received and appropriated by the will which frees itself through the appropriation, the relation by no means becomes this, that the will, in self-separation from the Spirit, should have any power for any independent activity whatsoever”; — that is to say, as regards the life of the spirit, for that by self-separation from the Spirit it can, as selfish will (*vol. naturalis*), again determine itself according to instinct goes without saying — “on the contrary! it can move only according to the Spirit, in being moved with freedom by the Spirit. The moving power of freedom is solely and entirely the power of the Spirit; but it depends on the will itself whether it will appropriate this power in inwardness, in true originality.” Om Hindringer og Betingelser for det aandelige Liv i Nutiden. S. 11–12.

Indeed, so divine-human are the fundamental determinations of the spirit that the will's self-determination, by which the power of the Spirit is appropriated, is just as much an effect of the

reciprocal action is infinite: only by proceeding out of and returning into the infinite do the finite determinations of will become divine-human determinations of the spirit.

From the standpoint of the finite and yet infinite reciprocal relation between the Spirit of God and the spirit of man, the extremes touched on above can now also be illuminated. Reciprocal action presupposes that there is influence on man from God's side, and that the activity taking place in man's spirit in turn conditions and determines the influence of the divine Spirit. From this the following three propositions can be derived: 1) in the religious sense no true human activity of spirit can take place except on the presupposition of divine cooperation; 2) no influence can be conceived [477] from the divine side that could either abolish or disturb the laws that hold for the self-development of the human spirit; 3) the limit of the heightening of the life of the spirit in human consciousness to which divine cooperation can go without abolishing the laws of selfhood is a Mystery.

With these principles in view we shall now shed light on the offense taken at the extremes. The assertion that hidden miracles are only imaginings unless they are expressly accompanied and made demonstrable by revealed ones is, from the standpoint of revelation, meaningless. Preservation and governance are hidden miracles; but they are by no means made demonstrable by outward miracles. The relation to God itself is grounded, according to the principle of faith, on a hidden miracle; but it does not follow that this relation should constantly be accompanied by outward miraculous facts. The hidden miracle, which forms the foundation of the given order of things, is perennial; the revealed miracle, by contrast, whose distinguishing mark is that it forms an exception to the existing order of things, cannot possibly be perennial.

Now as regards the first extreme, the miracle of inspiration (Acts 2), it is certainly an altogether incomprehensible phenomenon; but as a miracle it is indeed supposed to be so: a comprehensible miracle is a contradiction. By its conspicuous incomprehensibility, its improbability repellent in the very highest degree, this miracle stands quite in its proper place in sacred history, insofar as it stands as an ineffaceable mark, an abiding, speaking testimony that the Spirit of the Gospel, with "tongues of fire," is and will be heterogeneous, absolutely heterogeneous with that of science. Whether

divine as of the human spirit; but the divine-human effect presupposes self-determination in man, energetically decisive self-determination.

the miracle of inspiration, when the historical account is taken exactly according to the letter, perhaps contains features which the critique of knowledge could use to disprove its actuality is a question by itself, the treatment of which belongs to sacred history.

The second extreme, which corresponds to the negative experiences of the present age, receives a psychological illumination. It is quite characteristic that men of deep sense and thorough thought, men who with the torch of science would gladly, were it possible, penetrate into the abysmally dark depths of revealed religion, begin straight-way by misinterpreting the relation to God itself, in that they begin by misinterpreting the Spirit of revelation. "The fundamental form," it is said, "under which the divine Spirit accomplishes man's conversion and redemption is that of *genius*. Its distinguishing mark is pure, self-sacrificing enthusiasm, creative power. Within the universal fundamental form of genius there is an essential difference between scientific and artistic genius on the one side and, on the other, the genius that is the bearer of moral and religious Ideas. Here the Ideas are directed toward the will, the enthusiasm has the highest intensity, it is simple, unshakable certainty of the divinity of the revelation imparted, appeal to the divine authority. But nevertheless the 'inspiration and prophecy' proceeding from such genius is nothing other than 'moral-religious enlightenment'; genius is only the first proclaimer and awakener of what rests as something eternal in the ground of humanity⁷⁶." [478]

In this conception two essential points are to be held fast. The first is that the relation between the Spirit of God and the spirit of man is a relation of infinity. Self-consciousness at the stage of reflection cannot place itself immediately over against God as self against self, cannot say: this I said to God, and this God said to me; thus I spoke to the Spirit, and then the Spirit answered me with these words, etc. Where finitude in this conscious manner seeks to displace infinity, the relation is spiritless. The second is that the divine pronouncements are not given in empty formal arbitrariness, but bear the stamp of essentiality, in that they rise up out of the ground of the mind with an irrefusable claim of conscience. But when this is granted, the one-sidedness of the whole view is also easy to demonstrate. "The religious Ideas [479]

⁷⁶Dr. Karl Schwarz. *Den nyeste Theologies Historie*. Ovrst. Kbhvn. 1869. S. 365. Characterization of J. H. Fichte's "speculative theology."

are directed toward the will”: what can that mean other than that the religious Ideas are, in the absolute sense, Ideas of will? That they are Ideas of will cannot possibly mean, then, that from the divine side they are merely Ideas of instinct; in that case the boundary between the two absolutely heterogeneous spheres of spirit, that of knowledge and that of faith, is naturally easy to efface. For of the Ideas of science and of art it certainly holds that they announce themselves in consciousness with divine instinct, but by no means as declarations of God’s holy will.

The self-articulating reciprocal relation is in faith a relation of will and, in this its peculiar character, an actual relation of spirit. It is the human will, inspired by God himself, that in every decisive question of conscience is determined to determine what God’s will is. The unalterable demand of faith is that the pronouncement of conscience in every given case be referred to the divine Self, in order to be conceived and appropriated as the very pronouncement of the divine will; the irrefusable presupposition of religion is that he who has unconditionally placed his cause in God’s hand can also, through conscience, learn what God’s will is: the divine Spirit is conceived expressly as self-determining; each of its self-determinations announces itself from the depths with a holy impression, a pressure upon the conscience. But this happens only in faith; it is the function of faith as faith that is spoken of here. The whole thing therefore takes place not merely in man’s interior, but also in and through consciousness’s own [480] self-determining, hence in and through the human spirit itself. Thus finitude is taken up in a spiritual manner into infinity, and the opposition in the infinitely articulated reciprocal determination is just as thoroughgoing as the unity.

In the relation to God, expressly determined as a relation of spirit, there is here no more anything human by itself outside the divine than anything divine by itself outside or alongside the human: the articulated determinations of the spirit are divine-human fundamental determinations.

γ) Trinitarian Determinations of Form.

While supranaturalism, when it does appear so resolutely as to be willing to be recognized for what it is, always suffers from the difficulty that its skeleton is too rigid and its joints too stiff, pantheism, speculative rationalism, has on the other hand

another innate weakness, namely that its organism is so mollusk-like that limbs and joints flow over into one another. When the talk is of the relation between fixed and fluid determinations in the categories of existence, it makes an essential difference whether the standpoint is chosen in religion or in science.

If the realm of nature is considered from the standpoint of science, then the fundamental qualities of matter, the physical and chemical properties of the particular substances, are to be conceived primarily as empirically given determinacies. Elements such as oxygen, hydrogen, carbon, etc., each have their chemical peculiarities; it is of no use to brood over why or whence the carbon atom has come by just these properties, the hydrogen atom by those: the various properties hold with necessity and yet look like pure contingencies. If one now considers how these substances fit one another as if by a *harmonia præstabilita*, what a multitude of elementary formations (acids, bases, salts, double salts, and so forth) arise from their combinations, and what role these [481] formations play not only in inorganic but also in organic nature: then one receives an impression of objective reason, of divine wisdom in the world. In the objective reason, the divine wisdom, is seen a system of fixed and fluid determinations, on whose law-bound, articulating activity the natural order of things rests.

From the standpoint of religion, that is, with express regard to God and the Godhead, a judgment must now be passed on the reason of the world: whence this wisdom comes, and how the matter really stands with the fixed and fluid, indwelling and overreaching determinations in its thought-rich content. That the scholastic supranaturalist must come into conflict with the doctrine of nature is evident. Insofar as he appeals to God, he of course has an easy enough time explaining wisdom to himself. But how do things look with the emergence of this wisdom in nature? It is God himself who, by virtue of unconditioned acts of will, has fixed all fundamental determinations and arranged everything from the beginning. Whence, pray, does oxygen have its peculiar chemical character? From God's will! And hydrogen its? From God's will. Indeed, it is precisely an eloquent proof of God's creative wisdom that he has formed oxygen and hydrogen such that they can combine and form water; he evidently thought of water when he formed oxygen and hydrogen. Without actually introducing a Solomonic personification of wisdom, the supranaturalist nevertheless constantly

brings before his view only the image of a represented wisdom's supernaturalness; but the real concept of wisdom, the reason indwelling in nature itself, he does not cognize. And why not? Because in a spiritless manner he conceives all fixed determinations of nature, not as determinations of essence in nature, but as determinations of will over nature.

[482] It is otherwise with the pantheist. For him the categories of reason hold as original forms of nature. They are concepts of nature which immediately state the nature of things; to that extent he can keep to physics. But when the doctrine of reason is to be developed further, then comes the difficulty. In their factual empirical existence the categories of nature have a contingent appearance. The essence of oxygen cannot be derived from that of hydrogen, any more than that of hydrogen from that of oxygen. Certainly they suit each other, and water arises through their union. But they are, after all, united merely *so that water can*, but not *in order that it shall*, be formed. Where now is the wisdom? On this the pantheist, so long as the question concerns determinate particulars, individual determinate substances, individual determinate formations, can communicate nothing but what stands in chemistry: all determinate determinations are empirical. And yet it is surely not his task to give us a little abstract of chemistry; his task is to present reason in its originality as reason, as divine wisdom. So he must then swing himself up above the empirical, that is to say: dissolve all determinate determinations as moments in the infinite totality. The parts are now thus because the whole is thus, and the whole in turn is thus because the parts are thus. Now everything is fluid. In a conceptual system of abstracted forms of nature, which are passed off as a priori, and which with a little dialectic can easily be brought to pass over into one another and be reflected in one another as means in ends, the immanent wisdom is to be revealed. But it is a wisdom standing on such weak feet that anyone who wishes can blow it over⁷⁷. The weakness is that the omnipotently determining Self is lacking.

[483] Just as the fluid determinations in the pure doctrine of reason correspond to universal selfhood, so the fixed, decisive fundamental determinations in the real concept of wisdom correspond to the divine self-determination. Then comes "speculative

⁷⁷Cf. "Philosophisk Propædeutik i Grundtræk". Kbhvn. 1858. S. 189.

theology” and makes yet another attempt with wisdom. “The world,” it says, “is not merely a system of members mutually corresponding to one another, but also an ascending series of stages of ends. Each individual member is in itself an end and at the same time a means for another, the result of a lower, the starting point of a higher series of development. And here there appears the striking semblance that what has been attained, realized, although a product of what went before, is nevertheless at the same time that for whose sake alone this exists. Thus what is not yet operates in advance of its being; the end is at the same time cause, but posited as effect; the means is likewise effect, but posited as cause. This operating of what is not yet in advance of its being, this reversal of end and means, calls for a resolution of the contradiction that sets in. The ends operate in advance in their means. Of course the means do not properly bring about the end, nor does the end itself operate in the means; for the end does not yet exist. So a third is then required, which bends each means toward the end and lets it operate through the means. This end-positing activity of the Absolute resolves the contradiction appearing in time; it sublates the temporal difference of the members that fall apart from one another, means and ends, by seeing through their eternal unity. A world-order of ends can only be thought without contradiction when an operative and willing Absolute pervades them and is present in them”⁷⁸.

The “rational theism of speculative theology” certainly borders very closely on the religious; but the speculative Godhead is not the God of religion and can never [484] become so. “The knowing and willing Absolute,” whose end-positing activity is to resolve the contradictions of science, is an ambiguous being.

If “immanence” is held fast with logical rigor, then the opposition of means and ends loses its tension: the means is goal, the goal means; the determinations flow over into one another; the end-positing activity is only a necessary unfolding of the Absolute’s necessary content of reason. The knowing Absolute has only a willing, but no will. Its knowledge is only a knowledge of the necessity of the ends and the means, a knowledge that it itself is not able at any point to bring the very slightest change into either the end or the means, a thorough knowledge that its end-positing will is a potency as powerless as it is superfluous.

⁷⁸K. Schwarz. Anfr. Skr. S. 359–60.

If “transcendence” is taken seriously, if the Absolute is actually to be “a third, which bends each means toward the end, posits the end before it yet exists,” then the emphasis falls on the omnipotently willing Self, and the antirational blows “speculative theology” sky-high.

The rational is that ends and means in the infinite system must correspond to one another, so that the one does not, through thoughtless arbitrariness, do damage to the other. There must be ends, but which ends? There must be means, but which means? There must be connection, but which connection? When these questions are to be answered, when it is to be decided precisely why *these*, just these ends corresponding to *these* means, are posited, and not others, although *other* ends with *other* means must, according to the doctrine of ends, always have been possible, then the antirational enters with the fixed determinations of will, and the fixed, decisive determinations of [485] will must — we repeat it — in the science of reason necessarily appear as utterances of divine arbitrariness.

Only on one condition can human knowledge be reconciled with the arbitrariness grounded in God’s wisdom; this one inviolable condition is faith. Faith does not exclude knowledge in the sense that it should abolish reason and push science out of consciousness. Faith and knowledge form the deepest opposition in the cognizing spirit of man; but spirit, which posits and masters all oppositions, masters this one too. In the spirit of science the rational, and with it “immanence,” is the matter of principle; but in the spirit of faith the antirational with “transcendence” is what is first and last decisive.

According to the articulating reciprocal determination of the rational and the overreaching antirational, the fundamental determinations in the Self of the Spirit must be trinitarian. The trinitarian unity of opposition means something other and more than the reflected identity of opposite sides or the fluid transition of fluid “moments.” It is contentful totalities, comprehensive world-systems, that are in question here. If God in himself, the omnipotently creating Self, is set against the created world, then it is seen at once how the thoughts of faith must work their way through opposite totalities. The divine Self is not empty; in God as God, in God’s interior, all worlds are anticipated in a totality of ideal determinations of power transparent to knowledge.

In its opposition to God the world, created by God, is not God-forsaken; its totalities of means and ends are revelations, real determinations of power, of the universal substantial selfhood: it has an indwelling Godhead; it is inspirited by God. If the Spirit is now to be seen to master this original fundamental opposition teleologically as the Spirit of wisdom, then this must be seen in trinitarian forms.

The first thing is that the end is posited, not as an end in general, but as *this* determinate end; the end-positing activity is, in God's interior, ideal and spiritual. [486] In the inner, ideal world, means and ends are transparent to God's all-pervading knowledge, namely in the sense that they are purely *possible* means for purely *possible* ends⁷⁹ — an infinite system of concepts in God's inner selfhood. That an end is now expressly posited as *this determinate* one comes about through a system of the selfhood-determinations reflected in themselves being transformed into peculiar self-determinations, fixed, inviolable determinations of will. The end thus determined now requires an external world, a *world of means*.

The external world is, according to its character as external, a world of means with immanent ends. Just as selfhood, through the inner world, is merged in the determining Self — the Godhead in God — so now in the outer world the determining Self, *the will*, is at every point merged in the selfhood of the plan, the universal willing — God in the Godhead⁸⁰.

The system of the external world of means and the internal world of ends is in the Spirit itself one and the same system; for the inner world of ends has all the means within it as moments of knowledge; conversely, the world of means has within it, in its rational connection, the immanent ends as substantial motives; the teleological reciprocal determination of the inner, *ideal* and the outer, *real* world-plan is in the Spirit as Spirit a totalized unity of opposite totalities, a trinitarian unity.

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c) The Personality of the Spirit.

⁷⁹How the matter stands logically with these possibilities and their relation to necessity is shown in Grundideernes Logik II S. 222–293.

⁸⁰That the relation between the system in the inner world (the ideal system) and the system in the outer world (the real system) is by no means determined by a simple parallelism can be seen from Grundideernes Logik e. g. I. S. 449–456.

§ 33.

It is a quite characteristic feature of objectively dogmatic church doctrine that, while it has never found any difficulty in determining the Father and the Son as divine persons, it has always found itself in a certain embarrassment when it was really to express itself clearly and determinately about the personality of the Spirit.

As we now undertake to investigate whence the difficulty arises and how it is removed, we must first of all draw attention to what follows directly from the foregoing: that the Spirit, conceived in general as spirit, places the relation between self and selfhood in a quite peculiar light. It begins with the self in the Father and the self in the Son being determined as fixed, unshakable centers, whereby an opposition of two divine extremes is formed. As the mediating being of the extremes, the Spirit then effects the unity of the opposition by assuming the form of selfhood, and by its infinite formative activity mediating between self and self. From this standpoint it looks as if the self, the inner kernel of personality, were to be sought only in the Father and the Son, while the Spirit, the mediating being with the fluid determinations of transition, would have to content itself with the form of universal selfhood without a fixed personal center of its own.

By developing the consequences contained in these presuppositions, however, we have convinced ourselves that the matter stands otherwise. So far is it from being the case that the Spirit can be separated, either with its ground in the universal from the self in the Father, or with its ground in the individual from the self in the Son, that the self-doubling whereby the Father distinguishes himself from the Son rests
 [488] precisely on the Spirit: the fundamental act of self-doubling is an act of the self in the Spirit. Seen from this side, the matter then takes on quite another appearance; for now it looks as if the self were posited solely in the Spirit, as if it were the Spirit that, in the development of its own essence, solely for the sake of self-opposition, and thus for the sake of self-development, so to speak, allotted to the Father and the Son each a self of his own, so that by the mediation of the extremes in the unity of the opposition it might take up the separated members in full forms and hold fast to itself alone. Since now the latter conception is evidently just as one-sided as the former, it becomes a task for the philosophy of religion to show how it follows precisely from

the concept of the Spirit that the divine personality must have its threefold point of unity, its living center, in a threefold personal unity of self.

α) The Spirit of the Father.

That the Father, the omnipotent Self who brings forth all things, cannot possibly be personal for himself in separation from the Spirit has already been shown, and can be seen expressly in the concept of omnipotence. Omnipotence is: 1) self-power, God's power; 2) power in another, the reality of the world; and 3) power over another, infinite over-power. Omnipotence is trinitarian. It is then just as absurd if anyone were to say that it is the Father who has taken the self from the Spirit, as if anyone were to maintain that it is, conversely, the Spirit that has taken the self from the Father. The Father and the Spirit have, in this first original concentration, one and the same self, one and the same infinite selfhood. Why then do we call this self the Father's, not the Spirit's? It lies in the peculiar character of the paternal personality, in the original opposition of the omnipotent God to the world as of the Creator to the whole creation; it shines forth from the Father's personal works, from creation, from preservation, from governance.

Creation is trinitarian; for the Creator is, as the omnipotent Self, exalted above [489] the world; he is, as the universal, substantial selfhood, in the world; he is both at once by means of the Spirit. Only by virtue of the omnipotent unity of opposition of self and selfhood can the Father be Creator, but the unity of the opposition is personal only in the Spirit. If the Spirit is thought away, the concept of creation is a spiritless concept. The creating God then sinks down to being a finitely represented person, a mystical individual without individuality. The divine works of creation would in this light come to appear as finite acts of power, utterances of arbitrariness of a finite will. And why? Because the universal selfhood, bearing the content of the totalities, falls away with the Spirit. Only in the Spirit and by means of the Spirit can the omnipotent, primordially paternal Self in unconditioned freedom raise itself above the inner system of coherent possibilities of worlds; only in the Spirit and by means of the Spirit can the creating will sink itself into the unity of these possibilities as into its own selfhood, can with the self-determining power of its will breathe into these

possibilities the plan of wisdom in fundamental determinations fixed in essence, and through these fundamental determinations, for the real revelation of power, release the finite elements of reality to natural self-development. The unity of the natural development of things in the substantial selfhood of the Godhead and of the acts of will in plan and disposition whereby the natural development is determined is, in the personal Self of the Father, a unity of opposition, a trinitarian unity, by means of the Spirit.

Preservation, on account of its unity of opposition with creation, is in a special sense trinitarian. It is the reciprocal determination of self and selfhood, of the punctual will and the universal willing, on which it again depends. If we disregard the Spirit [490] with its God-and-world fundamental determinations, it will be impossible to form any sound concept of the seemingly abrupt transition from creating activity to preserving rest. In the Spirit, by means of the Spirit, the opposition is explicable. In the extreme of divine creative activity the incipient activity of nature is already to be understood; the universal willing furnishes the ground for the determining will. In the extremes of preservation creative activity is to be understood; for the will's infinite self-determining does not, after all, cease because in its inner operation it holds back the particular acts of will: the will is only resting because it personally keeps itself in rest, the active rest that bears the world. Preservation is not simply a continued creation, but a creation converted into natural development, i.e.: into divine willing, an extreme which has its opposite within itself and is in the Spirit trinitarian.

In a still more many-sided sense governance is trinitarian. From the concept of governance it is seen expressly how the two extremes, creation and preservation, mutually include each other; for governance presupposes the natural development of the connection of things and events, and to that extent coincides with preservation; but governance also presupposes the active cooperation of the will, and from this side coincides with creation. The unity of opposition of creation and preservation which is posited by the Spirit in the governing will shows clearly what it means that the Spirit is the Spirit of the Father, that the Father is a personal God, that the personal God can act. In personal action finitude is taken up, for the will operates punctually, now here, now there; now thus, now again otherwise. But the divine action proceeds

from inner infinity, does not break the essential connection at any point: the punctual will is everywhere in essential understanding with the universal willing. Thus the Spirit operates in the Father's essence; its infinite self-operation is on all sides directed toward uniting all personal activity in the paternal Self; the personal Spirit is the Spirit [491] of the Father: *the Spirit proceeds from the Father.*

β) The Spirit of the Son.

The God-man, the Logos-Self become man, is in his opposition to the Father one with the Father; this unity of opposition is trinitarianly personal in the Spirit, corresponding to the divine-human fundamental determinations in the Self of the Spirit. But the Self of the Spirit does not in this connection step forth specially over against the Son. On the contrary! its infinite self-operation here aims at uniting all personal activity in the personality of the Son. This center is individual: the Spirit operates on the ground of the individual. The Son's personal works, his law-fulfilling, redeeming and atoning activity, are, as works of the Spirit in and through the Son himself, all trinitarian.

For the fulfillment of the law it is the self in humanly limited individuality on the one side and the law, the universal, divine selfhood, on the other side, that form the extremes. The unity of the opposition now shows itself in this, that individuality expresses the universal, that flesh and blood are subjected to the law, that the self freely gives itself up into selfhood. It looks as if the latter extreme gained over-power over the former. But — this is the personal operation of the Spirit — the latter extreme is conversely taken up and transfigured in the former. It is not the law that here gains over-power over individuality; it is, on the contrary, individuality that gains mastery over the law. The law's strictest demand is satisfied; but as the law is fulfilled, its perfect fulfillment becomes its complete destruction: it goes under in the personality of the Son — by means of the Spirit. Selfhood is not violated, is not rejected by the Son; no, what is personal in the Spirit shows itself precisely in this, that the extremes [492] are preserved in their unity, that the sublation of the law is its fulfillment.

The infinite reciprocal determination of suffering and operating which characterizes the fulfillment of the law in turn forms two new extremes, of which the first

reduces the personal self-activity to a moment of the suffering, while the second posits the personal suffering as a moment of the self-continuing personal activity; this is, in the Spirit itself, the opposition of atonement and redemption. Judging by the one extreme, one might be tempted to conceive the atoning suffering as if it concerned merely the individuality of the sufferer and, as something historically concluded, belonged to the past, while the redeeming activity concerned the universal and therefore extended through all times; but how spiritless such a separation is has been shown in the foregoing. It is precisely the distinguishing mark of all the functions of the Spirit personal in the Son that the individual is point by point transfigured in the universal, and the latter in the former. Where the Spirit of the Son is to operate, in the word of baptism, in the words of institution of the Supper, the Son himself must personally cooperate. But that the Son cooperates means that he, present as individual personality, by means of the Spirit, is spiritually-bodily present in the word.

In order to further the spiritual conception, people have sought to push back the representation of the bodily presence; this is a preposterous procedure, for when the Spirit, the Spirit that masters the oppositions and unites the extremes, is thought away, an individual personality cannot possibly be present in more than one place at a time. To believe in the spiritual presence of the individual personality and deny the bodily presence is nonsense; for the individual personality is, according to its concept, spiritual-bodily.

Yet — we will not keep silent about it — precisely where the talk is of the Son's [493] personal transfiguration in the Spirit, a transfiguration on which the possibility of his sacramental multilocal presence rests, a problem arises so hard that it at first glance looks as if it would clinch the paradox and put the absurd in the place of the Mystery. "For the possibility that Christ's body could be essentially present in the Supper in the many places where it is celebrated, Luther appealed in the first place in general to the divine omnipotence, for which nothing is impossible; then he let, more determinately ... Christ, who also according to his human nature sits at the right hand of God, be present together with this right hand in all creatures, as he expresses it, in stone, in fire, in water, even in the rope, consequently also in the bread and wine of the sacrament. When this now seemed to be only Amalric of Bena's materialistic pantheism and

panchristianism, and in no case to give the elements of the Supper a preference over other bodies, Luther made the further distinction that Christ, although present in all things, nevertheless lets himself be grasped and enjoyed only in those where he wills and expressly declares it, as in the Supper; but by this one merely came back by a detour to the appeal to the divine omnipotence"⁸¹.

It is in the present context not specially with regard to the sacrament, but with regard to the Spirit, that the problem is brought out. Two main propositions seem here to stand in irreconcilable conflict with each other.

It is not particularly with regard to the sacrament, but with regard to the Spirit, that the problem is brought forward in the present connection. Two main propositions seem here to stand in irreconcilable conflict with one another. The one is that Christ's individuality is incorruptible; the other is that the personal Christ can be present with his body and blood wherever his Supper is held. In order to hold fast to the latter proposition the Lutherans essentially dissolved the former; for in the doctrine of the ubiquity of Christ's body his individuality is, after all, completely dissolved. In order to hold fast to the former, the Calvinists must deny the latter. Christ cannot [494] be bodily present in the Supper, for his individual body is in heaven. Now so long as one continues, on the one side, to hold fast to the bodily presence in the sacrament in such a way that it must necessarily dissolve the individuality, while, on the other side, one limits the individuality in so external a manner that the spiritual-bodily presence becomes impossible, the dispute does not turn on a holy mystery, in which finite conceptual contradictions can be resolved, but on an irrefutable paradox, an absurdity, whose consequences strike deadly blows on both sides.

It is the fundamental opposition between universal and individual personality, more precisely: between the Father and the Son, to which we must go back. The mediation of the extremes, the unity of the opposition, must be sought in the Spirit; for the truest, richest, fullest presence of personality is its presence in the Spirit. The personal spirit does not exclude bodiliness; on the contrary! Bodiliness is everywhere the means and the medium of passage for its self-active revelation. But universal personality stands in a different relation to bodiliness than does individual personality:

⁸¹Strauss. Troesl. II. S. 479.

the Father's relation to the world of bodies is qualitatively different from the Son's. The Father, the Almighty, is incorporeal; his inner personal self-power reveals itself in this, that through the Spirit he has all bodiliness in his power, is omnipresent in the bodily world. The Son, the revealer of the Almighty, is clothed in bodily individuality and has not, in the glorification — "at the right hand of God" — laid aside his individual bodiliness. Glorified bodiliness — this is the Mystery — differs from corruptible bodiliness in this, that as spiritual bodiliness it can express, in an individual manner, the concentrations of the will in a plurality of relative centers. Christ is not, as Luther [495] says, — "present in all creatures"; here there is evidently a double error. In the first place, it is overlooked that the Father's presence in "all creatures" is not an immediate sensuous being-present. In the second place, the thoroughgoing opposition between the Father's and the Son's personal relation to bodiliness is overlooked. But what they have in common is that glorified bodiliness serves the Son's personal will just as unconditionally as the bodiliness of the whole world serves the Father's; and Luther is to that extent right in what is, religiously, the main thing, namely that Christ *can let himself* be grasped and received in his sacrament: the sacramental presence in many places belongs originally to the Atoner's divine-human life in the Spirit.

That we cannot aim at any objective scientific comprehension either of glorified bodiliness or of the actual multiplication of individual presence goes without saying. On the other hand, we have expressly aimed at so reshaping the concepts of faith that belong here that the paradox can vanish and the Mystery be acknowledged. The spiritual-bodily individual presence of which we are speaking here is not sensuously objective. Of sensuously objective individual presence it holds unconditionally that when the individual is in one place, it is not in another; but the glorified Savior's spiritual-bodily presence is a personal presence in the Spirit.

Personal presence is one with the working of the personal will; this holds just as well of the Father's omnipresence in the world as of the Son's individual presence in his sacrament. It is not a finite distribution of divine powers, not the transfer of an individual from place to place in space; no, it is God's personal presence in the Spirit, concentrations of the divine Self, that is in question. That these concentrations must be different according as they correspond to the universal or the individual character

of personality involves no absurdity: the Spirit in the Father can to that extent be [496] opposed to the Spirit in the Son. But just as the opposition of the Father and the Son is a divine self-opposition in the Spirit, so too is the unity of essence of the Father and the Son a divine self-unity in the Spirit. In this self-unity the Spirit is personally one with, and precisely thereby personally distinct from, both: *the Spirit proceeds from the Father through the Son.*

γ) **The Holy Spirit.**

How faith in the Spirit that proceeds from the Father and the Son is related, according to the principle of faith, to faith in the Father and the Son themselves may well be discerned from what has gone before.

If anyone supposes that it comes easier to “a reasonable man” to believe in the personality of the Father than in that of the Spirit, then the philosophy of religion and negative critique, however much they otherwise disagree, will now be able to unite in bringing him to other thoughts. It does indeed look at first glance as if it were, without further ado, a need of human reason to proceed from the presupposition of a God in heaven, a supramundane personal God; it looks as if the first article of faith were quite reasonable, and as if one could best escape all the troubles with faith and knowledge by keeping to it alone. Without immersing ourselves in the endless disputes between deism and pantheism, we need only a decisive religious emphasis on *God’s omnipresence*, and the counter-rational⁸² (the antirational) shows itself immediately.

God, says religion, is present in his congregation. This presence would be al- [497] together unthinkable if God were not potentially present in human life in general, and particularly in the life of the people to which the members of the congregation naturally belong. But whereas God’s presence in universal human life is a hidden presence, a presence of immanence, in which selfhood veils the self, God’s presence in the congregation is, on the contrary, an actual, manifest, personal presence, a

⁸²One must constantly bear in mind the difference between the counter-rational, the irrational, and the contrary-to-reason. The irrational, what is absurd in itself, must be rejected; the contrary-to-reason must be corrected; the counter-rational must be believed. The antirational is in itself just as little in contradiction with the rational as, according to “the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas”, the antilogical is in contradiction with the logical.

presence which makes itself known particularly in this, that it is not the idea of God in indeterminate generality, but God's own holy Self, that stirs and works in the souls of believers. "How, then, can the Father at one and the same time be both personally in heaven, that is: exalted as God in himself above the whole world, and yet on earth, in a determinate community, personally in the congregation?" It is possible only through the Spirit. "Whence comes the Spirit?" It comes at one and the same time both from the depths and from on high. From the depths! For it comes from the ground of human nature, of souls, through the consciences; it comes up, then, where it already was; it comes, as God himself, up out of his own Godhead; it comes by a divine act of will: its coming is its self-revelation. From on high! For the act of will by which the Spirit reveals its holy presence is a personal expression of the act of will by which it is *sent* from the Father in heaven. That the Father sends the Spirit means that he expressly *wills* its revelation. To immediate intuition it does, to be sure, look as if God himself were in two places: in heaven and in the congregation. If this representation is held fast in external finitude, we literally get two Gods. Indeed, the finite representation goes further still. For there are not only many congregations on earth, inasmuch as the one congregation is distributed about in many places, but there are in each [498] congregation many members; in each heart, in each believing soul, then, God as God, God's own Self, is present. The absurdity that seems to arise from this stems solely from a spiritless conception. One looks out into space and dreams of places and places, instead of believing in the Spirit and understanding that the matter here is not places but almighty acts of will, punctual concentrations of the divine Self. Were we here to posit a separate God for every divine Self, we should indeed get a polytheism that meant something: we should get countless gods. No, the truth is that the one and same God, out from his eternal center, his absolute point of unity, is able to posit an infinite multiplicity of relative centers, in which, by virtue of an inner overarching self-unity, he repeats his own divine Self. This is the fundamental opposition in God's essence: on the one side the almighty Self, exalted in power and majesty, the God who "dwelleth in the light which no man can approach unto"; on the other side the multiplicity of the points of revelation in which the eternally working Self unceasingly repeats itself.

It is these extremes that are mediated by the Spirit; without the Spirit there would be personality in the former just as little as in the latter. In the first extreme God's Spirit is personally the Father's Spirit; in the last extreme it is personally the Spirit of the congregation. Therefore the Spirit of the congregation is not a universal spirit of selfhood, like the spirit of humanity or, particularly, like the spirits of the peoples; no, the Spirit of the congregation is the Spirit with God's own holy Self, the Spirit from God — from the Father — the Spirit as "God the Holy Spirit".

Should anyone think that according to this explanation one could then say that the Father himself is the Holy Spirit, and that the Holy Spirit is the Father, the misinterpretation is easy to show; for the unity of the Father and the Spirit rests expressly on the opposition. If the personality of the Spirit is absorbed into the Father, [499] then God remains in his heaven and, as a deistic, otherworldly God, cannot possibly be present in the congregation. If the personality of the Father is absorbed into the Spirit, then God is transformed into Godhead, and the Holy Spirit into an ethical spirit of reason, an immanent spirit of conscience without a divine Self. It is seen, then, how the Father and the Spirit bear witness for each other: the personality of the Spirit confirms that of the Father, and the Father's in turn that of the Spirit.

The same thing repeats itself with the Spirit's relation to the Son. The difference from the Father lies in the new center. Concentrated in the personal individuality of the Son, the divine Self furnishes the intuitable individual-personal presupposition for the Spirit. Christ himself is present in his congregation in that the Spirit of Christ is present. Should anyone think that, if the glorified Christ is actually present himself, the personality of the Spirit must be superfluous, or, conversely, if the Spirit is present in its own divine person, the presence of Christ must be superfluous: then it is easily seen how loose, indeed meaningless, such an opinion is. If the personality of the Spirit is absorbed into the Son, then Christ must remain seated at the right hand of the Father and cannot possibly come down to the congregation. If, conversely, the personality of the Son is absorbed into the Spirit, then Christ is transformed into a general idea of Christ, and the Spirit becomes an Idea-spirit without a divine Self. If the Spirit loses its personality, then not only the Son but, as we have seen, the Father too loses all personality. The third article thus has, as regards faith in the divine personality, the

same fundamental character as the second and the first.

Thus faith in the triune God furnishes the unshakable foundation of the life of the congregation. "Therefore", says Grundtvig, "the statement concerning *the unity of the* [500] *Three* must express no more than can be warranted by the congregation's Confession of Faith and the word of baptism, so that if more should lie therein, it is of no concern to the Christian congregation" ... "The same holds of the technical term "Trinity" (the Greek *trias* and the Latin *trinitas*), so that, if anything indefensible were found therein, it would be the scribes' own affair and not the congregation's, which has only to confess and defend what it wholly and fully professes at baptism to believe and lets itself be baptized upon".⁸³

B. The Works of the Spirit.

§ 34.

Since the Spirit, in its relation to the Father and the Son, is, according to what we have seen, neither a part of God nor an abstract divine essentiality, but the whole God, it follows from this that every work of the Spirit must be capable of being called both a work of the Father and a work of the Son. Nonetheless there is here a call to make the difference count. For the Spirit personally, as the Holy Spirit, is in a special sense the God of souls, the God of inwardness in the believers. The works of the Spirit are, with regard to this, to be determined as the works of the God who is present in the congregation. The influences that the Spirit exerts on the individual as individual are then to be referred, partly mediately and partly immediately, to the life [501] of the congregation⁸⁴. We comprehend these works under the three points of view: *awakening, regeneration, sanctification*.

a) Awakening: The Living Word.

⁸³Den christelige Børnelærdom. Kjbhn. 1868. S. 208.

⁸⁴That this point of view does not stand in conflict with the Kierkegaardian insistence on the category "the individual" will be understood when one reflects on the difference between the philosophy of religion and religious ethics.

§ 35.

From the opposition between the natural man (*ἄνθρωπος ψυχικός*) and the spiritual man (*ἄνθρωπος πνευματικός*) it follows that the transition from unbelief to faith must presuppose a deep stirring of conscience, a breakthrough of the Spirit. By what psychic symptoms such a breakthrough is accompanied is not the essential thing, since these may be highly various according to the inner and outer circumstances of the individuals concerned; the essential thing is that the Spirit comes in personal power; the essential thing is that an awakening takes place. The awakening Spirit may announce itself in the individual, may, so to speak, knock at the door of the solitary one, separated from the congregation; but it does not come as the solitary one — if it comes in that way, it is not the Spirit of Christ — it comes from the congregation and calls to the congregation; it does not come to the thinker in a system of general thoughts — if it comes in that way, it does not come with awakening — no, it comes with a personal, awakening word; the awakening word is *a living word*: thus it comes essentially by the hearing of the word.

That the two concepts, the personal Spirit and the living word, must essentially belong together can be seen in the following way. The Spirit, which in itself, as spirit, is both invisible and inaudible, could not possibly reveal itself if it could not make itself known in the word. If it is now asked: in what does the word have its most original expression, in written signs or in speech? then the answer cannot be doubtful. That the sounding word is more original than the written word shows itself not only [502] in this, that it is older, more natural, and so to that extent also more popular than the written word; no, it lies in its peculiar relation to the personality of the Spirit. As the spirit is, so must the word be. For the spirit of science the written word will not only be just as convenient but in many cases even far more adequate than the oral word; so, for example, the mathematical sign language: mathematics and “the living word” suit each other but little. Are we then to say that the spirit of mathematics is a dead spirit, and all mathematicians “dead-biters”? By no means! The spirit of mathematics is not a dead spirit but an objective one, the impersonal spirit of exact knowledge, of cold reflections, of abstract thoughts: the objective, impersonal spirit has no use for the personal word. That oral instruction is given in the strict sciences happens solely

for the sake of the individuals, not for the sake of the sciences: the clear, objective language of the sciences is essentially a written language.

But the Holy Spirit of faith is absolutely heterogeneous with the spirit of science; it lies in its personal essence to demand personal communication. The more weight is laid on the personality of the Spirit, the more weight must be laid on the oral word. In the oral word the speaker is present; but the written word presupposes that he who wrote it is absent. In the speaker the Spirit can stir, live, and work; for the speaker himself is a living being. But the written word is not a living being. The written word, though only a shadow-outline of the absent spirit, can indeed awaken thoughts and feelings and living representations; this holds especially of works of poetry: one thinks of a Homer, a Dante, a Shakespeare, and the imagination already comes alive at the mere thought. But what sort of living is that? It is a living in beautiful illusions, hence [503] an imagined living; but an imagined living is not personal. The awakening of the personal life in the Spirit presupposes a strong personal impression of the Spirit; but a strong personal impression of the Spirit presupposes the Spirit's personal working in a living personality⁸⁵. To read oneself into an awakening in a written word is impossible. One of two things: either it remains an awakening in thoughts, representations, and passing moods, hence a sham awakening without the power of actuality, or else the Spirit itself seizes the human being from within in an extraordinary way, and then the written word is only an accidental occasion, not an efficient cause; for this stands fast: nothing can come forth in the effect but what has been in the cause. The Protestant deification of Scripture is a denial in principle of the holy Spirit of personality. That this deification of Scripture did not vanish with critique's dissolution of the old dogma of verbal inspiration has its ground in this, that the written word is the objective word of science; so the personal Spirit was then to be forced into science: that is an unnaturalness against which protest must be made in the most forceful way. Not in itself, but in its disproportion to the Spirit of life, is the word of Scripture the dead

⁸⁵Those who assure us that they cannot understand what the living word is assure us by the same token that they cannot understand what a personal spirit is either. The oral word is not without further ado a living word, but conversely. To keep exclusively to the opposition between the oral and the written word will not do; for there really are those who talk big and become lively without the word thereby becoming living; and there are, again, those whose written word is wonderfully awakening, for example S. Kierkegaard's.

word; it is Grundtvig's immortal merit that he "in the power of the Spirit, with a living voice" has testified against "the dead word".

The word of awakening is a living word; but awakening in turn assumes many forms; we may here distinguish between the immediate or direct, the reflected or indirect, and the reformatory in principle.

[504]

α) Immediate Awakening.

The more strongly the opposition between the new light in religion and the spiritual darkness in the old conditions of the world can show itself to those concerned, the more favorable are the conditions for an immediately powerful awakening. Peter's speech at the feast of Pentecost (Acts 2) is typical of all speeches of awakening. The phenomena of awakening in the apostolic age bear, in their primally powerful immediacy, every mark of the Spirit's first personal working.

It is otherwise with the awakenings that take place in ages in which the life of the spirit has a far lesser tension. Much may indeed be accomplished here in all simplicity; the preachers of repentance in the Middle Ages, the Pietists and the Methodists in the eighteenth century have powerful examples of religious awakening in a popular direction to show. But unclarity about the spiritual as well as the natural conditions of life, in combination with much that is morbid, ecstatic, and fanatical, shows plainly enough that it is not a deeper self-understanding in the Spirit but an obscurely fermenting urge of conscience that has played the main role in these awakenings. There is a half-reflection that makes simplicity spurious and paralyzes the powers of the spirit. This half-reflection comes from an overpowering spirit of the age. The light of culture cannot be kept out; it steals into "the simple" and gives half-reflected piety an uncanny tinge of narrowness, pious borné-ness, indeed even of selfish conceit.

How little a powerful awakening, however immediately it may seek to cling to the first ideal presuppositions of the life of faith, is able to defy the history of culture, the Irvingites with their apostolic congregation furnish telling proof in the present day. The living word demands that the personal organs be in living understanding with the holy Spirit of personality. But when "apostolic" leaders, with forced simplicity, [505]

shut their eyes to the conditions of the life of culture, although the sun of reflection stands high in the heavens, they must wait in vain for the Spirit to work with original power through thought-blind, miracle-craving organs.

It is the resistance of reflection that the spirit in the present age must unconditionally overcome; so far as the principle is concerned, this can happen only if the essence of reflection becomes completely transparent, and thus only if the believing consciousness passes through the fiery trial of reflection. Herewith we come to

β) The Reflected or Indirect Awakening.

It is this standpoint that is represented in the very most proper sense by S. Kierkegaard. To translate religion into reflection in order to take it out of reflection again and preserve it in pure simplicity — that was the task this remarkable man set himself, and for whose solution he had received the call of the Spirit in the richest measure. S. Kierkegaard holds unshakably fast to simple faith; but in making Christianity a communication of existence, he draws a finely woven net of existence-tasks together around “the individual,” and so reflection begins with the indirect communication. The relation to God is “simple” and yet “infinitely reflected.” Everything is staked on “serving the truth,” but — by “a godly deception.” “The ideals are proclaimed,” but the proclaimer himself “is without authority.” The whole undertaking begins conservatively and ends revolutionarily. Seen superficially, it looks like nothing but contradictions; but if one enters into the whole design and follows the development in its details and ramifications, then the execution is consistent from beginning to end.

[506] It begins with the presupposition that Christianity is the eternal truth, the highest ideal power, and it ends with the declaration that Christianity hardly exists in the world, that “the Christianity of Christendom” is “an official deception”; that is truly for awakening!

But the awakening is indirect, reflected, negative. It is the earnestness of the awakening that men must begin by becoming afraid of themselves and asking in anguish of conscience: what shall we do? Thus, after all, the awakening also began at the first Pentecost. But here now is the great difference between an apostolic and a

reflected awakening. The apostolic awakening, which is personally borne by the Spirit as Holy Spirit, has immediate power over all the finite considerations of reflections; the modern awakening, reflected in negative form, takes the detour of mediacy in order to sharpen thought and, with thought, the sting that is to bore its way into the conscience. The Apostle's answer in the Spirit is positive: "Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost." But the thought-awakener's answer in the Spirit is negative: "Despair! For the eternal truth has been turned into deception. Despair! For the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists on earth." It is wounding, but it is — indirectly awakening⁸⁶.

γ) The Reformatory Awakening.

The Spirit of the Father and the Son is the Spirit of the congregation; this implies that the individual's life in the Spirit must in every age be conditioned by a corresponding life of the Spirit in the congregation. Even the preacher of repentance who declares the congregation dead nevertheless stands, by this very declaration, in a [507] positively determined relation to the congregation, and must necessarily presuppose that the dead one is not dead but sleeps; if he does not want to contradict himself, he must presuppose that among the many sleepers there is at least one who is awake. The task, then, becomes to awaken the congregation that has fallen asleep and lies in the sleep of death. This awakening can happen only by putting into force the conditions of life indispensable to the congregation. It is a reformatory task.

In the sixteenth century it was the papacy with the Catholic hierarchy that was on the point of stifling the congregation; then there was a break with the traditions of the hierarchy, and the word of Scripture was set, as a replacement, beside the sacramental institutions. Besides this, the Reformation not only indicated the conditions of the spirit indispensable to a freer life of the congregation, but it also brought about a deeper understanding of the relation between religion and culture.

⁸⁶Grundtvig in his "Børnelærdom" has called S. Kierkegaard "a hair-splitter"; that is a misunderstanding. From the standpoint on which he placed himself, K. is entirely right. His task was to illuminate the disproportion between the Christianity of Christendom and the Christianity of the New Testament, and he has done that thoroughly.

In the present age, when the life of the congregation is indeed not oppressed by external despotic power, but is partly encumbered with a host of inherited forms of compulsion, and partly exposed either to being screwed down under a doctrinal system of scholastically objective dogmas, and so getting actual human life against it, or — insofar as the spiritual leaders wish to keep up with the times to some degree — to collapsing, as the foundation of Scripture bursts and the characteristic features of revelation are wiped away by the damp sponges of the mediating theologians — in the present age a fundamental awakening from out of the totality itself is required once again. The task is twofold: 1) to reconcile religion with popular enlightenment by going back to the original unity-in-difference of universal human life and the life of faith; 2) to secure the congregation against all the disturbances that the surreptitious guardianship of the School over the concerns of life, and in particular over those of [508] religion, has called forth in the course of time. In both respects the Grundtvigian view is the only one among us that has a future.

b) Regeneration: The Sacrament of Baptism.

§ 36.

What has already been said of awakening holds of regeneration: in the religious-ethical sense it does indeed essentially concern the individual, but from the standpoint of the philosophy of religion it must be conceived as a work of the Spirit in the congregation. That the life of the spirit in the individual has its origin in the life of the Spirit that streams through the congregation is expressly seen from the sacrament of baptism. The individual is indeed baptized personally into Christ, is received in baptism by Christ himself, present in the Spirit with the Word — it then follows directly from the principle of faith that the sacramental fundamental word of baptism is not merely Christ's own word of institution, but the Word of life from the living Christ: only as the Word of the new life can the word of baptism be a word of regeneration, with divine power in the Spirit — but Christ does not baptize outside of, but in his congregation, in and into his congregation. The conditions for the growth of the life

of the spirit in the individual are therefore inseparable from the congregation's own conditions of life.

The original conditions of life of the congregation all have their source in the fundamental word of baptism. This fundamental word, in which the Spirit works through the cleansing element, does not have its significance in the fact that the holy act is performed at Christ's command, as though it were a work of the law⁸⁷, but personally in the fact that the act itself is an evangelical act of Christ and as such, in the Spirit, an actual sacramental act.

What takes place through this sacramental act in the soul of the individual being [509] baptized can be summed up in the one expression: the first fundamental effects of regeneration. But what these fundamental effects are, how they take place, whether they take place in the child in the same way as in the adult, etc., of that there is no objective knowledge. Every attempt to ground the "effects of grace" out of a scriptural-scientific system of faith ends in the mystical-magical, an eloquent proof that the grounding is inverted and that the doctrine of faith, according to its principle, is anti-rational. In this connection we shall consider the sacrament of regeneration as paradox, as Mystery, and as the beginning of the new life in the congregation.

α) The Sacrament of Regeneration a Paradox.

When "the individual's eternal blessedness is decided in time through the relation to something historical, which is furthermore historical in such a way that into its composition there has been taken up that which according to its essence cannot become historical, and so must become so by virtue of the absurd," then naturally both the act of baptism and regeneration have taken up into their composition elements which according to their essence cannot be composed, and which therefore must be composed "by virtue of the absurd." S. Kierkegaard's defense of infant baptism is highly characteristic in this respect. For he regards infant baptism "not only as defensible as orthodox and praiseworthy as the expression of the piety of parents who cannot bear to be separated from their children in regard to what is for them the matter of their blessedness, but also, in yet one more sense of which people are

⁸⁷In this sense the law ought to be excluded from the gospel.

perhaps not aware, as a good — because it makes it still more difficult to become a Christian”⁸⁸. Christ’s words (Matt. 18; Mark 10): “for of such” (namely little children) “is the kingdom of God” he explains thus,⁸⁹ that it is the disciples whom Christ wants “to distance a little from himself by means of a paradox” ... “The apostles rebuke the little children; but Christ does not rebuke in return, he does not even reprove the apostles; he turns to the little children, but he speaks to the apostles. The paradox lies in making a child the paradigm; *partly* because a child, humanly speaking, cannot be that at all, since it is immediate and explains nothing (therefore a genius cannot be a paradigm either — the melancholy in the genius’s distinction), not even for other children, for every child is merely itself immediately; *partly* because it is made the paradigm for an adult, who in the humility of the consciousness of guilt is to resemble the humility of innocence.”

The light and shadow sides of the dialectic of paradox become quite visible in this connection. As religious-ethical dialectic of existence it has an extraordinary strength, but in the sense of the philosophy of religion its intellectual arbitrariness is intolerable. If Christ’s divine-human essence is an absurdum, the sacrament of baptism an absurdum, regeneration an absurdum, faith an absurdum: then, undeniably, the Spirit of Christianity is in itself an absurdum, and all self-understanding in the Spirit only an absurdum. But self-understanding in an absurdum sublates itself.

β) The Sacrament of Regeneration a Mystery.

If *absurdum* is to mean not that which is in itself, by its nature, contradictory, but only to be the expression for what is incomprehensible in the sense of knowledge, then the contradiction dissolves in the self-dissolution of the concept, and the Mystery steps into the place of the paradox. That the Mystery in the sacramental act must be just as impenetrable as the Mystery in the paternal Self is grounded in the nature of the matter. As regards the institution of the new relation to God, it is just as impossible to articulate the reciprocal determinations of the divine and the human, of the supernatural and the natural, in the fundamental workings of the Spirit, in

⁸⁸Joh. Climac. S. 291.

⁸⁹Anfr. Skr. S. 457.

the hidden miracle, as it is impossible to articulate the reciprocal determinations of nature and spirit in the Father's own essence. The analyses corresponding to the psychology of regeneration do not at any point hit upon the first, original thing, but only what is derived from it. The first, original thing is that regeneration by means of the sacramental act is a work of the Spirit by means of the Son, a work of the Son by means of the Spirit, and in both respects a personal, divine-human work. The original thing is that the divine-human work furnishes the foundation for the self-conscious development of the life of faith in the individual. As self-consciousness is awakened and the human self enters into reciprocal action with the divine, this reciprocal action must invariably, uninterruptedly show itself grounded on the new life of Christ implanted by the sacramental act. Whether the individual is otherwise baptized as an adult or as a child, whether self-development can begin at once or only after an interval of time, the relation of the life of faith to the sacramental act will in principle nevertheless be the same. To believe in Christ is to appropriate Christ personally in the Spirit; but the act by which the believer in inwardness appropriates Christ personally is, after all, conditioned precisely by the act by which Christ himself has appropriated him personally, and thus conditioned by Christ's personal act of baptism: the appropriation of Christ is a living, uninterruptedly continuing remembrance of the covenant of baptism.

γ) The Sacrament of Regeneration an Act in the Congregation.

Insofar as it is the minister of the Word who performs baptism as an act of faith, the act is human; but insofar as the institution is from Christ, and Christ himself, present [512] in his Word, accomplishes the act, it is divine; to unite the divine with the human is the personal work of the Spirit. Whoever mistakes the Spirit must either regard the act from the merely human side and reduce the sacrament to a religious ceremony, or else conceive the human as an impersonal means and point of passage for the divine, whereby the magical, mystical, and sorcerous arises. If the one baptizing were not a member of the congregation, the human could not come into its own, and the act could not be an act of faith; but if the effect of baptism were made dependent on the subjective power of faith of the one baptizing, the divine could not come into its own:

baptism would then not be an act of the living Christ himself, not a sacramental act. The two main sides of the sacramental act are inseparably united in the Spirit of the congregation.

The same thing repeats itself when we consider the act of baptism in relation to the one who is baptized. As an act of Christ the sacrament has a validity independent of all human subjectivity: it is not the human individual who chooses Christ, but conversely Christ who chooses and receives the individual. This is the divine element in the work of the Spirit. But the work of the Spirit is a divine-human work, and is conceived spiritlessly when the human side is overlooked. Now since the act, seen from the human side, is an act of faith, the question arises whether there is not, after all, an essential difference between infant baptism and the baptism of adults. We answer: There is a difference, an unmistakable difference; but the difference is only psychological, not one of principle. The psychological difference is plain enough. In the adult the preparatory activity of the Spirit precedes the sacrament: the adult must [513] seek the sacrament in faith and to that extent bring faith with him. In the child who is baptized no preparatory activity of the Spirit precedes; the child in actuality brings no faith with it. Now if one forgets that the union of the human with the divine is the work of the Spirit, it seems as though there were here only a choice between one of two things: either to reject infant baptism or to concede that the sacrament of regeneration can work both with faith and without faith; then comes critique, and then one stands there in the midst of a tangle of insoluble difficulties. The difficulties vanish when we fix our gaze on the relation of the Spirit to the sacrament. Without the working of the Holy Spirit faith is impossible: the Spirit does not proceed from faith, but conversely faith from the Spirit. The working of the Spirit, whether in the adult it goes before in preparation or in the child's soul follows after in completion, is equally bound to and conditioned by the sacramental act itself. If we now remember that the Spirit is the Spirit of the congregation, that the act takes place in the congregation, that the one who is baptized is baptized to be a member of the congregation, then it is seen that the difference between the child and the adult is only psychological, not one of principle.

The baptized child, considered in the divine-human light of the Spirit, is, as "a child

of God,” at the same time a child of the congregation. Everything depends on the divine and the human not falling apart from one another spiritlessly. Certainly the Spirit can begin to work as the Spirit of faith only gradually, as the child’s consciousness is awakened; but already the first, the very first effects will point back through the awakening consciousness to the sacramental act. The question: where is the child’s faith when it is baptized? is easy to answer from the standpoint of religion. Faith is in the child as a possibility, but in the congregation as an actuality. “Then is it perhaps the congregation that believes in the child’s place?” By no means! Where there is talk of a substitute, there is talk of an individual. But the congregation is more than [514] an individual. In this light it is not the parents, not the godparents, not the members of the congregation as a sum, who believe in the child’s place; individuals, however many they may be, cannot possibly undertake in this way to believe in another’s place. To look to the individuals here is to be misled by finitude, is to separate the human from the divine and to grieve the Spirit. No, it is the congregation as congregation, as the temple of the Spirit, as “the bride of Christ,” that bears in its heart the conditions of real possibility for the development of the child’s faith. Through the act of baptism, therefore, the child is not merely received by Christ: but Christ “takes it in his arms and blesses it,” and then lays it in the lap of the congregation, the spiritual mother’s lap from which regeneration proceeds. “But,” it is asked, “what if no one takes charge of the child’s upbringing? Or if the child, on reaching the age of maturity, despises the sacrament of baptism and reproaches the congregation for having anticipated its free choice: what then?” The answering of these and similar questions belongs under the following point of view.

c) Sanctification: The Sacrament of the Lord’s Supper.

§ 37.

As a Christian concept of faith, the concept of the congregation is a divine-human concept. Seen from the divine side, the congregation is not a society of like-minded individuals, but a community of the Spirit; on its human side, on the other hand,

this community of the Spirit is an association of like-minded individuals. In the development of the life of the congregation the emphasis must, to be sure, fall with alternating preponderance now on the unity of the community, now on the diversity of the individuals, but always in such a way that the relation between the original and the
 [515] derived is kept clearly in view. If we look at the original, it is not the individuals who, by appropriating the Spirit one by one, have joined together and formed the congregation, but conversely it is the Spirit who, by “calling and gathering” the individuals, has founded the community. In relation to the divine work of the Spirit, the individuals in their singleness and individual diversity are to be regarded as personal possibilities; in relation to the human work of the Spirit, the personal possibilities are destined for free, independent development, a self-development in which each one for himself must live and work as an actual person, as the individual. The former must correspond to the sacrament of regeneration, the latter to the sacrament of sanctification. It goes without saying that, just as in regeneration the divine takes up and permeates the human, so the human, the self-development corresponding to sanctification, must proceed from and be grounded in the divine. From this standpoint we consider the sacrament of sanctification as paradox, as Mystery, and as an act in the congregation.

α) The Sacrament of Sanctification a Paradox.

It is highly characteristic that the representative of the dialectic of paradox — we mean, of course, S. Kierkegaard — has everywhere put the sacrament of baptism in the shade, whereas with evident predilection he has brought forward the sacrament of the Lord’s Supper. This is most intimately connected with his chosen standpoint: he takes “official Christianity” to task; so he fixes his fiery gaze on the individual, but overlooks the community; so he enjoins sanctification, but overlooks regeneration. Now if it really were a one-sidedness of principle, a kind of half-conscious or unconscious heresy, of which he made himself guilty, then the spokesmen of official objectivity
 [516] could easily dismiss him as an isolated subjectivist who wanted to work “in the direction of inwardness” by making a noise in the direction of outwardness; but that is not how the matter stands. The sacrament of baptism, regeneration, the life of the congregation — these religious presuppositions are by no means denied, but they are

indeed overlooked; that is to say, in accordance with the chosen task — to awaken consciousness of the ethical-ideal demands of the life of the spirit — they are pushed back, but not otherwise than that they can be brought forward again at whatever moment it becomes necessary. That is why “that individual” stands — not, as people have so blithely asserted in order to relieve the oppression of their hearts, outside, but inside the congregation, in the midst of the congregation; and the congregation that does not want to fall asleep on an imagined regeneration without sanctification does well to hear his voice.

As little as sanctification is possible without regeneration, just as little is actual regeneration possible without sanctification; regeneration is the real possibility of sanctification, and consequently sanctification is to be determined as the very actuality of regeneration: sanctification is the religious-ethical development of character, a development of character that alone can preserve “the joyful Christianity” in “fear and trembling.” Sanctification proceeds from regeneration as love from faith, which is also why the sacrament of sanctification is, as we know, especially designated the sacrament of love.

To the sacrament of love correspond “works of love,” for love in believers, the love that hides “the multitude of sins,” has — as a communication of existence this is a paradox of faith — its holy ground, its inexhaustible spring, in the incomprehensible love of the Atoner, the love with which he continues to give what in the fullness of time, once for all, he has given up — his body and blood for the remission of sins.

[517]

β) The Sacrament of Sanctification a Mystery.

If the sacrament of the Supper is to be objectified in knowledge, then, whether we take our stand on the evangelical Lutheran or on the papal Catholic standpoint, it becomes an insoluble paradox, an unconditionally repellent absurdity. The Lutheran representation that Christ’s body should actually be imparted *in, with* and *under* the bread, Christ’s blood *in, with* and *under* the wine, is in the sense of science just as mystically unreasonable as the Catholic assertion that it is the priest who, by virtue of the miraculous gift imparted to him at ordination, *transforms* bread and wine into Christ’s body and blood. The church parties (Zwinglians, Socinians, etc.) that have

tried to give the dogma of the Supper a more rational interpretation have with their rationality contributed, not to explaining, but to explaining away the sacrament.

Those who otherwise find it hard to see that the principle of faith is absolutely heterogeneous with that of knowledge, and objectification in knowledge naturally heterogeneous with objectification in faith, must surely have their eyes opened when the talk is of the sacrament of the Supper. What appears here when we objectify in knowledge? A box of wafers by itself, a cup of old wine by itself, a priest who reads the words of institution — these are nothing but external things, nothing but sensuously actual objects. Over all this there then hovers an image that fantasy forms for itself of the glorified Christ. These many heterogeneous elements of representation thought is then to work together into a dogmatically objective unity of concept; by virtue of this unity of concept *in, cum et sub* is to be scientifically explained: the explanation will be accordingly.

It is otherwise when objectification takes place in faith. The gaze does not then fasten on external objects in sensuous existence by themselves; but through the outer the inner is looked upon: the act is looked upon as a holy act, as the sacramental act of [518] Christ, present with the Spirit. All thoughts are now transformed into holy thoughts of impression: to awaken these thoughts is the work of the Spirit. Thus Christ is, by means of the Spirit, actually present, spiritually-bodily, in his sacrament. Objective knowledge vanishes: the presence is objectified in faith; but it is not a figment of faith, for Christ comes to the meeting at his given word. Yes, — says the Gospel — he comes with the Spirit in the word; he grants a personal meeting! Woe to him who dares to meet him in the sacrament without meeting in faith: such a one “eats and drinks judgment to himself.”

The sacrament of sanctification is thus not an absurdity, still less an object of reason; but it is a Mystery.

γ) The Sacrament of Sanctification an Act of Christ in the Congregation.

In the sacrament of regeneration man cannot be said, in the personal sense, to meet with Christ; for in this sacrament human personality is as yet only a possibility — nor, indeed, can a newborn child be said to meet personally with its own father. It is

the misunderstanding of the Baptists that in the sacrament of baptism they want to appear already as persons, instead of appearing as children. In the sacrament of the Supper, on the other hand, the individual cannot appear as a child, but must appear as an actual person. But when a human being is to meet personally with the Holy One, as self with Self, he receives a living impression of what it is to be a sinner. In the sacrament of regeneration sin is conceived impersonally, as a sickness in the nature of man and thereby in the nature of the will; but in the sacrament of sanctification sin is conceived personally in the strictest sense. According to the ideal of holiness, man should by now have developed into religious character; but his personal development testifies against him, for alas, he is personally — a sinner.

The forgiveness of sins at the Supper therefore bears a different stamp from the forgiveness of sins at baptism. *Forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors.* — “There is thus actually a double forgiveness of sins, namely the *divine*, which is bestowed [519] in *baptism*, and the *human*, which belongs to the *Supper*; and although the divine, which is bestowed in *baptism*, is conditioned only by *faith* and *confession* together, and is altogether *complete*, it is nevertheless given only on the *presupposition* that the *mutual human* forgiveness of sins is added in the *congregation*, consequently with the *reservation* that it *falls away* when the person concerned withdraws from it, as the Lord has both shown us in the parable of the ten thousand talents and has expressly testified to his disciples that if they do not forgive one another their debts, then neither will the heavenly Father forgive them theirs.”⁹⁰

Sanctification is the work of the Spirit; the sacrament of sanctification is the act of Christ. The sacramental acts of Christ have unconditional validity for the life of faith only by being objectified in faith; but they are objectified in faith only when they are presented in the light of the Spirit, in inseparable unity with the Spirit himself and the works of the Spirit.

C.

The Kingdom of the Spirit.

§ 38.

⁹⁰Grundtvig, Børnelærdom. S. 225–26.

The Kingdom of the Spirit is in the deepest sense the kingdom of personality. Individuals can indeed assert personal rights in other communities too, and to that extent appear as persons; but only in the Kingdom of the Spirit is the principle
 [520] of community itself personal. The principle of personality with its divine-human fundamental effects is the only thing able to nourish, form and develop the personal life of individuals for time and eternity. Since the Spirit begins the actualization of his kingdom in this world, he must no doubt engage with the world's terms and require natural conditions of life; but since the kingdom is not of this world, he must work unceasingly to transform the world and to change the conditions within the temporal into means for the eternal. The interaction between the Spirit in the congregation and the universal human spirit takes on, in every gifted people, a stamp of its own, which is determined by the spirit of the people.

a) The Spirit in the Congregation.

§ 39.

As the personal spirit of community, the Spirit himself is the organizing principle of the congregation. The organizing activity is at once both divine and human. If the relation between the divine and the human is distorted, either in such a way that the human is taken to be immediately absorbed into the divine, or in such a way that the divine dissolves and perishes in the human, the organism is attacked and "the body of Christ" sickens.

By laying weight one-sidedly on the immediately divine influence of the Spirit, one must necessarily be driven to one of two extremes: *either*, with the Catholics, to believe in the infallibility of a church visible in traditions and institutions, and then we have the hierarchy; *or*, with the abstract-critical intellectualism of the Reformed, to break the staff over all historically developed church forms and make the condition of the congregation in the apostolic age an external, unalterable norm.

[521] By one-sidedly emphasizing the human in the organizing activity of the Spirit one is driven to two other extremes: the *Lutheran-official*, which, while holding fast to the

apostolic divine in word and sacraments, ascribes to the traditional development of rite and church constitution so organic a historical validity that the human forms of law, although the human element in their origin is conceded in principle, are nevertheless regarded as inviolable on account of the prescriptive right once acquired; and the *humanistic-dissolving*, which, appealing to “the perfectibility of Christianity,” makes the spirit of the congregation a particular form of the world-spirit, and consequently cannot ascribe to congregational life any special, independently organizing principle.

In order to see how these extremes may be mastered by the Spirit himself, we cast a glance at the inner and outer organization of congregational life and at the relation between the two.

α) The Inner Organization.

“As instruments of the church-founding Spirit the apostles stand not only in the freest relation of unity to the Spirit, but also in the freest relation of unity to *one another*. Although there are diverse gifts, there is yet but one Spirit; and although there are diverse apostolic forms of doctrine, the one fundamental truth yet lives in them all. Precisely by distinguishing its content into a diversity of moments does the Spirit reveal its fullness and its riches. For the same reason it is not the consciousness of the individual apostle, but the *apostolic total consciousness* that is the complete expression of the revelation of the church-founding Spirit, just as this is also the complete expression of the Church’s consciousness of its fundamental relation to the Lord and the Spirit, its fundamental relation to the world and to itself. As representatives of the mother church the apostles express not merely the ecclesiastical [522] self-consciousness of a single age, but are the Christian Church’s representation for all ages.”⁹¹

Here we have the right, unalterable canon. We shall now see how it may be applied. The opposition between teachers and hearers, for example, is an opposition determined by the organizing activity of the Spirit, an opposition, therefore, that must have its divine as well as its human side. The divine side has been brought out with strong emphasis by the author of the “Christian Dogmatics,” where he says: “Christian

⁹¹H. Martensen. Den christl. Dgmt. S. 353.

preaching is ... not merely a human speech about Christ, but it is Christ himself who through it gives himself presence to the world and to believers ... This is the secret of Christian preaching, whereby it distinguishes itself from all other speech that can be delivered about a historical person, that in the same measure as it is actually a preaching in Christ's name, in the same measure the word still exercises *essentially* the same effects for awakening and confirming faith in the person of Christ as when he walked bodily here below, exercises essentially the same impression for awakening and confirming faith in the salvation that is bestowed on us in him; all of which is explicable only from this, that the Church has not an absent but a present Christ, who breathes livingly through his word."⁹² These are strict demands that are hereby placed on the proclaimers of the word in the congregation; but insofar as one looks exclusively to the divine ideal, they are by no means too strict.

In order to satisfy in some degree the divine demands of the Spirit, no exertion whatever, then, ought to be spared on the human side. The congregation must accord-
 [523] ingly do everything so that those who feel a call to proclaim the word may obtain a preparation that can make them fit, in theoretical as well as practical respects, to carry out so responsible a work of the Spirit. Those who do not in some measure satisfy the acknowledged demands the congregation must, then, be permitted to turn away; those, on the other hand, who do satisfy these demands it must uphold and acknowledge as rightly appointed, without regard to by what road and in what manner the preparation has humanly been attained. So it was, indeed, precisely in the apostolic age; and — “the apostles express not merely the ecclesiastical self-consciousness of a single age, but are the Christian Church's representation for all ages.” From this it follows, then, that when a preacher is unable to give the congregation a palpable impression of “the secret of Christian preaching,” is not capable of preaching in such a way that the word “still exercises *essentially* the same effects for awakening and confirming faith in Christ's *person* as when he” — Christ himself — “walked bodily here below,” then the spiritless preacher must be removed from his office as unfit for the ministry of the word, and the congregation is in the name of the Spirit not merely entitled, but even, according to the canon we have set up, directly obliged to put a capable man in the

⁹²Anfr. Skr. S. 424.

place of the incapable one.

If we now consider the imperfection of human things, it cannot be denied that the congregation, if it is to satisfy the claims of the Spirit, has a difficult task to solve.

β) The Outer Organization.

In order to reconcile the ideal with actuality, to restrict arbitrariness, and to bring about a social order adapted to the demands of the Spirit, weight is then laid on rules, laws and standing ordinances. In this way the transition took place from the free, circumstantial forms of the apostolic congregations to the objective, strictly rule-bound constitution that particularly distinguishes the Catholic church system. [524] The partition that was now set up in the name of the Spirit between clergy and laity was, humanly speaking, of great advantage to the clergy, but, spiritually seen, of irreparable harm to the congregation. Now, especially after *ordination* had been raised to a sacrament, it was of course not at all difficult to satisfy the congregation. The cleric's word, whatever the word might otherwise be like, was bound absolutely to give the congregation an impression of "the secret of Christian preaching," for the secret was that the cleric always preached in the power of the Spirit, because he preached in the power of his "holy office." Thus the objective, the official, stepped into the foreground. The Catholic Church lays claim to being a direct, infallible continuation of the apostolic, and yet the Catholic Church forms a decisive counter-image to the apostolic: in the Catholic everything is official, in the apostolic nothing.

The official is the externally objective, the impersonal; from this it follows that the holy Spirit of personality can never meet more dangerous resistance than that which lies in the official.⁹³ It is not a further development of the first constitution [525] that directly brings the official with it. On the contrary! A richer articulation, a more

⁹³"Imagine the following case. There comes to you a human being who (without in any way giving you the notion that he is insane) quietly, earnestly, yet deeply shaken, says to you: 'pray for me, O pray for me': is it not true, it would make an almost terrifying impression on you? And why? because you yourself personally received the impression of a human personality who presumably had to be fighting the uttermost fight with a personal God, since it could occur to him to say to another human being: pray for me, pray for me."

"When, on the other hand, you read, for example, in a '*pastoral letter*': Brethren, include us in your intercessions, just as we unceasingly night and day pray for you and embrace you in our intercessions — how is it that this presumably makes no impression on you at all? is it not because you involuntarily

definite separation between the various positions and functions, could very well take place without the original fundamental character being distorted thereby. It is not the distinction between lower and higher dignities, between deacons, presbyters and bishops, that has made the Catholic Church so absolutely unapostolic. No, it is the distortion of the organizing principle.

In the apostolic age the all-organizing principle is personal. Positions and activities are distributed according to the gifts; but the gifts are gifts of the Spirit, free gifts, "gifts of grace." No one has the gift because he is chosen, but he is chosen because he has the gift. The rule-bound order, the human side of the matter, is at all points dependent on the divine freedom: all forms are living.

It is otherwise with the official. The official makes the forms the main thing and adds the name of the Spirit. Now all dignity, all authority becomes something externally set up, something objectively represented, without personal truth. Now the deacon does not become priest, nor the priest bishop, because the Spirit gives him a higher gift; but he is assumed, he is represented, to receive the higher gift when he officially advances to the higher position. Now the spiritual leader does not have authority because he in truth possesses religious personal superiority; but he is assumed, he is represented, to be a holy man because he has entered "the holy office."

To abolish the higher clerical dignities and by leveling legal enactments to force through a republican or radical-democratic constitution of the congregation is by no means directly the way to master the official. One could by law screw the congregation back to a constitution that in all external particulars resembled the apostolic one: such a legally compelled copy of the free, personal exemplar would nevertheless be only a caricature of freedom, for the copy is official.

γ) The Interaction between the Inner and the Outer Organization.

The conflict between the personal and the official stems from this, that the divine and the human in the organizing activity of the Spirit are separated and combined in

conceive a suspicion that it may be formula, rigmarole, official, out of a handbook or out of a music box ... "For believe me, there is nothing that God finds so repugnant, no heresy, no sin, nothing so repugnant to him as the official." S. Kierkegaard. *Øieblikket* Nr. 4, 7.

an external, finite manner: the unity of opposites becomes an immediate unity, now in the one, now in the other extreme, and in both cases spiritless. The official does not lie in legally determined forms or in lawfully established offices. If a polemic against the official goes to the extreme of rejecting the thought of a well-organized constitution of the congregation, then the personality of the Spirit is violated; for the principle of personality is and must be organizing.

A clash between the two extremes, the divine, which aims at the free inner, and the human, which on the conditions of actuality demands its determinate outer, was already present from the beginning and will continue through all ages. This clash derives not only from the conflict between ideal and actuality, but is grounded in particular in the double-sided nature of personal life itself. The members of the congregation are, as regards the ground of their life, all indeed “members of one body,” all together “branches on one vine,” and must to that extent all be presupposed to have one fundamental will, one goal and one striving; but it is at the same time the demand of personality that the individuals, each with his own conditions, according to his gifts, must develop freely and independently: here there are thus many wills, [527] many points of view, many endeavors.

The independence of individuals, which from the divine side is grounded in their personality, is from the human side inseparable from their accidental individuality. The diversity of individuals must therefore be acknowledged for the sake of personality. Thus it is, then, impossible even for God’s own Spirit to organize a community of personally independent individuals without a system of laws: only by means of laws can the Spirit master the arbitrariness of individual wills, protect the freedom of individuals, and yet preserve the organic unity of the community. From this point of view we now return to the organization of the apostolic congregations, according to the canon set up: “As representatives of the mother church the apostles express not merely the ecclesiastical self-consciousness of a single age, but are the Christian Church’s representation for all ages.” It is 1) the legislative authority, 2) the peculiar character of the law, and 3) the observance of the law, on which attention fastens.

1) In the divine sense it is the Spirit himself that has the legislative authority; in the human sense it is the congregation. How both main sides come into their right can be

seen from the Acts of the Apostles, ch. 15. That the Catholics have departed from the exemplar must strike the eye. From the apostolic expression (v. 28): “Ἔδοξε γὰρ τοῖς ἁγίοις πνεύματι καὶ ἡμῖν” the legislative councils have formed for themselves a standing formula; the formula has stepped into the place of the principle, for the principle is denied. According to the apostolic principle — “Then the apostles and the elders with the whole congregation resolved, etc.” (v. 22) — it is the whole congregation that takes part in the legislation; but according to the Catholic principle it is exclusively the clergy that has appropriated the legislative authority. That the assembled clergy [528] are the organs of the Holy Spirit is not something actual; it is only something they represent: here we have the official, and to the official corresponds the formula.

If we give up the formula and hold fast to the principle, it then becomes clear that the legislative authority can be preserved in the congregation without one age therefore needing to copy another. There is in the apostolic congregation an essential opposition between the apostles themselves and the other members of the congregation, but this opposition is not formally juridical. The authority of the apostles is no official authority of office; it is grounded solely on personal superiority in the Spirit. Now it is clear from the principle how the canon set up is to be applied. Other times, other conditions; this holds of the finite, the purely human. Different arrangements can therefore be made at different times with regard to the manner in which the legislative authority of the congregation is best brought into exercise. Deviations suited to the times in this respect, be they democratic, aristocratic or monarchical, are not without further ado to be regarded as deviations from the original; for several forms are possible. But under whatever form the legislative authority appears, this nevertheless stands firm: that this authority can be exercised only in the name of the Spirit, as the expression of the will of the congregation. From this it follows that anyone who works for any organization other than one that expressly aims at asserting the free personal superiority of the Spirit with the active, living participation of the congregation, works against the apostolic, for the official.

2) That the peculiar character of the law must rest on the legislating spirit is self-evident. As different as the spirit in the congregation is from the spirit in civil society, just so different must the laws of the congregation be, in their fundamental

character, from civil laws. Civil laws are laws of compulsion, but — we repeat it — the laws of the Son and of the Spirit are laws of freedom, for the Kingdom of the Son [529] and of the Spirit is the kingdom of freedom. In this respect too the Catholic Church gives us the counter-image of the apostolic; for *Jus Canonicum* is a system of laws of compulsion. When, superficially seen, it nevertheless seems as if the laws of the congregation must impose external compulsion on individuals, this is not the fault of the laws but of the individuals themselves. External compulsion becomes felt only through the individual's wanting at once both to be a member of the congregation and yet to set his arbitrary individual will against the universal will of the congregation: then let the dissatisfied one step out of the congregation.

If we consider in particular the position that the ministers of the Word occupy in the congregation, it becomes evident what the laws of freedom signify. Without organizing laws, the life of the congregation would essentially have to come to rest on religious moods, whose fluctuation would be indeterminable. The one extreme would readily replace the other. Now a gifted preacher, by a superiority owing not so much to the Spirit of Christ as to individual and to that extent accidental advantages — natural gifts of speech, a practical eye, subjective and excessive zeal for the faith, etc. — would carry the majority of individuals along with him and set himself up as a kind of spiritual dictator in the congregation: this is the one extreme. Conversely, once the mood had turned and the individual members of the congregation had really got going in making the influence of the majority felt, the opposite extreme could also set in. Instead of bowing beneath the divine authority of the Spirit and the Word, the individuals of the community would then themselves decide what is to count as Christian truth, and would regard the minister of the Word as their servant, without considering that he nevertheless ought, personally and in the name of the Spirit, to be the servant of Christ. What is characteristic of the laws of freedom must now be placed in this: that the spirit of personality is able to master the extremes.

Those who work one-sidedly to secure for the ministers of the Word a position so [530] firm, and so independent of the mood of the individual members of the congregation, that the ministers can find themselves objectively safeguarded by juridically objective laws, break the canon we have set up; they misjudge the exemplary significance of the

apostolic congregation — for the apostles surely did not find themselves objectively safeguarded by juridically objective laws — they violate the holy spirit of personality, they work for the official. But let us not forget the opposite extreme either. For it is nevertheless incontestably true that if even the state may not be reduced to a mere product of the social instinct of interested individuals, still less may the congregation of Christ. The personal spirit of the congregation is and must be the ruling common spirit. Those, then, who by juridically objective legal provisions work to deliver the spirit of the congregation over to the encroachments of individuals in the form of an objective right of the majority, work just as surely, albeit in another way, against the apostolic — for an apostle would rather have laid down his life than put up with a majority of unclear individuals obtaining the right, in the congregation, to decide on the truth of the Gospel. The official is always one with the objectively formal, under whatever guises this formal element may appear.

3) From the fluctuation of the extremes cited it becomes clear that not only the laws but the *observance* of the laws entails tasks of a quite peculiar kind. In civil legislation the point is to give the laws a properly objective, determinate form and to secure their observance with formal strictness. This method cannot be applied to the laws of the congregation. It is true that ambiguities must be avoided; but in order to displace the official, or at any rate to reduce it to the least possible, all forms must be mobile: only mobile forms are living. Seen from an objective standpoint, then, the constitution of the congregation, as regards its rules and laws and particulars, acquires [531] something suspended, something that reminds us that this kingdom of the Spirit is not merely heterogeneous but absolutely heterogeneous with all other kingdoms in the world. Here is an organized actuality, and yet this actuality is, in every given form, only a passage to a new possibility. The application and carrying-through of the laws demand personal considerations in all individual cases of significance for the life of the congregation. To a superficial view it looks as though the whole were a web of nothing but personal considerations, unforeseeable decisions according to subjectively arbitrary judgment; it almost looks as though the free life of the congregation were designed for respect of persons. And yet precisely the opposite is the case. Respect of persons belongs precisely to the official, agrees with the official

as if by a *harmonia præstabilita*. What does the official want? Not personality itself, but the semblance of personality! But the semblance of personality belongs precisely to respect of persons. No, it is not respect of persons but the principle of personality that, according to the apostolic exemplar, is to rule in the congregation. Whatever is commanded or forbidden, whatever is agreed upon and established, whether it otherwise concerns the whole or the individual, must all be decided according to the principle of personality under the very strictest personal responsibility. For the sake of the principle forbearance may be shown toward the individual, but for the sake of the principle severity may also be shown toward the individual. The official always has, where personal decision under personal responsibility is concerned, a multitude of extraneous considerations that confuse the impression of what is essential, of what is in truth simple. But the spirit of personality knows nothing of extraneous considerations, will have nothing to do with them.

Is it then perhaps only an ideal of a constitution of which a sketch is given here? By no means! Here there is no groping after ideals; here a principle is pointed out, the principle of life, of freedom, of personality. But the principle of personality, be it noted, is a principle of faith. If we dare to believe in this principle and prove our faith in works, then the congregation comes to life; and if the life of the congregation increases in power, then the ministers of the Word too will receive the authority of the Spirit and will have no need to sigh after the official. [532]

It is precisely the apostolic principle, with the apostolic exemplar, that alone can furnish the canon. For “as representatives of the mother church the apostles express not merely the ecclesiastical self-consciousness of a single age, but are the representation of the Christian Church for all ages”.

b) The Spirit of the Congregation and the Spirit of the People.

§ 40.

The relation between the life of the congregation and the life of the people is originally to be determined by the relation between the natural man and the spiritual

man, and this in turn by the relation between the absolutely heterogeneous principles of revelation and of reason. It is thus given herewith that the life of Christ in the Spirit and human life in its naturalness can no more fuse together in any living people than the new man can fuse together with the old in any believing individual. But it is also given herewith that, just as the new life in the individual both forms itself on the basis of the innate individuality and must essentially be regarded as a transformation and renewal of this its natural first, so too the spirit of Christianity, working out from its own peculiar center, will not merely transform but, through the transformation, strengthen and rejuvenate the original vital forces in the people as a people. The right understanding of this presupposes a clear distinction between the three concepts: *church-state*, *state church* and *people's church*.

[533]

α) The Church-State.

As the great world-historical counter-image of the apostolic congregation, the papal church is a state within the state, and thus, not merely on the basis of the *patrimonium Petri* but expressly by virtue of its organizing principle, a church-state. By this the peculiarity and legislative independence of the religious principle over against the secular power is asserted. This is what is capable, what is vigorous, in Catholicism, that it has known how to uphold the autonomy of the Church, its inviolable self-legislation. One would now think that the one-sidedness consisted merely in an all too strict holding fast to the heterogeneity of the ecclesiastical principle with the principle of the state; but the fault is precisely the reverse. The Catholic principle of the Church shows itself only all too homogeneous with the principle of the state. Instead of an absolutely inward independence, the Church acquires an outward and relative independence, an independence resembling that of the state. It is precisely this outward political independence that has entangled the Church in disputes with the state, intricate disputes in which the church-state sinks year by year and goes to meet its dissolution.

β) The State Church.

At the Reformation the evangelical Protestant congregation gave up its right of self-legislation as regards its constitution: that was both too much and too little. Luther burned the canon law; a pity that he could burn only the book, not the principle. The principle passed by inheritance to the princes; and now the state churches stepped into the place of the church-state. The state church robbed the congregation of its self-legislation; that was a violation of the personality of the Spirit. To this very day there are complaints, and with reason, that the religious life of the community is not so developed that the congregation can straightway, without further ado, demand back its apostolic right. What do we learn from this? That it is not by amendments and partial alterations of the old state-church system of legislation that a new order of [534] things can be inaugurated! The juridical, official system of compulsion, which now for more than three hundred years has weighed upon the social self-consciousness of the congregation and maintained the condition of tutelage, will not by any improvement whatsoever be fit to lead it toward a genuine age of maturity. The apostolic principle must be put into force. Only when the congregation, through its freely elected representatives — to whom belong not only the trustees who are elected on a given occasion, but its appointed teachers and leaders, priests, deans and bishops — can take the legislative system into its own hands, does life come into the ecclesiastical community. This can of course happen only by the principle of ecclesiastical legislation being conceived as absolutely heterogeneous with the principle of civil legislation. But the reciprocal action of the heterogeneous principles is conditioned by the stage of consciousness which the people has reached.

γ) The People's Church.

In the state church the laws are laws of compulsion; in the people's church they are laws of freedom. Influenced by the spirit of Christianity, the people thus orders its great common affairs through two absolutely heterogeneous systems of law, that of the state and that of the congregation. By the laws of the state the people binds itself to secure for the Church the conditions necessary for its temporal, civil existence. The state must then, for its part, have security that religion preserves the fundamental character for whose sake the people, through its political representatives, has promised

the Church, as the people's church, its support and favor. Now since the foundation on which all members of the Evangelical-Lutheran Church must without contradiction be agreed is precisely the congregation's "Apostles' Confession of Faith", it follows of [535] itself that this Confession of Faith alone is able to furnish the criteria by which the civil legislative authority can recognize the people's church.

But the Confession of Faith is not a formula, not a sum of objective, juridically determined dogmas; it is a "living word", the fundamental word from which the great simple thoughts of the congregation proceed and to which they return again. Disputes must therefore be able to arise within the congregation itself about the development of this fundamental word, and many kinds of deviations take place. How far these deviations can go without altering or corrupting the fundamental character of the people's church, the state cannot determine; the congregation must decide that itself, through its religious trustees, its leaders and spokesmen: here, then, the laws of freedom come into full application. The state has — according to the apostolic principle — nothing directly to do either with the installation or with the removal of the teachers and overseers of the congregation: the offices of priests and bishops are not civil offices but offices of the people's church. Nor are these official positions dependent on the accidental mood of the members in a single congregation; for the concept of the people's church presupposes that the individual congregations enter as members into the whole comprehensive organism of the congregation.

That in the domain of the people's church's self-legislation a multiplicity of personal collisions must arise, tasks that can be solved only on the terms of freedom, personally, under the highest personal responsibility, cannot possibly be otherwise, as surely as the kingdom of the Spirit and of freedom is in the strictest sense the kingdom of personality. But herein lies, again, that the solution of the tasks in every age must be conditioned by the power of life and truth with which the Spirit of Christ is able to penetrate and move the spirit of the people. If the spirit of the people lacks religious [536] life, then the laws of freedom will either lose their force or be transformed into laws of compulsion with an unapostolic emphasis on the official.

"Just as spiritless and preposterous, therefore, as it is to wish to excommunicate and, as far as possible, root out the *old*, original human life in order to make room

and scope for the *new*, Christian human life, just as preposterous and spiritless is it to excommunicate and, as far as possible, root out the *life of the people*, in order to set *Christian life* in its place; for when one says to the *spirit of the people*: come out, thou unclean spirit, and give place to the *Holy Spirit*! one may well thereby be rid of the spirit of the people, but one is so far from getting the *Holy Spirit* instead that one thereby, as far as possible, shuts oneself and the people off from all spirits, from all *spiritual* influence, all *spiritual* and *heartfelt* understanding and enlightenment".⁹⁴

The reciprocal action, pointed out by Grundtvig, between the spirit of the congregation and the spirit of the people will be of thoroughgoing significance, if the present age is otherwise to succeed in extricating itself from the tangled confusion of state and people's church.

c) Conclusion.

§ 41.

The complaints heard far and near about disagreement in matters of faith, and with it also about a most threatening, imminent dissolution of the whole communal life of the Church, will without doubt diminish as people come to see, in the practical as well as in the theoretical, the necessity of going back to the principles themselves, to the first simple thing. The noisy strife between revelation and reason, religion and science, rests on a misunderstanding. The disagreement between the various church [537] parties among us is — if we leave aside the fractions expressly designated as sects — by no means so considerable as one would straightforwardly suppose from the strong pronouncements of those who set the tone. By reflecting on the relation between the principle of faith and the content of faith, one will gradually come to see that the content of faith cannot be supplied to the congregation from outside through official textbooks and great dogmatics, but must develop organically from within — from the simple fundamental words of the Confession of Faith. Of how such a development can be laid out and carried through in the form of a philosophy of religion, the present

⁹⁴Grundtvig, Børnelærdom. S. 153.

work was meant to offer a specimen. Far from nourishing the presumptuous fancy that the philosophy of religion in the shape here presented should in each and every respect have hit upon the one thing right, the author is much rather clearly conscious that the execution could in many points have been more many-sided, richer and more fruitful than is the case in this first attempt. But one thing has, during the working out, article by article and point by point, confirmed itself for him, and it is: *the necessity of holding fast the principle of faith as a principle of cognition peculiar to the religious life, and of developing everything from the principle.*
